Jack O. Balswick, Pamela Ebstyne King
and Kevin S. Reimer

The Reciprocating Self

Second Edition

HUMAN DEVELOPMENT IN THEOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

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To my students past, present and future. J. O. B.

To Aidan, Rhys and Jocelyn. P. E. K.

To Naomi and Danielle. K. S. R.

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Preface

THE PURPOSE of *The Reciprocating Self: Human Development in Theological Perspective* is to present an integrated view of human development that is based on social science research and biblical truths. We do this by drawing on a biblical model of relationality, where the created goal or purpose of human development is to become a *reciprocating self*—fully and securely related to others and to God, which essentially enables us to become more like Christ. The reason for writing this second edition is threefold. The first is theological. In addition to our trinitarian perspective of human nature, we also wanted to emphasize a christological perspective. Thus, we propose a dynamic and directional understanding of telos, God's purpose for humankind. Second is the need to update the research that has been done since our first edition. Third is the emergence of the *relation development systems* paradigm that is supported by the 2015 publication of the four-volume *Handbook of Child Psychology and Developmental Science* (Lerner, 2015). This landmark publication consists of over one hundred in-depth articles written by experts on specific aspects of human development, with a total of over four thousand pages in support of the claim that *relational development systems* (RDS) can be considered the new paradigm for human development science. Why our enthusiasm for RDS? Simply put, because our theological model of the reciprocating self and the RDS paradigm are both based on the recognition of and importance placed on the process of *relationality.*

While the ideas for this book came to us as we struggled together to teach human development in a holistic manner, the suggestion for using *reciprocating self* as a reflection for

trinitarian relationality was given by Pam. The major advancement we hope to achieve in writing an integrative model of human development is to address what we call the *developmental dilemma*—the fact that existing developmental models lack a comprehensive guiding teleology.

A parallel purpose to providing an understanding of human development within a theological perspective is to provide a context for the reader to understand his or her own developmental issues. As we trace the reciprocating self through the lifespan stages we will be able to address stage-specific *developmental issues*. A developmental issue is a concern, opportunity, tension, worry, or crisis encountered by the self in the context of change. The source of change can be personal and internal—bodily, mental, emotional, social—or external—relational, familial, communal, societal. Since internal and external change are continual and interactive, life is a process of facing one developmental issue after another.

Awareness of developmental issues is most salient at transitional points throughout the lifespan—learning to talk and walk, beginning to eat unassisted, going to school, developing secondary sexual physical features, leaving home, obtaining full-time employment, becoming engaged and then married, having a child for the first time, parenting an adolescent, watching your children move away from home, retiring, experiencing a decline in physical and mental health, and, finally, facing imminent death. God has created human beings for relationship with God and human others, and it is our contention that to be a self in reciprocating relationships is of major importance in negotiating the developmental issues.

Jack

Hi, I'm Jack and I have developmental issues. As I put the finishing touches on the second edition of this book I have just celebrated my seventy-seventh birthday and fifty-fifth wedding anniversary. At this age I find myself enjoying retirement, but reluctant to completely give up the academic side of my life that began over fifty years ago. Herein lies the crux of my developmental issue: I recognize the high level of teaching and writing expected at my seminary, and although desiring to continue contributing where I can, I recognize that I increasingly struggle to remember a scholarly citation and my speaking is not as free flowing as it once was. While I still enjoy writing, I find that my fingers don't glide across the keyboard as quickly as they once did.

Facing developmental issues is nothing new to me. When I began teaching some fifty years ago students were satisfied with a dynamic lecture that was coherent enough for them to take understandable notes. Along the way, I supplemented my lectures with overheads outlining what I was saying. With the computer revolution, I followed the younger professors in developing multimedia PowerPoint presentations. Before retiring I successfully transferred my lectures into PowerPoint presentations with all the bells and whistles. But now as I proudly marvel at the teaching and scholarly achievements of my younger coauthors, Pam and Kevin (although they themselves may now rightly identify themselves as middle age), I think I should just enjoy what they have become and "fade into the academic sunset." Am I too old to continue to make any contribution to seminary work, or should I "move over" completely and let younger persons take my place? This questioning of my continued academic abilities is a core developmental issue.

However, developmental issues are not only academic in nature. In our first edition I wrote that I played volleyball three times a week, but had moved from position of spiker to setter after suffering the good-natured taunts of the other

players commenting on my spikes, “Was that a spike or a dink?” Since then my deteriorating knees and a neurologically based balance condition have limited my physical activities to cycling and swimming. My key developmental issue at present centers on the extent I can safely participate with my riding club on forty- to fifty-mile rides and extended multiday rides down the Pacific coast.

I have been a grandfather for over thirty years. I grieve that I can no longer engage with my younger grandchildren in a variety of physical activities—acrobatic wrestling, surfing, snowboarding, mountain biking, and backpacking—as I did with my two oldest grandsons, Curtis and Jacob. I struggled to stay active with Liam and Taylor, who are now teenagers, and mourn that seven-year-old Elisabeth and three-year-old Ben must learn to be content with a grandfather who in some ways is a “shadow” of what he once was.

Successfully addressing this developmental issue may mean that I more positively accept a traditional culture image of a grandfather who is gray- haired, slightly bent and feeble, but who is kind, gentle, full of wisdom, and gently reads and interacts with his sympathetic grandchildren. My desire to be a vital and involved, if less physically active, grandfather to my younger grandchildren means learning to be who I am in a new way (similar developmental issues can be found in chapters twelve and thirteen on middle and elderly adulthood.) However, I’m not the only one with developmental issues, as you will quickly learn from Pam’s and Kevin’s comments.

Pam

Hi, I’m Pam, and boy, do I have developmental issues. At the completion of this manuscript I am forty-seven years old and my firstborn just turned twelve. This week he asked me for

face cleanser to help prevent pimples, and he sends "emojis" daily to a sweet girl at middle school. How did I get here? At the completion of the last manuscript he was ten weeks old. At that time, I was full of confidence in parenting my someday teen with my PhD and pretty extensive research in adolescence. But now that I have an official "tween," and two other children that think they are teens, I am humbled by how unprepared I am to parent adolescents in our complex age. That said, I am grateful for a telos that points me toward encouraging them to deeply know God, his people and creation. I am also grateful for the lens of relational developmental systems theory that provides me a means of seeing the resources and assets (and challenges) within and surrounding my children.

At this stage of life, witnessing my children become more themselves is a profound joy! My three, Aidan (twelve), Rhys (ten) and Jocelyn (eight), are each such unique people. My husband, Brad, and I marvel that they have any DNA in common. They help me teach all the time. Not only have they been coming to my classes for years—as infants to demonstrate Ainsworth's Strange Situation or as children to play with various toys with my graduate students—but they also give me lots of great illustrations for lectures! Most importantly, they have taught me developmental insights and wisdom beyond that which is available in textbooks and empirical research articles. They sure keep me on my toes!

This leads to my perhaps most significant developmental issues. I confess I still struggle to understand how to balance family and work. This was a major developmental issue at the time of publishing the first edition. I would have expected to have figured this parenting and professor/pastor thing out before now. Alas, this is not the case. I am still asking the same questions as twelve years ago when I decided to initially return to work part-time. I am still part-time. I am still ordained, but now I am tenured. Can I be a "good enough mother" and still work? No doubt, working part-time

has hampered my professional trajectory as an aspiring researcher and professor, but that is okay. I have learned to be a "good enough professor or scholar or teacher or mentor or pastor." I still struggle almost daily to strike a balance of my complex call as wife, parent, professor and minister.

I have always understood my work as a calling from God and take very seriously being a steward of my training, gifts and resources to build God's kingdom. For me, work is not only a job but a vocation in which I find great meaning and satisfaction. I have also come to understand being a wife and a mom as part of that call and vocation. I am grateful that I get to not only think, write, research and teach about human development—but I get to practice it every day!

I am grateful to say that my professional identity has solidified a bit. I have been able to integrate my call as a minister, teacher and scholar. I have always felt like my call was to enable people to become what they were created to be. This has fueled my passion for understanding telos and human development. Given this love, I have been grateful to pursue theological and psychological understandings of thriving—and particularly the role of religion and spirituality in human thriving. I continue to look for collaborative opportunities where I can teach, pastor, reflect theologically, generate empirical psychological understanding and bring about social change. Projects such as this book delight me because they allow me to draw on biblical truth and theological understanding as well as psychological theory and research. For the past decade, much of my research and writing has focused on issues of spiritual and religious development in young people.

I am grateful to Jack for referring to Kevin and me as the "young" professors. For although we are younger than Jack, we are officially middle age and there are new "young" professors. And I feel that. On good days, I can rest in my further differentiated professional identity and experience.

On less secure days, I can begin to fret over my dated statistical knowledge and my realization that I am old enough to be my students' mother!

I will note as a personal spiritual developmental issue that writing the chapter on reciprocating spirituality was extremely challenging and gratifying. I am very intrigued by the paradox of attempting to grow in my understanding of God and transcendence (theologically and psychologically), but ultimately have come to know God more fully not through my efforts to understand, but rather to surrender and to experience God. As I have aged (and I hope matured), I have come to reconcile this simultaneous active pursuit of and receptive surrender to God as an earnest openness to both receive and extend God's grace as God leads. I am humbled by the mystery of the transformative power of God's love, grace and presence. Consequently, I lean into Paul's admonition in Romans 12:1-2 and hope to intentionally offer my life daily as a living sacrifice, hoping for transformation and to enable others to know the fullness of life in Christ.

Kevin

Hi, I'm Kevin, and I have developmental issues. I'm forty-six years old and father of two grown daughters, Naomi and Dee. The eldest, Naomi, is recently married. Weddings are a developmental milestone in the family system. More than a celebration, such events reshuffle personal adaptations (i.e., goals) that tend to define each step along the life course. Whereas I once found myself consumed with the financial details of supporting my kids through college, I now think more about building a good relationship with my son-in-law, Peter. Children grow, differentiate through adolescence, become emerging adults and finally leave home. There is much to be renegotiated as parents learn to relate to children as fellow adults on the journey. These changes

coincide with almost twenty-five years of marriage. As "empty nesters" Lynn and I are revising goals for our relationship. These now have little to do with goals of the recent past—helping our daughters successfully navigate playground bullying, sports injuries and college entrance requirements. Lynn has decided to change careers in midlife, an increasingly common transition in our culture. Our refashioned goals are influenced by her decision to become a statistician and move into research academia. We are sharing new goals in unexpected ways. Yesterday everything was about juggling work along with the cooking and housecleaning. Today we are publishing scientific papers together and collaborating on research grants. It is important for middle-aged couples to find new opportunities for partnership, appropriately balanced with cultivation of individual interests and relationships.

Middle age is a period of renegotiated relationships, goals and priorities. My development is impacted by the development of others, particularly in-laws moving into senescence. Ten years ago, I wrote that children provided the most immediate, powerfully reciprocal impetus to develop as a matter of time, place and role. Today my elders equally catalyze growth as their needs multiply toward the end of the life course. Midlife individuals apprehend the life course a bit differently, recognizing the brevity of time on earth in terms of opportunity for reciprocity—horizontally with other human beings and vertically with God. We rediscover our need for God, as children and elders mirror back to us the less attractive features of our brokenness. These relationships are both a great blessing and a struggle, influencing my understanding of human experience and the grace of a merciful God. For me, they are a present reminder of our fundamental identity as God's beloved sons and daughters.

Acknowledgments

We could not have written this book without the help of numerous people. We would like to acknowledge the many students at Fuller Theological Seminary, Fresno Pacific Seminary and Azusa Pacific University who endured our attempts through lecture and written drafts to communicate the material that has become the content of this book. A number of students, drawing on their own personal developmental issues and theological and psychological insights, have given valuable suggestions. We also offer a heartfelt thank-you to Christine Merola, Nanyumka Redmond, Susan Woods and Christine Tzeng who contributed time, energy and spirit to the details of this volume.

Personal acknowledgment must go to the persons who have contributed most to our own development and developmental stability and well-being. For Jack, this includes Mom and Dad Balswick, who went to be with the Lord several years ago; my wife, Judy, who has been my partner in marriage, parenting, vocation and now retirement; my daughter, Jacque, and her husband, Dana; my son, Joel, and his wife, Uyen; and my six grandchildren, Curtis, Jacob, Taylor, Liam, Elisabeth and Benjamin.

For Pam this includes my parents, Bonnie and Douglass Ebstyne, who raised me with generous love and facilitated my faith formation, and my beloved "bros," Bryan and Michael. I am grateful to my husband, Brad, who has allowed his wife to "geek out" now for over two decades and taught me much about reciprocity. My three children, Aidan, Rhys and Jocelyn, have brought my vocation to life and fueled my interest in human development, bringing deep joy at every turn. I would also like to thank four mentors, turned friends, for their investment and belief in me over the years—the late Peter Benson, Bill Damon, Jim Furrow and Rich Lerner. They have not only taught, but modeled what it means to be reciprocating selves.

For Kevin this includes my two daughters, Naomi and Dee, who were an inspiration to study developmental psychology in the first place. This includes Peter, my wonderful son-in-law. I’m deeply indebted to Lynn, who affirmed my academic journey at every level. Much of the resulting fruit resides in this book. Finally, I am grateful for a remarkable friendship with Dr. Warren S. Brown. Whether fishing on the river or doing research in the lab, Warren has taught me more about reciprocity and development than anyone else.

Finally, we would like to acknowledge and thank Gary Deddo, who was more than an editor as he guided us through the process of writing the first edition of this book, and David Congdon, who has expertly guided us through this second edition. We also thank an anonymous reviewer and our late teacher, colleague and friend Ray Anderson, whose imprint on this book can be seen from beginning to end.

PART I

Toward an Integrated Model of Human Development

AN INTEGRATED MODEL OF HUMAN DEVELOPMENT is stymied by a *developmental dilemma*—the fact that existing developmental theory lacks a guiding teleology. Developmental teleology refers to developmental completeness or a theologically informed understanding of the *goal* of development. Our goal in part one is to define and develop a working teleology that can usefully be used as a basis to understand and discuss human development and stages of human development. The developmental dilemma is important to acknowledge because it rears its nasty head in the face of the student of psychology who is looking for a coherent Christian perspective of development or who hopes for an integration between theology and psychology. Chapter one seeks to address this developmental dilemma as a necessary basis for developing a guiding teleology of human development.

In the second chapter we provide the theological rationale behind the use of the concept of the reciprocating self. A trinitarian analogy of being and becoming will serve as our model for understanding the goal of human development as the capacity of being a reciprocating self.

Developmental theories give an understanding of how development takes place, but as we indicated previously, they tend to be limited in providing a teleological focus capable

of pointing to the type of *relational context* in which human development ideally takes place. Chapter three seeks to provide a biblical basis for such an ideal relational context. The biblical depiction of God's relationship to human beings is used as a model for how God desires human beings to be in relationship with each other. We argue that a reciprocating self can develop best in a relational context that is characterized by *unconditional love commitment, gracing, empowering* and *intimacy.* The developing person is not only affected by but also affects the social context in which development takes place. Thus our model of human development is also one of reciprocal influence—of mutual influence between the person and the external social structure or the environment.

Whereas no human developmental theory spells out the desired relational context as specifically as Scripture, there are significant aspects within each developmental theory that correspond to the biblical model we present. Thus chapters four and five provide a selected overview of developmental theories in light of their correspondence with our model. Chapter four focuses on the major developmental theories that conceptualize human development in terms of a developing self—psychoanalytic, object relations, social learning, symbolic interaction and cognitive-development theories. Chapter four concludes by giving a comparative overview of the capacity of developmental theories to handle such human phenomena as choice and agency, sin and internal conflict, and communal aspects of personhood. In chapter five we give an overview of the *relational development systems* (RDS) paradigm, together with a neurobiological and two sociocultural models (Bronfenbrenner's ecological theory and generational analysis) of human development. While each of these three views of human development is encompassed within the RDS paradigm, we believe a deeper understanding of each would enhance an understanding of lifespan development.

1

The Developmental Dilemma

OUR PURPOSE IN WRITING THIS BOOK is to address what we call the *developmental dilemma*—the fact that existing developmental theory lacks a guiding teleology. Developmental teleology refers to developmental completeness or a theologically informed understanding of the *goal* of development. Our goal in this book is to define and develop a working teleology and discuss it in regard to developmental stages. The developmental dilemma is important to acknowledge because it rears its nasty head in the face of the student of psychology who is looking for a coherent Christian perspective of development or who hopes for integration between theology and psychology.

Developmental theories, whether they bend toward a biological, sociocultural or psychodynamic emphasis, all share a common commitment to a naturalistic worldview. The methodology of developmental psychology is to compare and contrast within cultural differences and crosscultural-ethnographic evidence in order to determine what is normative or possible in terms of human development.

At one level it might be argued that all developmental theories inherently possess either an explicit or implicit teleology. Thus, for example, *adaptation* might be proposed as the key teleological concept for Piaget's cognitive development theory, *pleasure seeking* and *ego integrity* in Freud's and Erikson's developmental theories respectively,

and *complexity* in neurological models of human development. Perhaps the closest to our theological understanding of teleology is given within the relational developmental systems paradigm. Lerner states, "Adaptive developmental regulation results in the emergence among young people of an orientation to transcend self-interest and place value on and commitments to actions supportive of their social system" (Lerner, Dowling & Anderson, 2003, p. 176). Although actions that support a specific social system will vary by culture and era, Lerner proposes that optimal development entails the capacity to reciprocate with one's self, family, community and society (Lerner, 2004; Lerner, Lerner, Bowers & Geldhof, 2015). In short, from a RDS (*relational developmental systems*) perspective, the goal of development might be considered a reciprocating self.

Although these theories suggest a teleology, in each case the teleology is limited by the possibilities provided by naturalistic assumptions. The question raised in the song made popular by the singer Peggy Lee was "Is That All There Is?" Are we to be content with a teleology of human development that is limited to the bounds of a naturalistic worldview? In understanding the purpose or goal of human development—is that all there is?

Before answering this question we suggest that two additional factors have also contributed to the current developmental dilemma.

The *first* barrier to the emergence of a more comprehensive theory of development is the presence of cultural and psychological therapies promoting the existence of an *empty self.* In *Constructing the Self, Constructing America,* Philip Cushman (1995) identifies the empty self as a result of the lack of a developmental teleology that would offer a solution other than self-focused therapies. He articulates how the development of modern psychotherapy is intertwined with the evolution of American consumerism and how both affect the way we perceive and experience the self. He describes how current

theories and therapeutic practices promote a sense of self with an insatiable need to consume in the interminable human quest for self-fulfillment and for self-realization. The American values of independence and self-fulfillment have led to the American psychotherapeutic culture that nurtures individuals who are focused on self-care and personal fulfillment. He critiques the American therapeutic community for promoting individuals who are preoccupied and in perpetual need of filling and fulfilling themselves. Despite Cushman's harangue, he gives no alternative, no teleology to cure this empty self.

In addition to the perpetuating empty self, modern philosophies' view of the human condition is the *second* factor contributing to the developmental dilemma. This empty self is a product of the modern project—the pursuit of truth, universals, freedom and control. The modern project has become the modern predicament, resulting in an era of fragmented, lonely, isolated people. One of the main moves of modernity has been to displace God from the transcendent to the immanent sphere, shifting the locus of the divine from a God who is Other to impersonal forces within the human mind and will—into human subjectivity. Playing a major role in this shift, Kant posits that the will is absolutely self-determining and infinite. By doing so he displaces the infinite divine will from the universe and makes the will a matter of a subjective, self-reflective process. The Creator is replaced by the created. Theologian-philosopher Colin Gunton describes the loss of sense of self as the result of self-reflection. He writes, "When individual self-contemplation becomes the basis of self, rather than the relation to the divine and human others on which our reality actually depends, the self *begins to disappear*" (Gunton, 1993, p. 118, italics added).

Perpetuating the image of humans as empty selves in need of filling is neither helpful nor healthful. And we contend it is not theologically accurate either.

It would be easy to address the teleological question strictly in theological terms. Thus the Westminster Shorter Catechism states that the goal of humanity is to know God and enjoy him forever. A more relevant answer for understanding the purpose or goal of development might be found in Gunton's quote above: the goal is found in a person's "relation to the divine and human other." Christian theology and social science theory converge to suggest that the self does not need to be viewed from the perspective of being empty but rather as a reciprocating self. In this book we turn to theological anthropology as a source for understanding both the process and goals of human development.

In the first edition of our book we listed a third factor that contributed to the developmental dilemma: the limited nature and fragmented scope of existing developmental theories.

> The enormous scope of material on human development can serve as a barrier to the emergence of a metatheory explaining development in its entirety. Consequently, existing theories describe aspects and portions of the developmental process—whether cognition in infants, identity development in adolescents or generativity in adulthood. As a result developmental theory lacks an organizing principle through which to understand and evaluate these theories. Psychological and sociological contributions may offer insights into developmental processes, but they do not provide a framework for understanding the goals or ends of development. (Balswick, King & Reimer, 2005, p. 18).

Since then, this barrier has been greatly reduced, if not eliminated, with the 2015 publication of the four-volume *Handbook of Child Development and Developmental Science*. In well over four thousand pages, a host of experts contributed

over one hundred chapters that detail the evidence for the *relational developmental systems* (RDS) paradigm. The RDS model seeks to incorporate all developmental theories with their accumulated research evidence into one unique whole, and thus the claim to paradigmatic status, a concept that is used to identify a dominant scientific view of a phenomena—in this, case human development. The key unifying concept of RDS is *relationality*, which is the exact conceptual basis for the *Reciprocating Self*. Parenthetically, we should add that in our first edition we included a significant explanation of *developmental systems theory*, which contains the core elements of what Lerner, Overton and others have developed and refined into *relational* developmental systems.

The Turn to Relationality

It is worth noting that in his book *The Trinity and an Entangled World: Relationality in Physical Science and Theology* (2010), the eminent Oxford University physicist-theologian John Polkinghorne leads a number of scholars in applying the concept of trinitarian relationality to understanding the workings of the entire universe. In wanting to better understand a small but important part of that universe, we propose that a theological understanding of development will provide a lens through which to view and understand human development as revealed by the scientific approach. This book seeks to provide a Christian response to the empty self by drawing on theological anthropology and RDS in order to provide an alternative view of selfhood—the *reciprocating self.*

In his book *Reforming Theological Anthropology: After the Philosophical Turn to Relationality,* F. LeRon Shults (2003) documents a paradigm shift in how social scientists, philosophers and theologians alike think about human nature. From Aristotle to Kant, the *substance* of particular things—

such as an individual person—was of primary importance. Since Kant, *relationality* has become the key focus. Shults states,

> The philosophical turn to relationality has shaped not only the way we think about knowing and being, but also our understandings of human acting. In the early modern period human (free) agency had been dualistically separated from (mechanistically determined) nature, and this split registered its effect on anthropological theories. In contemporary psychology . . . humans and communities are more often described in ways that recognize that their *relations* are constitutive. A person is no longer defined as an "individual substance of a rational nature" (Boethius) or as a "punctual self" (Locke). Instead of autonomous subjects that stand over against the natural world and other subjects, today human self-consciousness is understood as always and already embedded in relations between self, other, and world. (p. 31)

Another example of the move to relationality within theological anthropology can be seen in Stanley Grenz's book *The Social God and the Relational Self: A Trinitarian Theology of the Imago Dei* (2001). Like Shults, Grenz develops his theological anthropology by focusing on relationality as the key aspect of being human. As the subtitle to his book suggests, Grenz anchors his understanding of the human self in trinitarian theology. Grenz states, "Theological insights regarding the manner in which the three Trinitarian persons are persons-in-relation and gain their personal identity by means of their interrelationality hold promise for understanding what it means to be human persons in the wake of the demise of the centered self and the advent of the Global Soul" (p. 9).

As Grenz points out, the call to extend trinitarian theology to the understanding of the self is not new. It can be seen in Karl Barth's *Epistle to the Romans* (1918) and in the writings of such eminent theologians as Emil Brunner, Dietrich Bonhoeffer, Martin Buber, John Macmurry and James Torrance. Torrance (1989) argues, "What we need today is a better understanding of the person not just as an individual but as someone who finds his or her true being-in-communion with God and with others, the counterpart of a Trinitarian doctrine of God" (p. 15). The call to extend a trinitarian understanding of the self continues in the current writings of such theologians as Jürgen Moltmann (1996), Colin Gunton (1993), Miroslav Volf (1998), Ray Anderson (1982) and Gary Deddo (1999).

Following the turn to relationality that began in philosophical thought, there has been a near parallel focus on relationality in the thought of social scientists as well as theologians. Shults (2003) observes, "In psychology proper, the turn is most obvious in 'object relations' theory where the agential relation of a person to objects is essential to his or her development identity" (p. 31). The view of the self that was seen in terms of its *substance* has been replaced in developmental theories by a new view of the self that is seen in terms of a person's embeddedness in *relationships.*

Like the theologians cited above we believe a correspondence exists between relationality in the holy Trinity and relationality in human beings. The specific purpose of this book is to draw on the biblical view of relationality within the holy Trinity as a basis for understanding the human self. This biblical model allows us to assess the human self as an interactive being. This we identify as the *reciprocating self*—the self that, in all its uniqueness and fullness of being, *engages fully in relationship with another* in all its particularity.

There has been at least one previous attempt to accomplish what we seek to do in this book. Until his recent death, James Loder (1989, 1998) had sought to utilize a theological model in understanding the purpose of human development. Loder uses the concept of the *human spirit* in his discussion of human development. While he neither directly bases his analysis on trinitarian theology nor specifically defines what he means by *human spirit,* it is quite clear that he is using the term in a way similar to how we intend to use the term *reciprocating self.* Loder (1998) writes of the correspondence between the *human spirit* and the *divine spirit*, "Although distinctly different in origin, destiny, and magnitude, the human spirit and the Divine Spirit are made for each other, according to a relationality ultimately designed to replicate the relationality of the divine and the human in the person of Jesus" (p. 16). Note the common emphasis on the importance of relationality. Loder accepts what he calls a *differentiated relationality* of human spirit to Holy Spirit. He suggests that "the human spirit is to humanity what the Holy Spirit is to God (1 Cor. 2:10), so these two are interrelated according to the bipolar relationality" (p. 35). A reciprocating self is the internal self-structure that makes differentiated relationality possible.

Loder's discussion poses an interesting challenge to Christian psychologists who take seriously the substantial body of literature that demonstrates a connection between neurological activity in the brain with the mind, self and behavior. "Human spirit" in Loder's understanding might be easily transposed into an interpretation of "soul," yet we are reluctant to define the reciprocating self as a soul. Certainly a reciprocating self engaged in a vital relationship with God retains "soulish" characteristics. However, the reciprocating self in our understanding exists as an emerging aspect of embodied, personal identity understood in the context of relationship, both with God and

with others. This is a complex idea that requires additional consideration with regard to traditional notions of human nature.

Body, Soul and the Reciprocating Self

In Christian theology the concept of soul has been used to argue for the special uniqueness of human beings among all of God's creation. A body-soul dualism (or even a tripartite body-soul-spirit model) is a common way for Christians to understand human beings as unique and distinct created human spirits. In *radical dualism* the soul "is separable from the body, and the person is identified with the former" (Brown, Murphy & Malony, 1998, p. 24). In this view humans are seen as physical beings who also have a nonmaterial soul. Human beings experience God through the soul. Classic body-soul dualism had its origins in the philosopher Plato, but it can be traced through Augustine to Descartes. In a slightly modified view, *holistic dualism* holds that "the person is a composite of separable 'parts' but is to be identified with the whole, whose normal functioning is as a unity" (Brown, Murphy & Malony, 1998, p. 24). It is probably fair to say that most traditional Christian theologies have presented a version of one of these dualistic models.

A third way to solve the body-soul issue can be seen in the *eliminative/reductive materialism* model. In this model "the person is a physical organism, whose emotional, moral, and religious experiences will ultimately be explained by the physical sciences" (Brown, Murphy & Malony, 1998, p. 25). Donald MacKay calls this position "nothingbuttery," for within naturalistic assumptions, which this model is based on, human beings are nothing but material beings. This is the most common model within the natural and social sciences today.

In their book *Whatever Happened to the Soul* (1998), Brown, Murphy and Malony propose the rather radical-sounding suggestion that there is no such thing as *the* soul, but rather human beings are distinguished by their capacity to have *soulishness* (pp. 24-25). In this model of *nonreductive physicalism*, "the person is a physical organism whose complex functioning, both in society and in relation to God, gives rise to 'higher' human capacities such as morality and spirituality." In this model it is not necessary to postulate a second or third ontological entity (soul and mind) to account for brain capacities and distinctiveness. Soul and mind are understood as *physiologically embodied.* This model is nonreductive in the sense that human behavior cannot be exhaustively explained by analysis at the lowest level (bottom-up explanations). Rather, higher level (top-down) explanations supervene statements about the physiological. In this monist model, nature, body, soul, mind, spirit or any other description all refer to the same entity.

An important element in the nonreductive physicalism model is the concept of *emergent functions*, where new functions emerge out of the complexities of lower levels. A formal definition of an emergent function is *a mode of operation in a complex system that cannot be explained by scrutiny of lower levels, although it is dependent on the lower-level operation*. The interactive operation of lower systems results in the emergence of higher functioning. However, once a higher-level system emerges, it exerts top-down determinative influences on the operations of lower system levels.

In nonreductive physicalism there is no soul, but rather human beings have biologically embedded capacities that facilitate knowing and relating to God. This involves having the cognitive, affective, sensory (or perhaps otherwise) capacities needed to relate to God, others and self. A person does not have a soul, but rather in a sense, *is* soul. From this perspective, "soul," for human beings, is not a

separate spiritual entity, but rather is better understood as a constellation of physically embodied properties. Thus it is not an entity with distinctive existence, awareness and agency. These capacities that allow us to relate to God result from encounters between embodied humans and God (who is spirit) or with one another in a manner that reaches deeply into the essence of our creaturely, historical and communal selves. This does *not* suggest that God is *not* divine and transcendent, but offers an explanation of how God has created the human species with diverse capacities for relating to God.

In *Whatever Happened to the Soul?* we conceptualize soul as an emergent property of *personal relatedness.* Thus in his chapter "' Bodies—That Is, Human Lives': A Re-examination of Human Nature in the Bible," the New Testament scholar Joel Green points out that the concept of the soul in Scripture is primarily used to point to the capacity and experience of deep personal relatedness. Human uniqueness in God's creation is primarily due to the capacity for covenantal relationships. Green (1998) states that

> the Old Testament does not locate human uniqueness in a doctrine of a (potentially disembodied) soul, but emphasizes instead the character of humanity as God's covenant partner, his counterpart in relationship. The *imago Dei* tradition highlights the location of human beings within the larger human family, emphasizing the human's covenantal relationships with other humans, and situates the human family in meaningful relationship with other whole cosmos. (p. 172)

In chapter three we will elaborate on Green's suggestion that covenantal relationship is an important foundation for the reciprocating self's development. Perhaps more important than deciding how soul is defined—in terms of a person *having* a soul that engages with God or *being embodied persons*

with diverse capacities to know and relate to God—is to understand that soul needs to be referred to not as a substance but in terms of relationality. In his chapter in *Whatever Happened to the Soul?* (Brown, Murphy & Malony, 1998), Ray Anderson defined the soul "as that which represents the whole person as a physical, personal, and spiritual being, especially the inner core of an individual's life as created and upheld by God" (p. 193). Humans are unique from nonhuman creatures because they have been created to be in *relationship* with God. This intrinsic relationality is at the core of every individual human being and the basis for a reciprocating self.

This emphasis on embodiment is crucial. God, Godself, came and lived among humankind as Jesus Christ the Son of God. He ate. He washed feet. He related to friends and to those less friendly. Being embodied is messy, and so is human development. Relationality is messy. Ask any married person. Of theological and psychological importance is the fact that the reciprocating self grows in everyday places with real people, communities and environments. Development contends with messy issues such as poverty and inequality. The telos of reciprocity is evident today and unfolding into the future. The "today" aspect can quickly become complicated—such as playground bullies, neglectful parents and adolescent depression. A full-bodied understanding of developing as a reciprocating self affirms our biological nature, created in the image of God but created nonetheless. As a result, we integrate theological and psychological discussion of the reciprocating self with honest recognition that purposeful development is fearfully and wonderfully made of bone, genes and neurons.

The Plan of This Book

To accomplish our task we have divided this book into three parts. The first section offers an overview of theological approaches and psychological theories that we draw most heavily upon in our formulation of the reciprocating self. The second part provides an overview of the development of the reciprocating self through the various stages of the lifespan. The third and final section focuses on moral, religious and spiritual development and the role of congregations in promoting reciprocating selves.

The first chapter has served to introduce the concept of the reciprocating self, present our dilemma in teaching human development as Christians and to provide an overview of the volume. In the second chapter we provide the theological rationale behind the use of the concept of the reciprocating self. A trinitarian analogy of being and becoming serves as our model for understanding the goal of human development—becoming a reciprocating self. In addition, we offer a christological focus by emphasizing the importance of becoming like Christ as our unique selves in and through relationships.

Developmental theories give an understanding of how development takes place, but as we indicated previously, they tend to be limited in providing a teleological focus capable of pointing to the type of *relational context* in which human development ideally takes place. Chapter three seeks to provide a biblical basis for such an ideal relational context. The biblical depiction of God's relationship to human beings is used as a model for how God desires human beings to be in relationship with each other. We argue that a reciprocating self can develop best in a relational context that is characterized by *unconditional love commitment, gracing, empowering* and *intimacy.* The developing person is not only affected by but also affects the social context in which development takes place. Thus our model of human development is also one of reciprocal influence—of mutual

influence between the person and the external social structure or the environment.

Whereas no human developmental theory spells out the desired relational context as specifically as Scripture, there are significant aspects within each developmental theory that correspond to the biblical model we present. Thus chapters four and five provide a selected overview of developmental theories in light of their correspondence with our model. Chapter four focuses on the major developmental theories that give a perspective on infant and child development—psychoanalytic, object relations, social learning, symbolic interaction, cognitive-development theories and Vygotsky's social-context theory. Chapter four concludes by giving a comparative overview of the capacity of developmental theories to handle such human phenomena as choice and agency, sin and internal conflict, and communal aspects of personhood. In chapter five we give an overview of developmental theories that focus on the sociocultural context human development takes place in. Specifically we focus on Lerner and Overton's relational theory, Lerner's developmental systems theory, and Bronfenbrenner's ecological theory.

In part two we trace the development of the self from birth to death, noting the relational context in which the self develops and changes. Daniel Levinson (1996) notes that development is continual and can be at the same time as up (*adolescing*) or down (*senescing*). Here we encounter the *developmental dilemma*, namely, what criteria can be used to distinguish *adolescing* from *senescing*. The developmental teleology and the concept of the reciprocating self as presented in part one will serve as the underlying principles to follow human development throughout life.

Part two is divided into six sequential chapters, each devoted to a major human developmental lifespan stage. Each of the lifespan development chapters is organized according to the following outline. First, we give a brief overview of

the developmental tasks of the present stage of development. A description of the type of scaffolding typically needed during this developmental stage follows. This helps us to examine the nested contexts development takes place in. Specifically, we begin by describing the microsystem, that level where dyadic relationships are the core focus of attention. Next, our attention moves to the mesosystem: the important group contexts where development takes place. Then we take up the influence of the exosystem, those systems that impact an individual even though they are not a participant in the system. Finally, we examine the macrosystem as a cultural context for understanding human development. The last section of each chapter gives an overview of the potential strengths, limitations and developmental issues of the person as a reciprocating self.

In emphasizing a dimension of human development that is generally neglected—the theological—we obviously do not give proportional attention to the breath of physiological or socio-psycho-cultural factors that contribute to human development. Our bias can be seen in our attempt to move beyond the boundaries imposed by naturalistic assumptions and to consider the moral, spiritual and religious dimensions of human development. In part three we attempt to fill out these often-neglected developmental dimensions.

In chapter twelve we utilize such concepts as moral identity and moral transformation in attempting to move the understanding of moral development beyond a traditional cognitive stage-development model. Drawing on the notion of reciprocity, in chapter thirteen we propose conceptualizing faith, religious and spiritual development as *reciprocating spirituality* that emphasizes relationality, personal transformation and contribution.

Drawing on reciprocating spirituality, in chapter fourteen we suggest the concept of a *differentiated faith* as a means to personally conceptualize one’s own experience of faith in the context of the church. Chapter fourteen then focuses on

the nature of the reciprocating religious community. Based on the theological insights of such theologians as Jürgen Moltmann and Miroslav Volf we find the trinitarian model of relationality to be appropriately applicable to the lived-out body of Christ. Given the obvious focus in this book on development throughout human life, this chapter includes discussions of *intergenerational reciprocity* and *congregational differentiation.*

The source of the model we propose for the church—the body of Christ—is thus the same as for individual human development, which is not found in human wisdom but in the very relationality of our triune God, and in the relationship God seeks to establish with us.

2

The Reciprocating Self

A Trinitarian Analogy of Being and Becoming

GIVEN THE COMPLEXITY AND DEPTH of this theological subject and the limitations of a book addressing human development, this chapter summarizes the main points of a christological and trinitarian anthropology in order to propose a developmental teleology. From a christological perspective, we point to Jesus Christ as the perfect image of God and recognize that becoming like Christ is God's intention for all of humanity. How we are conformed to Christ occurs through and results in mutual, reciprocal relations with God, humans and creation. This we understand from a trinitarian perspective. We address the significance of the two relational polarities of the Trinity—particularity and relationality. Additionally, we explore reciprocity as the form of relationality exhibited among the three persons of the Trinity who exist as one being.

Within the social sciences there is a renewed interest in the realm of spirituality and religion (Pargament, Mahoney, Exline, Jones & Shafranske, 2013; King & Boyatzis, 2015). This provides opportunity for a dialogue between theologians and psychologists that has not occurred since the early 1900s. For most of the twentieth century, psychologists' commitment to modern science has precluded interest in spiritual, religious or theological issues related to human development (Kerestes & Youniss, 2002). Fortunately, things have changed a bit in the twenty-first century. Despite the increased interest in the relationship between the sciences and faith, there is a relatively small, albeit growing, body of research and theory on spiritual and religious development and a lack of theologically informed understanding of human development. Consequently, when teaching within a faith-based context, there are few sources to draw

on for elucidating two crucial issues related to development: (1) a biblical or theological perspective on good or optimal development, and (2) the psychological processes that are involved in spiritual or religious development. The former is of central concern to this book and will be addressed throughout. The latter is of specific interest to us (the authors) and will be addressed directly in chapter thirteen.

During the writing of the first edition of *The Reciprocating Self*, the field of systematic theology was in a major transition—especially as it related to theological anthropology. At that time of first publication, the theological Zeitgeist regarding the *imago Dei*, or the doctrine of the image of God, was beginning to be more often understood from a relational perspective and less from a structural or impersonal ontological perspective. This trend started to emerge with Karl Barth in the early 1900s and gained great momentum in the latter decades of the twentieth century, with growing consensus among theologians that the uniqueness of the *imago Dei* was best understood through categories of relationality rather than inert structure (see Anderson, 1982; Gunton, 2001; Grenz, 2001; Shults, 2003; Volf, 1996; Zizioulas, 1991; Webster, 2003 and others).

Currently, theological perspectives are perhaps best understood as more expansive and less apt to limit the *imago Dei* to a single concept such as relationality, but rather emphasize that the image of God may be more fully understood from functional, directional and dynamic perspectives (see King & Whitney, 2015). More said on all this shortly. In the meantime, we note that the current theological climate continues to create opportunities for dialogue between psychology and theology in regard to human development.

Within this book, our primary intention is to provide an integrated perspective of human development. By *integrated* we mean to draw on theology and developmental science as resources for understanding the processes and goals involved in human development. We hope to offer the reader a means of understanding what good or optimal development might be through presenting a *developmental teleology,* or a theological understanding of the goal of development.

Until the recent movements of positive psychology and positive youth development, defining good or optimal development has not been a traditional task of the psychological sciences. Similarly, psychology has not focused on teleological issues (Csikszentmihalyi & Rathunde, 1998; Lerner, Dowling & Anderson, 2003; Lerner et al.,

2015). In general, developmental theories describe processes of specific domains of psychological development (e.g., cognitive development, identity development) and processes of normative development. For example, Erik Erikson's psychosocial stages suggest normal developmental benchmarks for the eight stages of the life cycle. In addition, developmental theories also describe pathological development, or that which deviates from the norm (Cicchetti, 2015). In fact, the field of psychology has predominantly focused on pathology and healing mental illness. Although historically different theorists (Antonovosky, 1987; Jahoda, 1958; Erikson, 1959) and recent efforts within positive psychology (see Benson & Scales, 2009; Damon, 2004; Lerner, 2006; Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000) have explored positive aspects of psychology, a disproportionate amount of scientific psychology has focused on pathology and repair, rather than positive or optimal development.

This emphasis on disease and treatment is more natural for the field of psychology. Given the limited "tools" of psychology as a scientific field of inquiry based on the modern values of reductionism and universals, making claims about *ideal* development is a challenge. When discussing and defining "ideals," values and ideology are invoked. Disciplines that address issues of ultimacy such as theology and philosophy are better equipped to define ideals. The healing approach in psychology has been facilitated by the fact that it is easier to define the desired or adaptive direction of change if the goal is to restore an earlier or "normal" state. It is much messier to define optimal development without engaging diverse cultural or ideological opinions. Thus, it is conceptually simpler to restore normal functioning and bring persons back to an original state than to determine what is good or optimal.

Psychology does not have the epistemological tools to address issues of teleology. Aspinwall and Staudinger (2003) point out that if psychologists intend to define good or optimal development, they must address several difficult questions. For example, do they determine optimal development based on adaptiveness or human functioning? If so, how do psychologists operationalize adaptiveness or functioning? Do they use subjective indicators and ask people for their subjective opinion if they are doing well or are mature? Or do they use objective measures and examine factors like longevity and define optimal development by those who live the longest? Do psychologists consult value or ethical systems? Do they consider

democratic ideals as a lens for viewing good development? Do they consider the virtues of Aristotelian ethics? These are questions traditionally asked by theologians and philosophers, not psychologists.

Furthermore, psychologists tend to follow a consensus criterion of truth, not absolute truth. As scientists, psychologists turn to empirical research to determine what people generally agree on. Consequently, truth is not deemed absolute but is determined by consensus opinion. This is referred to as "normative" or "conventional." For example, research on wisdom has reliably demonstrated high levels of consensus or agreement about whether or not a judgment satisfies the definition of wisdom. In this case the research identifies the consensus understanding of wisdom and does not have to define wisdom based on one philosophical tradition or another.

The *Imago Dei* and Human Development

However, as Christian psychologists we have an advantage. We are not only scientists but also believers in a creation that reflects something of its Creator and Redeemer. We are not limited to the resources of psychology, but can tap into the resources of our theology. Although both these two traditions address issues pertaining to maturity and growth as humans, they are not parallel lines of inquiry and do not address questions of human nature on the same level.

A Christian theological anthropology provides a worldview in which psychological theory can be critically engaged and shaped. The Bible offers a symbolic world that creates perceptual categories through which we can interpret reality (Hays, 1996). Our aim is to propose a developmental teleology—a theological understanding of becoming a complete human being. We recognize that Jesus Christ is the perfect image (Col 1:15 NIV) and acknowledge that God's goal or purpose for humankind is to become conformed to Christ. Please note, *conformity* to Christ does not mean *uniformity* with Christ. As we discuss further below, we are all unique creations, and we are to become more like Christ as our unique selves. In my (Pam) spiritual direction group, members often remind each other, "Jesus in you looks a lot like you." We are all given a unique constellation of gifts, strengths

and passions—and we become like Christ with these distinctions. So if we are to become *like Christ*, rather than to *become Christ*—what does this mean? How do we become conformed to Christ or like Christ?

To answer this question, we propose an understanding of ideal personhood in light of the interrelations of the triune God. In doing so we draw upon a theological analogy, warranted by the doctrine of the *imago Dei*, that makes a comparison from the unique trinitarian persons in relationship to human persons being and becoming in relationship (Gunton, 1993). This theologically grounded analogy, then, provides us a worldview or lens through which we can examine various developmental theories to see how they may contribute to our understanding of the human being as reciprocating self.

The theological inquiry of the likeness of God found in human nature is referred to as theological anthropology. Theological anthropology is the pursuit of a biblical understanding of being human and is a core facet of systematic theology. Theological anthropology may take as its starting point the affirmation that humans are made according to *imago Dei* (Latin for "image of God"), found in Genesis 1:26-27:

> Then God said, "Let us make humankind in our image, according to our likeness. . . ."
> So God created humankind in his image,
> in the image of God he created them;
> male and female he created them. (Gen 1:26-27)

Much ink has been spilled on interpreting what that "image," or "likeness," means. What does it mean to bear the image of God? Does being human mean being a part of a family? Does it have to do with being male and female? Being a certain ethnicity? Does it include things such as playing or having a sense of humor?

Within the field of systematic theology debates continue regarding accepted interpretations of the *imago Dei.* Traditionally, the *imago Dei* was viewed from a structural perspective and thought to refer to certain characteristics or capacities inherent in the structure of human nature (Grenz, 2001; Shults, 2003). From this perspective humans reflect the image of God because they possess within the substantive form of human nature one or some of the qualities God possesses. Theologians have not always agreed on the specific feature(s) found in the human nature that marks the divine image and thus makes humans similar to God. Culture and context have often

played a part in theologians' interpretations of what specific characteristic(s) comprise the image of God. Reason, will and love have always been contenders for the attribute indicative of the image of God.

However, this static structural view of the *imago Dei* is no longer unquestionably accepted as the correct view of theological anthropology. As the Christian tradition developed in dialogue with Western philosophical trends, the *imago Dei* passages were directed toward application to the *individual* self. During the last century, however, this emphasis on the *individual* self has been challenged. With the resurgence in the study of the Trinity—the threeness of the one God—an anthropology of the *relational* self has emerged. The perspective of the *imago Dei* presented in this volume draws on the relational understanding of the Trinity. With the teaching and authority of Scripture as our basis, we utilize the works of theologians such as Ray Anderson, Colin Gunton, Miroslav Volf, Stanley Grenz, Karl Barth, F. LeRon Shults, Katherine Tanner and others who share this relational understanding of the *imago Dei.*

Being created according to the image of God is very important to a Christian view of human development. Grenz (2001) contends, "Throughout much of Christian history, the link made in scripture between humans and the divine image has served as the foundation for the task of constructing a Christian conception of the human person or the self" (p. 183). Interpretation of the *imago Dei* strongly influences our understanding of what it means to be human. Consequently it has a significant bearing on our understanding of the processes and goals of human development.

The doctrine of the Trinity reveals that God exists as Father, Son and Holy Spirit. The three divine persons of the Godhead live in unity as one, yet remain three distinct persons. The communion of the Godhead does not compromise the distinctiveness of the three. In this way, *particularity* and *relatedness* co-occur because their relatedness is characterized by perfect *reciprocity* where the three live with and for each other. In the following paragraphs we conclude that to live as beings made in the image of God is to exist as reciprocating selves—as unique individuals living in relationship with others. We then assert that developmental teleology, the goal of human development as God intends, is the reciprocating self. To live according to God's design is to glorify God as a distinct human

being in communion with God and others in mutually giving and receiving relationships.

Within the Trinity there is unity and uniqueness (or diversity). In trinitarian theology relatedness comes hand in hand with particularity. The theological concept of *perichoresis* refers to the mutual indwelling within the Godhead, meaning that the three persons of the Trinity dwell with and within each other. Thus it describes a mode of being in communion that does not sacrifice difference or diversity. "God is what he is only as a communion of persons, the particularity of whom remains at the center of all he is, for each has his own distinctive way of being" (Gunton, 1993, p. 191). John Zizioulas (1991) writes that the being of God is not some blank unity but a being in communion. The particularity of Father, Son and Spirit is as vital as their unity as one. In addition, there is an ontological interdependence and reciprocity of three persons of the Trinity.

The Gospel of John emphasizes this conception of relatedness without absorption (Gunton, 1993). In the Fourth Gospel, Jesus the Son talks more about his relationship with the Father than he does in the Synoptic Gospels (Smith, 1995). Jesus claims simultaneous communion with and distinction from the Father. He paradoxically claims a degree of equality with the Father and that "the Father is greater than I" (Jn 14:28). Jesus testifies how he has no independent status apart from the Father. The Son does nothing by himself but only follows the actions of the Father (Jn 5:19). He has no independent will or judgment, for "there is complete unity of action between Father and Son, and complete dependence of the Son on the Father" (Barrett, 1978, p. 257). The Son reflects the character of the Father to the extent that to see Jesus is to see the Father (Jn 14:9). John's depiction of Jesus clearly provides one of the main meanings of sonship: essential identity with the Father (Barrett, 1978). Jesus later attests to the unity of Father and Son when he prays, "You, Father, are in me and I am in you" (Jn 17:21). Not only does Jesus testify to the unity of the Father and Son but also to the distinction between the two. The Gospel clarifies that the Father has committed the power to give life and the responsibility of judgment to the Son. Making the case that the Father and the Son share unity within diversity, Jesus tells the disciples, "For just as the Father has life in himself, so he has granted the Son also to have life in himself" (Jn 5:26).

Theology of Particularity

These passages suggest that the divine Being includes particularity and relationality. We will first develop a theology of particularity. Inherent in the *imago Dei* is the value of uniqueness. God exists as three distinct persons—the Father, Son and Holy Spirit. One is never compromised by another. The Father remains the Father; the Son remains the Son; and the Spirit remains the Spirit, each contributing uniquely to salvation history. Yet at the same time the three remain one. However, the unity of the Trinity does not jeopardize the uniqueness of the Father, Son and Spirit (Torrance, 1989, 1992). Through the Nicene Creed we affirm the unique relations among the members of the Trinity:

> We believe in one God,
> the Father, the Almighty,
> maker of heaven and earth. . . .
> We believe in one Lord, Jesus Christ,
> the only Son of God, . . .
> For us and for our salvation . . .
> We believe in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the giver of life,
> who proceeds from the Father and the Son.

At the heart of orthodox theology is the recognition of the coherence of the different activities attributed to the Father, Son and Holy Spirit. For example, it is the Holy Spirit that takes the lead enabling us to participate in the Son's ongoing life of worship of the Father. Our salvation and our glorification of God is not possible without each member of the Trinity.

The significance of uniqueness is further demonstrated through the work of the Spirit. Our Christian tradition often emphasizes the unifying work of the Spirit. The Spirit draws persons through Christ to the Father, and it is the Spirit that unifies the communion of saints. It is important to recognize that although the Spirit is the reconciling and unifying agent at work in human-divine relationships and among humans, such work does not abolish but rather maintains or even strengthens particularity. We are unified not for assimilation or homogenization but for relationship with others—relationship that does not subvert but establishes and affirms the other, whether God or humans (Gunton, 1993). Through the same Spirit individuals are given different gifts—healing, wisdom, prophecy, preaching,

discernment, speaking in tongues—and these gifts are given "for the common good" (1 Cor 12:7). These unique gifts contribute to our unity. The body of believers finds completeness in our diversity. Paul pointedly asks, "If the whole body were an eye, where would the hearing be? If the whole body were hearing, where would the sense of smell be?" (1 Cor 12:17). The particularities enable a unified whole.

As the analogy of the body and its many parts illustrates, relatedness comes hand in hand with particularity. For there is no distinction without unity. The personal identities of the members of the Trinity emerge out of their relationships. By definition there is no father without a son. An individual recognizes his or her uniqueness in relationship with another. In a sense the other provides an orientation for the self to be made known. I (Pam) have always told my classes that after I got married I began to know myself more fully and see my "particularities" more clearly. The closer and more intimately I have grown with my husband, the more I have learned about myself. It is in relationship with another that we more fully encounter—not only the other but ourselves. Spouses are excellent for helping us see our particularities! My experience of marriage has been like looking into a mirror. The closer I draw near to the mirror (in this instance my husband), the more I notice not only all the personality blemishes but also my strengths, unique aspects of my personality and my identity.

Theology of Relationality

Although Christians affirm the distinct members of the Trinity, Christianity is a monotheistic faith. We believe in one God. One of the greatest mysteries of the Christian faith is our understanding of the triune nature of God—that God can be simultaneously one being and three persons. Karl Barth (1975) wrote, "The divine modes of being mutually condition and permeate one another so completely that one is always in the other two" (p. 370). Although the three are distinct, they are not separate; they exist with and for each other. John commences his Gospel with this astounding reality: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (Jn 1:1). John testifies to the *distinction between* and *unity of* the Father and Son. Not only was the Father with the Word (the

Son), but the Word was God. We have already seen that Jesus witnesses to the unity of the Father and the Son by recounting not only his utter dependence on the Father but also by declaring that those who see the Son see the Father.

Thus we understand that relationality is at the heart of the Trinity. Human beings reflect this relationality. Just as God exists in relationship, humans are to exist in relationship: "To be human is to be created in and for relationship with divine and human others" (Gunton, 1993, p. 222). This concept is broadly represented in the New Testament. All believers are called by God to be a part of a relational community, placed in the body of Christ by the Spirit (1 Cor 12:13). In reminding us that community is what God intends, Bonhoeffer (1954) suggests that "Christian brotherhood is not an ideal we must realize; it is rather a reality created by God in Christ in which we may participate" (p. 30). For theologian Stan Grenz (2002), the image of God does not lie in the individual, but in the relationality of the persons in community.

The Importance of Reciprocity

Reciprocity is the glue that holds the relational polarities of uniqueness and unity together. Unity and uniqueness—in reciprocity—are at the heart of the triune God. The three persons remain unique through their mutual interrelatedness. The theological term *perichoresis* (coinherence, mutual indwelling) was applied to the Trinity to capture the unique nature of these reciprocal interrelations. Each person of the Trinity finds being in each other without coalescence. Reflections of the reciprocity between the Father and the Son can be found, for example, in the Gospel of John. The Father and the Son are one, and the Son was also sent by the Father. The Father has committed both the bestowal of life and the responsibility of judgment to the Son. Yet the Son judges and wills only as the Father does. The Father gives power and authority to the Son, and the Son reciprocates by following the Father's example.

The reciprocal dynamic is further seen in the high priestly prayer of John 17. Jesus prays, "Father, I desire that those also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory, which you have given me because you loved me before the foundation of the world" (Jn 17:24). The Father lavishes divine love on the Son and

thus glorifies him. In turn the Son reciprocates the love received from the Father and in this manner glorifies the Father eternally (Gunton, 1993, p. 327). This is not an example of codependent back scratching—I'll give you glory if you give me glory. Rather, in love the Father gives life to the Son, and the Son chooses of his own will to glorify the Father.

Moltmann (1996) nicely summarizes, "According to the Christian doctrine of the Trinity the three divine Persons exist with one another, for one another and in one another. They exist in one another because they mutually give each other space for full unfolding. By existing mutually in each other, they form their unique trinitarian fellowship" (p. 298). The mutual reciprocity among the Father, Son and Spirit allows them to experience diversity within union—to experience simultaneous unity and uniqueness. Within the Trinity there is no impinging on one another. They each contribute uniquely to their united working. The particularity of Father, Son and Spirit is as vital as their relatedness. Through the Spirit we participate in the Son's life of communion with the Father (Torrance, 1989, 1992).

Theological anthropology suggests that bearing the image of God means living as unique individuals in reciprocating relationships with others. To be human is to be a particular being in relationships, distinct and unique, yet inseparably bound up with the other, for "all particulars are formed by their relationship to God and the creator and redeemer and to each other" (Gunton, 1993, p. 207). Particularity is discovered in relationship with our Creator, our Redeemer, our Sustainer and with each other. If humankind is to realize its created intention, humankind must then be understood as "socialkind" (Gunton, 1993). It is the self's encounter with divine and human other that enables it to realize its uniqueness. To be human is to be in relationship with another. Humans experience their unique selves most fully when in a healthy relationship with God or another. Macmurray (1961) states, "Persons constitute each other, make each other what they are" (p. 17). In Luke 17:20-21, Jesus proclaims, "The kingdom of God is among you," suggesting to some commentators that God's reign is initially evident in the relationships between believers and only a sign of what is to become—or to develop.

This relational understanding of the *imago Dei* suggests that being human involves living in reciprocating, authentic relationships with

others. Following the pattern of the trinitarian relationships, such relationships are characterized by mutuality, give and take, and they enable the self to be known most fully in the process of knowing another. In such relationships there is space to simultaneously be oneself and to be in relationship with each other. There is room to encounter the other and to encounter the self through the other. The self is never lost in face of the other. The other does not impinge on the self, but the other promotes the presence of the self. In the reciprocating relationship there is give and take, and take and give. A high view of both the self and other is required to value the giving and the receiving. In mathematics the definition of *reciprocal* reflects this simultaneous distinction within unity. According to *Webster's Dictionary*, a reciprocal is "a pair of quantities whose product is unity." We could say that to be human is to live as unique quantities whose product is unity.

Who cannot help but pause and say, "Yes, that's it!" As humans we all long to be known, to have the deepest and darkest parts of our soul and psyche uncovered, affirmed and loved. We all long to be loved and to know we are special—or even just okay. The deepest parts of ourselves rejoice when we read Psalm 139, poetically describing our uniquely created self as a wonderful work of the living God:

> For it was you who formed my inward parts;
> you knit me together in my mother's womb.
> I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
> Wonderful are your works;
> that I know very well.
> My frame was not hidden from you,
> when I was being made in secret,
> intricately woven in the depths of the earth. (Ps 139:13-15)

Everything is created by God to be and become what it is, and not another. We are distinct and particular beings.

This concept of the reciprocating self can be graphically illustrated in a common tradition in Christian wedding ceremonies—the lighting of the unity candle. In this ritual the families of the bride and groom each light a candle symbolizing the life of the bride and groom, respectively. During the ceremony the bride and groom take their respective candles and simultaneously light another candle as a

symbol of their lives coming together as one. One of my (Pam) most profound pastoral pet peeves is when, after lighting the unity candle, the bride and groom then blow out their individual candles. I want to scream at the top of my lungs, "No! Stop! Don't blow yourself out. You keep on continuing!" Marriage is not about the abolition of the uniqueness of the two coming together as one. It is the unity of two distinct lives. Marriage at its best brings two individuals together through the Spirit in Christ to glorify God through a new life together and simultaneously enables each individual to become the person that God created them to be. By lighting the unity candle and allowing the individual flames to burn (and thus enacted correctly), this ritual beautifully illustrates our understanding of the reciprocating self.

An important nuance to this reciprocity is highlighted by recent "functional" interpretations of the *imago*. This approach emphasizes how humans are to relate to the rest of creation and is based on the commission that God gave Adam and Eve in Genesis. This interpretation suggests that bearing the image of God is apparent when human beings *act*—when they rightly exercise the authority that God has given to them (Mouw, 2012). Harry Kuitert (1972) describes humans as "covenant partners," which emphasizes a "role" that humans have been given by God to take on as God's living image. From this perspective, our call as humans is to be image bearers, and we do so by being covenant partners. "Covenant" emphasizes the importance of relationships, while "partnership" points to the privilege and responsibility of living with God, fellow humans and creation.

This view is not only consistent with our suggestion of the reciprocating self, but nicely amplifies the honor and responsibility we have in relating to not just God and fellow humans, but also to the rest of creation. Although a concern at the time of writing the first edition of this book, environmental mindfulness is a dominant social issue for people today. For example, seminal to characteristics descriptive of millennials is living in awareness of their environmental impact. Millennials are known for recycling, shopping locally and carrying water bottles. (No doubt, we see more reusable water bottles in our classes these days!) We affirm this trend and acknowledge that living as a reciprocating self includes living as covenant partners with the natural order. Joel Green (2004) helpfully summarizes, "Our human vocation [is] given and enabled by God, to relate to God as God's partner in covenant and to join in

companionship of the human family and in relation to the whole cosmos in ways that reflect the covenant love of God. [This] is realized in and modeled by Jesus Christ" (p. 197).

It is important to step back and clarify a couple of points that could be misconstrued regarding the *imago Dei.* Although some theologians suggest that human nature is endowed with the image of God, we are not equipped to comment with certainty about the substantive nature of the *imago*. That said, we align with nonreductive physicalists[1] (see Brown & Strawn, 2012) and can safely say that humans image God when they live in reciprocity with God, humans and the rest of the created order. From this perspective reciprocity is both the means and the end of human life. Our telos, God's goal for humans, is to live in perfect reciprocity with God, others and creation (though this will fully occur on the other side of eternity!), and the means by which we realize this is through relating to God, others and creation.

Developmental psychology describes in detail the importance of relationships for human development at every stage of the lifespan. Recent psychological research on spiritual development also highlights the developmental importance of transcendence—the awareness of our connection or relationship to God (King & Boyatzis, 2015; Miller, 2015). In addition, at the heart of the gospel is a God who desired to relate to his creation in such a profound manner that God became human and sacrificed his beloved son in order to be in communion with us. We understand our salvation to be dependent on our relationship with God—upon receiving and accepting this gift of grace from God. As a response to this magnanimous gift we offer our lives as living sacrifices (Rom 12:1). Our lives as Christians are based on an ongoing love relationship with God. Furthermore, it is through the ongoing work of the Holy Spirit in and through us, and through our response to the Spirit, that we are brought closer to the likeness of Christ.

This view can be described as a "dynamic understanding" of the *imago* and argues that the image is not a static capacity or ability, but rather that the image of God becomes apparent through human interactions with each other, God and creation (King & Whitney, 2015). From this perspective it might be more helpful to discuss *how* humans image God, rather than *what* the image is. The first is a verb, suggesting that imaging God involves action, whereas the latter is a noun and suggests the image is an entity. This dynamic perspective

also stresses that imaging God is a dynamic or ongoing process. Through the ongoing work of the Spirit we image God more fully as we grow in unity with God and others.

We couple this dynamic understanding with a directional understanding that emphasizes that imaging God is on a trajectory and headed toward becoming more like Christ as we live out the relatedness modeled by the Trinity. This is our telos. Although we do not come to completion/perfection in our earthly lives, through the work of the Spirit, the Sustainer and Perfecter of our faith, we live more fully the life of love that Christ exemplified. We were created with the capacity for transformation, and thus Jesus is the pattern for humanity (Crisp, in press). The old nature is what we have become as a result of sin, while the new nature is what we are becoming as the result of being conformed to the image of Christ. The ideal for humanity is characterized by compassion, kindness, gentleness, patience, forbearance, forgiveness, love, peaceableness, thankfulness and inspiration by Christ' s Word (Marshall, 2001, p. 56).

Turning to another potential point of confusion, although through our interactions with God and others human beings reflect the triune nature, human beings are not constituted by the triune nature. We recognize that God is triune and human beings are not (Anderson, 1982). Humans are not identical with the *imago* but bear the *imago.* Nor are we trying to build the case that individual humans are composed of three entities, aspects or functions—whether they are Father, Son and Spirit; id, ego and superego; or body, mind and spirit. This is not our intention. We are suggesting that to bear the *imago Dei* is to reflect the Trinity' s unity and uniqueness within our own relations with the divine and the human other. The relational life of the triune God is not represented *within* ourselves but *among* ourselves.

The Self and the Divine Other

We are created to be in relationship with God. This relationship is to be characterized by uniqueness, unity and reciprocity. Similar to the interrelationships within the Trinity, humans are to experience simultaneous communion with God that does not jeopardize our particularity.

Throughout the Bible, God continually affirms human uniqueness. Jesus' interaction with the woman at the well in Samaria (Jn 4:1-42) illustrates this point. He interacts with her as a unique individual with specific needs. He recognizes and accepts her as a woman and a Samaritan. He not only addresses the felt need of her thirst, but he speaks to her specific emotional and relational problems. Jesus also gradually reveals his own unique identity. The woman recognizes him first as a Jew, then as a rabbi and finally as a prophet. Jesus responds by declaring his distinct status as the Messiah and the means by which to worship God. In this interaction, both the particularities of the woman and of Christ remain intact. The encounter between Jesus and the woman at the well also illustrates reciprocal giving—Christ recognizes the woman's needs and offers to quench her spiritual thirst. She in turn goes out and proclaims the truth given by Jesus and draws others to believe and worship Jesus.

A person's relationship with God is characterized by the uniqueness of both the created and the Creator, and the unity between the two. This is evident when Jesus prays, "As you, Father, are in me and I am in you, may they also be in us" (Jn 17:21). Throughout the Bible life is found in Christ—not on our own: "I came that they may have life, and have it abundantly" (Jn 10:10). Full life is found in relationship with Christ. The Spirit's role in this is to "realize the true being of each created thing by bringing it, through Christ, into saving relation with God the Father" (Gunton, 1993, p. 189). We are most human when we are jointly united to Christ through the Holy Spirit, enabling us to participate in the Son's union with and glorification of the Father. Grenz (2001) declares that this is the telos for which we were created: "Glorifying the Father in the Son together with all creation is the ultimate expression of the *imago Dei* and therefore marks the *telos* for which humans were created in the beginning" (p. 327).

The goal of our lives—the point of human life—is to glorify the Father in the Son and through the Spirit. Being drawn into the worship life of the Trinity not only involves the glorification of God but also includes the glorification of all creation, for "by being drawn into the dynamic of the triune life, the new humanity participates in this eternal reciprocal glorification" (Grenz, 2001, p. 327). In the end the Spirit will bring together all believers with all of creation, gathering them into the Son, the one in whom all things "hold together" or find interconnectedness (Col 1:17). Thus

while the Spirit leads those who are found "in Christ" to glorify the Father through the Son, the Father glorifies them in the Son by the Spirit (Grenz, 2001). Because Christ and his people are unified as one, his people will also share in his glorification (Hoekema, 1986).

It is a marvel that in this union and reciprocity with the life of the Trinity, human particularity is not lost. In our relationship with God we not only encounter the living God, but we become most fully ourselves. Just as within the Godhead the three persons, Father, Son and Holy Spirit, exist with, for and in one another, so God does this with creation, giving us the space we need to be ourselves while remaining in relation to him: God's indwelling presence gives to created beings forever the "wide space in which there is no more cramping" (Moltmann, 1996, p. 308). God acts not as a dominating Other but the One in whom we live and move and have our being. Moltmann (1996) explains that relatedness to God does not threaten the distinctiveness of creation—"It is neither necessary for the world to dissolve into God, as pantheism says, nor for God to be dissolved in the world, as atheism maintains. God remains God, and the world remains creation" (p. 307). Our relationship with God does not sacrifice our particularity, but rather it allows us to become more fully who God created us to be. Trinitarian theology reminds us that we are most human when Jesus Christ brings us into the presence of the Father, drawing us to him by the Holy Spirit.

A graphic counterexample is of the early desert followers known as the pillar saints. These monastic saints permanently perched upon tall pillars, raising and lowering food and supplies to live. In this way their quest for holiness and closeness to God was minimally disturbed. But, according to our relational understanding of the *imago Dei*—to live in the likeness of God is to live as distinct individuals in relationship with God and fellow believers—these pillar saints only got it half right. Yes, they nobly dedicated their lives to communion with God, but they neglected fellowship and Christian community. They missed out on part of their God-designed nature.

Perhaps a better image than a pillar for the Christian life is the cross. For when we look at the cross, our eyes are directed heavenward toward God, and we are reminded that our humanity is found in our relationship with God. Simultaneously, just as Christ stretched out his arms on the cross, our eyes are directed

horizontally, reaching to our fellow sisters and brothers. To be human is not to live in exclusive relationship with God but to live in relationship with God *and* humans. For it is in and through these relationships that we not only grow to become the unique persons that God created us to be, but we will enable others to become who God created them to be, all the while participating in the life of the Son, through the Spirit, bringing glory to the Father.

The Self and the Human Other

To bear the image of God is to live in reciprocating relationships with God and our fellow human beings. Martin Buber, a Jewish theologian, referred to this type of relationship as an "I-Thou" relationship. Buber's (1970) theological anthropology was that human beings are to be in relationships where a whole self, the *I*, is in mutual relationship with a whole other, the *Thou*. This supposes an authentic personal encounter of both the I and the Thou. One is not dominant; the other is not inferior. The relationship is characterized especially by the reciprocity of communication. Buber starkly contrasted I-Thou with I-it ways of relating—the former being appropriate to the way a person should relate to humans and God, the latter the way to relate properly to the impersonal natural world. Buber regarded relating to persons as if they were things as a violation of humanity and God. Engaging in such I-it relationships among persons, the I could only experience him- or herself as superior, while also failing to see the other as a whole self and experiencing the other only as an impersonal it. Both persons were thereby dehumanized.

In an I-Thou relationship a person would acknowledge and respect the difference between themselves and others while maintaining a communicative relationship with them. They would experience unity in their mutual recognition of being Thou to each other but each remain personally distinct as I. Only in the context of encountering the other as Thou does the self truly encounter itself. In such a relationship, both "persons encounter their own being in the other" (Anderson, 1982, p. 46). Buber (1970) writes, "I require a Thou to become; becoming I, I say Thou" (p. 62).

Using Buber's theory of relatedness, we present a circumplex model (figure 2.1) in order to illustrate the reciprocating self and

its violations. The names of the four models of relatedness are derived from Buber's writing on the I-Thou relationship and are to be interpreted according to the theological anthropology we have been presenting. We also offer a number of artistic expressions that capture much of the contrasting qualities of relationality we are here considering.

These four models of relatedness are presented in a circumplex model that is organized on two axes. The two axes represent the view of the self and the view of the other. The *x* axis represents a continuum of the perception of self. The high end indicates having a strong and secure sense of self, and the low end indicates an unclear and insecure sense of self. The *y* axis represents the view of the other. The high end suggests a recognition of a unique other that is both recognized and respected. The upper-right quadrant, indicated by a high sense of self and other, represents the I-Thou relationship. The lower-right quadrant, measured by a higher view of self than other, represents the I-it relationship; the lower-left quadrant indicates a low sense of self and other, representing the dissociated it-it relationship; and finally the upper-left quadrant represents the it-thou relationship, suggesting a lower view of self than other.

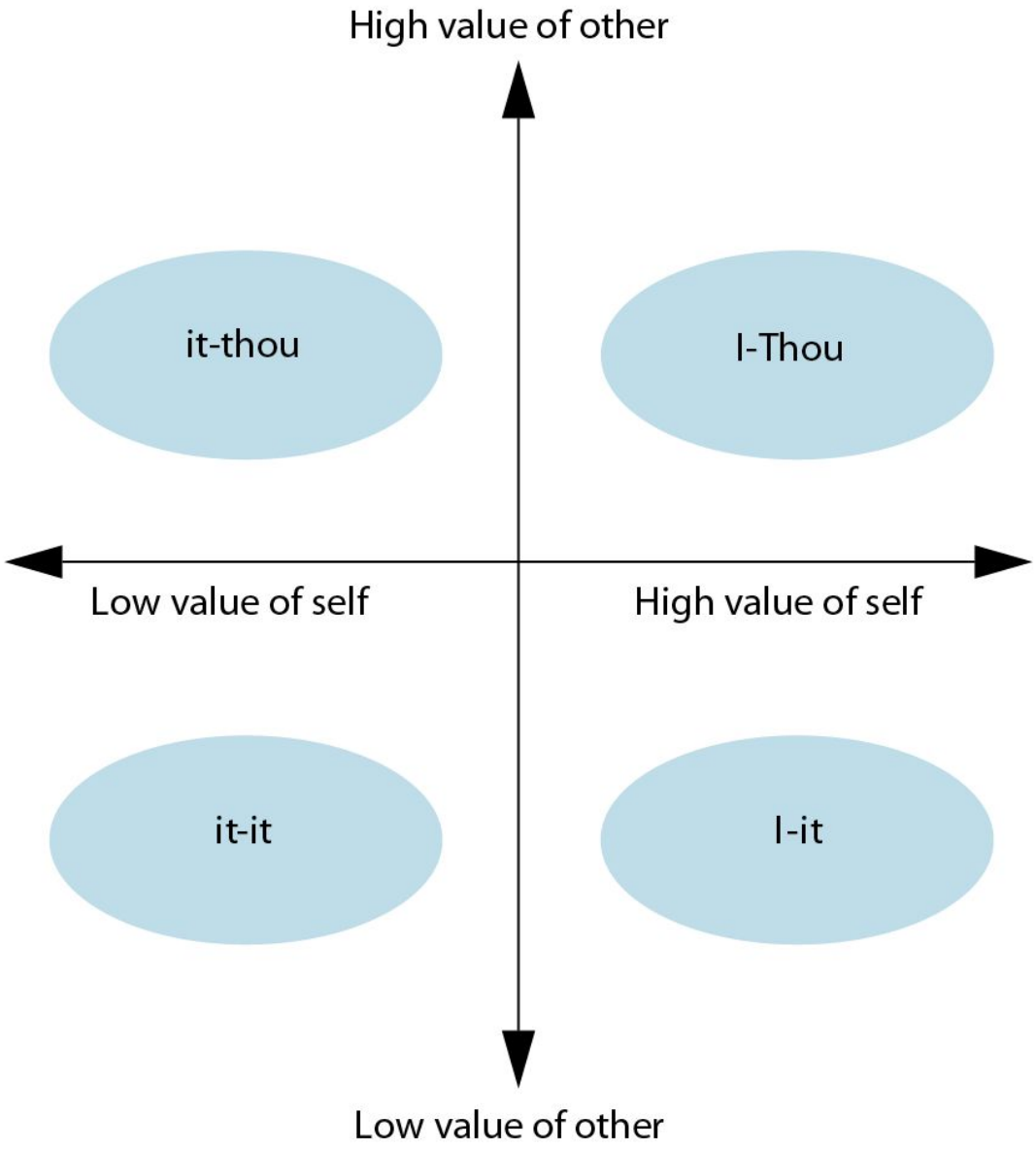


Figure 2.1. Circumplex model

I-Thou relationship. The upper-right quadrant represents the I-Thou relationship, which is characterized by a high view of the self and a high view of the other. As explained by Buber, the I-Thou relationship simultaneously facilitates uniqueness and unity. The self and other both experience the presence of the other in such a way that enables both to develop. Ideally neither impingement nor domination occurs in the context of the relationship. Rather, both

the self and other are recognized and appreciated as unique, differentiated selves. Such a relationship enables the self and other to become more fully what God created them to be and to experience their particularity more fully in their unity.

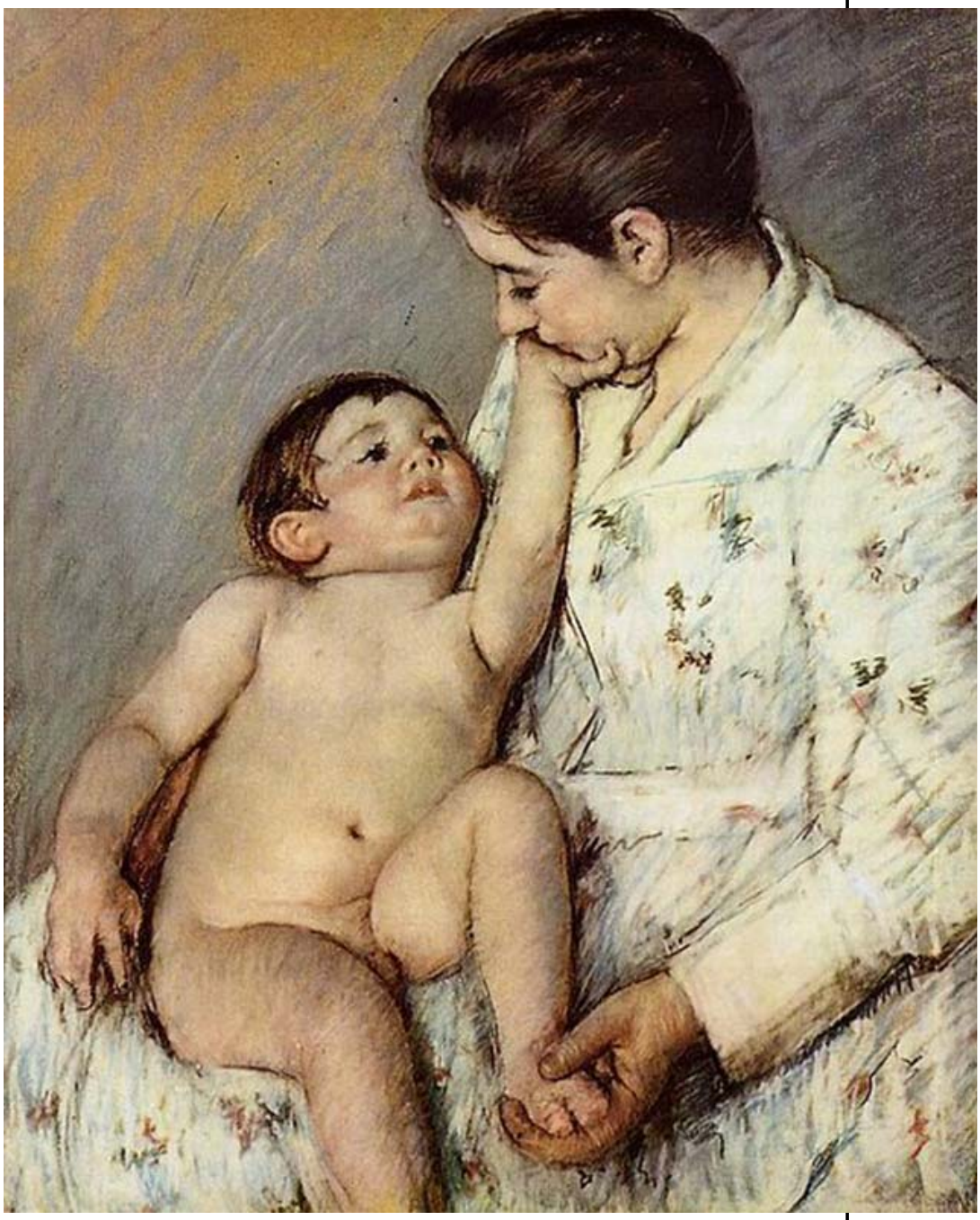


Figure 2.2. Mary Cassatt's *Baby's First Caress*

Mary Cassatt's *Baby's First Caress* literally paints a picture of the I-Thou relationship (fig. 2.2). The mutual touch and expression of the mother and child portray a simultaneous encountering of the

self and other. As the baby caresses the mother's chin, the mother not only encounters her child but becomes aware of her own feelings as her face tingles at the finger tips of her child's fingers. As the mother touches the baby's foot, the baby's own caress is validated by the mirroring action of the mother, and the child becomes aware of his or her own feet through the touch of the mother's hand.

In addition to the convergence of the gazes of mother and child, even the technique and style of the artist give a sense of unity and connection between them. The lines of the baby's arms follow the neckline and upper-arm line of the mother. The baby's thighs are almost perfectly parallel with the mother's forearm, neck line and the line connecting the baby's and mother's eyes. Cassatt's brush strokes create a harmonious melody that intertwines the two and that at no time distracts the viewer from the uniqueness of the beautiful babe and the tender, adoring mother. This painting vividly illustrates the following remark by Hans Urs von Balthasar: "And yet the child is aware, in the first opening of its mind's eyes. Its 'I' awakens in the experience of a 'Thou': in its mother's smile through which it learns that it is contained, affirmed, and loved in a relationship which is incomprehensibly encompassing, already actual, sheltering and nourishing" (cited in Neuhaus, 2000, p. 98).

I-it relationship. The I-it relationship is in sharp contrast to the I-Thou. The I-it relationship is characterized by a high view of the self and a low view of the other. The other is not experienced as a whole being, is not appreciated in its entirety. In the I-it relationship the other serves as an object, in a functional or utilitarian role for the self, regardless of the created uniqueness of the object. The self in the I-it relationship merely interacts with human others as objects. The other is instrumental, not integral, to the I's being. Individuals who relate to the other as an it are often dismissing. They have a positive view of themselves and a negative view of others. Such individuals avoid closeness with others because of negative expectations. However, they maintain a sense of self-worth through defensively denying the value of intimate relationships. Such individuals experience superficial relationships with others. Thus the interconnectedness of the I-Thou represents to them a struggle.

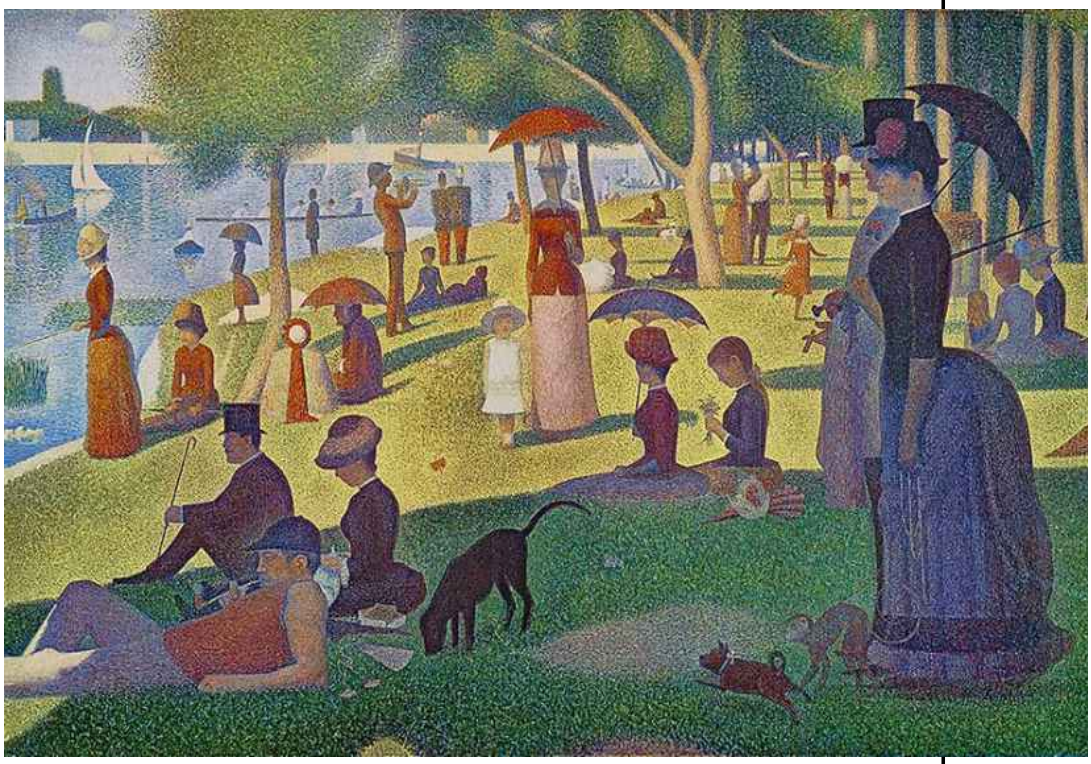


Figure 2.3. George Seurat's *A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of la Grande Jatte*

The neoimpressionist George Seurat's *A Sunday Afternoon on the Island of la Grande Jatte* (fig. 2.3) exemplifies the I-it relationship. The artist, who is known to be the ultimate example of the artist as scientist, used the technique of pointillism, or divisionism, on a massive canvas in order to depict a number of people enjoying a sunny afternoon in a park. Looking closely, we notice that the individuals in the picture are just that—individuals. Although people are walking or sitting side by side, with the exception of one couple, there is no engagement between individuals. There appears to be no true encounter of the other. Except for geographic proximity there is no evidence of relationality. Additionally, on closer examination we realize that these people are made of dots. Consistent with the thought and science of the modern era that sought universal laws, systems of natural order and reduction of matter into parts, people in Seurat's painting are reducible to mere particles. The painting does not

portray humans as interconnected beings but rather as entities composed of individual parts.

Fusion: The it-thou relationship. Another distortion of the I-Thou relationship is the fused relationship in which the individual holds a low view of self and a high view of the other. Although the other is more highly regarded than the self, this is not done in a healthy, differentiated manner. Rather the other is seen as a source of security or identity for the self. The other is not recognized as a unique, respected individual but rather as one who exists in order to conform to the needs of the self. Such individuals seek close relationships with another in order to gain a sense of acceptance or validation. They seem to believe that if others will act properly toward them, they will attain a secure self. This can lead to a fused personality. Individual uniqueness and distinctiveness are lost. No space for individual self-expression exists in this model of relatedness. Nor is there room for reciprocity. Neither the self nor the other has any space for personal development. Consequently, the other's unique self is not validated and is lost as it conforms to the thoughts, feelings and needs of the wounded self. In "Buberian" terms this form of relatedness could be called it-thou. In this formulation the self is referred to an it rather than an I in order to emphasize the low view of the self. Because the self sees the other as having something to contribute, the word *thou* rather than *it* is used to convey that the other is perceived as necessary to the self's being. The word *thou* is not capitalized in order to denote that the other is not mutually related to as in the I-Thou relationship.

The Viennese Art Deco painter Gustav Klimt reflects this tendency in his work. Time and again one body is conformed to another in a way that insinuates a fusion, a loss of uniqueness, especially by the other. For example, in *The Kiss*, the most evident distinction in the painting is the boundary surrounding the joined bodies, separating them from the background (fig. 2.4). In contrast, the boundary between the two selves is hardly visible. The woman's body, as the other, is being conformed to fit to the man's form, as the self. The self and other lose their distinction as they become one. The conformity of the other to the self and the lack of a distinct boundary between the two illustrate a neurotic fusion. This painting illustrates how the "other"—in this case the woman—has no space for developing. Rather she is forced to conform to the man's needs.

This is a vivid illustration of a person seeking out another to complete the self. This might represent an attempt to reduce anxiety because the person does not have an internalized sense of self. In popular culture this painting has been romanticized and can be found on Valentine's Day cards, mugs and calendars. At first glance the union between the lovers appears romantic, but on viewing the image through the lens of the reciprocating self, the sacrifice of individuality becomes more apparent and the painting must be regarded as more neurotic than romantic.

Figure 2.4. Gustav Klimt's *The Kiss*

Dissociation: The it-it relationship. The opposite of fusion is dissociation, where the self attempts to exist on its own, not in relationship with another. In the final quadrant the it-it relationship is characterized by a low view of self and low view of other. Unlike the previous model, where not enough space between self and other exists for self-expression, there is too much space in this

dynamic. The self does not perceive itself worthy of closeness with another, nor does it expect the other to offer closeness. Such individuals have often been hurt in close relationships. The negative expectations they form cause them to avoid interpersonal closeness to avoid the pain of loss and rejection. Defensively, they remain in isolation.

The modern architect Ludwig Mies van der Rohe graphically illustrates this detachment in his Farnsworth House (fig. 2.5). The architect designed his buildings to be perfectly self-contained systems that reflect what he understood to be the natural order. They exist on their own, irrespective of their environment. Such is the case with the Farnsworth House, which suggests no continuity with its surroundings. The house stands on its own as a self-contained system. There is no relationship between the severe, modern building and the rural landscape. This building reflects the dissociation experienced by the fearful individual. Just like the modern building, the fearful self looks out on the world from its isolated existence in ontological aloneness, not experiencing intimacy.

Figure 2.5. Farnsworth House by Ludwig Mies van der Rohe

The Reciprocating Self

Exploring the above stances of relatedness provides a basis by which the reciprocating self may be understood. The reciprocating self is the self that in all its uniqueness and fullness of being engages fully in relationship with another in all its particularity. The reciprocating self is the I or Thou in the I-Thou relationship. Buber (1970) writes, "Relation is reciprocity" (p. 62). It is the self that enters into mutual relationships with another, where distinction and unity are experienced simultaneously. The I-Thou selves reciprocate, having the capacity to give and to take. The reciprocating self does not treat the other as a mere utilitarian object from which it only takes. It does not seek fusion, where it takes to the extent that it demands the loss and sacrifice of the other. It is not dissociated—where there is no give or take. Rather the reciprocating self lives in a mutual relationship of sharing and receiving with another.

Conclusion

The purpose of this book is to provide a theological perspective on human development. As such, the notion of the reciprocating self serves as our developmental teleology. In other words, our understanding of God's intention for human development is for us to become particular beings in relationship with the divine and the human other. In mutually reciprocating relationships we encounter the other and ourselves most fully as we become more like Christ. Although this is an eschatological goal, meaning that reciprocating selves will only come to completion in the eschaton, we affirm the significance of enabling others now, as much as possible, to become reciprocating selves. This not only enables us to more fully image God, but allows humankind to participate more fully in God's ongoing activity in this world.

In regard to human development, we emphasize the importance of capacities that facilitate our relations to God and his created order. We are less concerned with identifying a limited or bounded singular substance, quality, ability or disposition that mirrors the image of God. As such, we argue for a malleable understanding of the image of God that is a dynamic process that enables us to participate in the life of the triune God and become more Christlike. From this

standpoint the image of God is not only dynamic, but it is directional. It is dynamic in that humans image God as they relate to God, humans and creation as they participate in the ongoing life of the Trinity, and it is directional from the standpoint that Christ is the perfect image of God. As such our understanding of thriving is informed by both trinitarian and christological perspectives (King & Whitney, 2015).

As we turn toward the discussion of lifespan development we examine theories, developmental processes and lifespan issues through the lens of the reciprocating self. In this way our developmental teleology will help us focus on the aspects of human development that help or hinder the formation of the reciprocating self.

It is our belief that God’s intention for individual development is inextricably intertwined with our relations with God, one another and creation. We use this understanding of being human to provide insight into existing developmental theories and to discuss how they might help or hinder our understanding of being human.

3

Reciprocating Relationships

In the last chapter we used a trinitarian model to suggest that the goal of human development is for individual humans to become reciprocating selves in the same manner as persons of the holy Trinity are with each other. They are one yet maintain their distinct personhood. In this chapter we seek to complete our theological model of human development by introducing a second biblical model—the depiction of *God's relationship to human beings.* A precedent for this was set in the writings of Ray Anderson (1982, 1985) and Gary Deddo (1999), who utilized the biblical concept of God's *covenant love* as an example of what God desires in human relationships. We argue that human relationships are meant to be reciprocal *unconditional commitments* characterized by reciprocal *gracing, empowering* and *intimacy.* We propose that human relationships are *authentic*—the way they are meant to be—to the extent that they are modeled after the way God enters into relationships with humans. This way of relating is necessary to foster both the development of the reciprocating self and to sustain its authentic quality.

Stephen Post (1994) has suggested that a theology of family relationships might be developed by means of an *analogical-familial* theological approach. This approach has been used in three books, one dealing with family relationships (Balswick & Balswick, 2014), another with sexual relationships (Balswick & Balswick, 2008) and the third with parent-child relationships (Balswick et al. 2003).

In each case a theology of human relationships is built on the biblical model of God in relationship with humankind. In the Old Testament, for example, God is described as relating to Israel as a parent (father), as a spouse and as a faithful lover. In the New Testament, God is frequently described as a groom in relationship to his bride, the church. We will examine the whole of Scripture through the lenses of these analogies to help understand God's relationship to human beings.

Our beginning point in developing a theology of personal relationships is found in God's covenantal relationship with the nation of Israel. Ray Anderson (1982) notes that in Scripture "humanity is determined as existence in covenant relation with God" (p. 37). In describing the relational components of covenant, Stuart McLean (1984) makes the following observations: (1) people are social and live in community, (2) the basic unit of family and of covenant is the dyad, (3) persons living in community will experience struggle and conflict as well as harmony, (4) persons living in covenant must be willing to forgive and be forgiven, (5) persons living in covenant must accept their bondedness to each other, (6) persons living in covenant will accept law in the form of patterns and order in relationships, and (7) persons living in covenant will have a temporal awareness as they carry a memory of the past, live in the present and anticipate the future (pp. 4-32).

Relationships That Form a Reciprocating Self

We propose an analogical-personal relational theology based on scriptural teachings on God in relationship. We believe that the reciprocating self can be nurtured best when (1) personal relationships are characterized by a *covenant* (unconditional love) commitment rather than a conditional commitment, (2) when the response to failure in relationship

is characterized by *gracing* rather than shaming, (3) when persons in relationship use their power, giftedness and resources to *empower* rather than to control the other, and (4) when the relationship is characterized by an openness that can lead to *intimacy* rather than isolation. Although the core biblical analogy of God in relationship is supremely applicable to marriage and parent-child relationships, it is also generalizable to what God desires in relationships in general, which is our focus in this chapter.

The maturing of a reciprocating self can best be thought of as a developmental process nurtured by ever-deepening levels of *covenant, grace, empowering* and *intimacy*. This sequential change is represented in figure 3.1, an inward spiral depicting the potential for personal relationships to grow into ever-deeper levels of reciprocal commitment, grace, empowering and intimacy. Whereas the model depicts what we believe is the primary *sequential* order, consistent with the assumptions of the relational developmental systems paradigm, we also believe that these four elements of a relationship can directly mutually interact and influence each other.

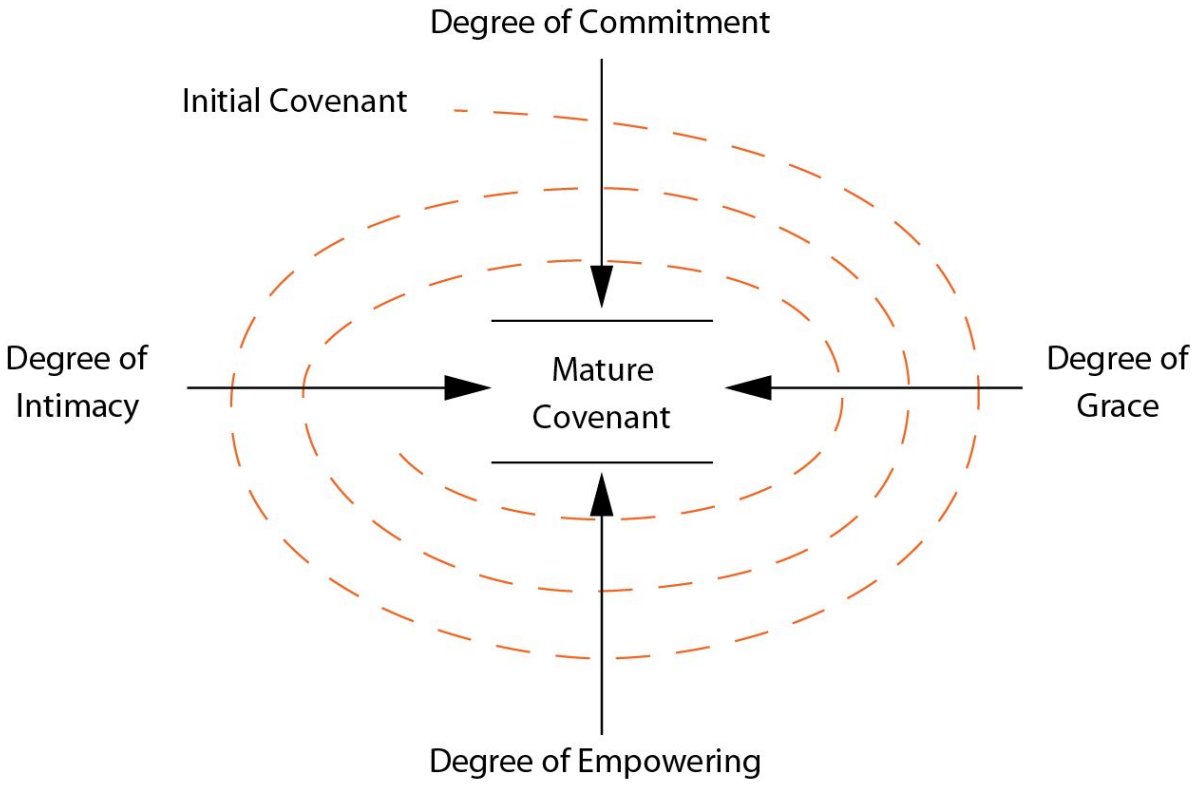


Figure 3.1. A theology of reciprocating relationships

Concomitantly, an *undifferentiated self* develops into a *reciprocating self* in mature relationships. As an infant develops language and the capacity to communicate, a self is formed. This beginning self, however, is an undifferentiated self, a self that is almost indistinguishable from the primary caretaker(s). The infant has the *capacity* to become a reciprocating self, but for this to happen the child needs to be in relationships with mature or reciprocating selves. Using the parent-child relationship as an example, the relationship between a parent and infant child begins as a unilateral (one-way) love commitment; as the parent lives out that commitment the relationship may grow into a bilateral (reciprocal) love commitment. In order for growth to take place in a relationship there must be involvement by both persons. Initially a child has no self and cannot enter into

a reciprocating relationship. But through socialization the self develops increasing capacities for relatedness (see chaps. six and seven). The more mature the reciprocating self of the caretakers, the greater the likelihood that a child will develop into a reciprocating self. The less the caretakers' capacity to relate as reciprocating selves, the more retarded is a child's development into a reciprocating self.

Even at the adult level, when one person in the relationship is unable or unwilling to reciprocate covenant love, grace, empowering or intimacy, growth in interpersonal relationships can be blocked or retarded. Thus growth in a relationship can come to a standstill at any point in this cycle. Since relationships are dynamic and ever-changing, if a relationship does not spiral into deeper levels of commitment, grace, empowering and intimacy, then it will stagnate and fixate on *contract* rather than covenant, *law* rather than grace, *possessive power* rather than empowering and *distance* rather than intimacy.

Parenthetically, we should note that we are not proposing a tightening of dyadic relationships that would exclude or ignore less primary relationships. On the contrary, the depth of bonding in primary relationships nurtures the reciprocating self and equips it to enter into empowering relationships with persons in the wider human community. While our early chapters on human development (chaps. six through eight) point to a child needing a certain degree of exclusivity in interpersonal relationships, our chapters on adult development (chaps. nine through eleven) will point out that the maturity that comes out of exclusive relationships is meant to become *inclusive.* Thus in our last chapter we will utilize the trinitarian relational model to suggest that the reciprocal self needs to be embedded in the *reciprocal community.* The true church—as the body of Christ—is to be *unbounded* in showing care and love.

Although the relational dimensions of covenant, grace, empowering and intimacy will be described separately, in reality they often overlap and should not be pressed into a logical, sequential, linear model of interpersonal relationships. It could be argued that any attempt to base a human model of relating on a divine example is a setup for failure. While human beings are created in the image of God, we are fallen creatures who fail in all aspects of our relationships. It is true that no human being can ever make a covenant commitment in the way that God covenants with us. It is equally true that no mere human will be able to respond with grace and forgiveness to the same degree that God offers grace. Human empowering attempts likewise fall short of the empowering model set by Jesus Christ. Finally, human attempts at intimacy will pale into insignificance when compared to the knowing and caring shown by God. Nevertheless, through God's active relating to humans and God's incarnate presence in Jesus Christ a perfect model of relationship is revealed in Scripture. As we live out our lives and relationships according to God's purpose, we have God as an active relational model.

Covenant

The central point of covenant is an *unconditional commitment,* which is demonstrated supremely by God. Genesis 6:18 is the first biblical mention of a covenant. God says to Noah, "I will establish my covenant with you; and you shall come into the ark." Noah is told by God what he must do: "[Take] your sons, your wife, and your sons' wives with you. And of every living thing, of all flesh, you shall bring two of every kind into the ark, to keep them alive with you; they shall be male and female" (Gen 6:18-19). In Genesis 6:22 we read, "Noah did this; he did all that God commanded him." In Genesis 9:9-10 God repeats this promise of covenant: "I am

establishing my covenant with you and your descendants after you, and with every living creature that is with you." Notice that the passage also indicates that this covenant is extended to include nonhuman creatures.

In Genesis 15:18 the covenant is extended to Abraham. Genesis 17 amplifies on the covenant God made with Abraham:

> The LORD appeared to Abram, and said to him, "I am God Almighty; walk before me, and be blameless. And I will make my covenant between me and you, and will make you exceedingly numerous." Then Abram fell on his face; and God said to him, "As for me, this is my covenant with you: You shall be the ancestor of a multitude of nations. . . . I will establish my covenant between me and you, and your offspring after you throughout their generations, for an everlasting covenant, to be God to you and to your offspring after you." (Gen 17:1-4, 7)

Genesis 17:9 focuses on Abraham's role in the covenant: "God said to Abraham, 'As for you, you shall keep my covenant, you and your offspring after you throughout their generations.'"

These two accounts reveal several important characteristics of God as the covenant maker. First, we see that neither Noah nor Abraham was offered any choice in the matter. God's covenant offer was not "Now I am going to commit myself to you *if* this is your desire." It is clear that the establishment of the covenant was based entirely on God's action. God's offer was not contractual; it was not based on Noah's or Abraham's keeping their end of the bargain. Whether Noah or Abraham accepted the covenant or not, God's commitment was firm. The second thing we learn about God as covenant maker is that he strongly desired (some might say commanded) a response from both Noah and Abraham. The strength of God's desire did not, however, make his covenantal offer conditional. God was not free to retract the

offer if Noah or Abraham did not reciprocate. God's offer was "an everlasting covenant."

A third aspect of God's covenant was that the potential benefits or blessings it provided were conditional. Noah and Abraham were given an option by God *within* the covenant. If they were to benefit from the covenant, Noah and Abraham had to agree to fulfill their end of the bargain. While receiving any of the blessings was conditional, the continuation of God's love was not conditioned on the nature of Noah's or Abraham's response. A fourth observation is that God extended the covenant to more than just these two individuals. Noah's and Abraham's families were included in the covenant as well. In the case of Abraham, God extended "an everlasting covenant" to "generations." Even more extensively, God's covenant with Noah was extended to include "every living creature." Further evidence of the unconditional nature of the covenant is the fact that Noah could not respond on behalf of the animals, nor could Abraham anticipate the obedience of his descendants.

The relationship between God and the children of Israel is best understood through the analogy of an unconditional parental commitment to a child. Scripture reveals a cycle of (1) Israel's turning away from God and getting into difficulty, (2) God's reaching out and forgiving them, (3) Israel's being reconciled into the intended parent-child relationship, and (4) Israel's blessing and renewal in their relationship to God. Similarly, the central message of the book of Hosea is that God pursued unfaithful Israel as a jilted lover.

The supreme expression of unconditional love is modeled in the life and death of Jesus. When the Pharisees and scribes criticized him for welcoming and sitting with sinners, Jesus responded with the story of the prodigal son (Lk 15). Just as the father in the story welcomed his wayward son home with open arms, Jesus responded with unconditional love to a people who had rejected his Father. The unconditional nature

of God’s love is most clearly expressed in 1 John 4:19: “We love because he first loved us.” Likewise this unconditional love is expressed in 1 John 4:10: “In this is love, not that we loved God but that he loved us.” God’s love is unconditional!

The issue of reciprocity needs to be discussed in light of the unconditional quality of God’s covenant commitment. Although there is no question regarding the unconditional nature of covenant love, in a relational context covenant can be used of unilateral or bilateral relationships. Figure 3.2 depicts the alternative types of commitment found in relationships.

	Conditional	**Unconditional**
Unilateral	Modern Open	Initial Covenant
Bilateral	Contract	Mature Covenant

Figure 3.2. Types of commitment

Covenantal relationships are based on unconditional commitments, but they can be either unilateral (one-way) or reciprocal (two-way). In order for a true relationship to exist between two persons, there must be some degree of reciprocity involved. Thus some might question if an exclusive one-way commitment should even be called a relationship. On a continuum representing degrees of

reciprocity in commitment, the concepts of unilateral and bilateral should be understood as polar opposites.

In figure 3.2 a unilateral unconditional relationship is labeled "Initial Covenant," while a bilateral unconditional relationship is labeled "Mature Covenant." All biblical references to covenants are examples of initial covenants since God initiates them. It would be erroneous to think of an unconditional unilateral relationship as partial, dependent or even immature, because from the individual's perspective a personal covenant without restrictions is being offered. Unilateral unconditional commitment entails the attractive possibility of someday becoming bilateral. That initial covenants become reciprocal and mutual (bilateral unconditional commitments) is God's desire.

Caring parents make an unconditional commitment of love to a child when it is born. At the beginning of life the infants are unable to reciprocate their parents' unconditional commitment. A relationship that began as an initial (unilateral) covenant can develop into a mature (bilateral) relationship as the child matures. When parents themselves age and become more dependent on their adult children, true reciprocity occurs because unconditional love has come full cycle. Here, in a mature bilateral commitment, reciprocal and unconditional love is especially rewarding.

Perhaps as a corrective to those who interpret the meaning of covenant exclusively in a bilateral context, James Torrance (1975) has described a covenant as unilateral and a contract as bilateral. We must remember, however, that Torrance is speaking of the establishment of the covenant between God and humans. Our covenant relation with God is not established equally by us and God—God is the initiator. Once established, the human is graciously given room to reciprocate in an asymmetrical yet bilateral way. The covenant relationship between God and humans cannot be directly applied in exactly the same way to human relationships. Although both God-human and human-human

relationships are reciprocal, it may be more appropriate to speak of human-human relationships in terms of *mutuality.* Torrance's primary concern is the contrast between a gracious covenant and the conditional nature of a contractual relationship. Covenant relations between God and humans and between human and humans are of the gracious sort, not the contractual sort, whether established unilaterally or bilaterally. The lack of conditions is the primary and shared aspect in both types of covenantal relationships.

Two types of conditional interpersonal relationships are represented in the first column of figure 3.2. The cell at the bottom left represents a quid pro quo arrangement, where a relationship is based on both partners fulfilling their agreed-on end of the bargain. When two people adopt this conditional stance, a relationship, even a friendship, amounts to a *contract.* Both participants in the relationship consider it satisfactory if they get about as much as they give. In reality, much of the daily routine in life is carried out according to informal contractual agreements. Advocates of covenant-based relationships recognize the importance of the mutual satisfaction and fairness. Although there may be contractual agreements within a covenant, a true covenant relationship will not be based on contract alone.

An emerging type of relationship, which we call the *modern open* arrangement, is symptomatic of a society in which persons are hesitant to make commitments in relationships. The 100 percent increase in premarital cohabitation in the last twenty years is characteristic of persons not even willing to enter a contractual relationship. The understanding, often unspoken, is that either party can terminate the relationship if it is felt that personal needs are not being met or that someone else might better meet one's needs.

Grace

From a human perspective the unconditional love of God makes no sense except as an offer of grace. It is difficult to distinguish between covenant and grace because covenant *is* grace by its very nature. We are called to share in a gracious relationship with God. *Grace* is truly a relational word and a natural extension of covenant love. Rogerson (1996) suggests that God desires the establishment of *structures of grace,* defined as "a social arrangement designed to mitigate hardship and misfortune, and grounded in God's mercy," to strengthen relationships (p. 41). Rogerson finds support for this in such Old Testament texts as Exodus 22:25-27—"If you lend money to my people, to the poor among you, you shall not deal with them as a creditor; you shall not exact interest from them. If you take your neighbor's cloak in pawn, you shall restore before the sun goes down." In his analysis of Old Testament writing on the family, Rogerson concludes, "What is really important is that theologically-driven efforts were made to counteract the forces that undermined the family" (p. 41).

Whereas relationships based on contract lead to an atmosphere of law, relationships based on covenant lead to grace and forgiveness. As designed by God, personal relationships are meant to be lived out in an atmosphere of grace and not law. In order for community to be a context for right relationships there must be a willingness to forgive (Borrowdale, 1996). The meaning and joy of being a Christian would be deadened if our relationship with God were conceived in terms of law and not grace. The same is true for relationships in the Christian community. Law leads to legalism, whereas grace provides a freedom from legalism, whether it is at the individual or community level. When community members act responsibly out of love and consideration for one another, they are acting as a community of grace.

The incarnation, in which Christ came in human form to reconcile the world to God, is the supreme act of God's grace to humankind. The basis for human love and forgiveness is God's act of divine love and forgiveness. As we have been forgiven, we can likewise forgive others. The love of God within makes it possible for us to love others in God's unconditional way.

This does not mean that there is no place for law, rules, guidelines or regulations in personal relationships. We need to be informed by the apostle Paul's writings: "Christ ends the law and brings righteousness for everyone who has faith" (Rom 10:4 NEB). Laws, rules or regulations are not in themselves bad; they might serve to point the way to how God relates. Being imperfect, human beings can never fulfill the law. They must recognize that Christ is the end of the law in the sense that he is its perfect fulfillment. Due to Christ's perfection and righteousness, we can be accounted as righteous. Righteousness and salvation are dependent on faith in Christ and not on keeping the law. However, something of God's ideal (the law) can be known when grace is applied to relationships even though no one can measure up to that ideal. In a community of grace, forgiveness will be offered when persons disappoint and fail each other.

The opposite of gracing is *shaming.* In a community of law where perfection is demanded, the person who disappoints and fails to live up to the standard will be *shamed.* In shame-based communities rules and regulations are rigidly set up to govern relationships. This kind of pressure for flawlessness adds guilt to the failure that is inevitable in such a situation. It is noteworthy that the less a relationship is based on trust and commitment, the more it needs legal definitions of what is expected in the relationship. Sociologically we would refer to such relationships as *formal,* as opposed to *informal* relationships that are more often based on personal commitment.

Although the covenant of grace rules out law as a basis for relationships, community members living in grace will accept law as patterns, order and responsibilities in relationships. In reality, much of our daily living has agreed-on rules for regularity and order. McLean's (1984) insights are helpful here:

> In the covenantal root metaphor, law and covenant belong together. The dyadic relationship necessarily involves creating specific forms, rules, and laws to guide community and personal relationships. The need for law, pattern, and form is mandatory, but the particular shape of law needs to be understood as relative to the actualization of dialogical-dialectical relationships, the creation of whole persons-in-community. The issue becomes which forms, which laws, which patterns are appropriate to the maintenance of humanity? (p. 24)

The application of the concept of grace in relationships is a special challenge in societal structures based on impersonal but legally defined ways of relating. Grace means that order and regularity are present for the sake of the needs and enhancement of each person in the relationship, and not as a means of repressing and limiting the other.

At the personal level it is helpful to distinguish between shame and guilt. Guilt is the feeling that one has when one *does a wrong;* shame is the feeling that one *is a wrong.* Breaking the law results in the feeling of guilt, and if the law is just, this is as it should be. Shame, on the other hand, is based on the feeling that one is *not good enough,* that one is deficient at the core. Theologically there is a place for shame. It can be seen in the Genesis account of Adam and Eve, who felt shame—that they were not good enough—before God after they sought wisdom apart from God.

However, the type of shame that emerges in nongracing personal relationships is neurotic or toxic shame. Such shame can be seen in churches, families and parent-child relationships. While visiting friends my wife and I (Jack) were met at the door by five-year-old Jenny. Jenny led us to her bedroom where she excitedly showed us that she had learned to make her bed by herself. Upon viewing Jenny's bed her mother exclaimed, "But Jenny, there are some wrinkles in the cover." In spite of the age-appropriate task Jenny had accomplished in making her bed, Jenny's posture changed from one of self-confidence and self-esteem to one of shame. Following her mother's message she felt she was not good enough. Children who grow up in shame-based families can come to have shame-based personalities, lacking the ability to feel good about themselves, even when objective criteria would seem to demand it.

Empowering

Power in personal relationships is the ability to influence another person. Note the emphasis on the ability or potential to influence, and not the actual exercising of the ability. Power is based on the *resources* each person brings to the relationship, where a resource is something that the other values. Thus a resource can be a material possession such as money or valuable objects, or it can be a personal quality such as nurture, intelligence or humor. If these qualities are valued by the other then they can be "converted" into power—the ability to influence.

Perhaps due to the tendency for humans to act in self-centered ways, the social science literature has focused on the use of power to control the other. In this regard, *least interest theory* (Waller, 1938) proposed that the person who shows the least interest in the relationship automatically assumed a "one up" position, or a position of power,

because they are indicating that they do not value or need what the other has to give in the relationship. Inversely, the person who is desperate to keep the relationship going assumes the least powerful position. This is the line taken by much social science research on how power is used in relationships—it is assumed that people will attempt to use their power to influence or control the behavior of the other. The person without power will try to gain it, while the one with power will try to maintain the more powerful position.

Empowerment is the opposite and far less common in relationships. In an empowering relationship one person uses his or her power *for* the other. This contrasts with *controlling,* which is the process of using power *over* the other. Erich Fromm (1956) pointed to parenting as an empowering process when he observed that the socialization of children is the process of getting them to want to do what they have to do. Here empowerment is the process whereby external control (the wishes of the more powerful) is transferred into internal control (the child actually wanting to do what the parent desires). We could charge that such a view of empowerment is selfishly motivated, but it is probably true that even in our most altruistic acts we fail to act selflessly.

In *Love and Will* (1969), Rollo May distinguished among five ways of using power in relationship. *Exploitation* influences by brute force, *manipulation* influences by devious sociopsychological means, *competition* influences through the possession and use of personal resources, *nutritive* power influences by providing socioemotional comfort and security (like parents with young children), and finally *integrative* power is the use of personal power for another's sake. While nutritive power is done with the right motive, integrative power is clearly what we refer to as empowering. Jesus and Gandhi are examples Rollo May points to as persons who used integrative power.

The supreme biblical model for empowering can be see in the humanity of Jesus Christ, who was totally human as well as totally God. Empowerment is an integral part of what Jesus proclaimed in his central message, "I came that they may have life, and have it abundantly" (Jn 10:10). In his teaching and by example Jesus was an empowerer of others. In Mark 10 we are told that James and John requested that when he ruled in glory they be permitted to sit on his right and left sides. We can almost see the gleam in their eyes as they anticipated the power they would have. Note Jesus' response:

> You know that among the Gentiles those whom they recognize as their rulers lord it over them, and their great ones are tyrants over them. But it is not so among you; but whoever wishes to become great among you must be your servant, and whoever wishes to be first among you must be slave of all. For the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve. (Mk 10:42-45)

By rejecting the use of power to control others, Jesus redefined power by affirming that it is to be used to serve others—to lift up the fallen, to forgive those who fail, to encourage responsibility and maturity in the dependent, and to build up the weak.

Jesus sought to empower his disciples in anticipation for his ascension, and he encouraged them by promising that the Holy Spirit would come to comfort them and help accomplish their ministry (Jn 16). Just before his ascension Jesus assured his disciples that they "will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you" (Acts 1:8). Following Jesus' ascension his disciples sought to implement an empowering model of community. Acts 2:44-45 describes that "all who believed were together and had all things in common; they would sell their possessions and goods and distribute the proceeds to all, as any had need." The followers of Jesus

took his message of servanthood seriously by mutually giving up the very resources conventional power is based on.

Empowering others does not mean yielding to the wishes of another person or giving up your own power to someone else. Rather, empowerment is the active, intentional process of enabling another person to acquire power. The person who is empowered has gained power because of the encouraging behavior of the other. The empowering process facilitates the increase of power in the other. As such, empowerment is the process of helping others recognize their own strengths and potentials, and guiding them in the development of these qualities. It may require that the empowerer be willing to step back and allow the empowered to learn by doing. Empowering does not involve controlling or enforcing a certain way of doing and being. Rather it is a reciprocal process in which empowerment takes place between people in mutually enhancing ways. The empowerer must respect the uniqueness of those being empowered and see strength in unique ways of being competent.

The apostle John points to empowerment when he states, "But to all who received him, who believed in his name, he gave power to become children of God, who were born, not of blood or of the will of the flesh or of the will of man, but of God" (Jn 1:12-13). This text is insightfully exegeted by Ray Anderson (1985) when he notes that power "of blood" is power in the natural order and "the will of the flesh" refers to tradition, duty, honor, obedience and all that is a part of conventional power. It is clear then that in this passage power is given by God and not by either physical or conventional means. The power given by Jesus is power of a personal order—power mediated to the powerless. God gives to sinful and powerless human beings the ability to become children of God. This is the supreme example of human empowering. By relating to human beings as a servant and rejecting the use of power to control others, Jesus radically redefined power.

The teaching and behavior of Jesus toward the poor and the powerless also exemplify an empowering model. In the patriarchal culture of biblical times Jesus showed this by honoring children and others who occupied a marginal status in the social structure (Francis, 1996). Paul says that others will know we are Christians by our love. The mark of Jesus Christ that we need to emulate the most is his empowering of others, for this is love in action. The view of authority within the church could be revolutionized if the Christian community began to practice empowering others. Largely because the secular view of power has been widely accepted within the church, authority issues hinder the Christian community from functioning as the body of Christ. Empowerment is the active side of unconditional love and grace. It is the act of using our gifts and strengths to build up the other person. The opposite of empowerment can be seen in the act of using power to control the other. The body analogy for the interdependent workings of the church makes no sense apart from an empowering model. The body functions as a complete whole only to the extent that each part is there for the good of the whole, which means each will contribute to the good of the other. When the good of the other has no priority, empowering ceases to be. The writer of 1 Corinthians 12 takes great pains to stress that the all parts of the body are of equal importance, for if one part suffers then all parts suffer.

The biblical ideal is for reciprocal empowering. I (Jack) took great pride in teaching my son Joel to play tennis. I remember when he improved to the point where he was able to give my game a challenge. By age sixteen he got to the point that he began beating me, but I still won most of the time, and that felt good. By age seventeen he had emerged as one of the best tennis players on his high school tennis team, and I found myself in danger of being overtaken by my son, and I was not so sure I liked this. In one of our matches I found myself struggling to return Joel's powerful serve and found

myself getting angry. I paused, reflected on the fact that I teach empowerment, looked at the expert player my son had become and said to myself, "Jack, you are a fantastic tennis coach!" The reframing allowed me to actually glory in what my son had become as a tennis player—this is empowerment in action.

My grown son and I still play tennis from time to time. It is no match at all, and Joel tries to disguise the fact that he takes it easy on me. The last time we played, Joel commented on something he had noticed in my form. He said, "Dad, on your forehand I've noticed that you are bending your elbow; you will get more power on the ball if you keep your elbow straight." What goes around comes around. My own son, who I had taught to play tennis, was empowering me! This is God's ideal for relationship—that the stronger, more knowledgeable or more skilled person in a relationship will use his or her resources for the other—that mutual empowerment might be a reality.

Insecurity causes us to jealously guard against using personal power for the other. Such a view is based on the false notion that power is a limited commodity. This secular view of power drives us to accumulate more and more power while reducing the power of others. The good news for Christians, says Scott Bartchy (1984), is that "according to Scripture, especially the New Testament, the power of God is available to human beings in unlimited amounts!" (p. 13). Such passages as Ephesians 4:11-13 and Galatians 5:22-23 assure that the fruit of the Spirit—love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, fidelity, gentleness and self-control—are available to all Christians in unlimited supply. The very character of God is available in unlimited supply because God's resources are inexhaustible!

Intimacy: To Know and Be Known

Christianity is unique in its teaching that God has broken into human history to be personally related to us. God wants to know us and to be known by us. Adam and Eve, for instance, stood completely open and transparent before God. In their perfect creatureliness, Adam and Eve were naked before each other and felt no shame (Gen 2:25) before each other and God. Thus Adam and Eve felt an intimacy that allowed them to be themselves without any pretense. They had no need to play deceptive games. Ray Anderson (1982) observes that this is "the power of subjectivity expressed as cohumanity. The vulnerability is in the defenselessness each has in the presence of the other" (p. 64).

Throughout the Bible we are encouraged to share our deepest thoughts and feelings through prayer. In Romans 8:26-27 we are told that the Holy Spirit intercedes for us and that God understands our deep sighs or unuttered groanings. Jesus modeled the type of intimacy desirable in personal relationships. At the end of Jesus' earthly ministry he asked Peter three times, "Do you love me?" (Jn 21). Given that Peter had earlier denied Jesus three times, it may very well be that Jesus was giving Peter the opportunity to reaffirm his love to Christ three times. We can imagine the guilt and shame felt by Peter after he had assured Jesus that he would not forsake him. Peter's self was in no condition to reassume a reciprocal relationship with Jesus. Jesus knew this and allowed for the needed healing to take place both within Peter and in their relationship. When our personal relationships become strained due to failure, disappointment and sometimes even betrayal, a similar healing is needed both in our own self and in our relationships. We firmly believe that the two types of healing—inner and relational—go together. We are healed through our relationships, and our relationships are healed as we confess our mutual failings and ask for forgiveness.

Instead of moving toward healing broken relationships, there is a human tendency to deny, withdraw and even hide

ourselves. Shame is born out of the fear of being known intimately. When shame is present, even members of the body of Christ put on masks and begin to play deceptive roles before each other. By contrast, in the Genesis description of the prefall human relationships, we find an emphasis on intimacy—on the knowing of the other. Adam and Eve's lack of shame at being naked must be understood at a deeper level than mere physical nakedness. In their created state Adam and Eve were free to be open, honest and who they were before the other. They did not seek to hide by putting on a mask or playing a role; they were free to be who they were. Following the break in their relationship with God, Adam and Eve felt naked, exposed, shamed, and as a result they tried to hide from God.

When personal relationships are based on mutual covenanting lived out in an atmosphere of mutual grace and mutual empowering, then each person in the relationship is drawn to freely communicate and express him- or herself to the other. The relationship is one of intimate knowing and being known. A concerted effort is made to listen, understand and want what is best for the other. Not only are differences accepted but uniqueness is valued and respected in a way that confirms the other person.

This is how we are to be submissive and loving in relationships. To have any union or partnership or interdependence with another, we must always be willing to give up some of our own needs and desires. It is what it means to be a servant, to empty oneself as Jesus did when he took the form of a servant. When members of the body of Christ come to each other with this kind of attitude and perspective, they will find a common ground of joy, satisfaction and mutual benefit.

For Christian brothers and sisters to communicate feelings freely and openly with each other is contingent on trust and commitment. Then we are not afraid to be intimate with one another. John gives us insight into this in 1 John 4:16, 18:

“God is love. . . . There is no fear in love, but perfect love casts out fear.” God expresses perfect love, and we can respond in love because God loved us first (1 Jn 4:19). This leads us back to the unconditional covenant love that is the cornerstone for honest sharing without the threat of rejection. As Christians offer their love unconditionally to each other, the security that is established will lead to deeper levels of intimacy.

Forgiving and being forgiven is an important part of renewal. There is a need to confess as well as to receive confession. This is a two-way street that will clear out the unfinished issues between members of the body of Christ. Being willing to admit mistakes and admit being offended by another puts a person in a position of vulnerability. In intimacy, however, Christians need not be ashamed to admit failure and ask for forgiveness and reconciliation. It is desirable that family members verbally communicate feelings of love and affection toward one another as well as ask forgiveness of and forgive each other. This brings relationships to full maturity.

The previous chapter focused on reciprocating relationships between the self and divine other. In reality, the model for relationships with human others is the biblical model of God actively seeking to relate to human beings. This reciprocating relationship is consistently reinforced throughout Scripture. It is most precisely summed up in the words of John: “We love because he first loved us” (1 Jn 4:19).

While there are similarities between human relationships and the human-divine other relationship, we do not mean to blur the important difference. The latter is a relationship between the perfect Creator and a fallen created being. We must not live in the illusion that we can love God unconditionally as he loves us. When we feel anger toward God and are tempted to blame him, we must not hold to the illusion that he needs forgiveness for his behavior. God does

not need us to empower him. God wants an intimate relationship with us, but we must not hold to the illusion that we are able to completely reciprocate God's intimacy.

The Bible uses metaphors that might help us understand the relationship between the human self and the divine other. In their book *The Sacred Romance*, Curtis and Eldredge (1997) identify five biblical metaphors that they believe capture the Christian's relationship to God: Potter-clay, Master-servant, Parent-child, Friend-friend and Beloved-beloved. Curtis and Eldredge order these metaphors from the least intimate (Potter-clay) to the most intimate (Beloved-beloved). These five metaphors are not systematic images or pictures describing the nature of God. Instead they picture the *nature of human beings in relationship to God.* Each metaphor reveals a different facet of the believer's relationship to God, and as such should be a deterrent against any attempt to oversimplify the complexity of the relationship.

Sin: Missing the Mark in Reciprocal Relationships

Not all relationships will reflect the biblical ideal we have described in this chapter. From a theological perspective sin can be defined as a failure to be in right relationship.

Sin is usually not part of the vocabulary of human development theories. In his book *The Crisis of Psychiatry and Religion*, the well-respected psychologist O. Hobart Mowrer (1961) surprised the psychological community by suggesting that sin may be more than psychological distress; it may be an actual offense against God that requires forgiveness and grace. While the thrust of this chapter has been to portray a biblical view of right relationships, in so doing it also provided a relational perspective on sin—conditional acceptance, shaming, controlling and isolating behavior. These miss the mark in reciprocating relationships.

In his book *Reforming Theological Anthropology*, F. LeRon Shults (2003) states that "to claim today that sin really has to do with our essence as persons requires that we speak of personhood in relational and not merely substantial terms. Responsibility, agency, and sinning inherently have to do with community and sociality" (p. 214). Ray Anderson (1990) also defines sin in a relational context: it is "defiance of God's gracious relation to those who bear his image . . . [resulting] . . . in separating persons from the gracious life of God" (p. 234). Shults (2003) concurs that the "heart of the doctrine of original sin . . . is that each and every person is bound by relations to self, others, and God that inhibit the goodness of loving fellowship" (p. 209).

Shults firmly ties the issue of sin to the broader question of the dynamics of human agency:

> What we call "sinning" has to do with the inability of human activity to establish or maintain a relation to the good it seeks. We desire objects that we hope will bring happiness, and we act in order to secure them. But our acting is overshadowed by an ambiguous relation to goodness, an ambiguity that is intensified as we come to recognize over time that our acting will never be able to secure our relation to those objects that we love. . . . When we act in ways that fall short of the glorious goodness of God (Rom. 3:23), we call this sinning. Persons are formed through their historical, dynamic grasping for goodness, and are miserable because of their separation from it. Guilt emerges in relation to this failure of our agency, as we act in ways that depend on our own power to love and secure what we perceived as good. If sinning is understood primarily as that which blocks our relation to the source of goodness, then salvation from sin is

> not merely pardoning, but also reconciliation in relation to the good. (pp. 214-15)

Shults concludes that a "theology of human acting explores the nature of the ultimate source that secures this relation, and tries to render intelligible the failure of finite human agents to secure the love and good they seek" (p. 215). In this chapter we proposed that the elements that contribute to a well-formed and developed reciprocating self are unconditional love, gracing, empowerment and intimacy. While these elements point to the factors that contribute to a secure reciprocating self, the ultimate answer to human sin is found only in God's divine intervention. Only God can offer a forgiveness that will bring about "the renewal of a positive relation between people and God. Forgiveness means restored relation, not merely granting an exception to a moral law . . . forgiveness restores an authentic moral history of being in relation" (Anderson, 1990, p. 234). As Shults (2003) affirms, this divine intervention can affect human agency:

> As Christians share in the suffering of Jesus Christ, their human agency is freed to participate in the infinitely vulnerable reconciling love of God. Here too in the doctrine of sin we are confronted with an opportunity to return to the relational roots of the biblical tradition and reflect on human acting in light of the trinitarian God. For Christians, ethical anxiety is alleviated by the atonement effected in the history of Jesus Christ. The whole experience of Christian salvation is structured by the dynamics of the Trinity: "If the spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, he who raised Christ from the dead will give life to your mortal bodies also through his Spirit that dwells in you" (Rom. 8:11). (pp. 215-16).

Developmental theories share a naturalistic perspective in viewing human behavior as part of the natural order. Thus sin is not a part of their vocabulary. One of the basic assumptions of naturalism is that the principles governing the human species are no different from those governing other species. Utilizing a biblically based teleology to understand human development invites a corresponding consideration of what it means to fall short or miss the mark in human development. In our relationally based model, sin is the relational condition of falling short of being a reciprocating self.

4

The Reciprocating Self and Developmental Theory

In chapter one we indicated that developmental theories share in common a naturalist assumption. Historically these theories have shaped the way psychologists understand human nature and human development. In spite of teleological limitations, each theory may provide essential insights and confirmation to our model of the reciprocating self. It is far beyond the scope of this book to provide a full understanding of the major development theories. We instead focus on each theory's capacity to contribute to our understanding of the development of the reciprocating self. Given our model, the developmental theories we find most useful are those that conceptualize humans beings as self-conscious agents who are not only acted upon but who are capable of being active agents in relationship, actively participating in the formation of their own environment.

Theoretical orientations that we find most helpful in understanding the development of the reciprocating self are the psychoanalytic (Freud), object relations (Winnicott), symbolic interaction (Mead), social learning (Bandura), cognitive development (Piaget) and social context and scaffolding (Vygotsky) theories. Most of these theorists concentrate on childhood development, seeming to imply that human development ends with the advent of adulthood. This is certainly not the case, as we will see when we examine the

lifespan development theories of Erik Erikson and Daniel Levinson in part two of this book. Although moral, spiritual and religious development are important aspects of a developing self, these will be the exclusive focus of chapters twelve and thirteen.

Human development has too often been approached from a traditional mental health model that views development as a pathology or neurosis waiting to happen. In his 1998 presidential address to the American Psychological Association, Marty Seligman challenged psychologists to work more from the perspective of positive psychology. In line with the growing emphasis on positive psychology, we affirm a positive view of development, focusing and elaborating on strengths throughout the human lifespan. In this regard we find a balanced perspective in David Levinson's (1978, 1996) idea that *adolescing* (upward development) and *senescing* (downward development) are both an integral part of the human life cycle. Within a theological perspective, the residual effects of both creation and fall on human development must be recognized, thus the simultaneous process of *adolescing* and *senescing.*

The Reciprocating Self in Developmental Theories

Most developmental theories consist of systematically organized knowledge that has been accumulated through empirical observation of children. A good theory is like a pair of glasses in that it allows one to focus more sharply on what is being observed. To illustrate this, suppose that representatives of the major theories of child development are viewing a child playing in the family living room. Although the observers will be exposed to the same behavior, they will not *see* it through the same set of eyeglasses. Each observer will perceive the child's activity in accordance with a set of predetermined assumptions about human behavior.

For example, the cognitive development theorist will be especially aware of the particular stage to which the child has developed; the Freudian theorist will look for unconscious motivations in overt behavior; the symbolic interactionist will concentrate on the child's self-concept; and the proponent of social learning theory will pay special attention to what the child has learned from observing others. Although it is not a conscious process, all of our theorists actually engage in selective perception, viewing the child's actions in accordance with their own general conceptualization of human behavior. We will present the developmental theories in the approximate order they emerged.

Psychoanalytic Theory

Sigmund Freud, the father of psychoanalysis, presented a theory of child development that concentrates on the interplay between biological instincts and parental influence. Although Freud's model by itself may not be a viable model of understanding human development, it is important in providing the basis to understanding the human psyche and the foundation of the modern psychology movement. Freud (1949) did not use the concept of the self in his three-part depiction of the personality, which consists of the id, ego and superego; the ego corresponds to the meaning we give to the self. How similar is Freud's ego to the reciprocating self?

Although Freud's ego can be equated to the self, it is probably more fruitful to ask if Freud's model of the mind allows for the conceptual emergence of the reciprocating self. Freud gives a dynamic model of the mind in which the id is the source of energy present already at the birth of a child, whereas the ego and superego develop as the child is socialized. For Freud there is a high degree of conflict in the mind, with the id and the superego battling each other

for control of the ego. The id is amoral, impulsive, ruled by the unconscious and irrational, and demands immediate gratification. The superego, which consists of internalized parental and societal restrictions, is moralistic, seeking to deny the irrational impulses of the id. The superego operates as a type of moral police officer as it attempts to contain the id and control the ego. When the superego gets its way, it rewards the ego by building up self-esteem, but it punishes the ego with a guilty conscience when it does not get its way.

Although a bit of a strain, it is possible to conceptualize the emergence of the reciprocating self within Freudian theory. To begin with, Freud gives a great deal of credence to biological roots in the formation of the self. This is no problem if the self is equated with Freud's ego. However, the self is much broader than merely ego, and an argument can be made for equating the self with the mind in Freud's theory. If this is done we might even argue that by taking into account the self-centered instinctive urges in the id, Freud's model is consistent with a biblical description of the fallen nature of humankind.

In stressing the importance of unconscious and irrational aspects of human motivation, Freud differs from self theories. His fundamental theory of the mind has been referred to as the iceberg theory because it holds that the major part of the mind lies below the surface; only the tip rises to the level of consciousness. The theory is a bit weak in its focus on the importance of extraparental relationships in the formation of the person.

Perhaps the greatest limitation in psychoanalytic theory is the view that human development does not significantly change beyond the early formative years. Freud believed that the first six years of life are vitally important for developing the three parts of the mind and determining how they will interrelate to form personality. According to Freud, during the first six years of life a child is moving

through three developmental stages, within each of which a different part of the body serves as the focus of gratification.

First comes the *oral stage.* In the first twelve to eighteen months pain and pleasure are centered in the oral zone. Pleasure is experienced when the infant receives food from a loving mother or sucks on a thumb or some other object. Pain is experienced when the infant is deprived of such oral gratification. Children who are weaned too abruptly or are inadequately nurtured during the oral stage may grow up to be oral-type personalities: greedy materialists, thumb suckers, smokers, pencil biters, excessive babblers and so on. Freud would say that each of these individuals has discovered a substitute form of oral gratification.

Toilet training begins the *anal stage,* at which time control over excretion becomes an important issue between children and parents. Overly rigid toilet-training methods that involve unrealistically high expectations can contribute to the child's developing an anal-type personality: meticulous, punctual or tied down by petty self-restraints. Or the child may react by becoming the very opposite: messy, disorderly and lacking in self-control.

After toilet training, children enter the *genital stage,* at which time attraction to the parent of the opposite sex and bonding with the parent of the same sex are major developmental issues. Freud explained that boys desire an exclusive relationship with their mother—independent of their father—to the extent that boys subconsciously want to eliminate their fathers (the Oedipus complex), while girls desire an exclusive relationship with their father—independent of their mother (the Electra complex). In a healthy family the love between the mother and father will be unwavering, and the child will eventually conclude that the parent of the same sex cannot be defeated in the competition for the exclusive affection of the parent of the opposite sex. The psychological solution is for the child to seek to

be like (identify with) the parent of the same sex and suppress the attraction for the parent of the opposite sex. In a dysfunctional home the weak bond between the mother and father may result in failure to identify with the parent of the same sex.

In traditional psychoanalytic theory the genital stage is the period in which sexual identity is formed. Adult problems that can be tied to unsuccessful resolution of this stage include preoccupation with proving one's masculinity or femininity, confusion in sexual identity, hesitancy to marry and sexual dysfunction.

Between the ages of six and thirteen, children go through the latency stage, characterized by a strong identification with members of their same sex. This is the age of the girls "against" the boys. If healthy conditions have prevailed during the first six years of life, gender identity and self-esteem will firmly develop during the latency stage. But if childhood conditions were less than ideal, there may well be difficulty in relating to others, increasing self-doubt and lack of self-esteem. By puberty the basic personality has been formed; changes in personality thereafter are seen as being minimal.

Although psychoanalytic theory is a dynamic-process model, in actuality it gives minimal insight into the formation of the self, which is based on the interplay of the child and its parents. It offers a less than satisfying account of the developing self in relationship with others and, just as importantly, how the self can and does change as it interacts with others. It is also limited in that it only gives explanations of child development. We now turn to the discussion of object relations, which developed out of psychodynamic theory.

Object Relations Theory

While object relations theory is rooted in psychoanalytic theory, it delivers a bit more understanding on *self* development. We find within object relations theory a useful understanding of the development of the reciprocating self. Object relations theories emphasize the development of the self or personality within the context of an infant-caregiver relationship. These theories contend that personality is shaped and formed by the early interactions of an infant (to young child) and his or her most intimate caregiver, usually the mother or father. Although object-relations theories acknowledge the significance of the phylogenetic structure, the biologically determined shape of the unconscious, these theories also convey the significant contributions of the environment, in particular the caregiver.

Object relations theory developed out of Freudian and psychodynamic theory. The most notable change involved a move from *biological* to *interpersonal determinism* and a corresponding change from a *drive* to a *relational* structural model. Melanie Klein is the theorist most noted for facilitating this change. In Klein's (1932) theory physical drives are replaced by *psychological and relational drives,* where the developmental focus is on relationships rather than on erogenous zones (e.g., oral, anal, genital) or body parts. The pleasure instinct (*libido*) was replaced by *love* and the death instinct (*thanatos*) by *aggression* or *hate*.

The core element in Klein's theory consists of the internalization by the child of its relationship with its mother. In this process a representation of the mother becomes internalized as an *internal object.* Once internalized the internal object is capable of bringing to the child comfort or pain. According to Klein the internal object is a synthesis of all relational experiences with the significant caregiver as he or she interacts with the child's *phantasy*. Phantasy is an important part of the human unconscious. For Klein, we are all born with an unconscious that comes "loaded" with phantasies, much like a computer comes loaded

with software. These phantasies are a part of our unconscious and shape the way we experience relationships. The phantasies are filled with emotions like hate, love, greed, fear and anxiety. According to Klein much of this phantasy is negative. Consequently, no matter how well the caregiver interacts with the infant, the infant most likely will internalize an object with some negativity. Since there is never a one-to-one correspondence between the mother and the mother as internalized, the internal object is a product of *phantasy* plus the *external object* (mother/caretaker).

It is most important to the future development of the infant that the internalized object then becomes an organizing principle for future interactions. Children who internalize a good or safe object will feel secure and anticipate that other external objects (other individuals) will form positive relationships. If children internalize an anxious or hateful object, they will anticipate having negative experiences with other relationships.

Klein's work is important because it makes a significant shift from the biological determinism of Freud's psychoanalytic theory to an interpersonal emphasis. From our perspective in the twenty-first century, her theory is still strongly biologically determined because of the significant role of the phantasy in shaping the internal object. However, given the time of her writing, her work brought about a major paradigmatic shift from biological determinism to introducing the significance of interpersonal interaction. That being said, it is important to note that many since Klein have challenged her writing and negated the significance of phantasy. Today it is generally recognized that caregivers have more influence than she gave them credit for.

One such psychologist was Donald Winnicott. Winnicott's work on personality development strongly emphasized the role of the mother (see Grolnick, 1990). In fact he wrote the statement, "There is no such thing as a baby, just a nursing couple." In Winnicott's version of object relations theory

the mother or caregiver is almost solely responsible for affecting the development of the self. She does so by creating a "holding environment," which refers to a physical and psychological space created by the mother, where the baby experiences a sense of continuity. In the holding environment the infant has a sense of "going on being," for an individual must have a sense of being before doing. It is within this holding environment that the infant has a sense of self and other. Through this environment the infant internalizes the mother as an internal object that gives the infant a sense of security and safety. The holding environment does not have to be perfect, it just needs to be "good enough," reflecting Winnicott's emphasis on the "good enough mother." According to Winnicott the mother does not need to be perfect in order for the infant to develop healthily—just good enough.

The good enough mother is *affectively attuned* to the infant's needs, meaning she is aware of the baby's physical and emotional needs (see also chapter 6, p. 140). Although she is affectively attuned, she does not impinge (mothering as smothering) on the child. The good enough mother is also able to find a balance between empathetic gratification of the infant's needs and her own needs. A good enough mother is also effective in *mirroring* the child's behavior and feelings. Such affective attunement can be seen when a mother mimics rhythms and intonations of the child. Effective mirroring contributes to an authentication and validation of a child's sense of self. A good enough mother demonstrates her connection with the child's world through appropriate reactions, neither ignoring nor overwhelming the child. Through mirroring, the infant simultaneously experiences self and other and is able to internalize the sense of other as an object.

An adequate holding environment will also include *transitional space*—psychological space within which the child can experiment with fantasy and reality. Such

psychological space is needed in order for the baby to react, respond and internalize the good object. Transitional space is the place creativity comes from. As the child develops it also gains the capacity to be alone. This takes place as the self emerges through the process of internalizing the presence of an emotionally attuned but nondemanding other. The capacity to be alone is retarded by both an emotionally absent and an overdemanding other. The capacity to be alone occurs through times of transitional space when the infant can be present to itself. Only in being alone in the company of a significant other can an infant discover his or her own personal life. A *transitional object* is a physical object that helps internalize real external objects. For example, a toddler might find comfort in a special blanket or a stuffed animal. This transitional object acts as a symbol of the caregiver and helps young children internalize a sense of the real external object in the caregiver's absence.

In summary, a good holding environment means a present, mirroring, nonimpinging mother, in which there is transitional space and a fostering of the ability to be alone. Transitional space is created by the nondemanding good enough mother in a holding environment where she is nonimpinging and mirrors the child.

By providing a descriptive understanding of the emergence of the true as opposed to the false self, object relations theory contributes to our understanding of the reciprocating self. The true self is the authentic, spontaneous self, aware of and comfortable with his or her uniqueness. As expressed through an infant, it entails its own rhythmic and tonal variation of movement and sound. Transitional space allows for the expression of the true self. The false self results from a lack of transitional space. Children with a false self often abandon their own wishes, instead molding their self to external expectations. While all children must yield in a certain degree to external expectations, in its extreme form the result is a fragmented self characterized by the state of

not knowing oneself and not being able to be in mutually reciprocating relationships. The major contributors to the false self can be seen in the extremes—*absent* or *impinging* parents.

Figure 4.1 presents a continuum representing the range in the boundaries of the reciprocating self. At the extreme left is the *fortress self* around which are reinforced "concrete" boundaries. The fortress self is highly defended, seeking to be in complete control of all life circumstances. The fortress self results from chronic failure on the parts of parents to meet the child's needs. The fortress self is closed off to others but at the same time needy and wanting others' help and affection. A less extreme version is the *protected self,* who appears to be completely self-sufficient. The protected self can come across as being "better than," or as being a good or perfect person. Although the lack is not chronic, the protected self nevertheless has experienced consistently inadequate fulfillment of their needs from parents. The protected self is unaware of others, seeking to cover up their own neediness in relationships.

The *cohesive self* represents the ideal reciprocating self whose personal boundaries are sufficiently protective yet permeable to the influence of others. The cohesive self is an integrated self that has internalized resources sufficient to meet the child's own psychological needs. The cohesive self has had consistent parenting with only occasional lapses—it is a product of the good enough parent. The cohesive self is sensitive to the emotional state and needs of others, open to both receiving and giving nurture in a relationship.

The *vulnerable self* has weak personal boundaries, making this person vulnerable to hurt and harm that may be inflicted by others. The vulnerable self is needy because it has few internalized resources to meet its own needs. The vulnerable self can be characterized as *hungry*—in seeking acceptance, approval and affirmation from others. As with the protected

self, the vulnerable self has experienced consistent parental deviations from adequately meeting his or her needs.

However, contrary to the withdrawing tendencies of the protected self, the vulnerable self displays a transparent hunger for what others can give. The vulnerable self actively seeks fulfillment from others. The *fragmented self* is an extreme version of a person with weak personal boundaries. This person is truly fragile with no internalized resources. Like the fortress self, the fragmented self has experienced chronic failure of parents to meet that individual's needs. The external appearance of the fragmented self is one of desperation that can come across as being demanding and even rageful or addictive.

Social Learning Theory

Reflecting a neopositivist tradition, classic learning/behavioral theorists have argued that any science of human development must purge itself of such mentalistic concepts as the "self." However, the father of social learning theory, Albert Bandura, has increasingly brought the self back into learning theory.

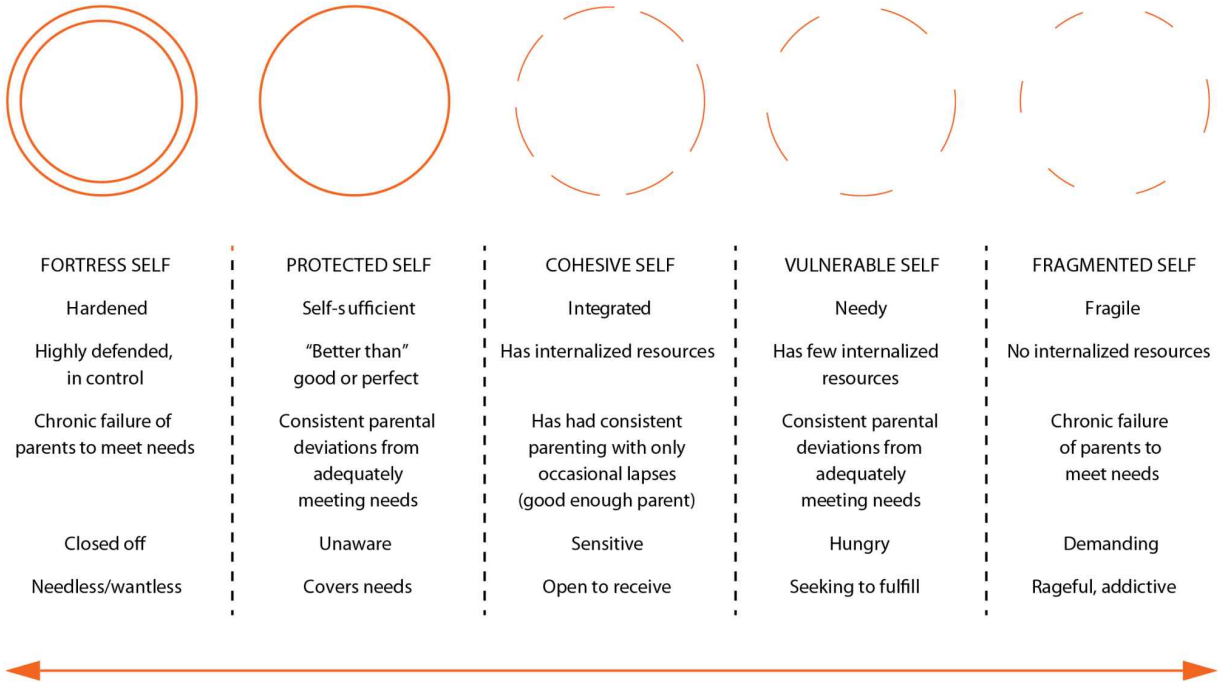


Figure 4.1. Boundaries of the reciprocating self. A modification of a figure developed by Walter Becker

Social learning theory is a theoretical offspring of classical conditioning, which is well illustrated by Ivan Pavlov's celebrated stimulus-response experiment. By ringing a bell just before giving food, Pavlov conditioned a dog to salivate when merely hearing the bell. This simple experiment contains the major elements of classical conditioning: the food is the unconditioned stimulus; salivation at the sight of the food is the unconditioned response; the bell is the conditioned stimulus; and salivation at hearing the bell is the conditioned response.

By the mid-twentieth century behaviorism came to be the dominant paradigm in psychology. During the latter half of the twentieth century, behaviorism was shaped by the creative research and writing of B. F. Skinner. Skinner (1953) developed what is known as operant conditioning, which is a modification of classical conditioning. Rather than using a

stimulus to bring about a desired response, Skinner's model emphasizes reinforcement, that is, a system of rewards for desired behavior and punishment for unacceptable actions. The basic principle here is that behavior is shaped and maintained by its consequences. Operant conditioning has proven useful in bringing about changes in behavior, especially as applied to correcting more basic behavioral problems such as bed-wetting or undesirable habits.

The view of the self within social learning theory can be found most fully within three of Bandura's publications, *Behavior Theory and the Models of Man* (1974), *Social Learning Theory* (1977) and "The Self System in Reciprocal Determinism" (1978). Since these publications Bandura has continued to affirm the place of the reciprocal self in social learning theory through his publications.

The initial difficulty in assessing Bandura's view of the self is that he does not specifically define it. That this is so may be the first clue to his distinctive usage of the term. Bandura might feel uncomfortable in conceptualizing the self as a separate entity; to do so might be interpreted as conceiving of the self as a psychic agent that controls action. Instead, Bandura (1978) explains that the "self system within the framework of social learning theory comprises cognitive structures and sub-functions for perceiving, evaluation, and regulating behavior" (p. 344).

The "self system" consists of the "reciprocal determinism" in the triadic interaction among *behavior* (B), the *person* (P) as the cognitive and other internal events that can affect perceptions and actions, and the external *environment* (E) (see fig. 4.2). The important point for us to gain from Bandura's social learning theory is to realize that he has divorced himself from the unidirectional environmental determinism of traditional behaviorism and has adopted a "reciprocal determinism," which sounds most consistent with our model of the reciprocating self.

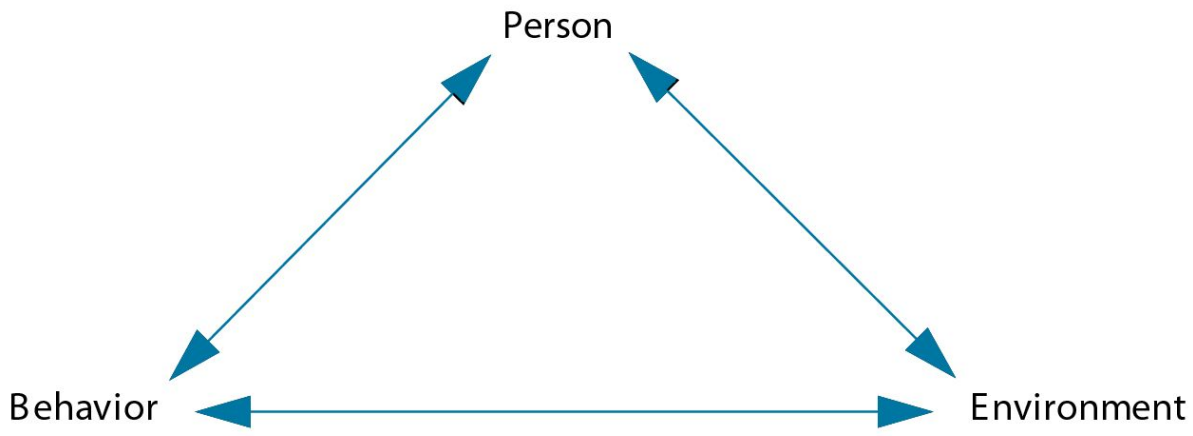


Figure 4.2. Reciprocal determinism

> Bandura's reciprocal determinism allows him to write,
>
> In their transactions with the environment, people are not simply reactors to external stimulation. The extraordinary capacity of humans to use symbols enables them to engage in reflective thought, to create, and to plan foresightful courses of action in thought rather than having to perform possible options and suffer the consequences of thoughtless action. By altering their immediate environment, by creating cognitive self-inducements, and by arranging conditional incentives for themselves, people can exercise some influences over their own behavior. An act therefore includes among its determinants self-produced influences. (1978, p. 345)

In Bandura's model, learning by observation rather than through direct reinforcement is the norm. Children learn how to behave by observing the consequences of the behavior of other persons. For example, learning not to hit other children on the playground comes primarily by observing that children who do hit others experience some negative

consequences, such as getting hurt him- or herself, or being reprimanded.

Social learning theory also emphasizes that children learn from the *modeling* of people who are important in their lives. Parents and other significant others are role models, influencing children by their actions. Comparison of direct learning (reinforcement) and indirect learning (observation and imitation of modeled behavior) reveals that the latter is more effective. Social learning theory advises that resourceful caretakers will model the behaviors they would like children to implement.

In social learning theory the stimulus of change is not found exclusively in the environment, as in behaviorism and classical learning theory. The idea that learning comes through the child's observation and interpretation of behavior implies a self-consciousness and self-determination within the child. Change then can be activated both by environmental stimuli and by the child. Clearly, the self is an integral part of a social learning theory of development.

Symbolic Interaction Theory

Although he predated Bandura by some forty years, the father of symbolic interaction, George Herbert Mead (1934), anticipated much that has come to be accepted within social learning theory. Mead used the concept of self primarily to refer to a person as an object of one's own activity. A person can act toward anything that is conceptualized as an object; therefore, if conceptualized as an object, one's own self can be acted on. In fact, one way of defining the self in symbolic-interaction terms is to view it as the sum total of self concepts that an individual has. Hence, the self consists of the individual's attitudes or plans of action toward his or her own mind and body, which are viewed as objects. As suggested by one interpreter of Mead, the self

consists of all the answers an individual might give to the question "Who am I?" (Kuhn, 1954).

Symbolic interaction, more than any other developmental theory, provides a rich understanding of the development of the reciprocating self. In this regard, in his book *The Social God and the Relational Self*, Stanley Grenz (2001) states that "the social self in social psychology, launched by William James and advanced by George Herbert Mead . . . opened the way to a *perichoretic* understanding of the self-in-relationship" (p. 19). Mead believed that the self only develops in a context of interaction with other human beings. The verification of this can be seen in the documented instances of feral children—cases of extreme child neglect that results in the child failing to develop either speech or social awareness. Some symbolic-interaction theorists go as far as to suggest that infants are not born human but become human through social interaction. As the name of the theory implies, it is the symbolic interaction with caretakers that enables the infant to become human in a social sense.

Of all living creatures, human beings are unique because of the vast amount of culture (learned and shared knowledge) that they possess. The accumulation of culture is possible because humans have elaborate language systems. The more elaborate the language system, the greater the potential richness of a culture. The infant is born without language, without culture and without a sense of self or of others. All of these develop as caretakers communicate with the infant.

According to Mead (1934) the self develops through three stages. First is the *preparatory stage*, within which the infant is prepared to use language. The purpose of language is to communicate, which can be thought of as occurring on two different levels. Most communication between animals involves gestures. Thus a beaver slapping its tail on the water, a rooster crowing or a dog barking can all be thought of as communication by means of a gesture. On the human level, gestures have meaning, but the meaning is not precise

enough to build an elaborate language system. Thus communication in the preparatory stage is one of gestures. *A gesture can be defined as any part of a social act that is a sign for something else.* There is rich communication between parents and their infant through touches, smiles, frowns, laughter and utterances, and these are examples of communication at the gesture level.

The second level of communication is a communication of *significant* symbols. Mead thought that a language system can develop only when oral gestures become significant symbols. *A significant symbol is a gesture that has the same meaning for the creature giving it as for the creature receiving it.* Notice the difference in your emotional reaction between the two questions "Would you like to eat a juicy steak?" and "Would you like to eat a juicy snake?" Yet the difference between the two is a very slight change in sound. The words *steak* and *snake* are significant symbols because of the precise meaning (and resultant feeling) they carry from one person to another.

Parents begin to communicate with their children through gestures—a smile, a soft pat on the hand, a warning glance or the wave of the finger. Words accompany the gesture, and thus children learn the meaning of a word in the context of specific situations. In time a child comes to view the word *from the parent's perspective.* In this way the child first learns its specific meaning (in relationship to a forbidden act) and gradually its general meaning. For instance, once the word *no* is understood in relation to a behavior that has never been forbidden before, the child has learned its general meaning.

Children develop self-concept in much the same way; they see themselves from their parents' point of view. And not only do children see themselves as they think their parents see them, but in defining themselves they make use of their parents' very words. If parents tell their three-year-old daughter Sally that she is good or smart, little Sally will

view herself as good or smart. If Greg's parents' continually tell him that he is bad as well as stupid, he is likely to view himself as bad and stupid. Children develop their self-concept by *internalizing* their parents' attitudes toward them.

When children are able to communicate through significant symbols, they have entered the second stage of development, the *play stage.* The play stage usually begins between the ages of one and two, and continues for several years. During this period children begin to play (imagine themselves in) the roles of a number of other persons. They play at being mommy, daddy, big sister, a policeman or doctor. Putting themselves in the place of each of these individuals, they assume or take on that person's attitude toward them as well. For example, a three- or four-year-old child may move from one dining-room chair to the next and take on the personality (role) of the individual who usually sits in that chair. While sitting in daddy's chair, little Kathy turns toward the chair she usually occupies and asks in a deep voice, "Did you have fun today, Kathy?" She actually takes on what she believes her father's attitudes are toward her. Having tired of this, Kathy proceeds to the chair where her older sister sits, points to her own chair and says, "You're a crybaby!" In each instance Kathy is adding to her self-concept by taking on what she imagines to be the other person's attitude toward her.

During the play stage, children are limited to taking on the role of only one person at a time. In the process they come to view themselves as they think others view them. Increasingly, there is a sharpening of the child's sense of self as distinguishable and separate from others.

At age three to five children reach the *game stage.* Before reaching this stage it is impossible for children to play certain games because they are unable to take on the role of more than one person at a time, which they can at the game stage. For instance, note the futility in trying to play

hide-and-seek with a three-year-old. To play hide-and-seek the child must be able to take on the perspective of both the hider and the seeker. To play a game like basketball or baseball is even more complex—the child must be able to take on the perspective of each team member at the same time.

During the game stage children develop an idea of how they appear to others in general. Thus when a ballplayer strikes out with the bases loaded, she imagines the team's collective attitude toward her. As a child listens to the applause after he has recited a poem at the school program, he gains a general impression of the audience's evaluation of his performance. The cumulative effect of relationships with other individuals and groups is that children continue to take on new and changing attitudes toward themselves.

All of life can be thought of as the process of moving out of certain groups and into others. Of supreme importance to the development of the self is that we acquire a general view of ourself from each group to which we belong. Research indicates that the self is even affected by groups we aspire to be a part of. The "reference group" will affect the self of a graduate student who aspires to be a teacher. Personal identity is found in the groups that we use to define ourselves. Some aspects of the self structure (identity), such as being a male or female, are firm and stable. This particular aspect, which is anchored in gender categories, calls forth gender-appropriate behavior already in the first year of life. Other aspects are formed when children have new experiences. For example, on the first day at school, they begin to identify themselves as students. Through time individual identities are both reinforced and altered. In the end, human personality is the sum total of self-concepts that an individual has experienced and developed through a variety of relationships.

In symbolic-interaction theory the self or self-concept reflects what we believe others think of us, and we behave accordingly. Our lives then take on the character of a self-

fulfilling prophecy. This contention of symbolic- interaction theory is supported elsewhere in child-development literature. For example, it has been found that children who fail in school have, from an early age, had low opinions of their learning abilities, whereas children who excel have developed positive views of themselves as learners.

This point leads us to labeling theory, an offspring of symbolic interaction. It has been discovered that juvenile delinquents are likely to have been told as children that they were no good, worthless and destructive. So labeled, they proceed to behave in accordance with the brands placed on them.

Cognitive-Development Theory

Cognitive-development theory is similar to symbolic-interaction theory in allowing for a conceptualization of the self. Developed by Swiss psychologist Jean Piaget, cognitive-development theory has become extremely influential in the United States (Flavell, 1963, 1985). Since Piaget's insights are central to understand infant and child development, his views are presented in chapter six and seven.

Piaget started with the assumption that far from being passive objects in the conditioning process, children *actively construct their own reality.* Once reality is constructed, life experiences are turned into action. Although the concept of the self is not as central in cognitive development as in social learning or symbolic-interaction theories, it provides a rich understanding of the increasing cognitive capacities of children and thus is capable of handling the development of the self.

In many ways cognitive-development and symbolic-interaction theories have many similarities, not the least being the importance they place on language acquisition. All that is needed is the suggestion that at a certain point of

development (three to five years) children are capable of viewing themselves as an object. In viewing oneself as an object there are many schemas in which one can define oneself. The *plan of action* toward the self in symbolic-interaction theory becomes a *scheme* for the self in cognitive-development theory. The focus on relationships is less important in cognitive development than what it needs to be. Discussion of the self as a reflective object in a maze of social relationships is lacking.

Vygotsky: Social Context and Scaffolding

The reciprocating self, as an emergent property of cognition, requires other people. We might say that the reciprocating self is constructed from *mental representations* that can be sustained over time and in different social situations. Steven Pinker (1994) calls representations the *mentalese* that comprises our thoughts. Representations are symbols, images, feelings or commitments that constitute our thinking. Representations aren't language, but they serve as the "coat hangers" on which language is "hung." A six-month-old infant, lacking the formal ability to speak, will nonetheless construct representations of his or her mother, father, toys, basic feelings and even sibling relationships. Representations are formed around the child's growing sense of a separate self and the others that live in her world. Representations become increasingly sophisticated through gradual, incremental development as children encounter situations where they find themselves "mirrored" through the perceptions of others. The careful reader might note the similarity between the concept of mental representations and the insights given by Jean Piaget and George Herbert Mead.

It is a foregone conclusion that the first and probably most important representations of the self appear in infancy through experiences with the primary caregiver, usually the

mother. The attachment relationship, with its positive and negative characteristics, will have an effect on the growing child's ability to extend itself into new relationships. Through adolescence and into adulthood it is the individual's ongoing catalog of experiences with others that shapes the reciprocating self, growing into maturity measured by the ability to love and care for others.

How might representations of the reciprocating self become established in childhood, adolescence and adulthood? Lev Vygotsky (1937/1986) was a contemporary of Piaget who studied children in a hostile and suspicious Stalinist Russia of the 1930s. Passionately committed to developmental study, Vygotsky risked his life and reputation to scrutinize Piaget's research as it was being published. Vygotsky was aware that Piaget's work was biased toward internal processes of development in childhood, generally avoiding relational influences typical of social context. Concerned that Piaget's emerging view of growth might be overly individualized, Vygotsky applied his energies to unearthing social processes in development, particularly those achievements made on the basis of the child's relationships with others.

To focus his study of how relationships were significant in development, Vygotsky chose to examine the emergence of language in childhood. The advantages of language study were threefold. First, language is a *social activity.* While many other animals have the ability to communicate with each other, the sophistication of human language is unique in the world, permitting a wide variety of expressions and shared emotions that capture the complexities of human behavior. By studying language acquisition and usage Vygotsky could evaluate the degree to which external relationships, such as between a child and parent, were significant to development. Moreover, he could compare the relationship between parents and children to other relationships of potential significance, such as between a child and peers. Vygotsky

rightly hypothesized that relationships were a present but shifting influence on the child's development. A twelve-year-old girl is much more likely to be influenced by peers than she would be at age four. Additionally, the kind of influence exerted by her twelve-year-old peers is markedly different than at age four. At twelve, girls create intricate peer associations and alliances, and are beginning to explore opposite-sex relationships. At four the same girls are simply learning how to share toys. Vygotsky's decision to study language acquisition reflected both the magnitude of relational influences and their specific location in the child's world.

Second, language study permitted Vygotsky to study *how children think.* Language is connected to representations of remarkable complexity. The preschooler's simple request for a drink evolves rapidly into the sixth-grader's ability to deduce complicated outcomes and consequences of hypothetical actions, including the relative merits of imbibing highly caffeinated sodas for breakfast. Vygotsky believed that studying language in childhood would allow him to see how the child's relationship with others was influential in changing his or her thought processes. He expected that social influences would be significant in learning, problem solving and in the means by which the child developed representations of the self and other. Vygotsky's best-known work reflects the measure of developmental importance he gave to language acquisition, published in *Thought and Language* (1937/1986).

Third, and most significant to the aim of this chapter, Vygotsky's concern with language enabled him to find out how children *think about the self.* Language is an expression of how we represent the self and others. Again these representations are more or less sophisticated, depending on age and experience. A preschooler is apt to describe herself in somewhat fragmented and concrete terms—"I am a good swimmer, mom tells me so, watch me dive!" By contrast, a school-aged child is more categorically inclusive but equally

concrete in the same description of self—"I am good at sports." In adolescence the abstract capabilities of the brain are evident in self-representation, where youth might describe traits or behaviors that make them unique—"I have a sense of humor; I am a good team leader when the chips are down." Vygotsky knew that language would help reveal the extent to which the child understands him- or herself through reciprocating relationships with others.

Vygotsky's studies of language development in children were remarkable in their scope, meeting Piaget's theory head-on. Vygotsky discovered, as Piaget had before him, that children develop their language abilities out of vocalizations beginning with the newborn's cooing. Between four and six months infants develop more deliberate sounds, including *ba* and *da*. Short words become evident in the second year, with increasingly sophisticated syntax and vocabulary making their appearance through the preschool years. Because the child would often speak to him- or herself without anyone present, Vygotsky, like Piaget, called speech before the age of five years *egocentric.* Piaget had assumed that egocentric self-talk meant that the child was learning to turn outside of the self to engage others in conversation. He maintained that by kindergarten the child would establish an ability to have a real conversation where the other person was fully engaged. Vygotsky rejected this view, arguing that the opposite was taking place. From early infancy, Vygotsky insisted, the child is already interacting with other people in the social world. Even the newborn's vocalizations represent an attempt to communicate with someone else. Instead of developmentally transitioning from the inside-out through the first five years, language acquisition progresses from the outside into the child. The child's egocentric speech represents a point at which relationships and social experiences are internalized and incorporated into the child's ego.

This was a radical departure from cognitive-development theory. Vygotsky proposed that the child's social context promotes language acquisition rather than the child's ability to first form thoughts that could be extended outward to others. In effect, mental representations of the self are dependent on social context rather than the other way around. Vygotsky's observations meant that people in the child's world were enormously important to development, particularly where those people were involved in the child's growing understanding of the world and the self. Additionally, Vygotsky paved the way for an understanding that *culture* is a significant influence on development insofar as the child is socialized into a particular worldview. Language, as the medium of interpersonal relationships, serves as the primary vehicle for the transmission of cultural information. Vygotsky's perspective helps to explain why children growing up in Japan tend to be more focused on the needs of others than on themselves, particularly when compared to American children (Heine, 2001; Hirata & Warschauer, 2014). Japanese language has few words for the self but many words to describe other people and their needs.

Vygotsky's contention that development arises from social influence is readily visible in the life of a preschooler. Four-year-old Eduardo has just received his first jigsaw puzzle for his birthday. He sits down to work on the puzzle but is quickly frustrated. In the Piagetian view this is the result of the child's inability to solve complex spatial problems related to fitting the pieces of the puzzle together. But for Vygotsky a parent's intervention enables the child's growth to solve the problem. The boy's father, sitting down at the table, offers Eduardo some tips. He suggests that Eduardo begin with the edge pieces of the puzzle. He points out that matching pieces can be found in the pile because of their shared colors. When Eduardo becomes frustrated, dad moves matching pieces into the boy's field of vision, raising the likelihood that he will discover a

successful match. As Eduardo gets the hang of the puzzle, dad gives words of encouragement. In this example it is social context that facilitates cognitive growth rather than the child's repeated attempts and failures.

Vygotsky called the context of Eduardo's interactions with his father the *zone of proximal development.* The zone contains the range of tasks that a child cannot yet accomplish without the active assistance of parents and others with greater knowledge capabilities (Vygotsky, 1937/1986). The zone of proximal development makes new possibilities real as the child's skill base is expanded through interpersonal relationships. Skills beyond the child's immediate potential cannot be magically realized within the zone of proximal development. No matter how encouraging he is, Eduardo's dad will not be able to help Eduardo master a game of chess. But within the zone of proximal development, dad can help Eduardo develop new problem-solving capabilities that extend from the puzzle. With mom the next day, Eduardo is able to match colored socks with an improved rate of success after incorporating dad's tip on observing same-colored puzzle pieces. Better, he is able to do this even when a number of socks have similar but slightly different colors and textures. The zone of proximal development implies that as the child learns and masters new skills through relationships, he or she will be increasingly able to independently handle tasks and challenges.

Whereas Piaget thought of the growing child as an independent explorer, Vygotsky thought of the child as a collaborator, learning new skills through interactions with more cognitively advanced individuals. Within the zone of proximal development, strategies such as dad's use of color matching with Eduardo's puzzle effectively "build" cognitive and self-related processes. Vygotsky called this *scaffolding*, reflecting the construction technique of placing ladders and walkways around a building in order to give workers access to every part of the emerging structure.

Caregivers can provide a scaffold of development that optimally extends just slightly beyond the child's abilities, but never so far beyond as to create unreasonable expectations that end in certain failure. Rogoff (1990) notes,

> Vygotsky's model for the mechanism through which social interaction facilitates cognitive development resembles apprenticeship, in which a novice works closely with an expert in joint problem solving in the zone of proximal development. The novice is thereby able to participate in skills beyond those that he or she is independently capable of handling. Development builds on the internalization by the novice of shared cognitive processes, appropriating what was carried out in collaboration to extend knowledge and skills. (p. 47)

Vygotsky's theory carries significant implications for the reciprocating self in development. If Eduardo's problem-solving abilities are improving within the zone of proximal development, it is additionally likely that the scaffolding provided by dad is helping Eduardo to understand himself in new ways. Rather than experience shame for his struggle with the puzzle, Eduardo quickly learns that the activity is for discovery, that mistakes are acceptable and that the goal is ultimately to have fun. Eduardo learns that his essential self is desirable, leading him to construct new representations of self and other based on his experiences with dad. These representations will become lodged in Eduardo's memory for comparison when future situations require it.

The reciprocating self indicates a high level of interpersonal commitment in its formation. But what happens for children that do not receive this kind of developmental scaffolding? A number of outcomes are possible. Abused or

neglected children will, in the absence of consistent scaffolding, develop negative representations of the self and other. Depending on the nature of the abuse and its longevity, the child may develop various protective strategies for the self. If Eduardo were to be shamed and verbally attacked by his father while working on the puzzle, he would likely withdraw with a deep sense of personal failure. Preschool children who lack adequate scaffolding are at risk to develop "all or nothing" categories of thinking about the self, such as an internal conviction that "I'm all bad." Harter (2012) notes that abuse frequently results in the child's internalization of social influences on the basis of responsibility. So shame, violence or emotional abuse result in a self that reciprocates negativity to others. This might become evident in a child's bullying behaviors, delinquency or violence.

We might consider the fact that four-year-old Eduardo's social context is much simpler than when he will be eleven or eighteen. Advancing age brings increasingly complex social contexts and relationships that potentially scaffold development. At eleven Eduardo might have an established peer group, play on various sports teams and participate in his faith community. At eighteen Eduardo additionally might be involved as a volunteer in the local convalescent hospital and work for pay as a restaurant server. Each of these environments contains increasingly complicated relationships that he must navigate. As he grows, Eduardo's reciprocating self learns to adapt to each social context by acquiring the ability to play an appropriate role. Representations of self and other are configured around these roles and the individuals that populate his relationships.

If we were to speculatively follow Eduardo's development into adulthood, we might describe his increasing role as a builder of scaffolds for those younger than himself, such as his own children. In considering Eduardo's elderly years we might even describe his need for scaffolding as he finds his

physical, intellectual and mental capacities diminishing. The notion of scaffolding has influenced many developmental theorists, including the authors of relational development systems (RDS), which we will turn to in the next chapter.

A Concluding Critique of Human Development Theories

The ultimate usefulness of each of the above theories can be measured by the extent to which they are utilized in part two as we describe the *process* of human development and the *context* in which it takes place. Before ending this chapter, however, it might be helpful to critique the human development theories in terms of two criteria central to a biblical model of the reciprocating self—*human agency* and the *relational context of the self*.

Human agency. The question of human agency is related to the issues of human responsibility, freedom and sin. In the last chapter we presented a relational perspective on sin—suggesting that sin is falling short of becoming a reciprocating self. We also quoted Shults (2003) as tying sin to the issue of human agency. In his view sin is the inability of humans to act in a way that will secure goodness and happiness. This is especially true in a relational sense as humans come to recognize that their actions are incapable of building secure relationships with objects of love. When humans act in ways that fall short of the goodness of God, they are sinning. Humans feel guilt when the power of their own agency is unable to secure the good. It is at this point that humans need divine intervention. Ray Anderson (1990) states that "as Christians share in the suffering of Jesus Christ, their human agency is freed to participate in the infinitely vulnerable reconciling love of God" (p. 234). Human agency can be transformed as it participates in a righteousness that is not its own but is secured by divine love. We are becoming good as we are drawn into fellowship

with the trinitarian God who is love. Then we are formed into the image of Jesus Christ (Shults, 2003, pp. 215-16).

Human agency is far too complex an issue to adequately deal with here. Suffice it to say that an integrated view of human agency must be informed by both theological and psychological wisdom. From a theological perspective human agency must always be understood in terms of persons who struggle to live as fallen and broken beings even though they are created in the image of God. From a psychological perspective human agency must always be understood in terms of persons whose choices are shaped and limited by both their organic base (physiological makeup) and sociocultural environment.

None of the theories adequately takes into account the biblical view that human beings are distinct from all other living creatures in that they bear the image of God (even though this image is marred by sin). The biblical view also holds that the human condition is marked by internal tension. As Paul states in Romans 7:21-24, "So I find it to be a law that when I want to do what is good, evil lies close at hand. For I delight in the law of God in my inmost self, but I see in my members another law at war with the law of my mind, making me captive to the law of sin that dwells in my members. Wretched man that I am! Who will rescue me from this body of death?"

Perhaps psychoanalytic theory comes the closest to providing a view of human existence as trapped in a state of internal tension between good and evil. Freud believed that a child is born with both constructive (*eros*) and destructive (*thanatos*) instincts. This tension becomes even more complex when, as a result of socialization, the superego develops within the child. The tension between the id and superego can be conceptualized as corresponding to the biblical view that sees internal tension as a natural human condition.

Symbolic interaction looks on the self as being caught in a state of internal conflict between the impulsive "I" and

the conformist orientation of the "me." However, as explained within symbolic interaction, this tension results from inconsistent internalization of external behavioral norms. The I, as the core part of the self, was internalized in the past, while the me, the more exterior part of the self, is seen as internalized more recently. In the individual's subjective experience, the I is what one really wants to do, and the me is what one thinks others want one to do.

The Bible presents a view of human beings as choice-making creatures who are responsible for their own behavior. Alternatively, built within most development theories is the assumption that human behavior, including decision making, can be explained on the basis of environmental conditioning. Evolutionary psychology, as a noted exception, explains human behavior by means of genetic determinism. The environmentally oriented theories differ significantly, however, in the degree to which they conceptualize humans as choice-making creatures. Whether human beings are mechanistic or active organisms is still debated in the social science literature.

Although there is great variation in contemporary psychoanalytic theory, Freud's original goal to establish a scientific psychology led him as well to a mechanistic model of human behavior. As Freud (1949) stated in *Project for a Scientific Psychology*, "The intention of this project is to furnish us with a psychology which shall be a natural science: Its aim, that is, is to represent psychical processes as quantitatively determined states of specifiable material particles and so to make them plain and void of contradictions" (355).

Classic learning theory assumes that children are born as clean slates on which social conditioning imprints the cultural script. Within this mechanistic model human beings are viewed as operating on much the same principles as do machines. Thus the behaviorist John B. Watson boasted, "Give me the baby and my world to bring it up in and I'll make it

crawl and walk; I'll make it climb and use its hands in constructing buildings of stone or wood; I'll make it a thief, a gunman, or a dope fiend. The possibility of shaping in any direction is almost endless" (quoted in Matson, 1966, p. 30).

Social learning theory, in contrast, leans toward the conviction that children are active organisms who continually act on and construct their own environments. Cognitive-development and symbolic-interaction theories likewise are based on the assumption that children *act on* and *react to* their environment.

As a whole the professional wisdom on cognitive theories of development has moved closer to what we believe is the biblical view of free will. It would be incorrect, however, to interpret contemporary theories on child development as emphasizing free will to the exclusion of determinism. Rather the prevailing understanding seems to be that some children and adults are freer than others because their biological dispositions and environmental contexts have combined to provide them with *greater rather than lesser options.* In some homes children have limited cognitive stimulus and moral teachings and, consequently, experience less of the cognitive and moral development that would render them more resistant to the draw of immediate gratification and more able to make decisions based on more long-range consequences.

Contemporary theories generally view children as being unable to take any action apart from the options that are presented by their environment. While we can use the wisdom of child-development theories to understand the formation of some of the parameters of human freedom, we must not allow this knowledge to deter us from a scriptural perspective that describes human beings as possessing existential freedom—the capacity to know right from wrong and the ability to choose one over the other. Having said this, we nevertheless feel compelled to acknowledge that due to physiological and environmental conditions, the range of choices among

individuals may vary greatly. In *Sin: Radical Evil in Soul and Society*, theologian Ted Peters surmises that "our social situation conscripts us into social sin frequently whether we know it or not, whether we will it or not" (1994, p. 287)

The issue of human freedom and responsible choice will be taken up in chapter six, when we address the question of a child's age of accountability, and continue through to chapter eleven, where we raise the question of accountability and responsibility among the elderly affected by dementia and other debilitating conditions.

The relational context of the self. A core assumption in our model of the reciprocating self is that the self is formed and maintained within a network or community of relationships. Developmental theories are consonant with this assumption to the extent that they posit a self structure. This is most central in object relations, social learning and symbolic-interaction theories. Whereas child-development theories have only recently leaned toward the view that children are active organisms, they have been in continuous agreement that human input is necessary if children are to take on human characteristics. Human behavior begets human behavior. Deprived of human social environment, there is very little in the biological structure of children that would induce them to embrace norms, values or attitudes. On the other hand, when children are nested within human community, they generally take on the attitudes and behaviors of that community.

We learn from Genesis 2:18 that human beings were created by God to live in community: "The LORD God said, 'It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a helper as his partner.'" The need to live in community is a common theme woven throughout the Old and New Testament. Humans require an empowering community of grace that is based on covenant commitment. This foundation leads to an intimacy within which they can experience the secure emotional bonding they crave.

Children need to be nurtured within an intimate family community. The unilateral covenant that parents make with their children can eventually mature and lead to a bilateral covenant. We have argued that this is the biblical ideal. The child-development literature offers two additional suggestions. First, developing the capacity to enter into covenantal relationships is contingent on the child's experiencing unconditional parental love. Research on infants and young children who receive little attentive care confirms this. Sociologist Ira Reiss (1980) declares, "The evidence in this area . . . indicates that some sort of emotionally nurturing relationship in the first few years of life between the child and some other individual is vital in the child's development" (p. 36).

Second, child-development theories suggest that human development is contingent on achieving language skills, self-identity and bonding capacity, in that order. The emotional nurturing, which Reiss asserts is imperative, can culminate in bonding ability only if the child is in the process of acquiring language skills and self-identity. Children, of course, need both emotional and cognitive interaction with their parents, a point that we made in the previous chapter.

Conclusion

This has not been a comprehensive overview of developmental theories. Rather, we have selected developmental theories in terms of their ability to inform our model of the reciprocating self. Several developmental theories are limited to more narrow preadult developmental age spans—John Bowlby's and Mary Ainsworth's attachment theory, Stern's theory of infant self-development, Marcia's theory of ego identity development, and Arnett's theory of emerging adulthood—and thus will be introduced in the appropriate lifespan development chapters. Other important developmental

theories are relevant to understanding adult development—Erikson, Gould, Vaillant and Levinson—and thus will be introduced in chapters ten and eleven. Before presenting chapters dealing with specific lifespan developmental stages, in chapter five we utilize the common emphasis on *relationality* to anchor our reciprocal self model within the RDS paradigm.

5

The Reciprocating Self and the Relation Developmental Systems Paradigm

Seeking a Common Ground Based on Relationality

> *Models derived from relational developmental systems thinking, and from a relational meta-model more generally, have become the predominant conceptual lens for the cutting-edge theory and methodological innovations guiding research in human development across the lifespan.*
>
> Richard Lerner

In chapter one we identified the lack of a guiding teleology in developmental theory as the *developmental dilemma.* Chapters two and three presented a theologically integrated model of human development based on teleological assumptions. In chapter four we sketched a general outline of human development in terms of a reciprocating self. We suggested that the reciprocating self carries a telos of theological significance in our tendency for relationship as beings created in the image of God. In this chapter we utilize *relationality* as the common ground for integrating the reciprocating self with the relational developmental systems (RDS) paradigm. As such, this chapter serves as a bridge between the reciprocating self model and the following

section, where we apply the model to lifespan developmental stages. Before moving to part two of this book, where we apply our model to understanding sequential lifespan stages, we briefly focus upon two theories that are helpful in understanding the wider sociocultural impact on development—Urie Bronfenbrenner's *ecological* theory for development, and *generation cohort* analysis.

The Relational Developmental Systems Paradigm

The RDS paradigm assumes that human development must be understood in the context of an individual's total bio-socio-cultural environment and the *relations* between each level. As such RDS seeks to incorporate all of the socially, culturally, psychologically and biologically based theories into one united whole, and in the process provide a lens for understanding how the development of the reciprocating self is embedded within interdependent developmental systems.

The RDS paradigm is an integrative approach to human development that seeks to incorporate all meaningful explanations of human development by recognizing the existence and importance of *relationality* between all contributing parts. Rather than adding together the percentage or amount each factor contributes to development, RDS is a relational model in that it conceptualizes each part of the developmental system being related to each other part. This means that the paradigm concentrates on the *interactive* effect of explanatory factors on human development. Further, reciprocal (two-way) interaction is conceived as existing not only between similar types of factors (all sociocultural factors related to one another and all biological factors related to each other), but rather that factors across domains are interrelated. The most obvious example of this is the rapidly accumulated evidence that the neurological system affects behavior and behavior affects the neurological

system. Such evidence for reciprocal determinism is responsible for the current explosion of self-help books and programs on *mindfulness.* Mindfulness generally refers to the practice of training/changing one's neurological system through careful regulation of one's behavior. The hoped-for result is that in changing the neurological system the desired behavior will be more "automatic" or a "natural" result that eases the need for demanding self-control.

Due to the similarities in the assumptions made about human development, we find RDS an extremely inviting perspective into which to integrate our theological model of the reciprocating self. RDS adds detail regarding the manner by which scaffolding might be conceptualized across the lifespan.

Ford and Lerner presented the forerunner of RDS as *developmental systems theory* (DST) in their book *Development Systems Theory: An Integrative Approach* (1992). Used as a basis for lifespan development, Lerner presented a more recent version of DST in his book *Concepts and Theories of Human Development* (2002). As is the case for systems theory in general, DST conceptualizes the organization of the human system as an interdependent whole, within which each part (unit or subsystem) is influenced by and in turn influences each other part in the human system as a whole. Although DST has progressively evolved toward paradigmatic status, the full emergence of the RDS paradigm is most completely realized with the publication of the four-volume seventh edition of *The Handbook of Child Psychology and Developmental Science* (Lerner, 2015). Although it is hard to do justice to all of the guiding assumptions suggested within the RDS paradigm, Lerner (2015, xxii) summarizes the defining features (see sidebar).

DEFINING FEATURES OF THE RELATIONAL DEVELOPMENTAL SYSTEMS PARADIGM

Relational Metatheory

Predicated on a philosophical perspective that transcends Cartesian dualism and atomism, theories derived from the relational developmental systems paradigm are framed by a relational metatheory for human development. This focus includes an emphasis on process and a rejection of all splits between components of the ecology of human development (e.g., between nature- and nurture-based variables, between continuity and discontinuity, and between stability and instability). Holistic syntheses replace dichotomies as well as reductionist partitions of the developing relational system through the integration of three relations moments of analysis: the identity of opposites, the opposites of identity and the syntheses of wholes. Deriving from the relational metatheory, relational developmental systems posit the organism as an inherently active, self-creating,self-organizing and self-regulating nonlinear complex adaptive system, which develops through embodied activities and actions, as they coact with a lived world of physical and sociocultural objects.

The Integration of Levels of Organization

Relational thinking with the rejection of Cartesian splits is associated with the idea that all levels of organization within the ecology of human development are integrated, or fused. These levels range from the

biological and physiological through the cultural and historical.

Developmental Regulation Across Ontogeny Involves Mutually Influential Individual →←Context Relations

As a consequence of the integration of levels, the regulation of development occurs through mutually influential connections among all levels of the developing relational system, ranging from genes and cell physiology through individual mental and behavioral functioning to society, culture, the designed and natural ecology and, ultimately, history. These mutually influential relations may be represented generically as Level 1→←, Level 2 (e.g., Family→←Community), and in the case of ontogeny may be represented as individual →←context.

Integrated Actions, Individual →←Context Relations, Are the Basic Unit of Analysis Within Human Development

The character of developmental regulation means that the integration of actions—of the individual on the context and of the multiple levels of the context on the individual (individual→←context)—constitutes the fundamental unit of analysis in the study of the basic process of human development.

Temporality and Plasticity in Human Development

As a consequence of the fusion of the historical level of analysis—and therefore temporality—in the levels of organization comprising the ecology of human development, the developing relational system is characterized by the potential for systemic change, by plasticity. Observed trajectories of intraindividual change may vary across time and place as a consequence of such plasticity.

Relative Plasticity

Developmental regulation may both facilitate and constrain opportunities for change. Thus, change in individual ↔ context relations is not limitless, and the magnitude of plasticity (the probability of change in a developmental trajectory occurring in relation to variation in contextual conditions) may vary across the lifespan and history. Nevertheless, the potential for plasticity at both individual and contextual levels constitutes a fundamental strength of all human development.

Intraindividual Change, Interindividual Differences in Intraindividual Change and the Fundamental Substantive Significance of Diversity

The combinations of variables across the integrated levels of organization within the developmental system that provide the basis of the developmental process will vary at least in part across individuals and groups. This diversity is systematic and lawfully produced by idiographic, group-differential and generic (nomothetic) phenomena. The range of interindividual differences in intraindividual change observed at any point in time is evidence of the plasticity of the developmental system, and makes the study of diversity of fundamental substantive significance for the description, explanation and optimization of human development.

Interdisciplinarity and the Need for Change-Sensitive Methodologies

The integrated levels of organization comprising the developmental system require collaborative analyses by scholars from multiple disciplines. Interdisciplinary

knowledge is a central goal. The temporal embeddedness and resulting plasticity of the developing system requires that research designs, methods of observation and measurement, and procedures for data analysis be change- and process-sensitive and able to integrate trajectories of change at multiple levels of analysis.

Optimism, the Application of Developmental Science and the Promotion of Positive Human Development

The potential for and instantiations of plasticity legitimate an optimistic and proactive search for characteristics of individuals and of their ecologies that, together, can be arrayed to promote positive human development across life. Through the application of developmental science in planned attempts (interventions) to enhance (e.g., through social policies or community-based programs) the character of humans' developmental trajectories, the promotion of positive human development may be achieved by aligning the strengths (operationalized as the potentials for positive change) of individuals and contexts.

Source: Table P.1 in Lerner (2015, xxii)

Relationalism

Developmental theories are conventionally evaluated on several important oppositional criteria—mechanistic versus organismic, nature versus nurture and continuous versus discontinuous. RDS attempts to move beyond such "splitting" of developmental viewpoints into oppositional camps (Overton, 2013). This is done by emphasizing the importance of understanding the *relationship* between factors contributing

to human development. Within RDS changing relations are the basic unit of analysis. Neither the individual nor context is emphasized in such theories; rather, the individual ← → context relations are the focus. RDS is an integrative, fused or relational paradigm that stresses the mutually influential connections among all levels of the development system, ranging from genes through society, culture, the designed and natural ecology, and history. In developmental systems theories the reciprocity between the developing person and his or her complex and changing context provides a means for studying and understanding development.

For example, RDS argues that components of development, such as nature and nurture, are not the causes of human development. Rather, the *relationship* of the components is what makes human development happen. This view, known as *relationalism*, conceptualizes human development as occurring through the interaction of person and context throughout the lifespan. The basis for change is anchored in relationships among the different systemic levels—biological, psychological, social, cultural and physical. RDS moves us beyond an additive model (heredity plus environment equals human behavior) to an *interactive* model in which the relationship among systems is the primary influence of behavior. There are two features of developmental systems theories that are important to stress in order to understand their use for conceptualizing positive development: relative plasticity and developmental regulation.

Relative plasticity is a concept used within RDS that seeks to move beyond the mechanistic versus organismic controversy. Relative plasticity refers to the ability for change across the lifespan and at multiple levels of the system. Although human agency—that human beings are active agents—is recognized, RDS also argues that the amount of choice, and thus change, is always constrained by past development and by present ecological conditions. Thus RDS defines human organisms as *relatively* plastic. Relationships

among the different levels within the human developmental system both facilitate and constrain opportunities for change. For example, change (learning a new language with native-speaker fluency during adolescence or adulthood) is constrained both by past developments (knowledge of your own native language) and by contemporary contextual conditions (the absence or presence of opportunities to immerse yourself in a new language and culture). Another example might be that I (Pam) am tone deaf. Given the limitations of my voice, no matter how much I intentionally try to cultivate my voice and influence my developmental system so that I might become a rock star, it is not going to happen. Plasticity suggests that I have the potential to change, but relative plasticity conveys that the change is not limitless.

Relative plasticity is explained by malleability and canalization. *Malleability* refers to the capacity (i.e., possibility) of the human being to develop along a vast array of possible trajectories. The range of development for any one individual is vast—from social worker to dictator. *Canalization* refers to the tendency of the human being to adapt to and be shaped by various elements in his or her experience. Canalization points to the *limitations* or narrowing of human responsiveness as a consequence of past experience. Thus, while an infinite variety of development trajectories is possible at birth, this range of trajectories is reduced by experiences that shape the individual. These experiences can be so powerful as to even alter individual DNA coding (Lerner, 2002).

RDS represents a modified organismic view of human development. Human beings are viewed as agents who are not only acted on but who act on their environment. Action (direction of influence) is viewed reciprocally: the individual acts on the system while at the same time the system acts on the individual. *Coaction* is a concept used in RDS to refer to events that occur in and affect multiple elements of a developing person and its environment.

The mutual influence between individual and context regulates the course of development. When these bidirectional influences maintain or improve the health or well-being of both components of individual ← → and context relations, they are termed *adaptive developmental regulations* (Lerner, 2002). From a developmental systems perspective healthy development involves positive changes in the relation between a developing person and a community supporting his or her development. A relationship between an individual and context that maintains and perpetuates the system is one in which the individual acts to support the institutions of society, and the institutions simultaneously support the healthy functioning and development of the individual. Thus it can be said that adaptive developmental regulations involve person-context relations that make positive contributions to self, family, community and society (Lerner, 2004, 2015; Lerner, Dowling & Anderson, 2003).

Lerner proposes an explicit developmental teleology. He suggests, "Adaptive developmental regulation results in the emergence among young people of an orientation to transcend self-interest and place value on and commitments to actions supportive of their social system" (Lerner, Dowling & Anderson, 2003, p. 176). Although actions that support a specific social system will vary by culture and era, in short, Lerner proposes that optimal development includes individuals who can reciprocate with their self, family, community and society (Lerner, 2004). In short, from a RDS perspective the goal of development is a reciprocating self.

The relational developmental system paradigm would view the development of the reciprocating self as an *epigenetic* process—development caused by the relations between the individual and the total environmental context. As such, human development always must be understood as *emergent*, as a process that is continually taking place. It is at this point that RDS addresses the continuity versus discontinuity issue. The emergent process must be understood as qualitative and

not merely quantitative change. Lerner (2002) states that human development is best conceived as "successive differentiated change," a phrase similar to how we describe the development of the reciprocating self. The reciprocal self continually emerges, but in its emergent state it becomes qualitatively different from what it was in the past. For example, humans are born as babies, and as we grow we do not just become larger babies. Rather, our personality, body, goals, spirituality and so on change over time because of the mutual relations between ourselves and our context (Overton, 2013).

Figure 5.1 represents the developmental contextual view of human development. The central focal point in this figure is the child, represented by the large circle at the left center. The many systemic levels *internal* to children are represented by the "pie" shapes within the circle—biological, cognitive, personality and so forth. The many systemic levels *external* to the children are outside of this circle. Two-way arrows connecting the child to the school network, the social network, the marriage network and the work network represent the primary social systems the child is embedded in. The most important of the child's relationships is with the parent, thus the larger circle (within which are the systems *internal* to the parent). Note that each of the other social systems—school, social and marriage networks—are composed of subunits that are subsystems themselves. (For instance, the school network is composed of two units—teachers and classmates—that are themselves social systems.) At the wider level the child is also affected by (and in turn affects) the community, social, cultural and designed and natural environmental systems.

Finally, the developmental context for a child exists within a time dimension. All human development is embedded in history, including the changing context within which the child and the environment interact. For example, along with the changing diets, nutrition and eating habits over time has

come a change in the average weight and height of children. The changing historical context has even affected lifespan markers, such as the onset of menarche among girls and the emergence of secondary sexual characteristics (voice change and body hair) among boys. The temporal dimension obviously continues to be an important dimension through a person's developmental lifespan, culminating with increased longevity and sophisticated medical care during the elderly years.

In RDS we have an understanding of human beings as inextricably embedded in their contexts. Thus when it comes to understanding human development, the unit of analysis must be the person-context relation. Although complex, figure 5.1 illustrates how RDS might be considered a metatheory capable of incorporating many other developmental theories within it. Parenthetically, it might be noted that RDS points to a cautionary approach in attempting to build a science of human development based on controlled or "pure" scientific methods. Studying development in so-called controlled environments does not provide information on the relationships between individually distinct people and their unique contexts. What is most needed is the study of human development in real-world settings, those involving people in their natural contexts.

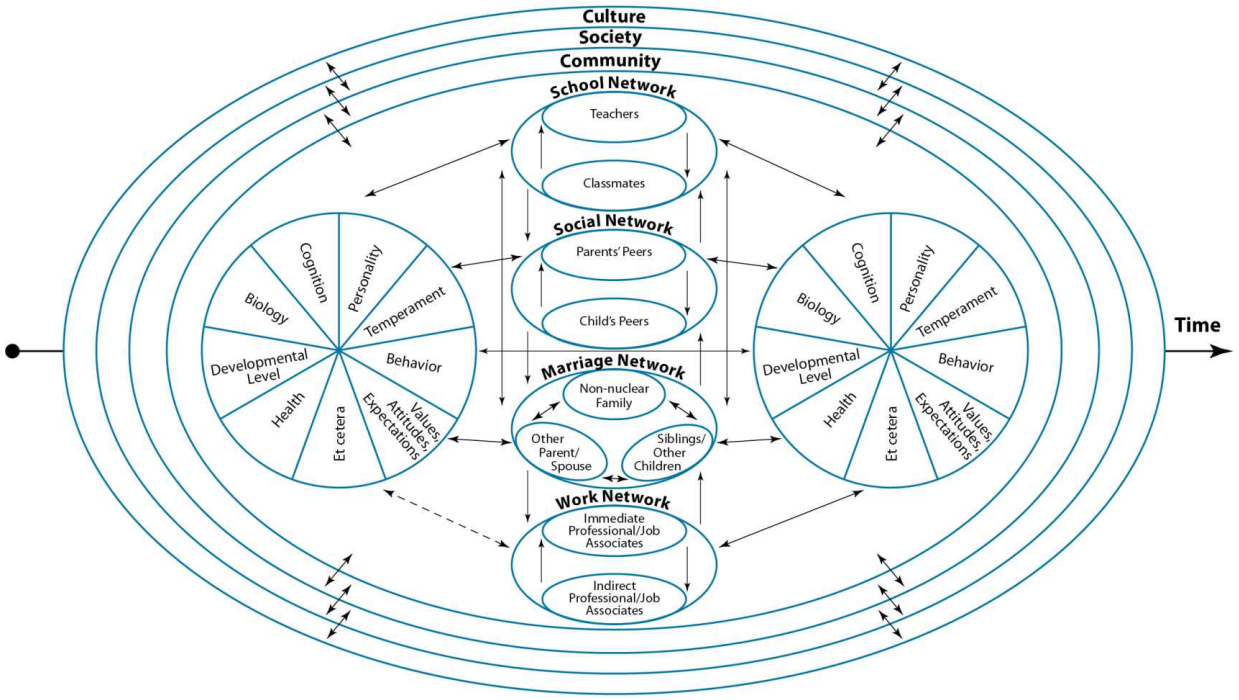


Figure 5.1. The developmental contextual view of human development

Understanding how people relate to their natural settings is at the heart of the reciprocating self. RDS provides a helpful lens for understanding how the self takes shape through the mutual influences between the individual and his or her developmental context. The ideal of becoming an individual who reciprocates with self, family, community and society comports with our understanding of the reciprocating self. Although RDS bases its teleological assumption on an evolutionary perspective—providing a theory that is based on the progress of society and individuals through adaptive developmental regulation (see Lerner, 2004; Lerner, Dowling & Anderson, 2003)—it provides a similar goal to that of the reciprocating self. An obvious difference is the emphasis on a relationship with God in the reciprocating self.

Bronfenbrenner: Roles and Ecosystems

The son of a zoologist, Urie Bronfenbrenner was trained at an early age to observe development in the wilderness. Bronfenbrenner spent most of his career teaching at Cornell University, where he pioneered a theoretical outline of human growth in context. His *Ecology of Human Development* (1979) was something of a watershed event. Prior to that time development was envisioned, as Bronfenbrenner notes with some sarcasm, as the study of strange child behaviors in strange situations. Bronfenbrenner alludes to the famous "strange situation" of Karen Main's attachment theory, an attempt to use an unfamiliar set of events to observe the child's level of security with a primary caregiver. Instead of imposing artificial constraints on the study of development, Bronfenbrenner argued for a naturalistic kind of observation that was grounded in human relationships.

For Bronfenbrenner, all people move through various relational contexts, each with unique possibilities that influence development. Moreover, we learn to assume different roles given shifting contexts. An undergraduate student knows that she plays one role with her sorority friends, namely that of fun-loving sister and confidant to her peer group. But the same student knows that her sorority role is not appropriate for her upper-division courses in electrical engineering. With her professors she is serious, studious and task-oriented. Once again, this same student recognizes that neither of these roles is appropriate when she is home for the summer. With mom and dad she has a familiar if slightly strained relationship, which is being renegotiated as she moves from adolescence into an adult child. The undergraduate knows that she "plays" these different roles in each context, yet the wide distance between her various selves does not cause undue stress or concern. In fact, she makes these transitions seamlessly and is barely aware that role transitions are taking place.

Our undergraduate's reciprocating self is able to sustain these various roles because at her core she has developed representations of past experiences and relationships that provide her with a sure footing. To put this in Eriksonian terms, she has acquired an *identity.* The strength of Erikson's identity theory is that our core self remains unchanged while moving through a variety of social contexts. Social contexts and relationships influence our identities, but in the presence of well-formed identity, changes are incremental and subject to our opinion of them. While social context is indicated for identity formation, Erikson had no means for interpreting the various contexts through which relationships are established and nurtured. Bronfenbrenner's key contribution is that he systematized "domains" of relationships, or social interaction, that play a unique role in development. Bronfenbrenner noted that the basis for stable role transitioning and the basis for the reciprocating self begins with the *dyad.*

Dyad simply means "two." Bronfenbrenner observed that the child's dyadic relationship with a primary caregiver constitutes a vital social context that becomes a core experience of other relationships. Through a dyadic relationship with a parent, the child learns how to relate more broadly to others. The dyadic relationship is Bronfenbrenner's overture to attachment, assigning special importance to early developmental processes between the infant and a primary caregiver, usually the mother. We will examine attachment relationships more closely with infancy in chapter six. What distinguished Bronfenbrenner's view of the dyad is that the object of study is not just the child's psychological state but the dyadic relationship itself. Bronfenbrenner notes that

> the ecology of human development involves the scientific study of the progressive, mutual accommodation between an active, growing human being

> and the changing properties of the immediate settings in which the growing person lives, as this process is affected by relations between these settings, and by the larger contexts in which the settings are embedded. (1979, p. 21)

Bronfenbrenner contends that it is the child's interactions with others that constitute an authentic basis for development. He referred to the growing child's web of social interactions in terms of relational *reciprocity*, recognizing that the child is not a passive agent but acts on his or her environment and is able to change it, even at a very early age.

Consider the following scenario. You are at a doctor's office and have waited for an appointment for over half an hour. During that time you have established a kind of polite distance with most of the people in the room. Intermittently you have had eye contact with many of them, sometimes exchanging smiles. But it is clear that no one is really interested in talking today, even about the weather. Then a young mother enters the waiting room with her eight-month-old infant son. The two sit down a couple of chairs away from you. The infant is adorable, cooing and touching his mother's face. His mother reciprocates, nuzzling and softly speaking to him. All of a sudden, the waiting room environment is changed. People are smiling as if sharing some kind of insider's secret. Two older women seated across from the mother and son begin a conversation about their grandchildren. The infant drops a toy and a young man immediately reaches across the aisle to pick it up. Even the nurses and administrators in the office are affected—you can hear them talking about their children behind the counter as they do their office work.

Ecologically speaking, the infant in this scene is actively engaged with his environment. He is able to change the collective mood of the waiting room simply through his

interactions with his mother. The reciprocity between mother and son are extended to include others, who then act reciprocally with complete strangers or distant colleagues. Bronfenbrenner notes that development is never restricted to a single relationship (such as with the mother) or even a small system (such as a nuclear family). Instead, development is a *nested phenomenon.* Like the fabled Russian nested wooden dolls, development is nested in various contexts of reciprocal relationships.

In order to effectively pinpoint dyads in their contexts, Bronfenbrenner had to outline boundaries for nested social contexts, or in his terminology, *ecosystems* (see fig. 5.2). The smallest system began with the caregiver-child dyadic relationship. This comprised the *microsystem*, where reciprocal interactions form patterns significant to the child's relationships with others beyond the dyad. Slightly beyond the microsystem is the *mesosystem*, or a system of microsystems. The mesosystem involves two or more participation settings. For a kindergarten girl this might include her relationships with her nuclear family, her classmates at school, her church friends and her same-aged neighbors. For her father the mesosystem would similarly include his nuclear family but also work colleagues and golfing friends. The mesosystem is an intermediate realm of relationships that constitutes a wide variety of intimacy and familiarity.

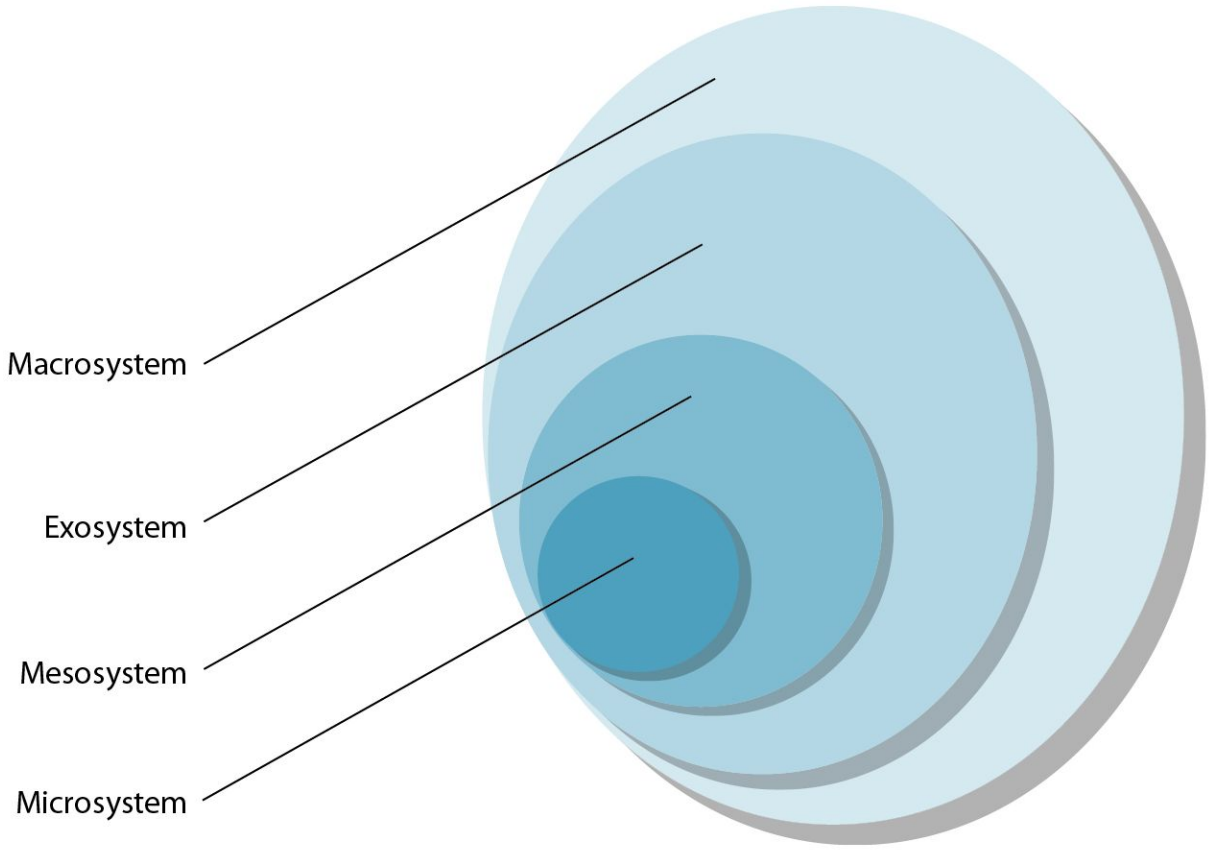


Figure 5.2. Bronfenbrenner's ecosystems of social context

Beyond the mesosystem is the *exosystem*. The exosystem does not involve the developing person directly as a participant. However, events in the exosystem do affect the developing person. For the same kindergartner, dad's place of work is a part of her exosystem. Her older brother's soccer team is a part of her exosystem. Exosystems exert considerable influence on the developing person but from a distance, usually through some sort of intermediary figure such as a parent or sibling.

The dyadic microsystem is nested even further within the *macrosystem*, or cultural level of reciprocal influence. Macrosystemic influences are evident in the media, the government and the cultural practices that are acceptable to

the immediate social context. If our kindergartner found herself growing up in urban Toronto, her macrosystem would consist of cultural variables typical of a large, cosmopolitan city. In such an environment ethnic diversity is common along with a spectrum of wealthy, poor and middle-class economic groups living together in close proximity. Pluralism might be a macrosystemic value operative in her environment. Relative to kindergartners growing up in rural Nebraska, the Toronto girl might have more exposure to various elements of urban life, such as neighborhood crime, crowding and pollution. Note that while Bronfenbrenner's ecological scheme is primarily focused on relationships, the physical characteristics of each system are also emphasized with regard to development. Thus the Canadian kindergartner's exposure to urban smog might make her susceptible to asthma, an influence on her overall well-being and development.

Bronfenbrenner notes that as we grow, we are increasingly enabled to move between systems of relationship and social influence. Like the undergraduate woman living in a sorority and pursuing an engineering degree, we learn through processes of reciprocation how to position ourselves appropriately given the expectations and boundaries of a given context. It is in learning how to manage these role transitions, Bronfenbrenner argues, that we are developing. The challenge of adapting to new environments, roles and relationships requires a self that is plastic or adaptive. In this Bronfenbrenner echoes Piaget, who made a case for cognitive dissonance as the means by which developmental growth occurs. But unlike Piaget, Bronfenbrenner envisions these transitions to be embedded in unique influences of particular ecosystems.

Biology of Relationships and Reciprocity

Lerner and Bronfenbrenner stand as theoretical giants—outlining complementary theories of relationship and reciprocity. Of course, valid developmental science must subject theory to empirical verification. Good theories prove themselves with a legacy of scientific studies yielding compelling support. Less adequate theories unravel once science is afforded opportunity for close scrutiny. What scientific findings support or dispel the claims of Lerner and Bronfenbrenner? To be sure, developmental scientists can't boil relationship and reciprocity down to simple nuts and bolts. However, recent work on specialized neurons in the brain has scientists talking about the mechanics of human relationships and social development. These cells, known as von Economo neurons (VENs; Allman, Watson, Tetreault & Hakeem, 2005; von Economo, 1926) and fork cells (Ngowyang, 1936) are heavily represented in portions of the brain responsible for social emotions, empathy and intuition. They are found only in the brains of humans, higher apes, whales and elephants—animals with sophisticated social interactions and networks. More compelling is the recent finding that individuals crippled with a severe form of dementia known as *behavior variant fronto-temporal dementia* (bvFTD) experience widespread destruction of VENs and fork cells.

The implications of a bvFTD diagnosis are chilling. First identified in the Victorian era, bvFTD is characterized by rapid change to personality with dramatic, negative implications for relationships and reciprocity. Progressing considerably faster than Alzheimer's disease, bvFTD victims quickly lose the ability to be empathic, manage impulses and act appropriately in social situations. The behavior of bvFTD victims can become morally unconcerned, even criminal or sociopathic. As the disease progresses, victims become distant and emotionally disengaged. Hygiene is compromised or forgotten. Some become explosively aggressive or violent. BvFTD effectively robs its victims of a key component in RDS and ecosystemic theories of human development—the ability to

adaptively understand self in the context of relationships framed by time, place and role. It remains beyond the reach of modern science to study the activity of selected neurons in living brain tissue. However, it is possible to conduct postmortem studies of brains taken from individuals afflicted with bvFTD. A group at the University of California, San Francisco, has spent the past decade looking at these brains (Kim, Sidhu, Gaus, Huang, Hof, Miller, DeArmond & Seeley, 2012).

Unlike Alzheimer's dementia patients, the brains of bvFTD victims show selective neuronal death focused on VENs and fork cells. Both neurons are heavily represented in the anterior cingulate cortex (ACC) and frontoinsula (FI), brain regions implicated in social information processing, social emotion and empathy. Significantly, VENs and fork cells are more heavily populated in the right hemisphere, considered a locus for social information processing. VEN and fork-cell death in this hemisphere proved to be highly correlated with bvFTD (Kim et al., 2012). In effect, the death of these cells, particularly in the right hemisphere, divests bvFTD victims of the capacity to maintain meaningful relationships and reciprocity across varied contexts and lifespan changes. Study authors suggest that selective destruction of VENs and fork cells erodes the brain's capacity to integrate social information (including context appropriateness) with emotions able to govern moral and socially appropriate behaviors (such as guilt). Without this internal governance, the bvFTD victim is compromised in her or his ability to participate in the constantly changing world of relationships and reciprocal interaction. RDS and ecosystemic theories of development are, to a significant extent, built on relational adaptation. The unfortunate story of bvFTD suggests these theories appropriately engage the "real world" of adaptation at the biological level.

We are now at a point where we might pull together our discussion on behalf of the reciprocating self in social

context. Representations of selves and others are formed in dyadic zones of proximal development where scaffolding enables the child to explore and realize skills. Representations of a reciprocating self are forged in the dynamic web of relationships that characterize the individual's social contexts: from the dyad to family, neighborhood, community and culture. In adolescence the individual learns to sustain representations of self in tension with other selves that play context-specific roles but without compromising the integrity of the core self. In adulthood these representations are solidified in a manner that permits a wide variety of reciprocal relationships, where the individual is able to influence others and their respective contexts. Finally, elderly persons again need scaffolding in order to allow semi-independent behavior where diminished physical and mental abilities make self-care more difficult.

Reciprocating Patterns: Culture and Generations

The reciprocating self is visible in a number of ecosystems, each of which provides different scaffolding for development. Let's take a moment to reflect on the development of the reciprocating self in context. So far we have sketched a fairly individualized reciprocating self, reflecting a Western view of human development and relationships. However, many Eastern cultures think about human development in communalistic terms. We would be wise to ask whether there are communal patterns for the reciprocating self in human development. Put a different way, we should pay special attention to the means by which Bronfenbrenner's cultural-macrosystem scheme results in developmental patterns for large groups. Culture implies a collective way of life and is an immensely important contributor to the formative process of persons within it. Anthropologist Ralph Linton has noted

that culture is to a human being as water is to a fish. Linton asks us to imagine a fish that lived its entire life in water. One day swimming upward toward the surface, it emerges into air. The great discovery to the fish, Linton observes, is not air but rather that its entire life was lived in a different substance—water. In a similar sense humans can live their whole lives within their own culture and not be aware of its influence on them. It is not until a person "breaks the surface of culture" by spending time in another, that he or she becomes more fully aware of the macrosystem.

Generational Analysis

Whereas cultures are fairly stable and enduring, they do change over time. Thus it is important to identify the major cultural issues that preoccupy a society during the formative years of an individual. *Generational analysis* represents an attempt to identify cultural phenomena that significantly affect the developmental process. Within life-course theory, this is represented in terms of *historical time* (see Lerner, 2002, p. 236).

The term g*eneration* has been used in a variety of ways, including different biblical applications. The Old Testament word *dor* ("generation") carries the root idea *to go around, to go in a circle, to inhabit or dwell for a time, an age or a period of time*. Thus in Ecclesiastes 1:4, 9-10, we read,

> A generation goes, and a generation comes,
> but the earth remains forever. . . .
> What has been is what will be,
> and what has been done is what will be done;
> there is nothing new under the sun.
> Is there a thing of which it is said,
> "See, this is new?"

It has already been, in the ages before us.

Jesus sometimes referred to his audience as a generation: "Truly I tell you, this generation will not pass away until all these things have taken place" (Mk 13:30; see also Lk 7:31; 17:25). More frequently, Jesus used *genea* ("generation") to address a specific segment of his audience that was distinguished by a common moral characteristic or flaw—"this adulterous and sinful generation" (Mk 8:38), "you faithless generation" (Mk 9:19), and "this generation is an evil generation" (Lk 11:29). The apostle Paul also distinguished "the saints," who as the children of God were to do all things without murmuring and arguing—from the "crooked and perverse generation" among whom they were to shine like stars in the world (Phil 2:15). Taken together we might infer that *generation* usually refers to age differences in understanding, along with different responses to culture. As an illustration we will give overviews of two approaches to generational analysis.

The most comprehensive attempt at generational analysis is found in William Strauss and Neil Howe's book *Generations: The History of America's Future, 1584-2069* (1991). Strauss and Howe identify a recurring cycle of four distinct types of peer personalities, arriving in the same repeating sequence. They label four generation types, including *idealist*, *reactive*, *civic* and *adaptive.* The characteristics of each generation are formed by what is going on when individuals reach adulthood. Idealist and civic generations enter the adult years during a period of spiritual awakening, while reactive and adaptive generations reach this phase of life during a secular crisis. Strauss and Howe define a generation as a special cohort group whose births span a basic phase of life, usually about twenty-two years. Thus the generational cycle covers roughly ninety years before it repeats. Each

generation is on the stage for a limited period of time, parading unique styles, customs and characteristics.

The last complete generational cycle began with those born between 1860 and 1882. These were idealists who formed the *missionary generation.* This was followed by those born between 1883 and 1900, a *reactive* or *lost generation.* The *civic generation* was born between 1901 and 1924; it is also known as the *G.I. generation* or as "The Great Generation." This was followed by the *silent (adaptive) generation* born between 1925 and 1942. Following the silent generation came the *baby boomers*, born between 1943 and 1960. Boomers initiated a new cycle as *idealists*, redefining the inner world of values and culture. Following the boomers was Generation X, a *reactive* cohort critical of the previous excesses, born between 1961 and 1981. Those born between 1982 and 2003 constitute the new civic generation called *millennials.* As millennials have entered the workforce and placed themselves for leadership positions, some would question if they are committed to civic values in the same way as the previous civic G.I. generation. Millenialists argue that they are willing to work hard, but not at the expense of their personal self-fulfillment. A successor silent generation is emerging (2004–present), tentatively referred to by such names as *postmillennialist, homeland* or *iGen* to reflect what some consider current cultural tendencies toward developing narcissistic children. Both parents and parenting experts differ on the wisdom of hovering "helicopter" parenting, parenting that focuses on building up a child's "self-esteem," or a need to infuse an emphasis on strong discipline in the parenting process. An overview of generations is given in table 5.1.

Table 5.1. Generational transitions and characteristics

Generation	Years	Characteristics

	of Birth	
G.I.'s	1901 - 1924	World War I, II: hard work; safe, loyal (civic); the Great Depression, cautious, intolerant
Silent	1925 - 1942	Peace and fit in; don't question (adaptive); prosperity
Baby Boomers	1943 - 1960	Large numbers; cause-oriented (idealist); protest war; challenge system; affluence; question authority, electronic media
Generation X	1961 - 1981	Broken families; feel neglected and lonely (reactive); dual earners; practical education; hesitant to commit
Millennials	1982 - 2003	Computer, the Internet, return to civic values?
Homeland/iGen	2004 -	Return to tradition; connected by cellphone; postmillennials present safety at home

While the Strauss and Howe scheme has merit, an alternative view of generational interpretation was provided by Karl Mannheim (1952). Mannheim's perspective has been refined by Vern Bengtson. Mannheim argued that distinctions between "generations" are somewhat arbitrary, but sometimes youth in sufficient numbers experience a *fresh contact* with culture. Culture is developed by individuals who come into contact anew with the accumulated heritage. In the nature of our physical makeup, a fresh contact (meeting something anew) always means a changed relationship of distance from the object and a novel approach in assimilating, using and developing the preferred material (Mannheim, 1952, p. 294).

Fresh contact with culture most significantly influences youth, distinguishing them as a *generational unit.* Whereas a generational cohort includes all members of a generational

age group, a generational unit includes *all members of a generation who have developed a common consciousness and response to a sociohistorical situation.* Generational units develop a *generational personality*, which is recognized and determined by (1) common age location, (2) common beliefs and behavior, and (3) perceived membership in a common generation. It is common life experience that forms generational personality. Obviously, generational personality implies the reciprocating self, not as an individualistic concept but in a collective or shared sense among persons within the generational unit. Intergenerational differences and similarities result from the fresh contact of succeeding generations with accumulating cultural heritage of a society.

Baby Boomers, Hippies and Jesus People

Mannheim's approach to generational analysis is perhaps best understood through the baby boomer generational cohort. Boomers gained their name from the birth boom that immediately followed World War II. Most boomers entered adolescence or young adulthood during the 1960s. Research on the 1960s indicates that young and old did not share the same perception of external reality, and this difference in perception resulted in part from differences in position through the lifespan (Ahammer & Baltes, 1972; Bengtson & Kuypers, 1971). Youth during the 1960s experienced a fresh contact with a cultural ideal, summed up in a memorable challenge through the acceptance speech of President John F. Kennedy—"Ask not what your country can do for you; ask what you can do for your country."

Boomers nurtured an idealism that was highly critical of what they perceived to be hypocrisy. During the early 1960s, protests formed around the issues of student rights, the war in Vietnam and the counterculture movement led by hippies. Major social institutions—government, churches, schools,

businesses and families—were perceived as being overly rigid and unresponsive to change. The hippie movement could best be understood as a reaction against three aspects of the American middle class: *compulsive consumption, passive spectatorship* and *time held captive by the clock* (Davis, 1967, pp. 10-18).

Although counterculture youth shared some of these overarching ideals, many simply dropped out of society, choosing drugs and an alternative, hedonistic lifestyle. Still others became seriously involved in political action against what they saw as an unresponsive establishment. By the end of the 1960s the Jesus People movement emerged as a generational unit within the wider baby boomer cohort.

The Jesus People phenomenon provides an interesting example of the type of influence the macrosystem can have on persons during their adolescence. The Jesus People showcased an unlikely combination of conservative Christian belief system with the hippie symbols of long hair, beards, rock music, castoff clothes and open rejection of the American status quo.

As an alternative Christian movement, Jesus People expressed their beliefs through gospel rock music instead of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century hymns, and through psychedelic art forms and underground gospel newspapers instead of religious publishing houses. Fresh contact with a conservative approach to Christianity resulted (as Mannheim would have predicted) in an identification of religious inconsistencies with an attempt to establish an alternative expression of Christianity.

One of the functions of organized religion is to perpetuate the values of a culture from generation to generation. To an extent the Jesus People altered this process. They chose a theologically conservative protest to the organized church. Jesus People criticized liberal Christianity for its failure to recognize human beings in an alienated state and needing to be rightly related to God.

They criticized conservative Christianity for mere lip service to a personal gospel that was often unloving, intolerant and discriminatory. They saw American Christians as obsessed with building expensive and lavish church buildings (the practice that Roman Catholic bishop Fulton Sheen labeled our "edifice complex"). They saw the church as an organization whose objective was to be served, not to serve. For Jesus People traditional church services were archaic, with one-way pulpit communication that allowed no opportunity for dialogue. The Jesus People reacted against this kind of institutional rigidity in a manner similar to the relativistic emptiness of the youth counterculture. Thus cultural influences through the macrosystem are capable of shaping generations, potentially influencing the social institutions that shape future generations and the reciprocating self (Bengtson & Black, 1973; Strauss & Howe, 1991).

Concluding Thoughts: Developmental Theory and Practical Atheism

We have outlined some important theories that help shape our understanding of development. The theories of Lerner, Overton and Bronfenbrenner are helpful in understanding the formation of the reciprocating self. Generational-analysis perspectives are highly theoretical in nature, focusing on macrosystemic or cultural factors that influence the reciprocating self. Because this book is interested in practical outcomes, we should step back for a moment and reflect on just what "theory" is and how theory should be considered in a rapidly changing world where social science is often misunderstood.

It is a difficult time for psychology and sociology. The prevailing atmosphere of postmodernism has raised questions over whether social science is a valid field and if the

traditional scientific affinity for theory in fact represents singular points of view that are misleading in their universal claim of truth. Defining postmodernism is a tricky thing, but for our purposes *postmodernism* can be characterized as rejecting the assumption that through reason human beings may find universal truth. Beginning with Nietzsche and growing through the work of Foucault, Derrida, Lyotard and Gadamer, postmodern philosophy mounted a frontal assault on the credibility of social science by questioning whether people can be adequately understood through psychological or sociological theories. For the postmodern, the reciprocating self is a potentially dangerous *metanarrative*, or universal claim, for developmental processes that cannot accommodate the diversity of human experience. Thus, the reciprocating self could become an imposition of the authors' backgrounds and experiences. In the case of this author (Kevin), the reciprocating self might reflect a particular ethnic (European), gendered (male) and socioeconomic (middle-class) perspective. The reciprocating self may prove completely irrelevant to the African American teenager, the Latina farm worker or the Japanese American internment survivor. In the mind of the postmodern the reciprocating self is limited as a theory of practical significance, apparently reflecting the viewpoint of a single social grouping.

We acknowledge a potentially valuable counterpoint in the postmodern critique of developmental theory, and in particular the reciprocating self as sketched in this chapter. Consequently, we do not propose that the reciprocating self, despite its context-sensitive outlook, is a developmental theory that accommodates human development in its totality. Yet we are also unwilling to relegate the reciprocating self to the margins of relativism, noting that to do so would be to forfeit our Christian conviction that all truth is God's truth, wherever it may be found. Rather than live unanchored in the middle of this tension, we prefer

to take a step toward a solution that in our thinking is *integrative* in its theological consideration of psychology and specifically the reciprocating self.

We suspect that the great debate about whether truth is foundational or relative obscures a more immediate concern. The nineteenth-century Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard once remarked that society is constantly tempted to live as if God does not exist. Kierkegaard called this temptation *practical atheism*, noting that Christians and atheists alike are capable of behaving as if God does not exist (Gay, 1998). Kierkegaard noted that even in the Christian church there is much planning and laboring that proceeds as if God were absent or at best a distant onlooker. We are concerned that the modern scientist and the postmodern critic, by making all-or-nothing claims to truth, are at risk of behaving in a manner that is practically atheistic. For the Christian, truth is embodied not as an abstraction but in terms of a relationship. Jesus invites us to know truth not simply as a cognitive, rationalist prescription but in and through his own person. Jesus states that he is "the way, the truth, and the life." In our estimation the truth noted in any theory, including the reciprocating self, is subjected to reconciliation between what is seen in the developmental worlds of Lerner or Bronfenbrenner, and what is not seen in the sovereignty of the risen Christ. Indeed, the reciprocating self we have proposed in this chapter remains a witness of these two contexts of exchange and meaning. So the reciprocating self is an ad hoc theoretical position, one that claims not to be universal in any theoretical sense but that does make a claim to truth, emerging as it does from a theistic commitment to God's role as architect of all that is true. In our interest to avoid practical atheism we perceive the reciprocating self as a developmental theory that is "both already and not yet." The reciprocating self is already evident in human developmental processes, but it is not yet realized in its theological richness through the

reconciliation of human beings in the grace and love of Christ.

The reciprocating self should probably be thought of as more than mere theory. We might go a step further to call it a theologically integrative motif in our understanding of human experience through social-scientific lenses. Moreover, it is an integrative experience that, while articulated by Western scholars, is potentially applicable to other cultures and diverse populations. The “not yet” aspect of the reciprocating self, true to its reciprocal nature, seeks dialogue with difference. With this caveat, we now turn in the interest of better understanding an appropriately theistic basis for human development.

PART II

Lifespan Stages

In part two we trace the development of the self from birth to death, noting the relational context in which the self develops and changes. Daniel Levinson (1996) notes that development is continual and can be at the same time up (*adolescing*) or down (*senescing*). Here we encounter the *developmental dilemma*, namely, what criteria can be used to distinguish *adolescing* from *senescing*. Developmental teleology and the concept of the reciprocating self as presented in part one will serve as the underlying principles to follow human development throughout life.

Part two is divided into six sequential chapters, each devoted to a major human developmental lifespan stage. Each of the lifespan development chapters is organized according to the following outline. First, we give a brief overview of the developmental tasks of the present stage of development. Next, we discuss the important neurological/physiological/neuropsychological factors/issues that one needs to understand in this specific developmental stage. A description of the type of scaffolding typically needed during this developmental stage follows. This helps us to examine the nested contexts development takes place in. Specifically, we begin by describing the microsystem, that level where dyadic relationships are the core focus of attention. Next, our attention moves to the mesosystem: the important group contexts where development takes place. Then

we take up the influence of the exosystem, those systems that impact an individual even though they are not a participant in the system. Finally, we examine the macrosystem as a cultural context for understanding human development. The last section of each chapter gives an overview of the potential strengths, limitations and developmental issues of the person as a reciprocating self.

6

Infancy

The Emergence of the Reciprocating Self

THE NATURAL WORLD IS FULL OF SURPRISES. Perhaps nowhere is this more evident than in the life of an infant. Some years ago developmental psychologists believed that infants were confined to the physical limitations of the brain, in a manner similar to an autistic child. Consequently, infancy was perceived as a cute and inaccessible developmental period. Serious study of infant development lagged behind other lifespan stages simply because infants could not tell researchers what it was like to be an infant. Worse, developmental researchers themselves had no memory of infancy. However, it turns out that infant development is filled with remarkable and unexpectedly complex phenomena.

In this chapter we will outline the reciprocating self for infant development, gradually expanding our discussion to consider ecosystemic contexts of influence. Given the importance in this section of the book of establishing developmental boundaries, we will confine our discussion of infancy to the first two years of life. First, we will briefly review physical development for infants as a foundational basis for the reciprocating self. Second, we will review work on the brain and self that enable infants to build and sustain relationships significant to reciprocation. In particular, we will focus our discussion on the

attachments infants form with a primary caregiver. Third, we will review twelve different features of the developing self in infancy. Finally, we will consider the parenting literature in order to understand how unconditional love, gracing and empowering can be applied on behalf of the infant child. We will extend this parenting overview to a discussion of how the infant self is potentially scaffolded across the ecosystem.

Physical Development

Although she cannot tell us about it, a four-month-old infant girl is a reflection of the *imago Dei.* Biologically speaking, her ability to act on, sense and perceive the world is fundamentally geared toward adaptation. It is our contention that the infant's physical development is essentially adaptive because changes in her body anticipate relationship with other human beings and God. Whereas many mammals are physically able to defend themselves or run away from a threat just after birth, humans require months to obtain these capacities. In fact, the young infant is wholly dependent on a caregiver for defense or flight in the face of danger. The character of infancy is such that even the development of gross motor skills and perception are related to the quality of relational bonding with caregivers. In the absence of a caring relationship infants may suffer profound biological (neurological) impairment or delayed development, a sad lesson observed in Eastern European orphanages of the early 1990s, where a single caregiver might have been responsible for dozens or even hundreds of infant children.

It is beyond the scope of this book to provide an in-depth review of physical development in infancy. Consequently, our discussion is focused on two aspects of physical growth that are foundational to relationships and ultimately to a reciprocating self. First, we note that as relational beings,

humans have the ability to act on their world. At a basic level human action is physically expressed in terms of reflexes, along with gross and fine motor skills. Second, humans are able to sense their world. This may be immediately adaptive in terms of sensing a threat, but more often this means that the infant is developing the capacity to learn from and about his or her environment, including the people that live within it.

Infancy is a period of rapid neurological development. During the initial months of life the brain is forming many new neurological connections known as *synaptic pathways.* The brain is also becoming better connected with the rest of the body through the *myelination* of axons, or basic nerve fibers. Myelin is a kind of fatty insulation that permits neural impulses to travel more quickly and efficiently through nerves, providing improved responses between the brain and limbs. We commonly understand this in terms of *coordination*. These processes are just getting underway in early life. Because a newborn lacks extensively organized neurological connections and myelination, the brain is unable to effectively suppress a cry related to hunger or pain. Later in infancy, changes to the brain facilitate better regulation of these and other impulses. Improved neurological connections and myelination are directly implicated in the development of motor skills.

Reflexes, gross and fine motor skills. Reflexes, or involuntary reactions to external events, are an important aspect of early human survival. Consider the significance of reflexes for the hungry infant. Without the reflexive ability to suck, an infant would be unable to feed. Associated with sucking, an infant must be able to locate a nipple for the purpose of feeding, a kind of rooting reflex that babies can accomplish from birth. Of course the infant must be able to communicate hunger to a caregiver, reflexively expressed in terms of crying. After feeding, the infant may need to burp, possibly spitting up in the process. This reflex action,

familiar to parents and caregivers the world over, prevents overfeeding. By definition the involuntary nature of reflexes suggests a fairly basic level of neurological development. Indeed, some reflexive behaviors, such as sucking, are evident while an infant is still in the mother's womb.

Gross motor skills are premised on reflexes. The infant's ability to wave arms, crawl, walk and jump are eventual consequences of gross motor development. The first two years of life include tremendous gains in the coordination of gross motor skills. By the age of six months most infants are able to belly crawl with raised head, progressing to full-fledged crawling by nine months. Standing and walking usually come shortly thereafter. The rapidly increasing range of gross motor skills enables an infant to explore the world and to discover many new things. Parental monitoring and supervision are particularly important during this period; infants and toddlers are at risk of physical harm from electrical outlets, household chemicals, ledges and deep water (e.g., swimming pools).

Whereas gross-motor-skill development is characterized by sudden accomplishments, fine motor skills are acquired incrementally. *Grabbing* represents one of the most important examples of fine motor development. In the first couple of months an infant is unable to grab objects, although arms may flail at the sight of some desired item. Intentional touching may follow by three months, but not until five months can babies consistently grab and successfully hold onto an object. The refined coordination required to grab an object leads to increasingly sophisticated fine motor control; then, infants begin to manipulate items within reach. Gibson (1988) notes that the onset of fine motor development enables what she terms the "eye-hand-mouth" exploratory system. Consequently, fine motor development is centrally implicated in the infant's ability to experience and understand the world.

Sensation. A growing infant must be able to navigate his or her environment on the basis of sensation and perception. It is important to note that in development sensation and perception are not synonymous. Sensation and perception are related principles, but have different roles in assisting the infant. *Sensation* refers to the detection of a stimulus, such as when the small bones of the inner ear vibrate in response to sound, sending electrical signals to the brain. *Perception* refers to the brain's process of understanding the meaning of the stimulus. The sound could mean a lullaby or the bark of an angry dog. Both sensations and perceptions are enormously significant to the child's growing ability to make meaning of the world and, in particular, relationships. In the following paragraphs we will review changes in sensory abilities.

Vision represents one important sensory dimension for the growing infant. At birth vision is poorly developed. Newborns are unable to make clear distinctions because objects in the visual field are blurry and undefined due to a lack of depth perception. However, this rapidly changes. By six months infant vision is about 20/40, reaching 20/20 by twelve months (Haith, 1993). Beyond the matter of visual clarity infants are also developing the ability to focus on an object without a wandering gaze. By three months most infants are able to effectively scan an object and attend to its critical features, making face recognition an easier process. Along with these changes infants learn to follow the movement of an object with greater speed. These changes are central to infants' ability to sense social interactions, providing a basis for interpreting emotions in others.

Hearing is a second crucial sensory dimension for the infant. Unlike vision, hearing is relatively well defined from the moment of birth. Infants are easily startled by loud noises and attracted to pleasant sounds (such as a warm conversation between mom and dad). Newborns are able to make these more immediate relational connections through hearing

that is well developed even when the infant is inside the mother's womb. Remarkably, babies are able to differentiate between subtle differences between sounds used in other languages. Adults in the English-speaking world have difficulty with Thai and Czech vocalizations, but Thai and Czech babies are able to identify phonetic differences with ease (Jusczyk, 1995). This infantile sensitivity to vocalizations may be one reason that children are quickly able to acquire multiple languages.

Taste, smell and touch are all functional sensory capacities for infants. Researchers have noted that newborns are able to clearly distinguish between salty and sweet tastes. Infants are able to differentiate between the smell of mother versus the smell of another lactating woman. Taste and smell are more sensitive in the first two years of life than at any other age, making first impressions of foods particularly important. It is quite possible that children with picky eating habits were exposed to a narrower range of foods during late infancy than children with a more adventurous palate. Infant exposure to a wider range of foods should, however, be tempered by a physician's advice in order to avoid potential allergic reactions. Touch is also well defined from birth, and by six months infants are able to assess temperature and texture. These sensory aspects of development are essential to the growing brain's ability to understand and predict changes in the environment.

Brain and Self

About eighty years ago, cognitive processes in child development were exhaustively described in the work of Jean Piaget. His brilliant observational research provides a sound basis for understanding how infants think about their world. First, we will review Piaget's contributions to an understanding of infant perception and cognition. From this

foundation, we will consider neuroscience research on how the self is organized in the developing infant brain. This will lead to discussion regarding the growing infant's reciprocating self through attachments with caregivers. Finally, we will revisit the developmental claims of Vygotsky for a socially engaged infancy by tracing twelve key elements of self through three vignettes.

Piaget started with the assumption that children actively construct their own reality. Once reality is constructed, life experiences are turned into action. Perceiving an object, an infant instinctively looks at, grabs and sucks it. In the process the child constructs various plans of action or *schemas* toward the object. Schemas are cognitive structures that help organize mental representations related to a particular experience. The schema in turn provides the basis for understanding, whereby meaning is attributed to the experience. Thus a fourteen-month-old infant who is given a wooden block will experiment by looking at it, grasping it, sucking it, banging it and dropping it. In a manner of speaking, the child adopts the role of a little scientist, discovering the schema that provides the best fit for the block.

Gibson (1988) notes that moments of infant discovery reflect environmental opportunities for perception and interaction. Such opportunities, or *affordances*, suggest that no two children will form the exact same schema in response to the same stimulus. Returning to the example above, the infant will assess the block on the basis of past experiences, current developmental level, sensory awareness of present opportunities and immediate needs or motivation (Gibson, 1997). The affordance perspective underlines the uniqueness of the individual infant in relation to the ecology of his or her social contexts with their varied stimuli.

Piaget provides a detailed account of perception and interaction in terms of assimilation, accommodation and

equilibration. *Assimilation* means that the infant absorbs information in a manner consistent with an established way of thinking. Whatever is perceived is made to fit into existing schemas. It is quickly evident, however, that no new schemas will ever emerge if assimilation is the sum total of infant learning. New schemas must be created through a process of *accommodation*, where existing cognitive structures are altered to make space for new stimuli or schemas. Finally, processes of assimilation and accommodation must be regulated or kept in balance. *Equilibration* represents an infant's ability to efficiently place novel stimuli into existing or new structures that facilitate meaning and understanding.

Piaget outlined six sensorimotor stages of infant development that provide a kind of developmental "roadmap" to the infant's ability to perceive the world, learn from it and act within it. Stage one (birth to one month) is largely reflexive, including sucking, grasping motion, and listening reactions. Stage two (one to four months) includes more adaptive reactions requiring basic coordination. Thus infants in this stage might learn the different sucking actions required for mother's breast as opposed to a bottle. These are basic, albeit significant, alterations to mental schemas that are accomplished at a remarkably early point in human development.

Infant perception and reaction to objects are foremost in Piaget's observations of stages three and four. The emphasis for these stages is on the formation of schemas that maximize the infants' adaptation to the world. In stage three (four to eight months) infants acquire the ability to actively respond to interesting people and objects, working hard to keep these close by or within a field of view. In stage four (eight to twelve months) infants begin to work out plans and purposes in response to people and objects in their world. Increasingly sophisticated schemas of the self and other permit infants to form representations of relationships.

Finally, infants begin to show the ability to creatively experience and act on the world, demonstrating the range of assimilation, accommodation and equilibration typical of early childhood. In stage five (twelve to eighteen months) toddlers are actively experimenting with people and objects in the world. In stage six (eighteen to twenty-four months) toddlers begin formulating goals that direct behavior, running hypothetical planning scenarios prior to actually engaging in an activity. Cause and effect are comprehensible to toddlers along with object permanence (the ability to recognize that a person or object continues to exist even when no longer visible).

Piaget's developmental roadmap operates from an unwritten premise. For infants, the ability to create, experiment and construct interpersonally significant goals is linked to expanding awareness of self. Assimilation, accommodation and equilibration hint at the infant's growing ability to integrate experience in ways that situate self in relation to the world. In a contemporary affirmation of high-quality observational work, Piaget's sensorimotor stages closely track cutting-edge neuroscience research on the brain and self. As it turns out, we are equipped from birth with brain structures invested in the integration and organization of experience—particularly experiences relevant to a sense of self. Four brain structures are involved, working together as *cortical midline structures* or CMS (Araujo, Kaplan & Damasio, 2013; Moran, Heatherton & Kelley, 2009; Northoff & Bermpohl, 2004).

The first of these structures is the *orbitomedial prefrontal cortex* or OMPFC. This portion of the brain is located behind the eyebrows and above the sinuses. This is where self-referencing representations and schemas are formed (Northoff & Bermpohl, 2004). Our awareness of self in terms of distinct personality traits begins in the OMPFC, although the capacity to furnish abstract reflections on this knowledge must wait until adolescence (Araujo et al., 2013).

The OMPFC is “online” and operational early in development. In a classic developmental study, Meltzoff and Borton (1979) hypothesized that newborns would demonstrate a capability for representation if they could transfer one sensory experience to another. If infants could take an experience of touch and correctly link it to an experience of sight, this would demonstrate the ability to represent an external object. To test this idea, three-week-old infants were blindfolded and given two different pacifiers. The first pacifier was smooth but the second was covered with “nubs” or small protruding bumps. Blindfolded infants were permitted a lengthy suck on each pacifier in order to learn how it felt in the mouth. In the first experiment blindfolded newborns were given the smooth pacifier first and the nubbed pacifier second. Blindfolds were removed and the infants were immediately presented with both pacifiers for comparison. All infants looked intently to the nubbed pacifier they had just sucked. In the second experiment blindfolded newborns were given the nubbed pacifier followed by the smooth one. Once again blindfolds were removed and the infants were presented with both pacifiers for comparison. All infants looked intently at the smooth pacifier they had just sucked. Even at three weeks the OMPFC is capable of representing the feeling of the pacifiers in the mouths such that infants could make accurate visual comparisons and judgments (Hayne, 2002).

The second of these structures is the *anterior cingulate cortex* (ACC). Located just behind the OMPFC, the ACC is involved in monitoring and error detection (Seeley, Merkle, Gaus, Craig, Allman & Hof, 2012). Crucially for infants, this involves developing the capacity to monitor self in relation to other faces, important for maintaining close attachments with caregivers. Yogi is a new walker, about twelve months old. On a trip with her mother, she spots a playground for preschoolers next to the airport departure gate. For twenty minutes Yogi explores and experiments with age-appropriate objects. Mom is close by, keeping a watchful eye on the

toddler. The gate area is busy with many people seated adjacent to the playground. Startled by a public announcement, Yogi turns around and distractedly toddles over to a woman who distantly resembles her mom. After extending arms for a hug, the little girl quickly discovers this is not her mother! As Yogi frantically searches for her mother, she begins to cry. Fortunately mom sees what is happening from across the playground area and quickly moves to intercept. Yogi, now in a state of elevated arousal, recognizes her mother's face and breaks into an enormous, relieved smile. ACC coordinates external monitoring of faces with actions appropriate for mom, but not a stranger. The girl is able to monitor external stimuli (i.e., faces) and internal feeling states (i.e., wanting to find mom, feel secure, hug) in sophisticated ways, despite lacking well-developed language skills.

The third CMS structure of note is the *dorsolateral prefrontal cortex* (DLPFC), located behind the forehead. This structure helps evaluate stimuli and make judgments about their meaning and value related to the self (Moran et al., 2009). In a groundbreaking study of early infant development, Ockleford and colleagues found that newborns less than twenty-four hours old were remarkably and preferentially responsive to voices (Ockleford, Vince, Layton & Reader, 1988). Infants with heart-rate monitors were exposed to brief, eight-second recordings of mother's voice, father's voice and the voices of several strangers. Heart rates of all infants in the study slowed considerably when exposed to mother's and father's voices, respectively. Heart rates accelerated significantly when exposed to the voices of strangers, an effect which became increasingly pronounced with age. As infants grow into preschoolers, strange voices are capable of elevating heart rate in a manner suggestive of anxiety or stress. DLPFC activity helps infants make important distinctions among different voices, sounds, textures, smells and tastes. Beyond personal preference,

these judgments are potentially important to maintaining safe proximity with caregivers and strangers.

The final brain structure pertinent to the developing self is the *posterior cingulate cortex* (PC). The PC integrates goals and experiences into a coherent sense of self that builds over time with the addition of autobiographical memory. It should be noted that PC integration happens slowly in infancy, partly because memory in the PC is linked to the hippocampus and amygdala. These structures are poorly developed at birth, one reason why infancy is almost never remembered by older children, adolescents and adults. The period before age two is subject to *infant amnesia*. As the PC and related structures develop and organize, a growing composite of goals and experience is laid down, beginning an important process of maturation that eventually culminates in identity during late adolescence. Interestingly, the PC becomes increasingly active in recognizing the personality traits of others (Araujo et al., 2013). The notion that self becomes known in the presence of other is embedded in cortical midline structures of the infant brain, developing into an increasingly coherent reciprocating self. The "little scientist" of Piaget's observational work creates, experiments and generates goals through a process integrating self-referencing experiences with context.

Reciprocation in Attachment

Infants are capable of creating mental representations in the first few weeks of life. Even though infants cannot talk about those representations, they are able to mentally represent the face of a caregiver, the warm presence of the family dog or a mobile hanging over the crib. This has implications for the developing self. If infants can represent symbols and people, then we can assume they have some kind of working memory. With this memory infants are

able to construct representations of their relationships with other people, even if they can't precisely remember these representations later in the life course. Far from being the passive protohuman of early developmental studies, an infant has a direct experience of relationships and subsequently of the self.

Obviously, the infant self is much less sophisticated than that of childhood or adolescence. But foundational relationships in early life are powerfully influential on later relationships and the development of a reciprocating self. It was John Bowlby (1980) who thought of this process in terms of *attachment* or a behavioral, motivational system for the developing self. As infants bond with caregivers, they develop an *internal working model* of relationship. The internal working model consists of an infant's remembered experiences of a relationship and the representations that reflect those experiences. Jodie is six months old, too young to have an adult's *episodic memory,* remembered stories that adults tell about particular events, people or places. But Jodie does have the ability to record many experiences of an important person—her mother, Tanya. Tanya is a good mother, giving Jodie affection, love and attention to basic needs. Jodie has learned from Tanya that relationships are places of safety and comfort. Bowlby suggests that Jodie's internal working model of relationship, influenced as it is by her secure attachment with Tanya, is a representation that can be readily transferred to other people. In brief, Jodie is well positioned to move through childhood with the ability to trust others.

Life circumstances might conspire to complicate this idyllic picture of Jodie's developing infant self. Tanya could be involved in a serious car accident when Jodie is nine months old. Because of her injuries Tanya undergoes a lengthy hospitalization and rehabilitation. During this period she is unable to directly care for Jodie. Infant Jodie is not yet fully verbal, but she is acutely aware that mom

cannot consistently be with her. These experiences result in new memories, changing Jodie's internal working model. Jodie discovers a new set of emotions associated with insecurity in cherished relationships. From Jodie's perspective mom is no longer available and may not return in the foreseeable future. Even though Jodie is securely attached to her mother, the girl's internal working model might be altered to an extent by Tanya's hospitalization. The integration of experiences in her brain flexibly adapts to the new state of affairs, despite their unfortunate nature and consequence.

The internal working model of relationship is indicated in the formation of the infant child's reciprocating self. An infant is capable of constructing deeply held beliefs about the self as a result of early encounters with others. We might skip ahead in Jodie's development to late infancy, around twenty-two months. At this point Jodie is a toddler. With her newfound freedom comes opportunity to interact at a more emotionally significant level. Jodie is playing with dominoes in the corner of the living room. Now recovered, Tanya suggests that it might be fun to build a domino "train" that could be tipped over in a design on the kitchen floor. Jodie does not really understand what this means but wants to be with her mother and joins her. Tanya's kitchen domino project becomes mildly obsessive, an intricate sunrise that requires more than four hundred dominoes. True to her toddler life stage, Jodie loses interest after a few minutes and wanders away. She returns to the kitchen a half hour later, wanting to reestablish the connection she had with her mother. By accident Jodie prematurely bumps the dominoes, causing the whole train to tip over in turn. In this pregnant moment Tanya has several parenting options at her disposal, each of which carries implications for Jodie's internal working model of relationships.

Confronted with Jodie's mistake, Tanya could laugh and involve Jodie in the fun of watching the dominoes tip over. Tanya could emotionally withdraw and leave the room in anger.

Tanya could yell at Jodie. Or, Tanya could silently watch and then begin rebuilding the design, ignoring her little daughter. Regardless of which course Tanya takes, the entire episode of the dominoes will become recorded in Jodie's memory and, consequently, her internal working model of relationship. The infant's developing self, emerging from an internal working model of relationship, directly encounters the internal working model of her mother. Tanya and Jodie's relational encounter is *intersubjective* in the sense that the infant's self is subjectively known and experienced on the basis of relationship. Hopefully, Tanya chooses to laugh and involve Jodie in the fun of watching the kitchen floor shimmer with falling dominoes. In this intersubjective encounter Jodie learns that it is her essential self, above all else, that has value to her mother. Nothing can obscure Jodie's worth as a person. If Tanya were to choose another, less caring response to Jodie's accident, the infant might intersubjectively learn that she is flawed, unworthy or undesirable.

If the infant's internal working model of relationship is implicated in her ability to trust people in the future, we might wonder whether attachment quality affects our ability to form a relationship with God in later development. It is unlikely that any researcher will ever be able to resolve this issue with actual infants, owing to communication limitations. However, it is possible to assess attachment quality in adolescents and emerging adults. In a large study of American college students, Neufeld (2004) found a moderate but consistent relationship between attachment quality and relational intimacy with God. With this "retrospective" approach to the attachment issue it appears that internal working models of relationship do affect spiritual formation, although the specific reasons for this remain unanswered (Kirkpatrick, 1999).

Infant Self in Three Vignettes

An infant's reciprocating self, premised upon his or her internal working model of relationship, is general as opposed to specific. The infant does not have the fine memory necessary to reconstruct specific situations and emotions in linear time. But the lack of episodic memory does not mean that the infant has no memory at all. Infant memory is capable of supporting enough relationship schemas to be significant, even in the tender weeks immediately following birth. Vygotsky indicated that self is fully differentiated at birth and development consists of the self's repeated efforts to establish positive relationships. Basic brain structures are already in place to support this notion, carried further by attachment theory. It is time to pull these threads together, reflecting on twelve abstract features of the self that indicate reciprocity (Araujo, et al., 2013; Northoff & Bermpohl, 2004). I (Kevin) will illustrate using three vignettes.

Vignette one illustrates *representation, monitoring, evaluation* and *integration*. Jean is three months old and keenly interested in the world around him. Jean's older brother, Antoine, is five years old. Antoine is fascinated with the baby. Even though Antoine resents the fact his mother now divides her attention between the two boys, he will spend long minutes gazing down at Jean. He will tickle the baby and hold his hands. Taking care to make sure no one else is watching, Antoine will gently sing to Jean. The infant quickly learns from these encounters that Antoine is not his mother or father. Antoine occupies a different schema of *representations* in Jean's experience than those of mother or father. Antoine does not feed the baby, nor is he yet allowed to pick him up. But Antoine is a close and significant relationship, already prominent in Jean's limited experience with the world. In the sibling tickle sessions Jean is able to associate external stimuli with a

new relationship through the beginnings of a reciprocating self.

Jean gradually begins to *monitor* the world for signs of Antoine, referencing the absence of external stimuli against the self. Jean begins to wake from his afternoon nap roughly around the time Antoine comes home from kindergarten. While it would be a leap to say Jean is consciously looking forward to Antoine's return, he is able to preferentially monitor the world based on internal representations in memory. Jean's preferences aren't simply limited to Antoine as a person—they may also relate to immediate, sensory inputs. Antoine discovers that Jean will whimper and turn his head away when Antoine tickles by squeezing the legs above the knee. But Jean will immediately regain eye contact when Antoine gently nudges his ribs. Jean is able to *evaluate* specific actions (e.g., tickling) and weight these in terms of personal likes and dislikes. Even at three months Jean is developing preferences, a self-referencing process that will continue as each brother learns more about the other, eventually exploiting that knowledge for less than noble purposes!

Jean's developing representations emerge in tandem with a capacity to monitor and evaluate information pertinent to the self. An important part of this process involves *integrating* parcels of information significant to the self and its context (Northoff & Bermpohl, 2004). Integration is significantly shaped by feelings, a link that will continue for the rest of Jean's life. He experiences positive feelings related to nursing at his mother's breast. Because of their feeding times Jean learns that life is not a static or monotone existence. The environment contains people and relationships that are capable of resolving basic needs such as hunger and, additionally, needs related to the self. Jean may experience occasional colic. During these periods of cramping he cries and is not easily comforted. Only at his mother's breast does Jean find relief, not because the

cramping has stopped but because he has integrated self-important information (e.g., discomfort) with available support and closeness with mom. More than feeding, time with mom can compensate for discomfort, even if Jean is not actually hungry.

Vignette two illustrates *agency, unity, emotion* and *autobiographical memory*. Monica is nine months old. She is bright and vivacious, with a special fondness for faces. Her father's lap is a favorite place to hang out. She loves holding his fingers and bouncing up and down. One evening, while on dad's lap after the bath, Monica grabs his nose with surprising force, attempting to rip it clear away from his face. In the moment, Monica has little sense of self insofar as her actions are related to consequences. But there is no doubt regarding action and reaction. Monica's tiny fingers are endowed with sharp, flimsy nails that quickly create small red paper cuts. Dad is suddenly on the receiving end of a bad nose job. If he mutely endures his daughter's handiwork, the girl will fail to make a causal connection between her hand, his nose and the state of their relationship. But if Monica's father says "ouch!" and turns his head away, she will learn that this connection is significant. Monica discovers that she is an *agent*, capable of acting on an environment that will reciprocate to her (Bandura, 1978, 1998).

Along with agency, Monica's action creates opportunity to develop *unity* in the growing sense of having a core self. Unity is predicated on an infant's knowledge that he or she is a whole being. In the encounter, Monica's father grimaces and gently (but firmly) pulls the girl's hand away from his face. Monica learns that her actions lead to a less-desired response (communicated through facial expression) that alerts her to the reality that she is not her father. Monica did not experience pain as a result of her interest in human cartilage. But her father did. Because of her growing ability to relate to others, she learns that her actions are not

mutually agreeable. These boundaries are necessary for any relationship in order to help the infant understand the unified dimensions of the self.

Monica is becoming aware of feelings associated with the self in relationships. Feelings are the subjective experience of underlying *emotion*. With increased relational skills and a newfound ability to explore the environment, infants encounter a widening number of other people. For Monica, emotions are warm and cozy with mom, safe and fun with dad, but strangely distant with grandma, who is not comfortable with children. The infant's growing sense of self suggests an emotional barometer of closeness that affects the character of each relationship and, importantly, her primary attachments with mom, dad and sister. Monica learns that relationships are not equal. Eventually Monica will adapt this knowledge to various roles she will play in her family, her peer group and her school.

Finally, Monica is beginning to establish an *autobiographical memory*. She is accumulating remembered experiences engaging self with other, even if she will not be able to directly recall these in adulthood. With increased capability to remember and recall information, infants gain a sense of having a past and a present. Monica comes to realize that she will wake up tomorrow and still be herself. Autobiographical memory supports the infant's sense of core self where agency, unity and emotions are experientially integrated into a larger sense of what it means to be "me." At nine months Monica not only knows her name but that she exists separately from her parents. Because she is securely attached, Monica is empowered by the emotions associated with those relationships to explore new connections and along with them an expanded autobiographical memory supporting a framework for the self.

Vignette three illustrates *mind-reading, spatial perspectivity, ownership* and *self-awareness.* Justin is nine months old. He is a burly toddler who loves to eat, smile and

laugh. Thick curly brown hair is already established on his large head. Like others his age, Justin is a curious explorer. One of his favorite places to explore involves the beach. Justin's family lives a few miles from an excellent white sand beach with gentle waves. A warm Saturday finds Justin, his mom and his dad down at the beach. Justin is seated beneath an umbrella, having a great time with sand toys. A low, throbbing drone becomes audible. The drone becomes louder. A large blimp is cruising parallel to the beach, just offshore. The blimp is advertising sunscreen and soda pop. Although he hears the blimp, Justin doesn't see it. Knowing her young explorer might find the blimp interesting, mom calls to Justin, pointing in the sky toward the approaching aircraft. Unlike younger infants, Justin is able to connect the dots regarding mom's intention. Rather than look at mom's hand, Justin looks in the direction that she is pointing. Justin is *mind-reading*, not literally, but figuratively in terms of figuring out whether the focus of mom's attention is correctly interpreted and shared between two reciprocating selves. In effect, Justin now understands that when mom is pointing to something, she is essentially saying, "Look!"

A year passes. Justin is now twenty-one months old, an even larger and more outgoing version of his younger self. To parental dismay, he has discovered the overhand pitch. Justin loves to throw things. Perhaps more significantly, he has learned to throw long and hard. Balls are a favorite, as are rocks and garden implements in the yard. Just about anything will do. Justin is particularly intrigued with the action of a tennis ball off the house siding. He discovers the ricocheting ball can be directed depending on his position relative to the wall. Justin is mastering *spatial perspectivity*, or sense of self in space. Along with this new expertise, the boy is developing a sense of *ownership*, where environment and body can be configured (by self) to create a desired outcome—namely, a ball that bounces off the wall and

toward the dog. Justin has elevated his game, acquiring a deeper and more comprehensive sense of self as agent.

Something else is happening. Justin is now able to cleanly distinguish between self and other. He is sufficiently *self-aware* that he can recognize himself in a mirror. Indeed, Lewis and Brooks-Gunn (1979) found that before eighteen months infants do not know that what they see in the mirror is their own reflection. Fourteen-month-old infants with rouge on their cheeks pointed to the mirror and verbalized a response, generally about that "other baby." But after eighteen months, rouged infants began touching their own cheeks rather than the mirror. Self-awareness means that Justin's sense of "me" exists not only internally but also externally. This becomes increasingly important as the boy begins to identify goals and pursue them. When dad praises Justin with "good boy," it activates different representations, schemas and memories than when mom gives the same encouragement. With dad, Justin associates this praise with situations that usually accompany it. Dad often praises his son when he masters a new task. On the other hand, mom might use the same phrase when Justin is playing with other children or at times when good behavior is important. The infant's emerging self-awareness leads to a sharpened internal working model of the reciprocating self in relationship.

Parenting and the Infant Self

In the introductory section of the book we discussed several theologically derived concepts that are important to the whole of development. These were *unconditional love, gracing, empowering* and *intimate relationships* (Balswick & Balswick, 2014). In this section we will reflect on how these concerns are "translated" into the positive development of a reciprocating self. We might approach this task by briefly

reviewing some terminology used in the parenting and family studies literature. This literature provides us with a means to apply love, grace, empowerment and intimacy in the varied ecosystems of infant development. Specifically, we rely on the classic work of Diana Baumrind, who conducted detailed studies of children from infancy into adulthood (Baumrind, 1996, 2012; Rollins & Thomas, 1979). I (Kevin) have firsthand knowledge of Baumrind's work—her famous sample included several of my childhood friends in Berkeley, California. This section serves as a bridge between our discussion of the reciprocating self in infancy and the nested contexts in which the self might be scaffolded.

How might unconditional love be understood in the developing selves of infants? The parenting literature recognizes the significance of *unconditional love* in terms of *support* for the growing child. Support is just that—the extent to which the parent is emotionally supportive of the child. For the infant's reciprocating self, support is extraordinarily important. From the above discussion, we can conclude that the lack of consistent emotional support for an infant could be catastrophic. Indeed, the tragedy of Romanian and Ukrainian orphanages in the early 1990s demonstrates how critical support is to the infant. With ratios of 150 babies to one caregiver, infants were often terribly damaged from inadequate support. Lacking an appropriate other with which to create internal working models of relationship, some of these orphaned infants demonstrated reactive attachment disorders, brain damage, learning disabilities and antisocial behavior.

The developmental language of unconditional love suggests that infants should receive *consistently adequate* emotional support. Since this does not imply perfection on the part of parents, we might do better to speak in terms of *the good enough parent* (Winnicott, 1971). Indeed, life is too chaotic to permit more than a consistently adequate benchmark of support. Take Jodie, the infant whose mother, Tanya, was

hospitalized by an automobile accident. For a time Jodie is unable to directly experience her mother's emotional support. Yet there are other caregivers in her world that are able to compensate for this deficit, particularly in a manner that affirms Jodie's reciprocating self. Jodie's paternal grandmother, Anita, comes to stay with the family. Together with her father, Bill, Jodie receives consistently adequate support that permits her not only to grow in her own sense of core self but in the range of relational possibilities that are available to her. Support is a critical factor in positive early development (Baumrind, 1972, 1991).

How might we understand grace in the world of an infant? *Grace* implies a relationship, particularly one where a less-powerful individual is afforded the space to make mistakes and grow through those experiences. The parenting literature defines this kind of attentive parenting presence in terms of *monitoring.* Monitoring refers to the parent's involvement in the child's activities with a view toward safety and growth. The parent that does not monitor the crawling or toddling infant risks a variety of safety concerns, particularly in relation to places where a child might fall, experience electrocution, drowning or accidental poisoning. Even beyond basic safety issues, a lack of monitoring communicates an essential unworthiness to the infant's reciprocating self. Unmonitored infants are also ungraced infants, left to their own devices to make mistakes and pay dearly for them in the absence of a caregiver.

How might we understand empowering in the life of the infant? *Empowerment* suggests that an infant is learning to be a capable and appropriately other-focused agent. This does not happen automatically. In the parenting literature, *intervention strategies* refer to preferred techniques to correct children such that they develop character. Rollins and Thomas (1979) further specify intervention around negative and positive strategies. *Coercion* is negative in the sense that it is punitive. Coercive intervention might be

physical, emotional or both. Coercion may also include deprivation or removal of privileges. While coercive intervention is not necessary with younger infants, it will become so with the child's increased mobility. Coercive intervention strategies should be focused on creating logical consequences for dangerous or inappropriate behavior rather than as a means of subjugation. Baumrind found that coercive strategies, such as time-outs or withdrawal of privileges, were more effective correctives than physical punishments, shame and love withdrawal (Baumrind, 1971, 1996, 2012). This kind of moderate approach to coercion tended to promote empathy and other-oriented thinking, even in toddlers.

A positive intervention strategy might include induction. *Induction* means that the parent "reasons" with the child about his or her actions, particularly with regard to potential consequences. Consider twenty-month-old Nadia, who impulsively toddles out into the street and is narrowly missed by a car. Nadia's mother, who is justifiably terrified, nonetheless recognizes that the toddler has no means of understanding how serious her actions were. Instead of giving Nadia a spanking (physical, coercive strategy), she gets down at eye level and tells the girl in measured tones that to run out into the street means that she could be hit by a car and hurt or killed. This kind of inductive reasoning is effective when combined with a moderate form of coercion such as a time-out. Even if the toddler lacks full understanding of her mother's explanation, a precedent is being set. Through induction the mother is communicating a high degree of worth to Nadia's reciprocating self, along with very serious concern for a dangerous situation. The seriousness of the situation is further reinforced by a coercive intervention. Baumrind found that children who experienced a lot of inductive intervention knew themselves and were able to make better decisions than children who lacked induction. Presumably, induction helps the verbal

infant in a process of policing the self away from behaviors that are dangerous or potentially hurtful to others.

How might *intimate relationships* be translated for the infant's reciprocating self? *Control* is an important aspect of human relatedness that figures prominently in parenting behavior. Control is present in any human relationship. Of itself, control is neither positive nor negative but can be handled in a manner that promotes or restricts human intimacy and trust. Extreme examples of parental control often capture national headlines. Unfortunately, most of these examples document child abuse. Moderate examples of control help the infant to differentiate the self from the other, establishing boundaries that will one day be readily transferable into peer relationships. In the parent-child dyad, control is an essential element in creating an effective developmental scaffold (Baumrind, 1991, 2012). Given the power differential that is natural to the parent-child relationship, appropriate control is premised on trust, the basic ingredient that makes intimate relationships possible.

Recalling Monica's nose job on her dad, we can note that his response incorporated control that leads to trust. Instead of a harsh, vindictive reaction, dad makes a measured intervention that helps Monica to better understand what reciprocates intimacy and closeness in relationships. This happens in conjunction with a growing sense of the self as different from dad, yet still linked with him. An overcontrolling response might include a yell and slap of the hand. An undercontrolling response might be no response at all. Either course fails to help Monica understand herself as both agent and recipient of trust through a reciprocating self.

The Ecology of Infanthood

In this final section we will discuss how an infant's reciprocating self is potentially influenced by successive ecosystems. In particular we will look at infant development in terms of scaffolding. Issues of support, monitoring, intervention strategies and control will be assumed in this discussion.

Microsystem. The microsystem has already figured prominently in this chapter as a means for considering the reciprocating self. We considered the attachment relationship with a primary caregiver and the importance of the dyad in establishing the infant self. Finally, we considered unconditional love, gracing, empowering and intimate relationships from within the parenting literature. Parental support, monitoring, intervention strategies and control all reflect important relational dynamics within the microsystem.

We might think of the microsystem in terms of helping to securely establish an infant's reciprocating self. Because the microsystem is nested within other, larger systemic categories, it is a vitally important place for a growing infant to learn about the self and other in relative safety. Attachment theorists often speak of relationship quality in terms of security. This metaphor makes good sense given that a child's ever-expanding social contexts require increasingly sophisticated role transitions. Thus security in the dyad might be one way of thinking about developmental scaffolding. For example, an infant might grow with an insecure reciprocating self through inadequate parenting practices in the microsystem dyad. A child's internal working model of relationships might be confused by a number of issues, including trust, sharing, emotional support and empathy. This insecurity carries over into real challenges for the individual in middle childhood and adolescence. Such insecurity might result in an avoidant personality, where the child fears rejection. Avoidant children often grow with a deep-seated anger that leads to isolation, chronic pleasing or bullying behavior. Or a child might grow with an

ambivalent sense of self, often leading to a manipulative approach to relationships. In the worst-case scenario severely abused or neglected children might be disorganized or disoriented. The highest likelihood of positive development is established in infancy. Secure relations in the microsystem are vital in scaffolding the child's growing sense of what it means to exist and, doubly important, how to exist in relationship.

Mesosystem. In infant development, the mesosystem is not often studied beyond the influence of nuclear families. Some developmental psychologists have recognized the fact that neighborhood environments, for example, do influence development in significant ways. Neighborhood mesosystems tend to be somewhat removed from the infant's everyday experiences, but they can indirectly exert considerable influence. Infants growing up in a depressed, inner-city neighborhood might inherit the stresses experienced by their parents' struggle to make ends meet and keep the family safe. Stress from socioeconomic deficits, ethnic oppression and other factors can creep into microsystem relations between parents and child, sometimes undermining the parents' efforts at scaffolding a reciprocating self. As an example, it is difficult for a single parent living in a depressed neighborhood to practice much induction with a toddler simply because the child might spend large blocks of time in daycare. The good news is that many parents daily overcome the odds and provide consistently adequate parenting in spite of neighborhood-related stresses.

The mesosystem typically includes extended family and kin. These aunts, uncles, cousins and grandparents have tremendous influence on an infant's developing self. Positive regular connections with extended relations are important opportunities for a developing infant self; so is exposure to different styles of influence through scaffolding of support, monitoring, intervention and control. This larger sense of "family" carries significant potential to help the infant

learn self-understanding through relationship. In our California context, many Latino/a families place high value on their extended family. Often these families make career sacrifices in order to stay close to extended kin. These cultural priorities for family life are advantageous to the infant's reciprocating self and the language of relationship that he or she will learn by spending time with so many different individuals.

Exosystem. Usually a parent's place of work does not figure into our thinking about infant development. But the exosystem can exert indirect influence on the infant's reciprocating self. In their research on executives and their spouses, Small and Riley (1990) found evidence of adverse spillover from work to the parent-child relationship. Balswick and Balswick (1995) suggested that adverse spillover may be problematic among dual-earner parents. Balancing commitment to work and parenting results in some dual-earner parents trying to retain full commitment to both arenas (acrobats), some trying to convince the other to assume more parenting responsibilities (adversaries) and some trimming back involvement in work in favor of joint parenting (allies). A creative example of the latter is Janet, a fourth-grade teacher who chooses to job share her position in order to spend three days a week at home with her seven-month-old daughter, Harriet. Janet's principal and coteacher are both supportive of the mother's decision, recognizing the benefit for Janet's family life and the benefit of keeping a valued teacher and team member on the school's faculty. Janet's job-sharing schedule will only be for a few years, allowing her to eventually reenter the elementary faculty as a full-time teacher. This kind of exosystemic influence is enormously helpful to Harriet and the scaffolding of her reciprocating self. The infant is an indirect beneficiary of the support her mother receives in her workplace. Consequently, we can expect that Janet is more easily able to offer support to Harriet with the knowledge

that she is supported in her commitment to be a consistently adequate mother.

In European countries it is increasingly common for parents to job share. Moreover, many European countries place a premium on early infant scaffolding by giving paternity and maternity leave to young parents. This is in contrast to the United States, where reduced paternity and maternity leave is the norm, and working parents are expected to take advantage of paid childcare solutions for their infants. We do not have space here to critique the developmental advantages and disadvantages of these two approaches to infancy and family. It is clear from an exosystemic perspective that the European situation offers better support for the developing infant simply through the supportive environment experienced by the parent in the workplace. In economic terms American policymakers would do well to weigh the costs of paternity and maternity leave next to the long-term repercussions of parents who do not feel supported by their work environment. Such parents are likely to be less loyal to their jobs and colleagues, and more likely to move to a new job, thereby creating additional transition stressors for the family system.

Macrosystem. How might culture affect the infant's reciprocating self? There are many different possibilities in our accelerated, information-laden Western society. Given space limitations, we will briefly focus on television aimed at early childhood. Most toddlers are fascinated by television, particularly those programs that are populated with age-appropriate characters. In the United States *Sponge Bob SquarePants* is a popular show aimed at toddlers and preschool-aged children. Generally, such shows are not fully absorbed by children under the age of two. Toddlers simply do not have long enough attention spans to take in a thirty-minute program. But within their limited attention, toddlers are still influenced by television. Television characters become representations that at times figure prominently in

toddler play. Often, a Sponge Bob character can become central to the toddler's expanding capability for creative play.

Do these programs influence an infant's sense of reciprocating self? Few studies have been done in this area. Yet this dearth of research does not mean that the question is unimportant. At least superficially, television's ability to scaffold the reciprocating self is minimized by its lack of direct, relational interaction. Children may *relate* to a program and its characters, but *lack a relationship* with those characters. Herein lies the rub. Television can become a poor substitute for the scaffolding of a child's reciprocating self because it superficially appears to occupy the child's attention, at least for a time. But television is not a dynamic, reciprocating entity. The child is only a recipient rather than a contributor. This lack of reciprocity does nothing to help a child learn new contexts and languages for relationship reflecting his or her internal working model. Support, monitoring, intervention strategies and control are not on the agenda for television or its characters. Thus while a child may extract some bits of "learned" information from a program, he or she will gain little by way of self-understanding in relationship.

Concluding Thoughts

We have outlined a number of issues related to the reciprocating self in infancy, beginning with biological and cognitive factors in development. We have attempted to describe how love, gracing, empowerment and intimate relationships are experienced through the language of the parenting and family studies literature. Finally, we used Bronfenbrenner's ecosystemic model to consider how the reciprocating self might form in various social contexts. Much of this work may come as a surprise to readers who

assume infancy to be a relatively unremarkable period of egocentrism. We believe, however, that the developmental literature makes a compelling case for an active infancy. The depth of our argument will be tested as we expand it through childhood and adolescence.

7

Childhood

The Reciprocating Self Goes to School

MARK TWAIN ONCE OBSERVED that it would be better for humanity to be born at the age of eighty and then develop *down* the lifespan to eventually become children! This kind of backward growth implies that everyone would begin life with the wisdom of age, a considerable advantage when navigating the challenges of childhood. Twain's joke speaks to the many complications of growing up. Indeed, his humor might be prophetic, given an accelerating American culture that places significant pressures on modern children.

It is unwise to romanticize the childhood of Twain's context in the mid-nineteenth century. Victorian parents placed considerable achievement expectations on their children, whether this meant doing a good job with chores on the family farm, dedicating oneself to a trade or working to help their financially struggling family unit. A major difference between Twain's world and ours is that today's child is increasingly asked to achieve apart from immediate family concerns, to "make it" in a highly individualized America. The pressure of achievement in childhood extends to school performance, extracurricular activities, sports and peer leadership. It is likely that these pressures exert an influence on the child's reciprocating self, particularly as

he or she gains a deeper sense of identity as a person created in the *imago Dei.*

How do children develop a coherent, reciprocating self through the din of Xbox, shouting volleyball parents and mass-marketed music? In this chapter we will consider the developmental scaffolding of childhood from three to eleven years of age. To accomplish this we will break our discussion into two sections. In the first section we will consider the biological, cognitive and socioemotional characteristics of self in early childhood (three to seven years), also known as the *play years.* In the second section we will review biological, cognitive and socioemotional characteristics of self in older children (seven to eleven years), often referenced as the *school years.* Next, we will move on to consider the child's reciprocating self in terms of *attachment*, *risk and resiliency* and *parenting issues* related to unconditional love, gracing, empowering and intimate relationships. Finally, we will take a look at the child's ecosystem, focusing on issues relating to the family and the child's role in society. In particular, we will consider *divorce* and *discrimination.*

Play Years: Biological Changes

Early childhood is a period of rapid biological development. Extending from infancy, the brain continues to establish synaptic pathways that are accompanied by ongoing *myelinization*, a process whereby insulating white matter is laid down, promoting connections between brain regions and individual neurons. Children in the play years become increasingly effective in their reactions to stimuli and demonstrate improved control of their responses. A five-year-old boy is better able to handle the frustration of a playmate's refusal to share toys than he was at age two. While conflict remains likely in this situation, the boys are

more apt to handle things verbally rather than immediately resorting to a temper tantrum.

An interesting aspect of brain development in the play years involves a bundle of nerves close to cortical midline structures (CMS) associated with the self. The bundle is known as the *corpus callosum.* The corpus callosum connects the left and right hemispheres of the brain, serving as a kind of information pathway for communication between brain halves. Children in the play years experience rapid myelinization and growth of the corpus callosum, expanding the range of coordinated activity. Additionally, growth to the corpus callosum facilitates better processing of stimuli and past experiences relevant to self. This is one reason that children in the play years are somewhat less at risk for physical injury than toddlers. The five-year-old is able to understand and respond to a red stoplight signal without impulsively jumping into the street. Indeed, the five-year-old actively uses the self as a way of enhancing memory encoding about things like stoplights and busy streets, known as the *self-reference effect* (Ray, Shelton, Hollon, Michel, Frankel, Gross & Gabrieli, 2009). The child keenly remembers the look on mom's face after impulsively leaping out into the intersection without first checking the lights. Her fear and carefully reasoned explanation emphasized real danger to the child self.

Increased coordination and improved processing are immediately helpful to the young child's ability to recognize letters on a page or to handle a pencil for the purpose of writing. These changes make it possible for the child to link speech with written language, making connections between letters and sounds that anticipate reading. By age six the brain is mature enough to move ahead with formal instruction in reading, writing and mathematics. This should not serve, however, as a hard-and-fast threshold on the road to literacy. Indeed, there is evidence that reading to two- and three-year-old children significantly

aids brain development such that the child is well positioned for formal reading instruction in kindergarten.

Gross and fine motor skills are rapidly improving for the young child. An activity such as riding a bicycle is out of the question for the two-year-old toddler, but it becomes a real possibility for five-year-old children. Cultural conditions and expectations result in variation between gross motor accomplishments in the play years. In Canada, many children begin ice skating at two or three, becoming competent skaters by kindergarten. In Polynesia five-year-olds are able to swim in waves or climb rock formations that would intimidate many Western adults. Many of the gross motor accomplishments typical of the play years occur in the context of reciprocating interactions with peers rather than direct instruction from adults. The dynamic relational aspect of play yields dividends in terms of the young child's ability to master complex activities and sports in a manner that scaffolds the social dimensions of the reciprocating self.

Consistent with ecosystemic predictions in development, recent work suggests the biological foundations of the reciprocating self are influenced by cultural context. Two recent studies compared activation of CMS in the brain for Chinese and Western (i.e., American) children, respectively (Chiao, Harada, Komeda, Li, Mano, Saito, Parrish, Sadato & Idaka, 2009; Zhu, Zhang, Fan & Han, 2007). Noteworthy differences were found between the two groups. Whereas Westerners demonstrated two separate, localized CMS activation areas in response to cues regarding self and other, a single region in the prefrontal cortex was activated for the Chinese, suggesting that self and other are tightly integrated in ways reflecting cultural expectations for interdependence and collective obligation. Cultural context and expectation are capable of significantly influencing experiences related to reciprocation through the play years.

Play Years: Cognitive Changes

We will use Piaget's observations of children in the play years as a foundation for Vygotsky's insights on cognitive development and self. Piaget maintained that the primary difference between the toddler and play-aged child is the preschooler's ability to think symbolically. The play-aged child acquires the ability to interpret various symbols in the environment, including the family dog. *Dog* refers to more than just an animal; it also includes an entire domain of knowledge including barking, playing fetch and neighborhood walks after dinner. A child in the play years can identify meanings associated with dogs that are beyond a toddler's range of interpretation. For example, a five-year-old knows that dogs are *household pets*, a concept that is elusive to toddlers.

Piaget referred to the play years as a period of *preoperational thought.* Although the newfound symbolic ability of the young child is a hallmark of the preoperational period, Piaget's work tended to focus on what children in this age bracket could not do rather than on what they could accomplish. Preoperational children are not logical, in Piaget's view, because of their tendency to focus on one aspect of a situation to the exclusion of everything else. Such *centration* means that preoperational children cannot combine conceptual categories in a way that makes logical sense. In the preoperational child's mind, wolves and coyotes are not related to dogs because these animals do not live in the house as domestic pets. For Piaget this kind of one-track thinking reflects egocentric tendencies typical of the play years.

We have already discussed the social and relational bases for development in terms of Vygotsky's cognitive theory. We considered the means by which relationships *scaffold* cognition in early childhood, specifically through a *zone of proximal development.* For Vygotsky, scaffolding and proximal

development are based on the idea that children are *apprentices* to others in their social context. The child looks to others in order to better understand the world and the way it works. For Vygotsky recognition of the play-aged child's inability to recognize the same volume of milk in glasses with different shapes is less important than the fact that when learning the truth of the situation, the child turns to a nearby adult and asks why. The child's cognitive development is significantly supported by interactions with receptive, patient adults willing to provide age-appropriate answers. With their rapidly expanding linguistic capabilities, children are able to communicate with adults such that ideas and concepts previously out of reach become accessible.

One important consequence of social learning for the young apprentice is that he or she acquires the ability to understand mental processes in others. Building on infancy, children in the play years are able to generate an increasingly sophisticated *theory of mind*, knowing that others have thoughts, beliefs, preferences and desires. This can have immediate and positive implications in terms of empathy. A five-year-old is more than capable of understanding a friend's despair over a treasured cat that ran away. Conversely, the same five-year-old is now able to understand that his younger sibling doesn't like spiders, exploiting that knowledge by teasing with a plastic tarantula. Interestingly, developmentalists have found that general language ability is correlated with the child's ability to understand the thoughts of others (Moore, Pure & Furrow, 1990). The reciprocating self, understood in terms of relationships with others, suggests a theory of mind that uses language to figuratively stand in the shoes of another person.

In step with these changes is a growing capacity for children to catalog autobiographical memories. The play years represent a significant leap beyond infantile amnesia.

Preschoolers and kindergarteners can remember many things, including situations and events relevant to the self. Novel experiences such as a birthday party or trip to the amusement park reference self in relation to peers, parents, authority figures and the general public. Autobiographical memories in the play years are foundational to the construction of coherent identity later in adolescence (Fivush, 2011). Many of these memories remain available for a lifetime. The rich symbolism and sensory stimuli associated with these memories are sometimes deeply etched in the brain. To this day, I (Kevin) am transported back to kindergarten by the aroma of orange blossoms. The wonderful outdoor citrus fragrance coincided with annual childhood visits to Orange County, California, and fun with my cousins at Disneyland.

Play Years: Socioemotional Changes

Socioemotional development in childhood is summed up through a simple query—namely, *what do others think about me?* (Pfeifer & Peake, 2012). It is important to note that external reality and internal perceptions may be some distance apart for play-aged children. Children are learning how to reconcile the two, acquiring new expertise in *self-appraisal* or the manner by which I imagine others perceive me. Self-appraisals are cognitively represented with powerful emotions. Known as *self-conscious emotions*, children begin to deduce answers to the question of what others think, significantly through feelings. Guilt, pride and shame are perhaps the most broadly recognized self-conscious emotions. The five-year-old experiences a powerful flash of guilt when mom enters the kitchen to find small hands deep inside the cookie jar—minutes after being told to wait until after dinner. The same five-year-old experiences a surge of pride when riding a two-wheel bike without training wheels. In kindergarten class, the child feels ashamed when other

children laugh uproariously at a wardrobe malfunction. These emotions are powerfully linked to the reciprocating self as positive and negative cues that can last a lifetime.

The play years are a debut for recognizably self-conscious emotions. Ross Thompson and June Tangney are developmental psychologists with research legacies in the field of self-conscious emotion. Tangney created a useful taxonomy of self-conscious emotion that neatly aligns with our discussion of the reciprocating self (Tangney & Dearing, 2002; Tangney, Steuwig & Mashek, 2007). *Guilt* involves negative attributions toward personal actions and behaviors, particularly with regard to impact on others. Moderate levels of guilt can nurture virtuous character, enhancing empathic concern for others (*what I did hurt your feelings*). The key involves the extent to which guilt offers a corrective for behavior without diminishing the essential value of self. Too much guilt can lead to paralysis where the child begins to fear making socially visible mistakes or taking risks that might result in severe retribution—with consequences for reciprocity. Overly guilty children may become hypervigilant, closely monitoring others at the expense of self. Too little guilt invites narcissism, where the child fails to learn the immediate consequences of actions and behaviors in relation to the welfare of others. The five-year-old caught in the act of taking a forbidden cookie will benefit from inductive reasoning whereupon mom explains her reasons for the rule, her fundamental regard for the child's self and her interest to design an appropriate consequence—there will be no cookies after dinner tonight. This creates reinforcement for moderate guilt, enabling the child to learn self-regulatory behaviors that endure even when mom isn't physically present.

Pride is considerably different than guilt. In Tangney's taxonomy, *alpha pride* is hubristic self-inflation with links to aggression and antisocial behaviors. Alpha pride does not promote a reciprocating self. In fact, an extreme

manifestation of alpha pride can serve as a marker for sociopathy. *Beta pride* is focused on personal actions and behaviors. As such, beta pride is the inverse of guilt, with potentially positive implications for reciprocity. Play-aged children are exploring, taking risks and attempting to master difficult tasks. This process is critically important to self-integration and maturation, anticipating identity development in adolescence. Beta pride can serve as a powerful emotional reward for appropriate risk taking and mastery efforts. Thus, not all pride is maladaptive or morally suspect. In fact, beta pride may complement virtuous action and commitments through childhood, adolescence and adulthood. In the play years, beta pride is visible in the moments immediately following that groundbreaking moment when the five-year-old masters a difficult task—riding a two-wheel bicycle without external assistance. The child acquires expertise and, even better, a sense of personal efficacy (*I can do it*).

Shame differs again from guilt and pride. *Shame* is understood in terms of negative self-attributions. Shame manifests rejection or condemnation of self. This can be powerful. Shamed individuals acquire a socially construed sense of self as defective. In a sense, shame is the emotional antithesis to a reciprocating self, undermining the child's fundamental sense of value in relation to a loving God. The research literature suggests that shame is rarely adaptive. Shamed children can be painfully shy, not as a feature of individual differences in personality, but through fear that social behaviors may be construed as further evidence of a worthless self. Shame is a well-known corrective in some Asian cultures that encourage children to think collectively rather than individually. Keeping reciprocity foremost in view, it is important to differentiate between enculturated shame as a behavioral norm and personal shame directed toward individual children in maladaptive parent-child relationships and environments. With

the latter foremost in mind, extreme shame can border on abuse, eroding the reciprocating self in development.

School Years: Biological Changes

The school years can be a wonderful and carefree life stage. Biological changes to the brain and motor skills continue, enabling children to succeed in sports and to accomplish increasingly complicated intellectual feats. However, the same period of life can be stressful and difficult. Stress and changes in the American lifestyle have had negative consequences for the physical development of children. American children in the school years are among the most obese (per capita) among Western nations, displaying weight-related medical problems and disorders. At the same time, children in the school years are notoriously unforgiving of physical differences in others. Freckles, hair, skin and weight can all become objects of criticism or teasing. Our discussion of biological development must be increasingly sensitive to the child's growing social capacity and reciprocating influences, particularly given the heightened importance of the peer group.

Physical growth slows somewhat in the school years, causing a kind of filling out for many children in middle and upper grades. Genes are a factor in how children carry their weight. In affluent countries well-fed children will easily achieve their genetically determined height for a given age in childhood. However, an increasingly sedentary American lifestyle combined with cheap junk food has created a situation where many children are vulnerable to obesity. By some estimates 20 percent of American children in the school years are medically obese, heightening risk for a range of orthopedic and respiratory ailments along with increased risk of heart disease. Children reciprocate the eating habits and basic self-care of their parents, siblings and peers.

Stressed-out parents who are unable to promote healthy nutrition at home can influence biological developmental processes in school-aged children by modeling to others that heavily processed food is an acceptable solution to problems. When combined with sedentary pastimes (e.g., video games), this kind of scaffolding can have significant impacts on child health.

Sports and group games provide healthy opportunities for children to exercise in a social context, promoting good health, coordination and diverse relationships for a reciprocating self. Brain development and motor skills for school-aged children are enhanced with involvement in activities such as gymnastics, soccer and dance. Children acquire improved hand-eye coordination through sports, demonstrating better reaction times and increased flexibility. Such activities can greatly support the development of a mature reciprocating self to the extent that children learn they are a whole, complete being created in God's image. With their bodies, children discover they can make valuable contributions as an accepted member of a team. They learn that life is a gift from God, something to be celebrated individually and for the sake of others. We suspect that a critical issue in children's ability to apprehend this truth relates to the degree of competition and expectation placed on them in sports and group games. The zone of proximal biological development in the school years is optimized when children are given challenges that are realistic and achievable. Unrealistic or impossible expectations can lead to negative reciprocity, where a child repeatedly fails and eventually gives up or withdraws.

The brain develops rapidly during the school years. As before, cortical midline structures are growing and changing. Significantly, changes are accelerating with regard to structural development of the organ in association with CMS and self. Pfeifer and Peake (2012) note that cortical thickness in the CMS region reaches an apex between eight and

eleven years of age. Increased thickness suggests improved connectivity or capacity for brain structures to work together in the representation of self and other. Indeed, the authors note that rapid cortical enhancement followed by increased connectivity and integration may explain why young children tend to blur mental boundaries between self and other, whereas school-aged children are able to more precisely differentiate between the two. School-aged children can construct sophisticated self-appraisals in the middle and upper grades. These can be positive (*I scored the winning run and helped the team*) or painful (*I wasn't paying attention and let the other team score, now everyone is mad at me*). School-aged brains are becoming better networked—literally. They are newly able to reference self in relation to intentions, goals and role expectations. With these changes comes a greater sense of inclusion or exclusion in relation to peer groups. Autobiographical experiences in school age can have lasting impacts on identity development later in adolescence.

School Years: Cognitive Changes

Children's cognitive abilities improve markedly throughout the school years. Memory is one area that changes dramatically. In the play years children often struggle to recount what happened yesterday. But in the school years children develop the ability to remember events in great detail, sometimes reproducing the entire plot of a book or movie. School-aged children have a developed *episodic memory* that is able to place life events into a personal narrative that becomes a significant foundation for the reciprocating self. *Procedural memory*, or the ability to repeat sequences of habituated behavior or learning, also improves. Children in the school years become adept at free throws in basketball and timed multiplication tests in class. Memory-related

successes are fostered in part by the school-aged child's improving ability to pay attention. Children in later childhood can be selectively attentive to a teacher or coach, listening intently even when peers are talking around them. This kind of concentrated focus greatly helps children acquire and retain information.

Piaget referred to the school years as a period of *concrete operational thought.* The concrete operational thinker is now able to master problems of logic that confound children in the play years. A nine-year-old girl is able to deduce that the volume of milk in squat and tall glasses is quite possibly the same, and can design a mini-experiment to prove it. The same girl is also able to understand that things can be reversed back to their original state. Play-aged children are unable to comprehend that addition is the opposite of subtraction, and that equations can be reversed to produce the same number. The school-aged child's ability to handle these basic logic issues opens the door to rapid learning in mathematics and problem solving.

Without a doubt, one of the most noticeable characteristics of the school years is a child's growing affinity for peers. Improved theory-of-mind capability makes intricate social allegiances and associations possible. Some gender differences may become obvious in this process. Boys may establish fraternal group identities where they understand others to value activity for a common purpose, frequently through sports. Girls do the same, but with slightly different criteria reflecting a broader range of interpersonal understanding. Girls may form complex alliances, in-groups and out-groups during the school years, demonstrating well-developed abilities to understand what others are thinking and desiring. Expanded theory of mind combined with a lack of personal experience makes children in the school years highly impressionable. Peer pressure becomes a potent force in the middle grades, a surprise to many who consider this to be an adolescent phenomenon. The school

years are a critical period for the reciprocating self, a kind of peer-oriented proving ground that can validate or inhibit social development.

The school years are a period of remarkable linguistic growth that mirror an increasingly complex set of social relationships. Children in this period of life must navigate home and playground relationships. With improved language abilities children in the school years are able to tell jokes to peers and recognize when these might not play well at home with mom or dad. Puns and other word games become cognitively possible, enabled by a larger and more precise vocabulary. The social basis for language acquisition is expanded in the school years, partly through the many new and complicated relationships that must be constructed with peers. Children in this period may create context-specific dialects or language codes with their peers as a way of maintaining group membership and establishing boundaries apart from adults. Slang makes its first appearance, becoming more common by the time children reach adolescence. These cognitive changes anticipate an increasingly advanced ability for relationships and, as a consequence, added depth and breadth for a reciprocating self.

School Years: Socioemotional Changes

The school years are characterized by increasingly sophisticated self-appraisals involving emotions such as guilt, pride and shame. This makes sense given that school-aged children have considerably more and varied experiences of self in social context. Roles continue to become increasingly complex. An eleven-year-old girl plays multiple roles of social significance, including daughter, older sister, best friend, soccer captain and honor student. Given these different interpersonal obligations, she must regularly appraise circumstances and adapt. Self-conscious emotions

operate along with those cognitive systems that enable her to respond appropriately. We might imagine our eleven-year-old encounters a situation that is simultaneously routine and novel. Her soccer team is highly successful, with a season-ending invitation to the state cup tournament of champions. She finds much that is familiar in the role and context of functioning as team captain in a soccer game. But this isn’t just any soccer game. This is a championship game. Tensions are high, parental expectations elevated and the level of competition intense. Accustomed to winning, the eleven-year-old and her team contend with excellent opposition. Midway through the second half, the captain’s team is behind by two goals.

Three appraisal moves are indicated in terms of pride. First, our eleven-year-old experiences triggered self-representations in memory based upon what is happening on the field. She remembers past episodes when her coach praised her leadership and athletic abilities. She experiences a sense of responsibility to her coach, but also to her teammates and families on the sidelines. Second, she must evaluate current events and relationships in terms of goals embedded in her reciprocating self. The chips are down. She is the team leader. The situation demands a captain that elevates her game, inspiring others to follow. Third, she must reconcile appraised events and relationships with the self, acting accordingly. She digs deep down, finding an extra reserve of stamina and creativity, scoring a breakout goal that energizes her teammates and propels them forward. Through these moves, our eleven-year-old girl powerfully experiences beta pride. This pride is contagious, influencing her peers and the level of team play. Indeed, a recent study found that people who were primed to experience beta pride changed their group behaviors, mostly for the better. Others perceived these individuals more positively and affectionately.

The Reciprocating Self in Childhood

We will now integrate our discussion of biological, cognitive and socioemotional foundations of childhood to consider the reciprocating self in developmental relief. We will follow the growth of Rolando, a likable and intelligent boy from El Monte, California. Rolando will help to sketch developmental issues relevant to the reciprocating self in childhood. First, we will consider how *attachment* plays out in childhood, particularly in the development of the self. To do this, we will look at how the self might be structured or organized in the child. We will also consider how a child's experience of the self might clash with internal ideals through comparisons with others. Second, we will review *risk and resiliency* factors for the reciprocating self in childhood. Finally, we will look at *parenting issues* and the formation of the reciprocating self, paying close attention to children's identity as *imago Dei.*

Our review of biological and cognitive changes in childhood hints at remarkably complex changes to the reciprocating self. These changes reflect an evolving social and relational sophistication in the child. The increased social complexity of childhood ushers in new challenges for the reciprocating self in development. Rolando is seven years old, a second-grader involved in soccer and baseball. Even at his relatively tender age, he is a gifted goal scorer. His father, Efren, is a well-meaning but overly enthusiastic supporter on the soccer sideline. Often Efren will bellow encouragement or loudly express disappointment to Rolando from the sideline. While he plays, Rolando must balance expectations from his father and his teammates, particularly in a big game against an undefeated team. The manner in which Rolando resolves these tensions is related to mental representations of his relationships along with his ability to trust others based on experiences of care in early life.

Attachment. We recall from the previous chapter that Bowlby (1980) proposed an *internal working model* (IWM) of relationships with others. The IWM consists of mental representations (symbols) of the self and other in relationship. We may expect some developmental changes to the IWM in the mind of a seven-year-old. With a growing episodic memory, or ability to remember events and experiences, Rolando is developing the ability to link specific memories with particular people. He is able to make some preliminary judgments about new situations on the basis of what he knows from older, more established relationships. Fortunately, Rolando had good care in his early life and is able to trust people fairly easily. But because he is only seven, Rolando remains unable to make fine distinctions between his own qualities and the qualities of others. His representations of self with dad are accumulating, recently characterized by several tension-filled moments when Efren yelled from the sideline in soccer games. While Rolando's representations of self with close friends are positive, he is increasingly anxious in light of team expectations for goals scored in tough games.

Internal structure. Harter (2012) notes that children in Rolando's age bracket are able to make rudimentary links between representations of the self and others, but these links are typically opposites that demonstrate all-or-nothing thinking. Some admired adults in Rolando's world may occupy a special place of nearly heroic status. Indeed, this is probably true of his relationship with his father. In Rolando's eyes dad looms large as an authority figure and also as a hero to be emulated and worshiped. If it turns out that Efren is a gifted weekend mechanic, Rolando may ask to be involved in his father's restoration project on a classic Ford Mustang. His relationship with father carries a strong "Dad can do anything" emphasis, which can lead to mentoring opportunities or more competitive interactions. If Efren happens to be insecure, he may try to compete with his son

even when the two are engaged in a friendly game of catch. If such a relational pattern persists, Rolando may form an IWM that includes an *oppositional*, or competitive, interpretation of his relationship with his father. In the all-or-nothing world of the seven-year-old boy, Efren's hero status may be juxtaposed with an oppositional understanding of dad as the competition to be rivaled and eventually surpassed.

Accuracy. Rolando's reciprocating self develops from aggregate experiences of relationships with others. Yet as he forms self-understanding, he may do so with some initial assumptions that adults would probably call naive. This is normal. At seven, Rolando's view of self is typically positive, with some blatantly obvious inaccuracies (Harter, 2012). Rolando knows that he is an excellent soccer player and a top scorer. This could translate to braggadocio (alpha pride) on the playground or peer-group conversations that extend these achievements into other arenas beyond what is likely or immediately possible. Thus Rolando may conclude that because he is a second-grade soccer star, he will probably grow up to become a professional player and make millions of dollars. He will live in a pricey Malibu mansion and drive a Porsche. While there is a small possibility of this happening, Rolando may have a better chance of winning the lottery. Rolando's episodic knowledge of himself in relationships is still fairly limited.

Comparisons to others. Rolando's reciprocating self reflects increased comparisons that he is able to make based on experiences of relationship within his IWM. Additionally, comparisons are made easier by his newfound ability to compare the Rolando of the present to the Rolando of the past. Rolando knows that two years ago he could not play soccer and was unable to score goals. As a kindergartner Rolando could hardly kick the ball straight. Rolando is now able to compare himself to the Rolando of the past as a matter of reference, helping him to better apprehend the Rolando of the present. Moreover, as a child moving into the

school years Rolando is increasingly oriented toward his peer group, and this becomes an unceasing source of comparison. He will compare himself to classmates on scholastic performance, video game prowess and, of course, on the soccer field. Around the age of seven, the childhood penchant for *fairness* makes its full-blown appearance, becoming the ultimate mitigating factor in all peer-group comparisons. Rolando's IWM evolves to accommodate a self that is "fairly" constructed on the basis of honorable principles. In his mind Rolando's success on the soccer field is legitimate, not just on the basis of goals scored but because he plays without cheating.

Sensitivity to others. Along with Rolando's heightened awareness of peers through comparison, his IWM is accommodating the opinions of others at new and more sensitive levels. More than just a gross yardstick for comparison purposes, Rolando is newly aware that peers make *judgments* regarding his performance. With this knowledge comes Rolando's implicit use of others' standards in helping him to establish his own benchmarks. Rolando's peers expect that he will score goals. This weighs heavily on him and adds to the considerable heft of dad's expectations for success. Rolando's reciprocating self is increasingly sensitive to the values that other people place on his gifts and performance. It is quite possible that this heightened sensitivity will result in some anxiety. The boy might anticipate a big game two full days before the actual event, knowing that his peers are counting on him and his family is watching. Rolando's IWM may shift on the basis of his success or failure at the fateful soccer game depending on the degree to which Rolando's reciprocating self relies on peer opinion and family expectation.

Risk and resiliency. What promotes developmental thriving in childhood? The complex interplay between the reciprocating self and others makes developmental predictions hazardous at best. We all remember child and adolescent peers who

apparently had everything going for them and yet ended up in prison, involved in troubled relationships or enduring financial failure. We also know children from difficult or abusive backgrounds who managed to make it anyway. How might we assess the direction of Rolando's development of a reciprocating self, recognizing that only God knows the precise details of his future?

In order to construct a more realistic basis for understanding why some kids succeed where others inexplicably struggle, psychologists outlined a theory of *risk* and *resiliency* in development. Leaders in this field include Anne Masten and Alan Sroufe at the University of Minnesota. For these theorists *risk* represents any factor in a child's world that jeopardizes healthy development. Risk might be "internal" in the sense that issues related to the child's physiology or psychological makeup might hinder normal development. A crack baby with low birth weight and cocaine-induced neurological damage carries numerous internal risk factors. Risk might also be "external" in the sense that unhealthy relationships or environmental conditions might derail normal development (Benson, 1997; Masten & Coatsworth, 1995; Sroufe, Egeland, Carlson & Collins, 2009; Werner & Smith, 2001). A six-year-old girl living in poverty might have limited access to adequate health care and proper nutrition. These issues represent external risk to the girl's development. By contrast, *resiliency* represents any factor in a child's world that promotes healthy development. Internal resiliency might include intelligence or moral restraint. External resiliency is indicated in supportive family relationships and mentors.

I (Kevin) teach the risk-resiliency model to psychology graduate students using the analogy of a two-platform scale (like those found in a middle-school science classroom). The scale is like a seesaw, weighted at either end by risk and resiliency factors respectively. All children, no matter what their background or situation, have at least some risk and

resiliency factors. For educators and clinicians working with children, the primary challenge is to make sure the resiliency side of the scale is heavily weighted. When risk and resiliency hang evenly in the balance or are tipped toward the risk side of the scale, children are in danger of developing psychopathology or other symptoms of normal development gone awry.

In seven-year-old Rolando's situation we might assume that the boy's resiliency factors outweigh his risk factors. Despite stress associated with overly enthusiastic parenting from the sidelines and pressure from his teammates, Rolando manages to score one goal in a big game that his team loses in the end. The game in many ways reflects real life—some triumphs are also accompanied by failures that must be socially integrated into a mature reciprocating self. Rolando is a reasonably happy child with a variety of personal gifts and a supportive home environment. However, this assessment is no guarantee for successful development. As with the attachment discussion, we are interested in briefly exploring how risk and resiliency offer insight into Rolando's circumstances along with his future development.

Risk. Risk can be overt, such as in the case of neglectful parenting or even something subtler. It may be that Rolando is a firstborn child. Several developmental studies have revealed that birth order does have implications for child development. In particular, firstborn children tend to be more competitive and potentially more anxious (Falbo, 1981). This may result from the firstborn's tendency to internalize and appropriate parental expectations more keenly than other siblings. If true, this fits well into our earlier discussion of heightened sensitivity to others manifest in Rolando's self-understanding and IWM. Rolando's firstborn status, combined with parental and peer expectations for success, could lead to excessive worrying or anxiety. Whereas birth order in itself is not necessarily a risk factor, in the presence of other mitigating issues it may present some risk

to Rolando's reciprocating self. Making things even more interesting, there is emerging evidence that parental experiences of stress can be passed down to offspring through *epigenetic* (changes to genome) transmission (Franklin, Russig, Weiss, Graff, Linder, Michalon, Vizi & Mansuy, 2010).

Rolando's relationship with his father might imply risk if Efren's competitive streak motivates him to shame the boy. Shame can be corrosive to Rolando's developing self as it mirrors back messages of failure and rejection that can be difficult to overcome. In the event that Rolando's relationship with his father continues to grow in its oppositional nature, the boy may export the motif of "Rolando as failure" into increasingly more relationships through a revised IWM. The tendency for shame to dominate a child's self-understanding over time could become a self-fulfilling prophecy in adolescence and adulthood. This can be expected to show up in all of the domains where Rolando considers performance to be important such as academic work, peer relationships and sports.

Resiliency. Rolando appears to have many resiliency factors. Rolando is intelligent and has a fun, gregarious personality. Rolando experiences secure attachment with his mother, and at a core level he perceives himself as fundamentally good. These traits have been known and reinforced throughout his childhood experiences. We might surmise that Rolando's preschool and kindergarten teachers picked up on these positive factors and helped draw them out further. We can also guess that Rolando chooses well-adjusted peers as friends, increasing the likelihood that his positive qualities will be reciprocated. Rolando has been shown respect as a child within his family context and is learning to extend this respect outward to include peers and other adults.

Rolando is blessed with a supportive mother and large extended family. This is particularly significant given Rolando's Mexican American identity. Family is of great

importance in Mexican culture. For many years the Roman Catholic Church of Mexico has encouraged large families. Traditionally, extended kin networks played an enormous role in the socialization of Mexican children. Rolando is part of a third-generation immigrant family that is significantly acculturated to American society. Indeed, none of his immediate family speaks Spanish. However, expectations for extended-family support and tradition are still powerful, evident in the many relatives that regularly attend his soccer games. Consequently, Rolando is the beneficiary of a range of supportive relationships that create resiliency for self-understanding and the organization of his IWM.

It appears that Rolando's two-platform scale is weighted toward the resiliency side. Rolando's future development is likely to continue normally. Earlier, we implied that Rolando might use increased peer affiliation as a compensation for the sometimes oppositional relationship with his father. This serves as a good example of resiliency factors overcoming risk in a child's overall developmental course. Children with a considerable number of resiliency factors are generally able to prevail in the midst of adversity and failure (Masten & Coatsworth, 1995; Sroufe et al., 2009; Werner & Smith, 2001). In summary, we might expect to see Rolando's growing peer network complement other deficiencies in his relationship with his father. As an intelligent and sociable individual, Rolando is able to adapt in ways that keep a predominantly positive perspective on his reciprocating self, particularly as this develops in relationship with others. Hopefully, the friction in Rolando's relationship with his father will be fleeting, and eventually it will reflect other, positive influences for Rolando's reciprocating self.

Parenting. We have already discussed the significance of *unconditional love, gracing, empowering* and *intimate relationships* in human development, and the specific connections among each of these factors with *parental*

support, monitoring, intervention and *control,* respectively. Now we will discuss each of these areas with a view toward finding an optimal profile of parenting behaviors that scaffold the reciprocating self as it develops in childhood. This search for effectively balanced and consistently adequate parenting takes us back to the work of Diana Baumrind. After her decades-long study of families, Baumrind concluded that parenting exists along a continuum of types. At one extreme are *permissive* parents, characterized by low support and low control. At the other extreme are *authoritarian* parents, who use excessively high control but are low in their support of children. Children tended not to thrive in either of these environments. In the middle of the continuum Baumrind noted a group of parents that combined high support with high control, upholding an *authoritative* parenting style that was very effective (Baumrind, 2012).

Support. Through the unconditional love of parents children acquire a reciprocating self that is secure, knowing that physical and emotional needs will be addressed. High support is a hallmark of authoritative parenting. The authoritative ideal is without question the most demanding and costly kind of parenting. Children's support needs often come at inopportune times. Sick children keep parents awake through the night. Broken limbs may require lengthy home stays. Contemporary children are involved in an extraordinary variety of activities, many of which require parental taxi services. Help with homework, chores, peer problems and spiritual concerns all enlist the involvement of mothers and fathers. In the rapid-paced environment of the United States, parents must balance career requirements with attendance at sporting events and performances that are enormously significant to young participants. True to the unconditional love of authentic parental support, many parents make quiet, daily sacrifices on behalf of their children, a kind of *kenotic* (emptying) commitment that follows after the example of Christ.

Monitoring. The play- and school-aged child requires grace. The authoritative parent places a premium on monitoring child activities, but not in a manner that obscures growing independence. Of course, monitoring strategies change across the range of childhood. A five-year-old boy will require direct supervision for play dates with a good friend. Care must be taken to ensure a safety-proofed kitchen, outdoor pool and age-appropriate toys. A ten-year-old girl will not require the same kind of monitoring. Parental supervision will be necessary, but monitoring for the independent, grade-school-aged child reinforces commonsense understandings about household rules and safety, along with encouragement to explore new activities. To an extent this must be adjusted to cultural and environmental conditions. It may be safe for the ten-year-old to ride her bike down the street to a neighbor's house to play, or her parent might have to give her a ride, depending on local context. The grace extended by parents through this kind of monitoring recognizes that the zone of proximal development includes both challenge and safety, a delicate equilibrium requiring emotionally involved fathers and mothers.

Some parents of school-aged students choose to homeschool their children. The reasons for this decision vary widely. A common justification for homeschooling involves parental concerns regarding the values learned by children in the public education setting. The homeschool approach affords the parent with the ability to closely monitor the child's development and the social influences that shape the reciprocating self. We appreciate the logic of parents wishing to grace their children with values and character traits that reflect biblical priorities. Regardless of whether the child grows up in public or homeschool settings, it is this parental prerogative to use monitoring as a gracing force for values integration that promotes positive development in the child's reciprocating self. Parents with strong, positive values will model these to children through

their monitoring, demonstrating forgiveness, patience and fidelity in situations too numerous to measure. Whether the child attends public school or stays at home, the gracing parent helps the child to reciprocate relationships of respect and dignity, affirming the *imago Dei* in others.

Intervention strategies. The authoritative parent uses high support and high control to empower a reciprocating self in childhood. We have previously considered two kinds of intervention approaches in parenting. These interventions serve as one means to providing control or structure to the child's developmental scaffolding. *Coercive*, or negative, interventions are commonly understood as punishments, including physical retribution or withdrawal of privileges. *Inductive*, or positive, interventions focus on reasoning with children over the anticipated consequences of an action.- Baumrind (1971, 1996, 2012) noted that effective, authoritative intervention strategies with play- and school-aged children tended toward withdrawal of privileges with abundant inductive reasoning. Harsher coercive strategies were less evident in this group. Her findings evoke an old debate over interventions and positive development. What kind of interventions empowers the reciprocating self in the child?

One way to address this question is to find out how parent interventions affect child behavior in social settings, specifically with regard to the most controversial interventions in *hitting* and *spanking*. A well-known study by Strassberg, Dodge, Pettit and Bates (1994) tracked 273 children (four to six years old) in order to consider the relationship between intervention strategies and child aggression toward peers in kindergarten. Child aggression was outlined in terms of (1) *instrumental aggression*, such as fighting over toys, (2) *reactive aggression*, such as physical retaliation toward peers, and (3) *bullying aggression*. Children were sampled from families that used three different strategies, including *no hitting or spanking*, *spanking only*,

or *hitting and spanking both.* On instrumental aggression there was no significant difference among any of the three parent-intervention strategies. However, a powerful effect emerged for reactive aggression. Children who were spanked were more than twice as likely as children who were not spanked to physically retaliate against kindergarten peers. Further, bullying aggression was strongly predicted by those children that were both hit and spanked relative to the other two strategies. The most extreme coercive intervention strategy (hitting and spanking) appeared to promote bullying behaviors and elevate the likelihood of physical retaliation against peers. Spanking seemed to facilitate a reaction in children to perceived threats of attack, resulting in a low threshold for self-control in conflicts with peers. Overall, peer aggression was lower for children who were not hit or spanked relative to the other intervention strategies (Strassberg et al., 1994). It seems clear that the parent's choice of intervention is to a significant extent reciprocated in the child's self relative to conflict behaviors with peers.

Should this serve as an argument for permissive parenting that avoids coercive interventions? We think this would be a mistake. Authoritative, balanced interventions are supported by the research literature and by our theological convictions. Christians have made passionate, biblically informed arguments weighted toward the use of both highly coercive and permissive interventions with children. Among our students we have noticed a similar range of opinions, typically generated on the basis of personal childhood experiences. Some of these opinions appear to be unique to denominational interpretations of the Scripture. We have argued in this book that interventions should be oriented toward the positive development of a reciprocating self in the child, empowering him or her to more fully experience identity as Christ's beloved. For us, Baumrind's findings regarding high support and high control (intervention

strategies) fit with our view that children are kingdom citizens ready for discipleship (Mt 18:1-4). Selection of intervention strategies should uphold a mandate of discipleship in our relationships with children. Discipleship implies correction as guidance embedded within an ongoing, committed relationship that reflects the parent's intimacy with Christ. This differs from correction as an imposition or exercise of power that diminishes the child's essential identity or value as a bearer of the *imago Dei.* Given this perspective we find it impossible to justify hitting or spanking a child for any reason. Indeed, Baumrind's work suggests that time-outs and withdrawal of privileges are highly effective interventions that empower children to fully experience their belovedness.

Control. Control presupposes intimate relationships that foster positive values and respect for others. Intervention strategies represent one aspect of parental control. In a cognitive sense control exercised through *boundaries* and *rules for conduct* functions as a second developmental scaffold. Certainly the growing child's capacity for self-control is an important feature for a mature reciprocating self. If Baumrind is correct, authoritative parents must create structure in boundaries and rules for conduct that enables children to explore and make mistakes without violating the parent's fundamental, unspoken promise to the child that "I'll be there for you." It is the primacy of the child's relationship with his or her parent that makes control effective. In the absence of parental control children are unable to effectively form boundaries in relationships, a problematic situation in adolescence and emerging adulthood. Boundaries assume that others exist separately from the self and that others are worthy of respect. By the same token, rules for conduct extend respect to others whether through the courtesy of a shaken hand or decent table manners.

We note that Baumrind (2012, p. 35) offers a helpful distinction between *coercive* and *confrontative* parental control practices. She surmises, "The kind of power that characterizes authoritarian parents is coercive (arbitrary, peremptory, dominating, and concerned with marking status distinctions), whereas the kind of power that characterizes authoritative parents is confrontative (reasoned, negotiable, outcome oriented and concerned with regulating behaviors)." She argues that "the effects of power assertion are detrimental only when coercive, so that the common presumption that power-assertive disciplinary practices per se are harmful is unjustified." Children raised in authoritative parenting homes acquire a capacity to make internal decisions, experience enhanced self-esteem, academic achievement, cognitive development, creativity, moral behavior and instrumental abilities (Buehler, 2006; Galambos, Barker & Almeida, 2003). Perhaps even more compelling, studies in Portugal (Franchini, Poinhos, Klepp & Aleida, 2011) and the United States (Blissett, 2011) indicate that children who experience authoritative parenting are more willing to eat fruit and vegetables!

The Ecology of Childhood

It is commonly observed that as children change, their environment changes with them. At times development works hand-in-glove with environmental shifts, but this is not always the case. Systems tend toward stability—also known as *equilibrium.* Equilibrium is that state where persons and relationships within a system are as stable as they are capable of being (O' Connor & Ammen, 1997). When change is introduced to a system, however, the system reacts and equilibrium is disrupted. Individuals or relationships within the system may move to oppose or block the change. It is in these situations that we can learn much about how development

happens. In this section we will consider how the child's self is influenced within nested ecosystems. Rather than deal with each ecosystem and its potential influence on the reciprocating self in childhood, we will use the remaining space to frame an ecosystemic discussion of important childhood issues. We will discuss changes to the reciprocating self on the basis of disruption to equilibrium within the ecosystem. Specifically, our discussion will focus on *divorce* and *discrimination.*

Divorce. Up until the late 1970s there were attempts to downplay the negative effects of divorce on children. This effort was based on research suggesting that children may be better off in a well-adjusted, one-parent home than in an unhappy two-parent home. The divorced home presumably became a more stable, less disruptive environment. A related view claimed that harm to children came from a conflicted marriage, in which children experienced trauma created by the psychopathology of their parents. In support of this view were Gordon's (2005) findings that the negative effect of divorce is short term, with children of divorce appearing to be less harmed. Gordon believed the impact of divorce on children to be fleeting and that long-lasting psychological problems displayed by children of divorce in adolescence and adulthood reflect problems with the pre-divorce marriage. Strohschein (2005, p. 1286) reported that even before the divorce, children whose parents later divorced exhibited higher levels of anxiety/depression and antisocial behavior than children whose parents remained married. She noted, however, that there were "divorce specific" increases in anxiety and depression (Strohschein 2005, p. 489). Another study (VanderValk et al., 2005, p. 533) reported "a further increase in child anxiety and depression but not antisocial behavior associated with the event of parental divorce itself."

The complex relationship between divorce and child development led to increasingly nuanced assessment through

the 1980s and 1990s. One of the strongest studies involved a randomly selected sample of 1,500 young adults from divorced and intact homes (Marquardt, 2005). The author found that children of divorce were four times more likely than those from intact families to agree with the statement, “My father has done things I find hard to forgive.” Although the difference was less dramatic, children of divorced parents were more likely than those from intact homes to agree that their mother had done things they found hard to forgive. Most researchers now agree that trauma created by the divorce along with resulting anxiety and uncertainty is harmful to children. A longitudinal study by leading divorce researchers Mavis Hetherington and John Kelly (2003) found that changes in everyday life following divorce do have an initially negative impact on the children. The altered behavior of parents during and after divorce (dating phase) is particularly difficult. It takes most parents two or more years to recuperate from divorce. During this time of adjustment both parents struggle with personal self-esteem needs. Some spouses are prone to sexual acting out, vengefulness against the former spouse, emotional outbursts, periods of depression and fearful concerns about future and finances. This transition takes a toll on the children because parents are often not available to help them make emotional adjustments. Children in the first year following divorce may exhibit acting-out or acting-in behaviors. Girls frequently recover in the second year, while boys may continue to have adjustment problems through adolescence, especially if they live with mother in a single-parent home. Though dependent on her, boys go through coercive cycles and tend to be more aggressive and noncompliant. Single-parent mothers and daughters tend to become very close emotionally until the onset of adolescence, which initiates conflict over sexual behavior and individuation (Hetherington & Kelly, 2003).

Recent studies expand on these themes. One study of 10,061 children reported that "divorce is associated with diminished psychosocial well-being in children, and that this decrease helps explain the connection between divorce and lower academic achievement" (Potter, 2010, p. 933). Yu, Pettit, Lansford, Dodge, and Bates (2010) found that marital conflict and divorce impacts the quality of relationship between the mother and her children. The negative implications begin early, at the first stages of divorce (Kim, 2011). Negativity can persist long after the divorce is completed. Afifi, Schrodt and McManus (2009) found that parents talking disparagingly about the divorced spouse emotionally affected their children. Factors beyond the divorce event can further exacerbate issues for children. Vousoura, Verdeli, Warner, Wickramaratne and Bailey (2012, p. 718) note that "results support previous findings suggesting that familial risk for depression largely overshadows the effect of parental divorce on child psychopathology." The elevated number of mental health problems noted among children of divorce is "mostly attributable to greater socioeconomic disadvantage and more dysfunctional family process among eventually divorcing households" (Strohschein, 2012, p. 489).

We acknowledge that divorce can save lives and child welfare in the presence of familial violence, substance abuse and addiction. We believe children deserve to grow up in a family with two parents who love them and each other. Since divorce undermines reciprocation between parents and children, it will always be a drastic last resort. The crucial question remains, "What is in the best interest of children?" Children are harmed by what transpires in unhappy and conflictive marriages, but they also suffer because of the divorce itself. The term *double-exposure effect* refers to how the *divorce event* and *parental distress* contribute *independently* to child and adolescent distress (Storksen et al., 2006). Regardless of the source of the harm, the

evidence indicates that children of divorced homes are burdened more than children of intact homes. In a summary of research on families with children, Crosnoe and Cavanagh (2010, p. 4) conclude that "for both genders, but especially boys, family transitions . . . (parental marriage, divorce, single parenthood, cohabitation, remarriage, etc.) . . . are associated with increased behavioral problems across all stages of childhood."

Discrimination. As with divorce, the effects of discrimination on the family and the growing child's reciprocating self can be profound. We recall that seven-year-old Rolando's family is third-generation Mexican American. This means that for three generations his family has lived in the United States. Nobody in Rolando's immediate family speaks Spanish. Rolando's father, Efren, went to a prestigious American public university. The family has attained a high standard of living, most likely considered upper middle-class. Nevertheless, groups of color are still subjected to discrimination in mainstream American society. It may happen that Rolando's mother, Rita, is called a "brown" by a senior businessperson in the office where she works. This awful event deeply hurts Rita. Efren is enraged. For several days the couple discusses potential options to confront the individual, including litigation. During this time the stress level in Rolando's household multiplies tenfold. Rolando learns of the situation when he eavesdrops on a phone conversation between his mother and her sister. After the conversation Rolando asks his favorite uncle about the meaning of a *brown* and why this term is so hurtful to his mother.

In the aftermath of the event we can see how increased stress levels might ecosystemically play out through the family. Both parents are justifiably angry, hurt and anxious. These emotions are typical of a heightened arousal state in the body. In this situation they are unlikely to sleep well, a problem that Rolando subconsciously picks up on. Efren's

frustration may additionally fuel his antics on the soccer field and expectations of his son's performance. In this environment Rolando's reciprocating self might be affected. Rolando learns, perhaps for the first time, that he is sometimes perceived as different from other children. The exosystem of his mother's workplace and the broader macrosystem of American society reflect something back to Rolando that he was not previously aware of. He is of Mexican descent. Rolando always thought of this identity as a source of pride, particularly around Christmastime when his European and African American friends would envy the homemade tamales his mother packed in his lunch. Now, however, Rolando understands that the wider ecosystem may not be as friendly to his ethnicity as once believed.

The impact of the event upon Rolando's IWM depends greatly on how his parents manage it. If Efren and Rita choose a *stress-sustaining* solution to the workplace problem, we can expect fairly dramatic changes to Rolando's reciprocating self. Developmentally, Rolando cannot make fine distinctions in his core self. Consequently, residual hostility in his home might affect Rolando's ability to trust others. He may understand himself in a less positive light and make quicker value judgments regarding the perspective and opinions of others. His IWM appropriates a view that, on the whole, people are untrustworthy, representing insidious elements of the system that his family struggled to overcome. If Rolando's parents choose a *stress-reducing* option to deal with the situation, the event becomes a different kind of learning opportunity for the boy's IWM. In this latter scenario Rolando learns that some (but not all) people in wider society harbor hurtful biases against people of color. Despite this, the goodness of Rolando's identity as a Mexican American will prevail and is worthy of the respect Rolando has already experienced both within his family and without. In terms of his self-understanding, Rolando adjusts his IWM to include a small category of

persons unfriendly to his Mexican heritage. But in the main, the implications of the event are less detrimental in terms of Rolando's ability to trust others.

Concluding Thoughts: The Reciprocating Self in Childhood

We have reviewed biological, cognitive and socioemotional changes for both play- and school-aged children. We explored the contours of the reciprocating self in childhood, particularly through *attachment*, *risk and resiliency*, and *parenting* issues in development. We attempted to obtain a wider view of development on the basis of changes to the child's ecosystem, including *divorce* and *discrimination.* In our interest to outline positive principles in development, we underscored the importance of helping children understand their fundamental worth as sons and daughters of God. This becomes especially important in a consideration of adolescence, a crucial lifespan moment where issues of identity become particularly important.

8

Adolescence

More Reciprocity Than You Think

At first glance the period of adolescence seems to have little to do with reciprocity. In general, people perceive adolescents as being preoccupied with themselves—their identity, their clothes, their friends, their music and their media. Parents often ask, "What happened to my sweet ten-year-old who used to like to curl up with me and read *Harry Potter,* or who would hold my hand as we walked down the streets? Now, the only give and take she seems to be interested in is taking from my wallet!" A colleague at Fuller Seminary wrote a funny anecdote in their Christmas newsletter about the similarities between cats and teenagers. He noted that neither cats nor teenagers turn their head when you call their name, nor do they like to be seen with you in public. (When was the last time you saw a cat being walked on a leash?)

The media does not help this rather negative portrayal of adolescence. More frequently than not, the stories featured in the news include those of teenage violence and delinquency. Additionally, our media-saturated lives are full of violent and oversexualized images of adolescents and role models for adolescents. The word *wholesome* does not exactly come to mind when thinking of performers topping the charts (e.g., Katy Perry, Eminem, Nicki Minaj). Regardless of era,

teens are of course known for their loud music, outlandish clothes and rebellious spirit—whether this be the greasers of the 1950s, the flower children of the 1960s, the punks of the 1980s, the goths of the 1990s or the loners of the new millennium. Every era is characterized by a style and means of rebellion. Although the more extreme groups do not include all young people of an era, they do significantly influence the way the media portrays and the public perceives youth. The general stereotype of adolescence is that biological changes of puberty create a developmental disturbance of emotional and social turmoil and problem behaviors. Research demonstrates that all too often adults are influenced by these negative stereotypes of teens, and they so fear the young people in their own community that they are reluctant to engage with them (Scales, 2003).

Although this perception of adolescents is less than favorable, in our society we are somewhat sympathetic to this period known for its radical growth and rebellion. Personal memories remind us of what an awkward and difficult period of life adolescence can be. Memories of shifting relationships with parents, adjusting to rapid growth and raging hormones, negotiating peer pressure, and navigating the waters of gender and sexuality are enough to make anyone relieved that they have survived this period. In addition, psychologists have significantly contributed to this unfavorable perception of adolescence. Since the time of G. Stanley Hall (1904), who stated that "human development included a period of *Strum un Drang* [German for 'storm and stress'] between childhood and adulthood," storm and stress has characterized what many people in Western culture believe about the essence of adolescence. Furthermore, the current status of social science research illustrates psychology's preoccupation with the negative aspects of adolescence. Studies of violence, suicide, depression, eating disorders, delinquency and substance abuse are found in disproportionate numbers

compared to studies examining aspects of positive development in young people (e.g., caring, spirituality, leadership).

Although popular and academic portrayals of adolescence suggest a more self-absorbed period of life, the concept of the reciprocating self challenges us to ask deeper questions: During the period of adolescence, how do individuals develop the capacity to be in reciprocating relationships characterized by the mutual encounter of two differentiated individuals? How is the *I* developing in relationship to *others?* How do adolescents reciprocate with other individuals, their families and society? What do the dangerous risk-taking behaviors often associated with adolescence have to do with the emergence of the reciprocating self?

This chapter considers how the developmental tasks that take place during adolescence relate to the emergence of the reciprocating self. More physical, cognitive and socioemotional growth may take place during adolescence than during any other period of life. We first provide a general overview of the major facets of adolescent development and then examine how aspects of individual development contribute to the sense of uniqueness or particularity present in a person capable of being in authentic mutual relationships. Such facets of individual development include identity development and differentiation. Then we explore issues of adolescent development that promote relationality and reciprocity by looking at the roles of intimacy and moral, spiritual and civic development.

Adolescent Development

Adolescence, as a period of life, has only been recognized in the last century. As noted previously, Hall (1904) was the first person to name the significance of a unique stage of development between childhood and adulthood. Since its

inception adolescence has been traditionally defined as the period of life between childhood and adulthood that commences with the onset of puberty and ends with the commitment to adult roles. As such, adolescence has typically been recognized to begin around the age of twelve and then to conclude somewhere between eighteen and twenty-two, at which point persons presumably move into the labor market, get married and begin families. As recently as the 1960s the transition into adulthood was well defined in most Western industrialized countries. Upon finishing high school, adolescents either went to college, got a full-time job or joined the military. For the most part people married in their early twenties and began families almost immediately (Arnett, 2000a). Consequently, the "stage" of adolescence was said to end and adulthood begin when people made commitments to adult roles—such as vocation and marriage.

However, at the commencement of the twenty-first century the onset of adolescence is beginning earlier due to complex social and biological factors that contribute to children starting puberty at an earlier age than they did one hundred years ago (Mortimer & Larson, 2002; Steinberg, 2014; Susman & Dorn, 2009). For example, the average age of menarche has dropped from fifteen to sixteen years in the mid-1800s to thirteen in the 1950s to closer to twelve years for young women today. Although the age that girls start their period has remained relatively stable in the last half of a century, the onset of secondary sex characteristics of breasts and pubic hair is starting much earlier (see Susman & Dorn, 2009; Diamond, Bonner & Dickenson, 2015). Research has shown that the earliest onset of puberty for boys is about ten (see Diamond et al., 2015). Consequently, adolescence in the Western world is now recognized as beginning between the ages of ten and twelve.

Not only is adolescence starting earlier but rapid demographic, sociocultural and economic trends have extended traditional adolescent-like behaviors well into the twenties.

Throughout much of the twentieth century only a limited number of fairly defined pathways from adolescence into adulthood existed. This is no longer the case; youth today are faced with many different educational or training, employment and spousal or partner options. As a result, commitment to traditional adult roles of stable work and marriage is delayed or not pursued. Thus, unlike at the publication of the first edition of *The Reciprocating Self*, it is not currently useful to think of adolescence ending when young people make commitments to adult roles.

Currently, developmental scientists debate "the end of adolescence." Some suggest that adolescence extends until about twenty-five—the reasoning has less to do with the commitment to adult roles, but more to do with brain maturation (see Steinberg, 2014). The most recent neuroscience today suggests that the burst of brain growth that occurs during adolescence slows down around age twenty-five, and at this age individuals are able to function more consistently cognitively and emotionally. Consequently, from a neuropsychological perspective, adolescents transition into young adulthood around age twenty-five when the high levels of malleability and plasticity typical during adolescence lessen. However, others like Arnett (2000a) propose *emerging adulthood* as a transitional stage of the lifespan between adolescence and young adulthood. From this point of view, adolescence is thought to end around age eighteen, when emerging adulthood begins and then extends through the mid- to late twenties. In the next chapter we will further discuss emerging and young adulthood.

Regardless of one's view of the theoretical end of adolescence, most youth today, especially in more developed nations, will have more complex and diverse experiences in their twenties than previous generations. Youth can expect to have as many as four quite different occupational careers throughout their life, anticipate living in a different community than the one they grew up in, and have multiple

intimate partners. In addition, economic strain and advances in science, technology and culture have altered the complexity of the job market. Consequently, more preparation is required as people make many vocational and relational commitments. In order to prepare adequately for the diverse labor market, more youth are spending more time in postsecondary education. At one point a GED or surely a BA or BS degree prepared most for employment. However, today more young people are preparing for their careers by pursuing master's or doctoral degrees. In many cases education expenses and lack of full-time employment cause young people to be financially dependent on and in some cases living with their parents until their mid-twenties. Additionally, the latest census reported that in 2010 the median age for marriage was almost twenty-seven for women and about twenty-eight and a half for men (US Bureau of the Census, 2012).

Given the diverse and complex lives of youth today, we appreciate the optimistic perspective that many developmental scholars have toward adolescence (see Benson & Scales, 2009; Damon, 2004; Lerner, 2004, Steinberg, 2014). Borrowing from the title of Steinberg's (2014) book, we view adolescence as an "age of opportunity." In the next section, we discuss how different scholars have approached understanding the developmental issues of this malleable and important time in people's lives.

Many theorists have proposed systematic ways of thinking about the developmental challenges, opportunities and risks of adolescence. Erik Erikson's (1968) lifespan model has been one of the most prominent models to identify the developmental tasks of adolescence and the other life stages. Although Erikson names *identity formation* as the definitive developmental task of adolescence, for individuals aged ten to eighteen his theory also includes the importance of developing a sense of *mastery* and *intimacy*. Other scholars have also included *autonomy, sexuality* and *achievement* (e.g., Carnegie Corporation, 1989) as important components of

adolescent growth. The National Academy of Sciences reported that in many different cultural groups these challenges involve the following more specific tasks: (1) changing relationships between adolescent-aged children and their parents in order for youth to take on a more mature role in their community; (2) exploring new personal, social and sexual roles and identities; (3) transforming peer relationships into deeper friendships and more intimate partnerships; and (4) participating in opportunities and experiences that facilitate future economic independence and interdependence (Eccles & Gootman, 2002).

Following the relational developmental systems approach, these adolescent developmental tasks need to be understood as taking place in a complex web of social, cultural and historical settings (e.g., Bronfenbrenner, 1979; Lerner et al., 2015; Overton, 2015). Optimal adolescent development depends on (1) the physical, psychological and cognitive assets of the individual; (2) available social supports; and (3) the developmental fit or appropriateness between each of the social settings and the young person. In other words, development occurs within a dynamic system including individual factors, contextual influences and the fit between the individual and their context. With rapid and numerous changes occurring over the course of a few years, an increased potential for both positive and negative outcomes arises. Although most young people make it through this developmental period without exceedingly high levels of stress and strain, many do not. The complex interplay of individual issues, whether biological, cognitive or-socioemotional, and contextual influences has significant ramifications for the emergence of the reciprocating self. In this next section we provide an overview of the developmental issues that may help or hinder the development of the reciprocating self.

Biological Changes

A thorough review of the biological changes associated with puberty is beyond the scope of this book, but given the significance of these changes we feel it is important to provide a brief overview of major issues including the presence of hormones and brain growth. The activation of hormones responsible for pubertal development prompts a significant growth spurt, the emergence of primary and secondary sex characteristics, the onset of fertility and the experience of increased sexual libido in most early adolescents (ages nine to thirteen). Recently, research has explored how hormonal changes occurring in early adolescence might relate to changes in behavior commonly associated with adolescence. Although there is some evidence for direct effects of hormones on such behaviors as heightened sexual feelings, mood swings and aggression, these relations are quite complex. Hormones and other biological systems interact with genetic predispositions and social experiences in multifaceted ways.

For example, it has been suggested that the gender differences associated with the onset of depression, eating disorders and aggression may be connected to differences in patterns of hormonal changes associated with puberty. However, evidence suggests that such mood and behavior patterns lie in complex interactions between life experience, gender-role socialization, genetically linked vulnerabilities and changes in hormonal systems (Eccles & Gootman, 2002). An illustration of this point is the research findings that the early onset of puberty for young white girls is often problematic and linked with increased rates of eating disorders, depression and involvement in problematic behaviors. (As an aside, early onset of maturation is advantageous for Caucasian boys, particularly with respect to athletic participation and social standing in schools.)

In addition, early maturation is not associated with these problematic behaviors among African American girls. These gender and ethnic differences are better understood in light of many ecological factors, and not merely by examining the role of hormones. It has been suggested that early pubertal maturation may be particularly problematic for Caucasian American girls because the changes associated with puberty, like gaining weight, are not valued by many Caucasian Americans, who often yearn for a slim, androgynous female body (an image promoted by the media). In addition, research suggests that because of increased sexual attention from boys and men, young girls who enter puberty earlier fall in with older peer groups. It has been suggested that these young women base more of their identity on their relationships with boys and men and less on developing individual competencies (Magnusson, 1988; Stattin & Magnusson, 1990).

In addition to affecting the growth of the physical body, hormonal changes are associated with emotions related to sexuality. The biological changes of puberty both increase young persons' interest in sex and their awareness of others' perception of them as sexual objects. Both physical and emotional changes can have a significant effect on development. Sexual behavior increases dramatically during early to middle adolescence. The last National Longitudinal Study of Adolescent Health (Blum, Beuhring & Rinehart, 2000) found that 16% of seventh- and eighth-graders report having had sexual intercourse and that this number increases to 60% during the eleventh and twelfth grades. It is interesting to note that a more recent report on age of first intercourse suggests a significant decline in the age of first intercourse over the last ten years. Currently 52.6% of girls between the ages of fifteen to nineteen report never having had vaginal sex. For boys, 56.3% report never having intercourse (Park, Scott, Adams, Brindis & Irwin, 2014). Accompanying these age-related sexual activities are the increased frequencies of pregnancy and sexually transmitted

diseases—both of which profoundly affect the future trajectory of a young person's life.

In addition to biological changes related to sexuality, the brain undergoes important growth and change during adolescence that is crucial for the development of the reciprocating self. Specifically, the brain development typical during adolescence greatly facilitates more intentional reciprocity between an individual and others. We will say more shortly. The brain actually achieves its full adult physical size by about the age of ten. Consequently, the changes in the adolescent brain are better characterized as *reorganization* than *growth*. Specifically, the parts of the brain are present, but the connections between them begin to be forged. By the early twenties, the neural networks are more established, insulated through myelination, and more effective at communicating. The two regions that are most activated during adolescence are the prefrontal cortex and the limbic system. The former is mainly responsible for self-regulation, decision making, time management and so on. The latter is responsible for generating emotions through assessing opportunities and threats. In addition, the midline cortical structure and several regions of the brain referred to as the "social brain network" also continue to come online to facilitate self-understanding and interpersonal relationships.

Larry Steinberg (2014) nicely summarizes three phases of adolescent—what we would describe as brain—"redevelopment." He refers to phase one as "Starting the Engines." This is not surprising as we often think of teens as easily revved up or aroused. With the onset of puberty, the limbic system becomes more easily activated and thus adolescents feel more emotions. During this time youth are more sensitive (e.g., to the opinion of others), more emotional and more intentional about seeking intense experience (e.g., love, risk, excitement). Phase two he describes as "Developing a Better Brake System." Starting

in preadolescence and completing close to age sixteen, the prefrontal cortex becomes better organized through the processes of synaptic pruning and myelination. As information flows more efficiently across the brain, "executive functioning" strengthens and allows for decision making, planning, self-control and problem solving. Teens appear much more reasonable as these skills advance. That said, given the tentativeness of these neural pathways, their use can easily be disrupted by stress, fatigue or even emotional arousal. In these instances, that adolescent prefrontal cortex might appear to be more like what I (Pam) describe as the "prefrontal vortex," given the inconsistent behaviors and emotions that result. Phase three is "Putting a Skilled Driver Behind the Wheel." During this phase, which is not finished until the early twenties, the teenage brain is becoming more connected. The brakes are learning to coordinate with the fuel system. As the connections solidify between the prefrontal cortex and the limbic system, older adolescents become better at impulse control, judgment, emotional regulation, organization. In addition, their rational thought processes are less susceptible to stress and fatigue.

In addition to these executive functioning skills, further changes in the brain continue to facilitate the emergence of the reciprocating self. Building on what was begun at earlier stages, the midline cortical structure (MCS) or corpus collosum continues to activate, thereby increasing the maturing teen's ability for self-reflection, which facilitates identity development. This structure of the brain is also used for reflecting on other individuals' personality and perspective. In addition to the MCS, the "social brain network," which involves medial prefrontal cortex (mPFC), temporoparietal junction (TPJ), posterior superior temporal sulcus (pSTS) and anterior temporal cortex (ATC) (see Burnett, Sebastian, Cohen, Kadosh & Blakemore, 2011 for review and Mills, Lalonde, Clasen, Giedd &

Blakemore, 2014), also undergoes changes that facilitate social-emotional cognitive skills that allow for greater interpersonal understanding and intimacy. There is a growing body of research that suggests that the structures within this network are accessed and utilized differently depending on one's age. Such mentalizing is foundational for the emergence of an intentionally reciprocating self as it allows for increased understanding of self and other.

Although these are general trends of maturation of the adolescent brain, we emphatically state that the development of the brain is based on experience. Brain development occurs in bidirectional relationships between a young person and their environment. Experience greatly shapes the brain. Different activities (e.g., computer games, arts, meditation) activate different pathways in the brain. Adolescents, more than children, are producers of their development, and this statement is true to brain development. Consequently, the activities a young person intentionally or unintentionally experiences or engages in affect the neural connections that get strengthened or whither. These neural connections shape the specialization of brains, and in turn influence the potential experiences available to young people. The relations among neurological, psychological and behavioral change are thus reciprocal.

Cognitive Development

The most significant cognitive changes that take place during the period of adolescence involve the increasing ability for young people to think abstractly. Abstract thinking includes being able to think hypothetically as well as consider the real and actual, to process information in a sophisticated and complex manner, to consider multiple dimensions of a problem at once, to take other people's perspective, and to reflect upon oneself. Such abstract thinking is the

cornerstone of Piaget's formal operational thought, assumed to begin during adolescence. Although cognitive processes do not emerge in qualitatively different global stages as Piaget described, most researchers are convinced that these kinds of thought processes are more characteristic of adolescent cognition than the cognition of younger children. Current research suggests that the development of these cognitive skills emerges gradually over the entire adolescent period and depends on individual factors and opportunities and experiences to use and practice them (see Liben & Mueller, 2015). This ability to think about one's thinking is often referred to as metacognition or executive control.

Cognitive skills greatly affect the way young people interact with the world. They affect a young person's capacity to learn, which can have important ramifications for their academic success. Information-processing skills (topic-specific thinking and problem solving), cognitive learning strategies (conscious strategies used to learn new information) and metacognitive skills (the conscious monitoring of one's own learning and problem-solving activities) also change over the period between the onset of puberty and adulthood. These skills also require intentional practice for their development.

In addition to learning, cognitive abilities also affect a young person's self-concept and understanding of others. The adolescent years are critical to the formation of a self-concept, which refers to a consistent definition or understanding of self. An understanding of self includes physical and psychological self-descriptions, stable social-personality characterizations of self, and the tendency toward conceptual integration of diverse aspects of self into a unified self-system (Damon, 1983). Abstract thinking, especially self-reflection, is necessary to attain a self-concept. A young person must have the ability to reflect on him- or herself and discriminate what makes them unique from others. Defining their relationships and roles with their

family, friends, community and society is an important part of this process. The ability to assess the future and consider what possibilities are available to them is an important aspect of coming to a deeper understanding of themselves in the social and cultural settings in which they live.

The higher-order cognitive processes discussed above allow for young people to increase their perspective-taking skills. They have the increased capacity to consider what other individuals may be thinking or feeling. They become more interested in understanding others' psychological characteristics. Friendships begin to be based more on perceived similarity in these characteristics. Although friendships are more often based on similarity, adolescents can benefit from a curiosity to understand perspectives of different types of people. For instance, a young person's ability to consider the perspectives of individuals from other ethnicities or cultures is an important facet of developing an openness to diversity or a sense of multiculturalism.

Social-Contextual Changes

During adolescence many changes occur in the young person's social context. These primarily include changes in friendships and peer groups, transition in parental relations, and school transitions.

When we think of adolescents, we think of the significance of peers—peer groups, peer pressure and so forth. During this period young people become much more peer focused. This is evident in the increase of peer-related social, sports, religious or other extracurricular activities and in the increase in the importance of romance and sexuality in peer relationships. Having previously addressed the romantic and sexual aspect of adolescent peer relationships, here we focus

on the emerging prevalence and influence of peer relations during adolescence.

Most adolescents attach great importance to the activities they do with their friends. To the chagrin of their parents and teachers, activities with peers, peer acceptance and appearance often take precedence over school activities (Wigfield, Eccles, Mac Iver, Reuman & Midgley, 1991). Because social acceptance is so important during adolescence, friendship networks during adolescence are often organized into relatively rigid cliques that have a different social status within school and community settings (see Brown & Larson, 2009). The ramped use of social media heightens this effect, allowing youth to reify and entrench their social networks. The existence of and commitment to these cliques probably reflects a young person's need to differentiate from family and to establish their own sense of identity and place in this world. Belonging to a group is a way to define oneself and also gain a means of affirmation.

Ironically, in the attempt to establish their own identity and to exert their individuality, adolescents often join with a peer group to such an extent that they act, talk and dress exactly like their group. Generally, joining in conformity does not typify differentiation. However, this process might be understood as a way of practicing individuality that can lead to individuation. It is as if youth are practicing being their own person free from their families. They exert their individuality to the extent that they can try out a new identity or expressions of self apart from their family, yet they are not capable of doing so completely on their own. Perhaps as a result they find a group of "individuals" with which they can practice. Although the youth might be distinguishing themselves from their families, they typically do so in an identical manner. In short, perhaps the community or unity of the group enables them to practice being unique within their families.

At the risk of dating myself, I (Pam) recall that when I entered a new school during sixth grade, I quickly figured out that to fit in and belong (which of course I desperately wanted to) I had to quickly acquire some brightly colored Gloria Vanderbilt or Calvin Klein jeans. From my eleven-year-old perspective, a girl who did not have purple, green, royal blue or some other such color pants (complete with comb in the pocket) was not part of the group. I recall repeatedly begging my mother to get me a pair of such pants. Despite her most rational and reasonable discussion with me regarding the ridiculous cost, issues of stewardship and the reality of peer pressure, I could not be persuaded. Finally she acquiesced to taking me shopping at Carson Pirie Scott. I will never forget the trip. She bought me one pair of pea-green Gloria Vanderbilt jeans. I thought I had arrived! I could hardly wait to wear my new pants to school the next day. What might appear to be a bothersome or frivolous trip to the department store was potentially a developmentally rich experience. In that trip to Carson Pirie Scott I was simultaneously differentiating from my family and asserting my own taste (or lack thereof!) from my mother, but at the same time I was bonding through conforming to my new peer group. Please note, to my mother's credit, she graciously bought one pair of these crazy pants, and left any future purchases up to my own babysitting monies.

Conformity to peers raises susceptibility to negative peer pressure as well (Brown, 1990; Ruben, Bukowski & Parker, 1998). Although much has been written about the prevalence of peer pressure and its negative affects on youth, most researchers do not accept the simplistic view that peer groups are primarily bad influences during adolescence (Eccles & Gootman, 2002). In fact, adolescents more frequently agree with their parents' views than their friends' views on major issues such as religion, politics, importance of education and morality (Ruben et al., 1998; Smetana, 1995; Smetana, Yau & Hanson, 1991). However, peers

have more influence on such things as clothing style, music and activity choice. In fact, youth tend to spend time with peers who hold views similar to those of their parents on the major issues above.

Family relations. As adolescents begin to gravitate toward their peers, they become less attentive to their families. An adolescent can be understood as a sort of satellite that is changing from orbiting around the family planet (desatellization) to the peer planet (resatellization) (Balswick & Balswick, 2014). The time, activities and emotions of school-aged children revolve around the family. During adolescence, however, this changes. Relational energy and time begin to revolve around their friendships. This transition is very natural and normal. In fact, the extent of actual disruption in parent-adolescent relationships is not as great as we might expect (Collins, 1990; Paikoff & Brooks-Gunn, 1991). As young people grow up they seek more independence and autonomy. They may begin to question not only family rules and roles but also religious and social norms. Such questioning often leads to parental conflict—especially around issues of appearance, dating and chores. Despite conflicts over these smaller issues, parents and their adolescent children agree more than they disagree regarding core values related to education, religion and politics.

Research demonstrates that parents play a very important role in the lives of their adolescent children. Although adolescent children may act out, adopt an “attitude” or appear disgruntled with family life at times, teenaged children need their parents. Having a strong sense of shared values, beliefs and goals with parents is strongly related to moral outcomes among youth (King & Furrow, 2004). Youth who are more altruistic and empathetic toward others report having higher levels of these shared values and trust with their parents. Youth who receive more parental monitoring, meaning their parents exert clear boundaries and expectation

for their children as well as are aware of their coming and going, report less delinquent behaviors and higher academic success (Jacobson & Crockett, 2000). Research also demonstrates the significance of parental influence on many areas of life such as religiousness (King & Boyatzis, 2015).

Not only do adolescent children need their parents' attention, affection and supervision, but they desire it. In my (Pam's) own research I have been continually surprised to hear young people talk about how important it is that their parents set curfews, be available for them to talk and give them guidance in their academic, social and religious lives. For example, I recall two rather promiscuously dressed sixteen-year-old girls who participated in a focus group. One explained, "You see, we're just teenagers, and we need our parents to tell us what to do! We need curfews. We need to know when to come home." The other added, "Yeah, like, sometimes we actually want to come home, and if our parents don't tell us we have to, then we won't have an excuse to go home, or not to go to certain parties." In amazement at what I was hearing, I responded, "Did I hear you right? You want curfews and to be told what to do?" One responded, "Yeah, we're only teenagers. We don't always know what to do. And if our parents tell us what to do and pay attention to us, we know that they love us. We need that. We might not always act like it, but that's what we want." The rest of the group nodded and smiled in agreement. These girls clearly articulated a message that I have heard time and again. Adolescents do not always act like they want boundaries and structure, and they might kick and scream about it on occasion, but they strongly desire that their parents not only pay attention to but be active in the choices that they are making.

The way children differentiate themselves within their families varies by culture. More typical of middle-class families in America is a decline in the amount of time spent interacting within and outside the home. Scholars understand

this distancing in relations between adolescent and parents as a natural part of the developmental process. This distance plays an important function for youth, allowing them to do more things on their own, to experiment and to discover their own competencies. In American culture this fosters the highly valued process of individuation from parents. This is not the case in all cultures. For example in most non-Western cultures and in both Hispanic and Asian communities in the United States, this distancing occurs less frequently, and when it does occur, to a lesser extent (Larson & Verma, 1999; Mortimer & Larson, 2002). In other cultures, youth take on more responsibility not by differentiating from the family and making more decisions about their own lives, but rather by taking on greater responsibility for their family and increased participation in family decision making and family support.

The role of adults. As youth progressively differentiate from their families, they seek the support of and guidance from adults outside the family. Adult support can take place through formal mentoring programs or in natural relationships in school, neighborhood or a congregation. These relationships are most effective in promoting positive outcomes in youth when they are characterized by trust, positive social interaction, communication and having a sense of shared values (King & Furrow, 2004). Similar to parents, mentoring adults not only need to provide affection and encouragement but also are most effective when they provide guidance, empowerment and accountability. A study of individuals who demonstrate an extraordinary commitment to caring for those in their communities reports that they had adults in their life who came alongside them and affirmed their gifts and vision, encouraged them in their service to others, and helped them clarify their beliefs (Colby & Damon, 1995).

At a "Youth Sunday" in a church in the Los Angeles area, one senior in high school pleaded with the adults to engage

the youth in the congregation. His message implored the congregation to come together and be like a family. He beckoned the adults to talk to the youth—even if they seem intimidating and listen to loud music. His message was clear that the youth longed for adults to engage them. Another senior girl articulated the potential impact adults could make on youth. She communicated to the adults that youth need to know that they matter. She talked about how potentially influential the adults in their congregation could be on the youth. She thought that if the adult members of the church trusted and believed in the youth and treated them more as people with potential than as "weirdos" who dress strangely and listen to strange music, then they would be empowered to do something for their society through God. She wanted to hear that she mattered to the adults. These youth clearly articulated to the adults in their congregation that they both long for and need adult support. They need their genuine interest, encouragement and guidance so that they can become contributing members of our society. I believe that underneath their pleas is their desire to be known. Adolescence is an intense period of growth—one in which young people need the presence of others.

Technology and social media. Given that technology is greatly altering the presence of others in the life of teens, we felt compelled to include it as an important context of adolescent development in this new edition. Today's youth have access and utilize technology at the highest rates ever seen in history. The PW Internet and American Life Project found that 93% of youth use the Internet, and more teens than ever use sites such as Facebook, Twitter and YouTube to interact with friends and construct virtual identities (Spencer, Swanson & Edwards, 2010). Of the teens that are online, 55% report having created online social network profiles. From a psychological perspective social networking can be seen as both a developmental resource and a risk. From a constructive perspective, social media can be used to

promote individual and artistic expression that when pursued authentically can be a helpful resource for identity development. In addition, youth can experiment with social expression and interaction online with less risk than in-person interactions. In addition, technology can be used to explore new relationships and enhance existing relationships.

Of the 55% of adolescent users, 70% of girls and 57% of boys report that they have created an online profile. The most popular uses of social network platforms include making plans and developing romantic relationships. Particularly for girls, social network platforms are used to form alliances, discuss problems and plan for events. Adolescents express that online communication is not as satisfying as in-person communication, but online networks can help them develop new peer networks that would have been very difficult to navigate otherwise (Boneva, Quinn, Kraut, Kiesler & Shklovski, 2006).

However, online social interactions are not always helpful. As much as youth find opportunities to build their relationships online, others find themselves shut out and ostracized via social media. If an adolescent has an opposing view from his or her network of friends then he or she may be shut out of conversations or demeaned by peers. Research conducted by Daniels (2008) found that many forms of hostility and racial stereotypes found in daily life could also be found online. In addition, social standings and negotiation into cliques can all be established via social network. In addition, relationships with strangers, especially adults, can be dangerous. Romantic relationships with strangers are a reasonable concern. There is evidence to suggest that adolescents increasingly use online platforms to connect with strangers for casual sex (Wolak, Mitchell & Finkelhor, 2006). Troubled teens that have significant conflict with their parents and no other significant relationships are more likely to partake in these relationships (Beebe, Asche, Harrison & Quinlan, 2004).

Although the jury is still out on the benefits and banes of teen technology use, from the perspective of the reciprocating self, we acknowledge that technology can be a positive resource when it promotes the development of the individual, allowing for appropriate exploration and expression, and when technology facilitates mutual, interdependent relationships. However, when technology use hinders individual development, whether through its impact on neurological development or social skills, or promotes antisocial behaviors and attitudes, we acknowledge the potential harm of technology on adolescent development. Furthermore, when technology replaces rather than enhances person-to-person contact, we caution against overuse. Current research on optimal relational capacity, quantity of technology use, the types of activities, extent of self-disclosure and the amount of parental monitoring will all be helpful to understand for whom and under what circumstances technology use may be helpful or hinder adolescent development.

Socioeconomics. More than 20% of America's forty-two million youth are living below the federal poverty line. Considering that there are a similar number of youth who are effectively poor, meaning they live at less than twice the federal poverty line, there are nearly twenty million "poor" youth in the United States. This is almost half (45%) of all youth in America. Consequently, socioeconomics is undeniably a relevant and crucial context of development.

Evidence suggests that being poor makes it more difficult to thrive. There are a number of socioeconomic issues affecting adolescent development. Youth in poor neighborhoods are exposed more often to violence, pollution, poor housing and conversely have less access to helpful institutions, effective schools and adults (Hart & Matsuba, 2009). Census data show that poor neighborhoods have more youth than wealthier neighborhoods, thereby decreasing the odds of positive mentors and adult examples. In addition, poorer

neighborhoods have few organizations and institutions that serve youth, again therefore decreasing the odds of positive resources for young people.

Evidence suggests that exposure to such chronic stress compromises physical health (Shishehbor, Litaker, Pothier & Lauer 2006) and personality development and can be detrimental to the development of moral attitudes and values (Hart & Matsuba, 2009). These outcomes are not only due to chronic exposure to environmental stressors, but also result because of lower levels of support due to lack of adult and institutional resources. This is not to say that middle- and upper-class youth do not have valid problems or stress, but youth in poor neighborhoods are chronically exposed to more environmental stress and have fewer social protective factors readily available. This is also not to say that youth in poor neighborhoods do not have developmental assets they can draw on. This is certainly not the case. Research shows that youth who have deep sources of inner strength through faith or a sense of purpose and resourceful youth who are keen at activating resources around them are especially effective at being resilient in adverse environments (Masten, 2014).

It is often said that during adolescence "the highs are higher and the lows are lower." Given the profound resources (e.g., technology, travel, education) and challenges (e.g., poverty, available substances) at hand today, we might also add, "The opportunities are more opportune, and the challenges are more challenging." Youth today are faced with immense access, which can offer both resource and risk. Ironically, the amount of scaffolding a young person experiences is extremely varied—some grow up in more monitored or "overly programmed" environments and some grow up in very permissive and "unregulated" environments. The amount of guidance and support youth experience greatly impacts their development as the reciprocating self has the potential for seminal growth.

The Reciprocating Self During Adolescence

How do various aspects of adolescent development relate to the emergence of the reciprocating self? In this section we will first consider how these issues factor in to the development of a unique, differentiated self. Then we will examine how they enable this self to participate in mutual relationships with others.

Emerging particularity. It is hard to talk about the particularity of adolescents with a straight face. Let's face it; adolescents can be extremely particular! Much of adolescence is about a child becoming his or her own unique person. Independence, autonomy, differentiation and individuation are all crucial aspects of adolescent development. Adolescence is when young people begin to get a stronger and clearer sense of their unique self. For the first time they begin to differentiate themselves from their families and begin to develop a firmer self-construct and identity. In doing so they explore different types of activities, behaviors and self-presentation.

Identity. The formation and consolidation of a sense of self, or identity, is central to the emergence of a reciprocating self. As youth struggle toward identity cohesion, they actively search for a sense of self. They embark on this psychological endeavor in order to consolidate and understand their experience of self as well as to identify the self in terms of familial, vocational and societal roles (Erikson, 1950). Personal goals, values, worldviews and a sense of meaning and purpose are integrated into an individual's understanding of self. This quest is marked by yearnings and behaviors that simultaneously bond youth to or locate them within something bigger than themselves and affirm their sense of uniqueness and independence.

Erikson (1968) explained that identity development is based on a psychosocial crisis in which adolescents have the

opportunity to explore different identities. This period of exploration is referred to as *moratorium* and is natural to this stage of life. Successful adaptation to this crisis of identity is accomplished by making an enduring commitment to an identity and the roles associated with it. The virtue of *fidelity* results from the commitment to an identity. For Erikson, fidelity is an unflagging commitment to an ideology that transcends the self and brings about genuineness, sincerity and a sense of duty to others. Fidelity might sound like an "old-fashioned" word that one does not find frequently in the scholarly literature or the popular press. However, it is foundational to the development of the reciprocating self. Fidelity requires clarity and commitment and results in the capacity to contribute beyond the self and allows one to be on the pathway to a thriving future. In this sense, identity development is crucial to the reciprocating self because it provides an individual a sense of self and commitment to others.

Differentiation. A major developmental task that takes place during adolescence is differentiation. Through differentiation young people wrestle with their identity; personal beliefs, values and goals; and boundaries with families, peers and romantic partners. During this process, young people may experiment with different identities, and they may explore different belief systems and try out different worldviews. They begin to formulate their own short- and long-term goals for their life. One way young people discover and set boundaries between them and the closest people in their lives is through risktaking.

Risktaking and rebellion are characteristic of the period of adolescence. Such behavior is often viewed as troublesome or dangerous and something that must be thwarted. However, appropriate risk taking can play an important role as young people attempt to differentiate themselves from their families, explore boundaries with society and bond to their peer groups. The tenuous brain development occurring during

adolescence may also be responsible for rebellious and dangerous activities. Adolescent risk taking can range from harmless (e.g., TPing a friend's house or piercing a belly button) to extremely harmful (e.g., drunk driving or substance abuse). That being said, risk taking always involves some risk or potential threat or danger—whether social, emotional or physical. It is important to keep in mind that risk is socially constructed and subject to cultural norms and personal experience. What might be considered a risk for one teen is not a risk for another.

Taking risks allows for young people to assert their own autonomy, explore social boundaries and experience commonality. It is important for adolescents to have safe and constructive outlets for this necessary action. Youth programs can provide a service to youth and parents by offering appropriate forms of risk-taking behaviors. For example, youth groups often participate in wilderness experiences where young people have the opportunity to jump blindfolded off a forty-foot pole or to rappel down one-hundred-foot cliffs. These activities, when properly supervised, can provide safe but risky-enough adrenalin rushes that allow youth to explore identity, push boundaries and eventually differentiate.

As individuals wrestle with issues of identity, meaning, beliefs, goals and their own behavior, they gain a clearer sense of self in relationship with those around them. In "Buberian" terms, they gain a clearer understanding of where the *I* stops and the *Thou* begins. Such an understanding of self is necessary for mutually reciprocating relationships. There can be no give and take if one does not know what one has to give.

Emerging relationality. Although individuation is a strong theme in adolescence, relationships are as well. Identity and differentiation provide a crucial component to adolescents' capacity for relationships. The sense of self that emerges enables the young person to begin entering into

relationships with peers, parents and other adults as authentic, unique individuals. Although it is tempting to say that identity formation and differentiation are foundational to intimacy, this is not necessarily the case. Even Erikson (1968), who claims that the identity crisis occurs developmentally before intimacy, recognized that this developmental process does not occur in an absolute linear fashion. Erikson contended that during all stages in life, individuals are working on all eight crises. Although he argued that during adolescence identity development is the most pressing issue and that resolving it to a significant extent is necessary in order for a person to move on to successfully resolve the crisis of intimacy versus isolation, he recognized that relationships greatly influence a sense of identity. Even more so than Erikson, scholars today generally agree that identity and intimacy evolve together.

Interpersonal relationships. To an adolescent, relationships are not just something, they are *everything.* Adolescence is strongly characterized by its social susceptibility (Feldman & Elliott, 1990). Intense bonding occurs between adolescents and their peers, intimacy grows in both same-sex friendships as well as in romantic relationships, and parents continue to play a crucial role of providing support and guidance. Not only does reciprocity/relationality manifest itself during adolescence in an interpersonal manner, but adolescents demonstrate their reciprocity in a give-and-take with the greater good. Central to adolescent development is moral, spiritual and civic development.

Moral, spiritual and civic development. Adolescence is marked by a time of biological growth that facilitates the development of cognitive abilities resulting in an individual who has new sensitivities, perspectives and reasoning abilities. These new or expanded capacities allow for the adolescent to engage with his or her world in a new way. For example, enhanced perspective taking facilitates the increase

of empathy, a moral emotion associated with moral action and behavior. Increased activation of the "social brain network" or perhaps even the parietal lobe on the right side of the brain allows one to focus less on oneself and may begin to allow for further self-transcendence (see Johnstone, Bodling, Cohen, Christ & Wegrzyn, 2012). Such brain activity may underlie the experience of transcendence of self that is necessary for such investment in the "beyond-the-self" social world. In addition, increasingly abstract thinking promotes the ability to consolidate and commit to a sense of identity, allowing for the sense of moral, civic and spiritual identities to develop. As discussed above, relationships are extremely important to adolescents. In general, they are very outwardly attuned—they are very aware of others. This sense of connection is not limited to peers and parents but involves less proximal others—such as their community, their ethnic group or even God.

These new abilities promote experiences of transcendence in adolescents. They become more aware of others and society. As adolescents grow in a sense of fidelity, they gain a sense of purpose in life, a sense of belonging and commitment to others and society as a whole (Furrow, King & White, 2004; King, Clardy & Ramos, 2014; Lerner, Roeser & Phelps, 2008). Lerner (2004) argues that adolescence is characterized by a transcendent or spiritual sensibility that propels young people to contribute to the common good.

Research demonstrates that youth have an immense capacity to care for families, friends and members of their community; they are engaged in volunteer activities and make commitments to religious communities and to God (see, e.g., the works of Daniel Hart, Kevin Reimer, James Youniss and Christian Smith). Such research reveals that adolescents are not in fact the selfish creatures that the media and traditional stereotypes convey. Adolescence, rather, is often marked by exuberant transcendence, where young people take considerable efforts to contribute to their friends, families, communities

and societies. (For further discussion on moral and spiritual development see chaps. twelve and thirteen.)

Although at first glance adolescents appear to be self-absorbed, awkward and rebellious, we see through the lens of the reciprocating self that this developmental period is characterized by rapid development of both a unique and authentic self as well as the ability to participate more fully in mutually reciprocating relations. Models of development that do not capture the depth and complexity of this stage do a disservice to our understanding of adolescence. One emerging approach that helps capture positive adolescent development more fully is the concept of *thriving*.

Thriving. A thriving young person is a youth who makes the most of his or her own potential and circumstances, has a meaningful and satisfying life, actively contributes to the common good, and is on the pathway to a hopeful future (Damon, 2004; King & Clardy, 2014; Lerner, 2004; Scales et al., 2000; Theokas et al., 2005). Such youth make the most of themselves and their circumstances. They not only have a sense of meaning and personal fulfillment, but they demonstrate a commitment to the community or society in which they live. In short, they are not only doing well personally or growing as an *I*, but they are giving back to others. Such youth, despite setbacks or negative experiences, are on a positive developmental trajectory.

Thriving young people have an appropriate sense of self. They have a clear sense of their identity, sufficiently knowing who they are and what they stand for. They have a sense of purpose and meaning that motivates and directs their actions. In addition, their personality is marked by a sense of positivity that comprises both a sense of optimism and joy. The sense of purpose and positivity contributes to tenacity that enables them to overcome obstacles and make meaning out of suffering. Also central to thriving is a future orientation, which involves having expectations for

oneself. Such thriving young people are adaptable and resourceful. They have the ability to access their personal assets and mobilize external resources available to them through family, community, school and neighborhood. In addition they can adapt to changing situations and can modify their expectations and dreams for self.

An important component of thriving is realizing one's potential. From the perspective of thriving, all youth can be successful. However, success looks different based on their unique gifts and circumstances. Thriving youth make the most of who they are and what they have access to. For example, a young boy who is physically disabled would not thrive in the same manner as a young girl with great physical strength and dexterity. In addition, having different resources available also affects how one might thrive.

The positive youth development (PYD) movement is often recognized for highlighting the concept of thriving. In addition to the potential of young people, understanding the role of context is also central to PYD. Our perspective of the reciprocating self recognizes that development occurs as a person interacts with his or her multiple systems as we described in regard to relational developmental systems theories (see chap. four). Lerner, one of the major minds behind RDS and PYD, explains that positive development occurs when these interactions between a person and their context are mutually beneficial, maintaining healthy and positive functioning of the young person and the systems in which he or she lives (see Lerner et al., 2015). Developmental contexts (e.g., locations, relationships, community and structures) offer youth a place to engage new roles and values through a safe environment. At their best, these contexts provide supports (e.g., relationships, opportunities and resources) so that youth may have the tools and abilities necessary for adult life.

One helpful way to conceptualize the potential resources to promote thriving available to diverse youth are the Search

Institute's 40 Developmental Assets. The "40 Assets" provide a framework to identify and assess individual and contextual resources that serve as building blocks for positive youth development. They emphasize that all youth need their families, schools and communities to offer various forms and experiences of (1) support, (2) empowerment, (3) boundaries and expectations, and (4) constructive uses of time. They also stress the importance of young people having personal or internal assets such as (1) a commitment to learning, (2) positive values, (3) various social competencies and (4) a sense of positive identity (see www.search-institute.org/assets).

Lerner and colleagues' (2005) research with the 4-H organization (see www.ca4h.org) has yielded a practical and popular approach to conceptualizing positive youth development that is often cited in the literature and has been used in many communities and youth programs. The "6 C's" (or sometimes referred to as the "5 C's") of positive youth development deliberately seek to broaden the conceptualization of successful development beyond skills and competencies and include Competence, Confidence, Connection, Character and Caring. Lerner and colleagues' (2015) research has demonstrated that the first "5 C's" predict the sixth C, Contribution. The extensive studies on the 4-H programs have shown that young people who report higher levels of personal competencies, self-confidence, relationships with others, strong character and a sense of compassion tend to report higher levels of contributions to others beyond themselves. From Lerner and colleagues' (2015) perspective, these youth are said to be thriving because of their capacity to demonstrate positive individual outcomes, as well as to contribute to the greater good of their surrounding communities. This moral emphasis underscores the previously quoted PYD mantra, "Problem free is not fully prepared" (Pittman, 1991), and casts a vision for young people who are active agents in their communities. It is important to note

that contribution takes on different forms for diverse youth with various abilities, passions and resources and is always contextually and developmentally appropriate.

Finally, central to an understanding of thriving is making a contribution to the common good. From the perspective of thriving, optimal development is not about individual success, achievement or subjective well-being. Thriving can include those things but also involves a commitment to giving back to society in some manner (Benson, Scales, Hamilton & Sesma, 2006; Bundick, Yeager, King & Damon, 2010). Lerner, Dowling and Anderson (2003) describe idealized personhood as a developmental teleology in which individuals experience reciprocity with their family, their community and larger society. As such, Lerner (2004) understands thriving young people to be on a developmental trajectory that will enable them to be in ever-increasing reciprocating relationships. We would add that a thriving young person is in a reciprocating relationship with God as well. The moral, civic and spiritual development that occurs during adolescence enables youth to reciprocate in these different domains.

Reciprocity on the Way

Although adolescence is a formative time for the reciprocating self, it is important to recognize that both thriving and the capacity to reciprocate are a process. Paul reminds the Christians in Philippi "that the one who began a good work among you will bring it to completion by the day of Jesus Christ" (Phil 1:6). We are all works in progress, and adolescents are no exception, only more obviously so. Although young people at this stage make tremendous growth in their capacities as reciprocating selves, they are not complete. From our teleological perspective, in the end—when Christ comes again—we will become complete reciprocating selves, fully able to participate with the new humanity in

Christ. We will not only experience unity and communion with one another but also be drawn into the dynamic life of the triune God, and participate in the reciprocating glorification of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

We need to remember that adolescents are not yet there. At times they come across as competent and confident, and at other times immature and hopeless. We must remember that they are on their way. During this period, the *I* grows in leaps and bounds in the context of the *Thou*. Identity takes shape in the processes of differentiation, experimentation and relationship building. At this stage relationships grow in intensity, yet they can quickly fall apart. Adolescents try new things. At times they are brilliantly successful and shine; at others, they stumble and fail miserably. This is all part of the growth process. With all the rapid growth there is as much potential to go right as there is to go wrong. Although youth are undoubtedly resilient, the self is in process—under construction, so to speak. Just like any structure under construction, the adolescent self needs scaffolding support. The adolescent self needs a certain amount of structure around it, providing guidance and stability as it firms its sense of beliefs, values and identity. Although the adolescents need a certain amount of structure and support, the developmental scaffold is different from that of a young child. The scaffold must continue to provide guidance, values, beliefs, boundaries and expectations. However, the scaffold at this stage needs to begin to come down, enabling the adolescent freedom to explore and experiment in order to differentiate and develop their own sense of self. If the scaffold remains rigid and high, the young person will not have the opportunity to explore and achieve identity commitment. He or she will not have the necessary space to differentiate—or for "full unfolding," to use Jürgen Moltmann's (1996) words. They can grow overly dependent on others to dictate their belief,

values, self-concept, preferences and foreclose on their identity.

Adolescence has long been viewed as a difficult stage in life. No doubt the highs are higher and lows lower, but too often adolescents are wrongly viewed as delinquents, dangerous, awkward or problems waiting to happen. A quote from a 1950s newspaper makes this point. In an interview with a junior in high school, a journalist concludes, “All too frequently these days, teenagers are portrayed as gawky, not-quite-adults who sit around drug stores, race around in hot-rods, cause trouble or stand around in groups on street corners discussing boys, girls, clothes and cars” (Pettingell, 1959). Although the issues facing society in the twenty-first century are more dangerous, such menacing behavior does not characterize all adolescents. The reciprocating self provides a means for understanding the hard developmental work that adolescents go through as they attend to becoming more clearly defined selves. The outward-appearing independent behavior is part of the journey toward interdependence. Because this journey is not without its perils, young people need company on the way to assist and guide them as they explore the terrain of life. As the journalist points out, many adolescents contribute much along the way: “But many young people are serious-minded, well-informed, forward-looking citizens, participating in and donating to school and community activities” (Pettingell, 1959). With the right support and encouragement, young people will emerge as more fully capable reciprocating selves.

9

Emerging Adulthood and Young Adulthood

The Solidifying of the Reciprocating Self

MY FRIENDS AND I (PAM) WERE VERY excited to graduate from college. We were equipped with our Stanford degrees, had a sense of call from God to various forms of work and ministry and had one another for support. But many of us were not quite sure what to do, where to go. We felt like well-trained athletes after an intense season of training. We were crouched in the starting blocks, equipped with state-of-the-art cleats. But when we heard the starting gun and burst forth from the blocks, we realized the race could be run in many directions. For many in their early twenties this frustrating feeling of potential combined with lack of a directional clarity is common.

At the turn of the twenty-first century, psychologists began to recognize a new stage in the lifespan—*emerging adulthood*. Arnett (2000a) identified emerging adulthood as the stage of life falling between adolescence and adulthood. Emerging adults, generally classified as starting in the late teens and enduring through the mid- to late twenties (roughly eighteen to twenty-seven), do not experience themselves as adolescents, nor do they feel comfortable describing themselves as adults. For most young people in industrialized

cultures, this time period is marked by profound change and importance. It is often a time of intentional exploration of vocational and love interests. In industrialized countries young people often pursue education and training that will equip them for occupational success and achievement the rest of their adult lives. In addition, this is a time to explore relationships, sexuality, gender, ideology and faith.

Not all psychologists agree that emerging adulthood is a distinct stage of the lifespan. Rather, they describe this period of life as a transitional phase to independent adulthood that is economically sanctioned and dependent on delaying child rearing and wage earning rather than a distinct period of the lifespan (see Cote, 2014). The exploration and experimentation characteristic of emerging adults is more prominent in more developed nations and not as evident in developing nations. This "emerging adulthood" phenomenon is more common in cultures and communities where young people are able to postpone entering into adult roles until their mid-twenties or later. In less economically privileged contexts, where less training is required for vocations and marriage occurs earlier in the lifespan, adolescents seem to transition right into young adulthood with these adult commitments. Consequently, the developmental issues typical of emerging adulthood are more evident in developed countries such as the United States, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, South Korea, Japan and most of Europe (Arnett, 2011).

In the current chapter we discuss the distinction between emerging adulthood and young adulthood, particularly as they relate to the emergence of the reciprocating self. Although not all developmental psychologists accept the distinction between emerging and young adulthood (see Cote, 2014), we discriminate between the two because many of the demographic, behavioral and attitudinal differences are prevalent within the United States and are relevant to how we understand the development of the reciprocating self. At risk of

oversimplifying the distinction between emerging and young adulthood, emerging adulthood is characterized by *transition* and *variability*, whereas adulthood is characterized more by *commitment*. Of course, these are gross generalizations—there is always transition and variability during every stage of the lifespan, but emerging adulthood has less consistency demographically and developmentally than any other stage. Adulthood, on the other hand, has more consistent demographic trends and less radical developmental change.

Emerging Adulthood

Many of the developmental issues that become prevalent during adolescence continue to intensify through emerging adulthood. In particular, brain development, identity exploration and expanding social worlds are especially salient. As such, emerging adulthood is characterized as

- the age of identity exploration,
- the age of instability,
- the self-focused age,
- the age of feeling in-between, and
- the age of possibilities (Arnett, 2004, 2000a; Reifman et al., 2006).

Throughout the chapter we will discuss these various features.

The theoretical roots of emerging adulthood. Although emerging adulthood is recognized as a "new" period of life, psychologists—without identifying it as a distinct lifespan stage—have alluded to the uniqueness of this period from the late teens to early twenties. For example, in his writing about the period of young adulthood, Erikson (1950, 1968) discussed a phenomenon he called "prolonged adolescence."

He commented that industrialized societies provided a psychological moratorium for young people, during which the young adult was free to experiment with different roles without undue pressure to commit until a particular niche was discovered. Arnett comments that, without naming it, Erikson seems to distinguish a stage that has qualities of both adolescence and young adulthood yet is neither one. "It is a period in which adult commitments and responsibilities are delayed while the role experimentation that began in adolescence continues and in fact intensifies" (Arnett, 2000a, p. 470).

Arnett also points to the work of Daniel Levinson (1978), who alludes to this period of emerging adulthood in his theory of adult development. He called ages seventeen to thirty-three "the novice phase" of development and suggested that the dominant task of this phase is to move into the adult world and build what he called a "stable life structure." Young people experience much change and instability as they explore various relational and vocational possibilities. And during this period, they move toward establishing ongoing love and work commitments that become part of their life structure. Levinson acknowledged the theoretical similarities between his conception of the "novice phase" and Erikson's formulation about role experimentation and psychological moratorium. (For further discussion of Levinson, see chap. eleven.)

Emerging adulthood: The demographics. Demographic changes in the time of marriage, parenthood and vocational commitments in the past several decades have established the period of emerging adulthood as typical for young people in industrialized cultures. Postponing these traditional commitments until the late twenties or often during the thirties allows the late teens and early twenties to be available for exploring possible life directions.

Among people in this age group the common demographic theme is variability. Emerging adulthood is characterized by

so much change that nothing is normative demographically. This is in sharp contrast to adolescence and young adulthood. During adolescence there is little diversity in many demographic areas. Over 96% of American youth younger than eighteen live at home with at least one parent (US Bureau of the Census, 2011). At the end of the first decade of the new millennium, over 89.2% attend school, while 98.3% are unmarried and less than 4% have a child of their own (US Bureau of the Census, 2011; Centers for Disease Control, 2011). Similarly, young adulthood is characterized by strong demographic norms. By age thirty-five, almost 90% of women and about 86% of men in the United States will have been married at least once (US Bureau of the Census, 2011). In the United States, the median age of marriage is at a record high (almost age twenty-seven for women and twenty-eight and a half for men) and has continued to steeply rise over the past forty years (Arnett, 2011). The mean age for first births for women was estimated at 25.6 in 2011 (Central Intelligence Agency, 2015).

In between these two periods a person's demographic status is not predictable. Arnett (2000a) explains that the demographic unpredictability and diversity of emerging adults aged eighteen to twenty-five is a reflection of the experimental and exploratory quality of the period. Emerging adulthood, more than any other stage in life, affords the individual a wide array of opportunities. Some choose to continue education, some travel and explore, some pursue serious jobs, some live at home, some cohabitate, some marry and some do not. Young people at this stage are not constrained by social norms and role requirements, making their demographic status of residence, employment and marriage unpredictable.

Here are some statistics to help paint the picture of how varied American emerging-adult experience is. Rates of residential change in American society are much higher at ages eighteen to twenty-nine than at any other period of life

(US Bureau of the Census, 2003). Roughly one-third of emerging adults go to college and live away from home after high school, but most do not marry and have their first child until at least their late twenties (Arnett, 2000a). This time away at college is "semiautonomous," where college students live in a combination of independent living and continued reliance on parents. Most college students take on new forms of responsibility for independent living (e.g., their laundry, hopefully) but in many cases parents remain responsible for others. Roughly half of the current generation of American and Canadian emerging adults will move back into their family home and then out again at least once during this period of life (Mitchell, 2007). From Americans aged eighteen to twenty-four, 4.6% live alone, 8.4% live with their spouse, 9.8% live with an unmarried partner, 22.2% live in another living situation, and 55.2% live as a child of the householder; however, of Americans aged twenty-five to thirty-four, 9.9% live alone, 44.3% live with their spouse, 14.2% live with an unmarried partner, 18.8% live in another living situation, and 12.8% live as a child of the householder (Vespa, Lewis & Kreider, 2013). There is a clear demographic shift after twenty-five: fewer young adults live with their parents and increasingly more begin to live with spouses or an unmarried partner.

School attendance also demonstrates a picture of variability. With higher rates than ever before, over 70% of recent high school graduates now enter some form of higher education (National Center for Education Statistics [NCES], 2012), which is up 10% from the 1990s (Bianchi & Spain, 1996). However, nearly half of students who enroll at a four-year college or university drop out before obtaining a degree (NCES, 2012). For emerging adults today, college completion is being pursued in a less linear fashion, where work and periods of nonattendance may break up times of full-time attendance. For those who do graduate from college, one-third enroll in graduate school the following year (Mogelonsky,

1996). This demographic diversity is reflective of the emphasis on change and exploration of the period of emerging adulthood. As young people make enduring commitments to love and work, these demographics begin to stabilize.

Subjective uniqueness of emerging adulthood. Demographics not only statistically illustrate differences among adolescents, emerging adults and young adults, but emerging adults report that they feel distinct from the two surrounding life stages. They do not see themselves as adolescents, nor do they feel entirely comfortable calling themselves adults. Arnett (2004) found that when asked if they have reached adulthood, the majority of Americans in their late teens and early twenties answer ambiguously: "In some respects yes, in some respects no." These "in-between" feelings in emerging adulthood are not just limited to the United States but have been found in many other countries, including China (Nelson et al., 2004), Argentina (Facio & Micocci, 2003), Israel (Mayseless & Scharf, 2003) and Austria (Sirsch et al., 2009). These findings suggest that, for the most part, emerging adults perceive themselves as having left adolescence, but not completely having entered young adulthood. It is not until the late twenties and early thirties that two-thirds of young people report feeling like they have completely transitioned into adulthood. That still leaves one-third not feeling like an adult by their early thirties.

Why would young persons in this age group feel this way? Perhaps it is related to the demographics previously discussed. Maybe this age group does not feel adult-like because they do not have a stable residence, or because they are still in school or because they have not married. Surprisingly enough, research suggests that for people in their late teens and early twenties these are not the top criteria for feeling like one has reached adulthood (see Arnett, 2000a, 2003). Such transitions as marriage, parent-hood, finishing school or settling into a career rank at the

bottom of importance of transitions that qualify a person as an adult. Since these demographic transitions seem to have little to do with emerging adults' understanding of what it means to become an adult, what does?

The characteristics that seem to matter most to emerging adults are not demographic transitions but rather personal qualities of character. Studies reveal that the two top qualities young people report making them feel "adult" are (1) accepting responsibility for one's self, and (2) making independent decisions. A third basis that ranks consistently near the top is becoming financially independent.

It is important to note that despite the fact that these three criteria are characterized by independence and are markedly more individualistic than collectivist, they are consistent across cultures, nations, ethnic groups and social classes. That said, research highlights additional unique criteria among more collectivist cultures that signify the transition to adulthood. For example, Israel requires mandatory military service. Consequently, completing military service is an important marker of becoming an adult in Israel (Mayseless & Scharf, 2003). In addition, emerging adults in India and China, societies that value familial and parental obligation, view being able to support their parents financially as necessary for reaching adulthood (Naito & Gielen, 2003; Nelson et al., 2004).

In non-Western, traditional cultures, marriage most clearly marks the transition to adulthood with adult privileges and responsibilities (Schlegel & Barry, 1991). This is in contrast to aforementioned studies that were conducted in the United States, Canada and other developed countries, where marriage consistently ranks near the bottom of possible criteria for adult status. In more collectivistic societies, criteria that emphasize an interdependent self such as through family or marital values may hold primacy over criteria that emphasize the independence and self-

reliance seen as generally more typical of emerging adulthood.

These criteria for making the transition into adulthood emphasize the significance of self-sufficiency, whether married or not, in emerging adulthood. During these years new levels of independence and opportunities for exploration and experimentation allow self-sufficiency to be developed. Accepting responsibility for one's self, making independent decisions and financial independence give the young person a sense of self-sufficiency. It is when young people have confidence in themselves that they transition out of emerging adulthood and into young adulthood. For most Americans this is accomplished by the late twenties.

Emerging Adulthood and the Reciprocating Self

Given our understanding of the reciprocating self, how does emerging adulthood function in the development of the individual who is able to be in mutual, reciprocating relationships—where they experience simultaneous intimacy and individuality—with others? The following section details the radical growth experienced by the self. Emerging adulthood is an active time! With all that is going on internally (e.g., biologically, cognitively and emotionally) and for the expanding social world externally, emerging adults are active in pursuing growth and exploration.

Current theories and research suggest that independent exploration and a growing self-sufficiency are characteristic of this stage. Opportunities to explore relationships and different vocational options allow a young person to know themselves better—define their interests, recognize their natural talents and abilities, experience their relational strengths and weaknesses. In many ways emerging adulthood functions much like adolescence in the emergence of self. However, given the increased or more consistent cognitive

functioning, levels of independence and options, the emerging adult has more opportunities for exploration. At this point in life parental scaffolding is almost completely removed. People in their late teens and early twenties are often responsible for their own curfews and whereabouts. Some of them are working and have discretionary income that allows them to pursue experiences of their choosing. Furthermore, they have acquired more skills and relationships that open doors for a larger variety of work and recreational experiences.

All that "stuff" we discussed in the chapter on adolescence regarding the brain and cognitive development only intensifies and solidifies in the twenties. Current science suggests that the brain does not grow in size during emerging adulthood, but that the connections among the existing parts of the brain solidify. In the twenties the neural networks, particularly between the prefrontal cortex and the limbic system, become more established, insulated through myelination and more effective in communicating. So although these pathways are established in adolescence, they do not always fire consistently, and thus much of adolescent and also emerging adulthood behavior is inconsistent and erratic. Generally speaking, further into the twenties, the brain circuitry functions more consistently; and, consequently, in the twenties we see more consistent impulse control, judgment, emotional regulation and organization. In addition, rational and self-reflective thought processes are less susceptible to stress and fatigue. This provides the brain a basis for further self-reflection and exploration of beliefs, values and morals that facilitate identity formation.

Consistent with the theme of exploration, experimentation and traditional "risk" behaviors peak during emerging adulthood, not adolescence. These risk behaviors include unprotected sex, most forms of substance use and driving while intoxicated or at high speeds (Bachman, Johnston &

O'Malley, 1996). Many substance-use problems actually seem to reach their peak in emerging adulthood (Stone, Becker, Huber & Catalano, 2012). However, individuals in the eighteen- to twenty-five-year-old range who *perceive* themselves as adults engage in fewer risk behaviors such as illegal drug use and drunk driving than the majority of other emerging adults engage in (Nelson & Barry, 2005).

Emerging adults from the ages of eighteen to twenty-four tend to have had at least one sexual partner in the past year (Regnerus & Uecker, 2011). However, the sexual behavior of emerging adults tends to be quite diverse; they are more likely than older adults to have had either more or fewer sexual partners, with one-third reporting two or more partners in the past year, but one-fourth reporting not having had sex at all in the past year. At the beginning of emerging adulthood at the age of eighteen, about half of Americans have had intercourse at least once and by the age of twenty-five nearly all have reported at least one instance of intercourse; however, those whose first experience of intercourse is later tend to do so by choice (choosing to wait for marriage for example, rather than because there was no opportunity for sex) (Patrick & Lee, 2010).

Although sexual behavior in emerging adulthood is most commonly seen in the context of a close romantic relationship, emerging adults are also more likely to engage in "hooking up" or recreational sex (Garcia, Reiber, Massey & Merriwether, 2012; Owen, Fincham & Moore, 2011; Lefkowitz & Gillen, 2006). One study reported that 30% of American college students reported at least one episode of hooking up that included intercourse, and 48% reported at least one episode of hooking up that did not include intercourse (Paul et al., 2000). The prevalence of popular online dating sites, some of which are even colloquially known as "hook-up apps" such as Tindr and Grindr, may also contribute to this trend. Rates of STIs are also higher in emerging adults in United

States and Europe than in any other life stage (Lehtinen et al., 2006).

Such behaviors reflect the emerging adult's resistance to settling down into roles and responsibilities of adult life. Erikson described "locomotion" as an important component of identity development. Locomotion refers to a young person's tendency toward sensation seeking. This is the need to experience the physical self to the fullest extent and simultaneously challenge social rules and norms. Consequently, experiences that qualify as sensation seeking, or locomotion, are often considered dangerous, novel and intense. Emerging adults generally have more freedom to pursue such experiences than adolescents because they are less monitored by parents and have more resources at their disposal. They experience more freedom than young adults because they are less constrained by the responsibility of roles such as parent or spouse.

The dynamism characteristic of emerging adulthood is not only evident in experimentation and risk taking, but also optimism and hopefulness. Emerging adults tend to be more optimistic about their lives and that they will achieve their dreams and goals, with 96 percent of eighteen- to twenty-four-year-olds in the United States agreeing with the statement, "I am very sure that someday I will get to where I want to be in life" (Hornblower, 1997). This can also be seen in an increase in self-esteem; although self-esteem tends to decline from preadolescence to adolescence, self-esteem actually tends to rise during emerging adulthood (Schulenberg & Zarrett, 2006). This is in part due to the fact that by emerging adulthood most people have passed through the awkward and uncomfortable stage of puberty and have become more comfortable with their physical appearance (which is important to adolescents' self-esteem). Additionally, from adolescence to emerging adulthood relationships with parents generally improve while conflict

diminishes, and feeling accepted and approved by parents tends to contribute to self-esteem (Arnett, 2004).

No doubt, emerging adulthood is an exciting and vibrant period of life. Tendencies toward exploration and optimism, partnered with new levels of freedom and minimal responsibilities, yield opportunities for intentional identity development. In regard to the reciprocating self, the emergence of the self becomes even more evident than during adolescence, and toward the end of emerging adulthood the self is more salient with clearer self-understanding and increased capacity to engage in reciprocating relationships.

Further solidification of identity. Arnett (2000a) contends that emerging adulthood is the period of life that offers the most opportunities for identity exploration in the areas of work and love. Even Erikson (1950, 1968), although he suggested that adolescence was the period to resolve the crisis between identity and role confusion, also argued in the 1950s and 1960s that Western industrialized societies allowed for "prolonged adolescence" necessary for identity exploration. Identity development involves testing various life possibilities and gradually moving toward making enduring decisions (Arnett, 2000a). In the forthcoming section we examine how identity exploration that begins during adolescence continues into emerging adulthood in the areas of relationships, work, gender and sexuality, and religion.

Identity and relationships. In regard to love, American adolescents generally begin dating in their early teens. These relationships typically last only a few weeks or months. Although they can be an important source of companionship, they are viewed as recreational and rarely come with the expectation of being lifelong relationships. Emerging adults tend to have different reasons for forming love relationships than adolescents. Generally, early and late adolescents consider recreation to be the most important function of love relationships, followed by intimacy and then

social status; however, emerging adults rank intimacy highest, followed by companionship, recreation and then status much lower (Montgomery, 2005). In contrast to adolescence, during emerging adulthood explorations in love become much more serious and intimate as couples more often take seriously the potential for emotional, spiritual and physical intimacy. Such relationships last longer than during adolescence and are more likely to include greater intimacy, sexual intercourse and sometimes cohabitation (Michael et al., 1995). Adolescent romantic relationships are much more transient whereas relationships in emerging adulthood often, but not always, raise more serious questions of identity: "Given the person I am, what kind of partner do I wish to spend my life with?"

Identity and work. Similarly, in regard to work, adolescent work is characterized by transient and tentative explorations, but emerging-adult work generally involves more serious and focused explorations. Although the majority of American adolescents work part-time, their work experiences do not provide them with knowledge and expertise related to their future occupations. On the other hand, during emerging adulthood young people intentionally pursue work experiences focused on preparation for enduring careers. Emerging adults intentionally seek out opportunities that allow them to explore identity issues that allow them to discover what kind of work they enjoy, are good at or find meaning in. Given that emerging adults are rarely providing financially for their offspring and many have the opportunity to lean on their parents financially, this period affords an opportunity to take advantage of unusual or risky work or educational opportunities. Consequently, many emerging adults pursue short-term volunteer or missionary work and others take opportunities to travel and explore other cultures. These experiences allow for rich opportunities of identity exploration, expanding the emerging adults' ranges of

experience prior to making more enduring choices of adulthood.

Identity and gender and sexuality. Gender is also an important issue for emerging adults. Gender is not only a seminal issue in identity formation, but it is particularly important for emerging adults. In addition, it highlights some important cultural differences. Considering the gender socialization people experience throughout childhood and adolescence, emerging adults tend to be aware of the different societal expectations held for males and females. Gender schemas—the way we notice, interpret and remember information in relation to the expectations we hold about gender—as well as the social roles men and women hold reinforce these societal gender expectations. However, there seems to be some evidence that emerging adults are less likely than adolescents to engage in or favor gender stereotypes (Lobel, Nov-Krispin, Schiller, Lobel & Feldman, 2004). Emerging adults become more aware of their own experience of their gender and less concerned to conform to social standards.

In developing countries, traditional gender roles are usually based at least partially on biological differences that determine the kind of work men and women can engage in. For example, since women have childbearing capacities and, if they are unable to control their reproductive lives through contraception, they spend most of their late teens, twenties and thirties either pregnant or nursing. Therefore, as mentioned previously, emerging adulthood can look very different in developing countries, especially regarding traditional gender roles. In more economically developed countries, emerging adults may not be as constrained by traditional gender roles and may feel more free to explore varied aspects of their gender identity. In the United States, this is evident in the LGBT movement and the growing acceptance of the transgender community, especially with the prevalence of transgender celebrities such as Laverne Cox

(who was featured on the May 2014 cover of *Time* celebrating "The Transgender Tipping Point").

Considerably more emerging adults experience same-sex romantic attraction than reported same-sex sexual behavior or an LGBT identity (Savin-Williams, 2005). Interestingly, young people who do engage in same-sex behavior are more and more resistant to being labeled as gay, lesbian or bisexual. For example, one study found that "nonheterosexual" young women who engaged in same-sex behavior from the ages of eighteen to twenty-five became increasingly reluctant to categorize themselves as lesbian or even bisexual (Diamond, 2009). This may be resistance against the idea of having a stable sexual identity and more of a proclivity toward young adults' experience of sexual fluidity.

Identity and religion. Generally speaking, emerging adults in developed countries are less religious than emerging adults in traditional countries. Religiosity tends to decline from adolescence through emerging adulthood. Both religious participation and religious beliefs decline throughout the teens and are lower in the late teens and early twenties than at any other period of the lifespan (Pew Forum on Religion & Public Life, 2008). Emerging adults often feel they need to make a break with their parents' religious beliefs and practices so they can establish their own independence in making their own decisions about their beliefs and values (Arnett & Jensen, 2002). Only about 30% of emerging adults attended religious services at least once a month, and over half attended only a few times a year or less; beliefs were stronger than behavior, with 44% reporting their religious faith was "very" or "extremely" important in their lives and 75% reporting belief in God (Smith & Snell, 2010). Additionally, about one-fourth of emerging adults reported they had no belief or interest in religion, in stark contrast to less than 10% of adolescents. Religious beliefs also tend to be highly individualized and do not adhere to a standard religious doctrine but instead pull from

multiple different sources (Arnett, 2004). The National Study on Youth and Religion (NSYR) identified four different categories of religiosity in emerging adults: committed traditionalists, selective adherents, spiritually open and religiously indifferent/hostile (Smith & Snell, 2010). This illustrates a surge of religious diversity in emerging adulthood, although the majority of the participants hold common beliefs of Moralistic Therapeutic Deism—that is, believing in God and being a good person, while emphasizing commonality between religions rather than differences (Smith & Snell, 2010). Still, the National Study of Youth and Religion also found religious belief and participation to be positively related to higher well-being and lower rates of risky behaviors (Smith & Snell, 2010).

All facets of identity are often under construction during the twenties. For example, although adolescents might begin to identify with different groups as a sense of their self-construct, their generally increased cognitive capacities that facilitate self-reflection and broader exposure to diverse peoples and experiences contribute to a more intentional time of identity exploration. For example, although youth during adolescence might begin to self-identify as a Christian or as a queer, the competencies and freedom associated with emerging adulthood allow for further exploration and a more sense of nuanced identity to take shape.

Consider the case of Eliza. She is a young woman who, after graduating college at the age of twenty-two, moves from Florida to Los Angeles to pursue her dream of being in the film industry. Since she has gone to an in-state college, this is the first time she is living apart from her family, and she begins a heightened exploration of her identity apart from her family unit. She is not married and has few financial or familial obligations, so she is able to take a few odd jobs waitressing and in retail to make ends meet while she dives more fully into her passion of acting. She

focuses primarily on herself and her acting career, but does not feel the pressure to be immediately successful because she figures, "It will all fall into place someday soon." She also experiences exploration in her personal relationships; she had been aware of being attracted to certain women in college and even in her childhood, but had never acted upon her attraction due to the conservative Southern culture she grew up in and a long-term college boyfriend. In California, where the LGBT community is more openly accepted, she begins to explore her sexuality and enjoys a period of dating both men and women. Eventually she begins dating her current girlfriend, who she meets at an audition for a local community theater. At some point she feels she will have to decide whether to be with a man or a woman, and she worries how her family back home would react to the news she is dating a girl; at the worst, she fears ostracization and rejection. However, at this time in her life, she feels the freedom to explore her own sexual identity without making any concrete decisions, and she even resists any labels such as *lesbian* or even *bisexual*, finding more resonance in the open-ended label of *queer*. To her, she feels that she simply "likes who she likes."

Distinguishing Between Emerging Adulthood and Young Adulthood

How are emerging adulthood and young adulthood different? Is it necessary to distinguish between the two periods? Arnett (2000a) builds a case for two unique periods. His research confirms that eighteen- to twenty-five-year-olds generally do not consider themselves having reached adulthood, while the majority of those in their thirties do. The majority of youth eighteen to twenty-five are in the process of preparing for long-term careers through education and training, whereas most in their thirties have chosen an enduring career path.

Most in this younger period are not married and are childless, and most in their thirties are married and have children. The term *emerging adulthood* captures the change and growth that characterize the gradual transition that young people make during this period as they mature toward young adulthood.

If exploration and experimentation characterize emerging adulthood, then what characterizes young adulthood? Stability. Erikson specifically addresses the significance of stability in relationships, and Levinson articulates the importance of building one's life structures during the young-adult stage. We will discuss the pursuit of stability in young adulthood through relationships and work.

Although relationships and exploring intimacy are important to adolescents and emerging adults, Erikson's explanation of the young-adult crisis of "intimacy versus isolation" affirms an important distinction between emerging and young adulthood. Erikson identifies the crisis of "intimacy versus isolation" as the predominant focus of young adulthood. He proposed that when a young person adequately resolves his or her identity, he or she is able to forge intimate relationships. He reasoned that once a young adult has established independence from his or her parents and can function as a productive person in society, he or she would be able to enter into relationships with satisfying intimacy—a closeness experienced without the fear of losing oneself in the intimacy. Although identity is never achieved outside of relationships, Erikson's point is helpful in pointing out the significance of solidifying identity in order to engage in intimate and mutual reciprocating relationships. The basic strength or virtue that results from a positive adaptive response to this crisis is *love*, which Erikson conceptualized as a mutual devotion to shared identity that permits a fusing of self to another without losing oneself. The late theologian James Loder (1998)

beautifully articulates this kind of intimacy: “Love implies a nonpossessive delight in the particularity of the other.”

Differentiated identity. The field of family life-cycle stages (see Balswick & Balswick, 2014) emphasizes the importance of *differentiation* as a major developmental task of early adulthood. Differentiation is a continuing process in the formation and reconstruction of the reciprocating self. Perhaps more than at any other time in life, persons in the early-adult transition are trying to figure out where their family’s values, beliefs and morals leave off and where their own begin; they are striving toward self-sufficiency. At its core, differentiation has to do with *identity*, with asking and successfully answering the question, “Who am I? Are my values and beliefs really my own? Is this ‘me’ talking and acting, or am I merely playing out a role my family expects me to play?” Youth who are enmeshed with parents—those who have not developed sufficient boundaries around their self structure—will have a very difficult time in finding their own separate identity. The family therapist Carl Whitaker suggests that youth who are too enmeshed with their families may need to leave their families in a huff. In Eriksonian terms the differentiated young adult has a solid sense of identity and is able to sustain intimate relationships.

Although differentiation is recognized as essential in order to successfully select a mate and maintain a marriage, it is also a necessary process for satisfying singlehood. Without clarifying one’s own values, beliefs, sense of identity and purpose, individuals—whether single or married—will struggle to find satisfying meaning, vocation and life.

One of the marks of young adulthood is marriage, and differentiation is essential in order to successfully select a mate and maintain a marriage.

Intimate relationship formation. With young adults, a most important demographic change has taken place in regard

to marriage. Whereas the age of first marriage was approximately twenty-three years for men and twenty and a half years for women in 1960, it has risen to twenty-eight and a half years for men and twenty-seven years for women in 2010 (US Bureau of the Census, 2012). During this same period the annual divorce rate (number of divorces per one thousand married couples) rose dramatically, from nine in 1960 to twenty-one in 2000. While the divorce rate has not risen in recent years, it has plateaued at this high level, meaning that if present rates continue, approximately four out of every ten marriages will end in divorce.

The traditional understanding of mate selection as a transition to marriage has become much more complex due to the premarital practices of "'hooking up,' internet dating, visiting relationships, cohabitation, marriage following childbirth, and serial partnering" (Sassler 2010, p. 557). Given the changes and prevalence of cohabitation, rather than using the term *mate selection*, some scholars are using the terms *relationship formation and development* and *intimate partnering* (p. 557).

There is evidence of a gender difference in what is valued in the mate-selection process. In a study based on 250 adults in their early twenties, it was reported that "females rated intelligence, stability, conscientiousness, height, education, social skills and political/religious compatibility significantly higher than males, who rated good looks higher than females" (Furnham, 2009). Wenzel and Emerson (2009) reported that socially anxious individuals believe others are less likely to select them than socially nonanxious individuals. McGee and Shevin (2009) found that persons with a good sense of humor are perceived as more attractive as potential mates. Montoya (2008) reports that "attractive perceivers expected to date more attractive targets while unattractive perceivers expected to date less attractive targets."

Corresponding to the change from a premodern to a modern society is a change in the nature of marriage. The *institutional marriage* of the past was a union between two families, with parents actively involved in the selection of a spouse for their children. The major functions of this marriage centered on economic well-being and the production of children. The *companionship marriage* of the present is primarily a union between two individuals who are in love and have personally selected each other. The major function of this marriage is companionship and personal fulfillment derived from the relationship shared together.

The simplicity of the parentally arranged marriage system in traditional societies has been replaced by the complexity of a mate-selection system that relies on the participants to detect true love. Given the distorting emphasis on romantic love in contemporary popular culture, this is a daunting task placed on young adults. Thus we offer an attempt to better understand the love-detection process placed on young adults.

In his attempt to sort out the complexity of romantic love, Roger Sternberg (1986b) has suggested that complete love includes three dimensions. These include *commitment*, which is the cognitive component, *intimacy*, which is the friendship factor and emotional component, and *passion*, which is the motivational component. Balswick and Balswick (2014, pp. 49-50) have suggested that Sternberg's model might be integrated with the three types of love known in ancient Greek culture and used in the New Testament. They suggest that *agape*—self-giving—corresponds to commitment, *philia*—brotherly love—corresponds to intimacy, and *eros*—physical desire for one's beloved—corresponds to passion.

In the participant-run mate-selection pattern of modern societies, passion is likely to dominate at the beginning of courtship, followed by a surge in intimacy, and finally commitment ensues as a couple contemplates the possibility of marriage. We suggest that while all three dimensions of love are important for a Christian marriage, courtship that begins

with commitment to the other person establishes an environment in which intimacy and passion can grow to full maturity after the marriage has been consummated. The ideal relationship will exhibit equal amounts of commitment, intimacy and passion before two people marry.

Parenthetically, this model of love also allows us to conceptualize forms of love that might not be complete enough for marriage. Thus when the self-giving love of commitment to a person is present, but passion (*eros*) or intimacy (*philia*) is lacking, there is hope that these dimensions grow with the relationship. When intimate friendship is present, but commitment (*agape*) and passion (*eros*) are lacking, then a decision to marry seems premature. When passion (*eros*) is dominant, but commitment (*agape*) and intimacy (*philia*) are lacking, then infatuation rather than mature love is present.

While most young adults today would not choose to marry someone who they did not love, most would not marry on the basis of love alone, giving some thought to the issue of personal compatibility. Compatibility, however, does not merely mean being alike, for a marriage in which partners were exactly alike in every way might not make a strong marriage. There are two differing theories on mate selection, one suggesting that *like marries like*, and the other that *opposites attract.* Research on mate selection reveals that in reality both theories are true. Persons tend to initiate relationships with those with whom they are alike in regard to *endogamous* factors—sharing a similar social background such as race, ethnicity, religion, education, occupation and geographical proximity. Relationships that move beyond this stage are then tested by another set of factors known as *homogamous* factors. Homogamy refers to persons being similar in regard to personal characteristics and interests, such as political beliefs, moral values, hobbies, intelligence, height, weight and physical appearance. This set of factors can be considered the second "filter" through which a few relationships progress to a more serious phase. The third

filter is know as *complementary needs.* For the relationships that reach this level of seriousness, opposite personality characteristics increasingly come into play. It seems that individuals tend to select a mate who has strength where they have a weakness. Thus research suggests that opposites tend to attract in regard to such personality factors as dominance-submissiveness, introversion-extroversion and nurture-succor. Needless to say, some adjustments are probably in store for the couple that has extreme differences in personality characteristics. The most attractive characteristic may become an irritation as the marriage develops or as one of the spouses grows in a deficient area.

At the beginning of the twenty-first century there are signs of a movement away from the certainty given by both traditional religious systems and scientifically based thinking. Postmodernity represents a radical response to the Enlightenment rationalism found in modernity. It embraces many flavors of truth, depending on one's personal experiences and group identities. Postmodernists reject the supposedly universal laws of nature as grounds for accepting or rejecting the priorities of certain life structures, because reality is viewed as multilayered with many ways of knowledge. Although postmodernity can be a useful corrective to the "certainties" of modernity, which promoted human reason as the basis for constructing meaningful life structures, it too can be problematic when taken to the extreme—that there is no reality except what is constructed by one's own experience.

The effects of postmodern thinking on the choices made by young adults can be seen in the emergence of a variety of alternative marital and family forms. Marriage is an option, but only as a conditional arrangement that can conveniently be terminated if it proves to yield insufficient self-fulfillment. There are a variety of ways a person can chose to be a parent while rejecting marriage—single motherhood, artificial insemination, single-parent adoption and

community-based living are a few examples. For the 1 to 3% of the population who are homosexual in orientation, a choice can be made to openly build a same-sex relationship rather than to build a heterosexual relationship and secretly live as a homosexual. Although this is still controversial, at the time of completion of this manuscript, the US Supreme Court ruled that the Constitution guarantees the right to same-sex marriages. Our purpose at this point is not to address the moral implications of each of these examples but to point to the nature of life-structure choices available to persons in postmodern societies.

Premarital cohabitation: A path toward, or alternative to, marriage. There has been a dramatic increase in premarital cohabitation in most industrialized societies. Cohabitation has increased in the United States from about 450,000 in 1960 to more than 7.5 million in 2010 (Wilcox, 2011, p. 75). By way of perspective, most marriages and remarriages taking place today will be preceded by a cohabiting relationship.

Cohabitation may have different meanings with respect to family formation in different societies, as the more accepting a society's attitude toward cohabitation, the more cohabitation is defined as an alternative to marriage (Perelli-Harris & Gassen, 2012). In their study of cohabitation in sixteen industrial societies, Heuveline and Timberlake (2004) report that at one extreme cohabitation is *marginal* in some societies since it is culturally rejected or even penalized. In other societies cohabitation is more accepted as a *prelude to marriage*, but legal marriage is expected prior to childbearing. In more accepting cultures cohabitation is considered an *alternative to marriage*, and at the most extreme of high acceptance, such as in Northern European countries, cohabitation is *indistinguishable from marriage* (Heuveline & Timberlake, 2004). We suggest that given the state of cohabitation in North America, it is somewhere in the middle of Heuveline and Timberlake's

suggested continuum—viewed by some as an alternative to single life and for others an alternative to being married.

In the United States age may be a factor, as "older cohabitors are more likely to view their relationship as an alternative to marriage, whereas younger cohabitors tend to view their relationship as a prelude to it" (King & Scott, 2005, p. 271). Gender may also be a factor, as Smock and Greenland (2010) find that cohabiting men and women differ in the way they conceptualize commitment. She finds that women perceive cohabitation as a step prior to marriage, whereas men are inclined to view cohabitation as a step prior to making a commitment. Gender differences are also present in the perceived drawbacks of cohabiting as men are more concerned about losing a sense of freedom, and women are most concerned with delaying marriage (Huang, Smock, Manning & Bergstrom-Lynch 2011).

By its very nature, a cohabiting relationship is one in which commitment is ambiguous. Marriage researcher and Christian therapist Scott Stanley (2005) describes cohabiting as "relationship inertia" in which cohabiters are "sliding" rather than "deciding" on a marital partner. He found that men who live with women they eventually marry are not as committed to the union as those who didn't live with their mates before marriage. Given the present state of knowledge, it is probably wise to recognize that for some couples, cohabitation is an *alternative* to marriage and for other couples it is a *stage* in a relationship that leads to marriage. Each interpretation might be true of different individuals and both might be true of the same individuals at different times in their life. A Christian perspective on cohabitation might best focus on its effect upon the biblical ideal of marriage based upon a reciprocal covenant commitment.

Vocation and the dream. In addition to love and intimacy, commitment to work and vocation is the other recognized developmental task of young adulthood. For Levinson (1978)

young adulthood is characterized by actively constructing one's own life structures. The "novice phase" is a transition and experimental stage occurring within emerging adulthood in which a young person explores his or her place in the world—relationally and vocationally. In young adulthood the individual places a more serious focus on developing and eventually committing to a career. For Levinson these acts involve attempts to make a space for oneself in the world.

The sequence in which a person's life structure is built will vary, depending on the priority one gives to education and occupation as opposed to marriage and beginning a family. Some of the most salient tensions and frustrations experienced by young adults emanate from the desire to "have it all"—a higher education, a successful career, a strong marriage, deep bonding with one's children and an affluent lifestyle. With high energy, young adults may launch into each, not realizing the amount of investment demanded by each life-structure situation.

The tension can be especially great among young women as they seek to balance marriage with a rising career, and at the same time hear the ticking of their biological clock that warns them that they need to begin a family. However, "having it all" stills seems possible during young adulthood, so we will postpone our discussion on this issue until the next chapter. The key development issues for most during young adulthood center on selecting a mate, beginning a family and education/occupational decisions.

An important aspect of making a place in the world is what Levinson calls the "dream." The dream is a vision of the future that gathers up deeply held personal feelings and translates them into images of the self in the adult world, "out there." The dream is shaped by an individual's present perceptions of him- or herself and what he or she is open to in the future. The dream has a transitional quality as it acts as a guiding vision for the future. In the current

psychological literature, research in the areas of goal pursuit and also purpose are burgeoning. We champion Levinson's concept of "the dream" because it represents the integration of goals, purposes and roles across different domains of life. It incorporates issues surrounding occupation, intimate relationships, marital adjustment, singleness, parenting and lifestyle. The dream acts as a guide for the young adult, providing a vision for the resolution of these life issues. The dream provides inspiration and motivation for pursuing vocational and relational paths that hopefully will result in the attainment of the dream.

For example, from an early age a young boy might have a "dream" to be a teacher and to one day help disadvantaged inner-city children. This vocational vision might serve to guide him as he navigates educational choices. The dream carries with it a sense of devotion that inspires him to stick with his dream despite challenge and obstacles. For instance, his parents may not approve of his decision to relocate to a more "dangerous" neighborhood in order to be accessible to his students and school. The dream can provide a sense of conviction that propels him to persevere with his commitments.

It is crucial that the dream is a person's own. If the dream is handed down from parents or imposed by a social or cultural order, it will lack integrity and misguide the young adult seeking his or her way in the world. The integrity of the dream depends on expressing an individual's innermost passion about him- or herself and vision for the future. Often in enmeshed families it is easy for adult children to dream their parents' dream for them. They might pursue a certain career or even a certain marriage partner because their parents' expectations are so deeply ingrained in them that those expectations have become the dream. This is often true of adult children of overbearing parents or for those who became parentified children, where they had to take on

the role of an adult within their family for various reasons. Such adults have a hard time dreaming their own dreams. Living out someone else's dreams can have grievous consequences for the adult. For example, an adult who carries out her parents' dreams and wishes for her and pursues a career in software development, only to realize (consciously or unconsciously) years later that she longs to work with and serve people intimately, will not only experience grave dissatisfaction and tension but may experience anxiety and depression as well.

It is also important that the dream is realistic. The dream offers no help when we have an unrealistic impression of ourselves. Forgive the illustration, but I am reminded of the early episodes of a season of the TV show *American Idol*, where "emerging adults" from around the country auditioned in their hometowns in hope of being invited back to Hollywood as the next potential American idol. Mixed in among the extremely talented were the not-so-talented individuals. A few of these individuals were certain that they would be the next American idol, oblivious to the fact that they had absolutely no musical talent whatsoever. These "dreams" are more like fantasies or delusional fantasies that mislead people and often result in disappointment or feelings of failure.

A mentor is important to making the dream a reality. Mentors are those who understand and share the importance and potential of the dream. They can practically connect the dreamer and the dream with the real world out there. They do this by giving realistic feedback and helping shape the dream in such a way that maximizes the potential of the dreamer and encourages realistic assessment. In addition, mentors use their position in the world to influence the world and open doors on behalf of the dreamer. For example, a professor might recognize a student's dream to pursue academics. Inviting the student to participate in a research project

would be one way of influencing the world "out there" and making the dream more of a reality.

Connecting vocation with intimacy, Loder talks about the importance of sharing the dream. Intimacy depends on sharing a dream with someone who can respect, enjoy and enrich one's own dream. Intimacy occurs when a special person can help an individual feel the power and depth of the dream as realistic. The dream can be shared between close friends or between spouses. It is important in relationships that one person's dream does not dominate. Often dysfunctional relationships occur because one individual is a great dreamer and the other needs someone else's dream to follow. The latter ends up supporting the dream of the partner, and he or she often ends up resentful. In some cases, one partner will have a dream and be too threatened to recognize the other's dream.

Deepest intimacy occurs when individuals empower each other in pursuit of their dreams. In marriage it is optimal when the spouses are able to merge their dreams to cocreate a dream that guides and sustains their lives as a couple. In keeping with the reciprocating self, this does not mean abandoning one's own dream but having space in the relationship to empower one another's dreams as well as being close enough to dream together.

Conclusion

Today, most scholars recognize that emerging adulthood and young adulthood are two distinct stages of the lifespan. Some scholars contend that emerging adulthood is a luxury of the educated and middle or upper classes, arguing that only those who stay in school and remain childless have the opportunity to experience it. Although this may be the case, it still applies to a significant amount of the American population and needs to be taken into consideration.

From the perspective of the development of the reciprocating self, emerging adulthood is helpful in that it highlights an especially poignant time of development of the self. In some ways it takes the issues of adolescence a step further, providing time and opportunity for young people to intentionally pursue the development of the self. In a recent article in the *Los Angeles Times* an editorial on the topic of emerging adulthood commented that this period of life was "a heretofore nameless nether world of angst and hope." This quote correctly gets at the active and profound questioning and searching as well as the hope and possibility that characterizes this period. Emerging adulthood might be described as a crucible, where the self takes shape in the fiery furnace of transformation.

Early adulthood is less about the *emergence* of self and more about *solidifying* a sense of self. Given new degrees of freedom and opportunities as well as expanded resources, including brain maturation, education and competencies, and money, emerging adulthood allows for the individual to deepen their understanding of self as they move outward and actively into the world. Most young adults have a solid sense of self; they have made at least initial commitments to vocation and often to love and relationships. If intimacy is not pursued in a marital relationship, young adults often establish enduring friendships with members of the same and opposite sex. During this time the self is actively reciprocating, investing in a vocation as well as in relationships. The self is found in mutual relationships and is preparing for the next more generative stage of life.

10

Middle Adulthood

The Generativity of the Reciprocating Self

THIS CHAPTER FOCUSES ON the period of time beyond young adulthood and before the elderly years, which roughly spans the fourth through sixth decades of life. Commitments to work, marriage, parenting, elderly parents and friends all constitute dimensions of a person's life structure in which the reciprocal self in relationships is continually shaped and reformulated. The internal reshaping of the self corresponds to the external middle adulthood process of "responsible scaffolding." The major responsibility in the majority of social institutions—family, religious, educational, political, economic—fall on persons who are in their middle adulthood years. Involvement in each institutional life structure demands a participatory role in "scaffold development." Persons in middle adulthood constitute the "backbone of society," on whose backs fall the major responsibilities of life. Responsibility constitutes the source of many of the anticipated fulfillments, as well as the developmental tensions and issues among persons during this period. Hoffman, Kaneshiro and Compton (2012) asked 153 persons aged forty to sixty-five to describe a recent joyful experience and its subsequent impact of their outlook on life. An analysis of their responses indicated that *interpersonal joy* was the most

frequent type of response, followed respectively by *external achievement* and *personal growth.* Lesser responses included *religious peaks, recovery from illness/accident, nature skill master, philosophical musing, development landmark, homecoming, nostalgia* and *serenity.* Issues to be addressed in this chapter include midlife crisis, emotional intelligence, change or decline in intelligence, and the development of wisdom.

Theories of Adult Lifespan Development

Since it is assumed that most human development takes place during the formative years, considerably less attention has been given to adult development. That which has been done has been guided by the theories of Erikson, Levinson, Gould and Vaillant. Although Levinson's theory has gained the most attention, the studies of Gould and Vaillant actually predate the work of Levinson.

Gould's phases of life. Based on both clinical data and responses to questionnaires by 524 nonclinical adults, Gould (1978) suggests seven chronological phases of life. *Sixteen to eighteen years*: adulthood begins when the desire for autonomy moves youths away from parents and toward closer relationships with peers. *Eighteen to twenty-two years*: individuals seek to deepen family-type relationships with peers as a way of resisting their family's attempt to "reclaim" them. *Twenty-two to twenty-nine years*: individuals work at being competent adults, begin to "really live," but are guarded against extreme emotions as they build for the future. Role confusion is characteristic of those from *twenty-nine to thirty-five* as individuals begin to question commitments to marriage or work as well as their own purpose and goals in life. This is a time when persons seek continuity between what they do and who they are. Those from *thirty-five to forty-three* characteristically feel they do

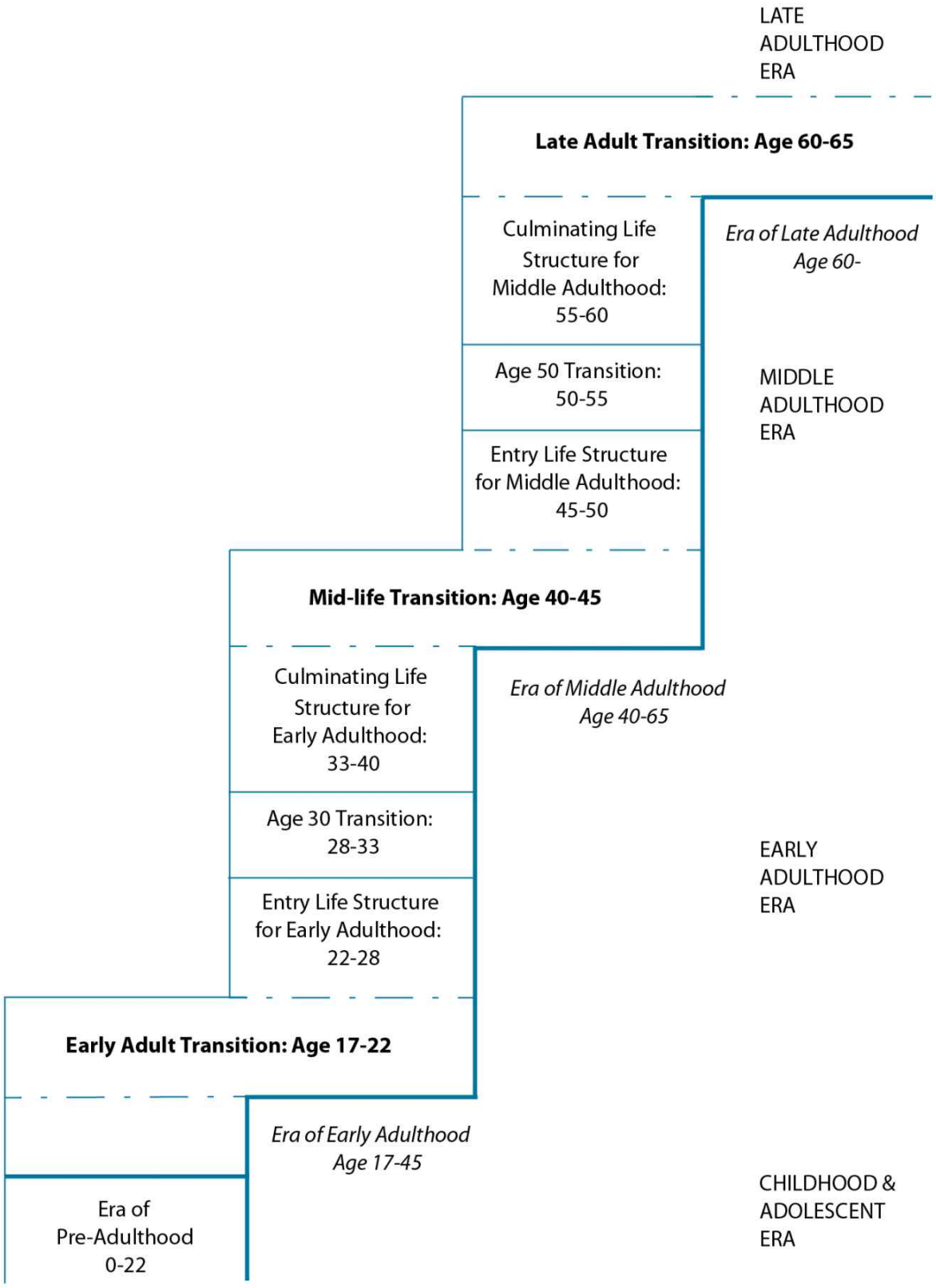
not have enough time to accomplish all that needs to be done. The time squeeze is not only felt at work but also in relationship with their children, whom they are fast losing influence with. *Forty-three to fifty* is a settling-down stage in which people learn to accept the limitation imposed by time and destiny. At this age a person wants to gain a better feel for his or her relational and affection needs from family and friends. A continuing quest for meaningful personal relationships characterizes the period from age *fifty to sixty.* This also is a time of warming and mellowing toward children, parents, spouse and friends. Gould's suggested phases of life contributes a richness to understanding the changing nature of the reciprocating self through the lifespan.

Vaillant's adaptation to life. Based on a longitudinal study of ninety-four male Harvard College graduates, George Vaillant developed an adult lifespan model that he characterized as *adaptation to life* (1977). Utilizing a variety of research methods Vaillant reported that his study confirmed the major developmental task proposed in Erikson's theory. Vaillant's longitudinal research was especially effective in demonstrating the accumulative effect of positive or negative stage-specific lifespan effects. He reports, for instance, that whereas about half of the subjects who had experienced poor childhood environments were among the thirty worst outcomes in their fifties, only 17 percent with poor childhood environments were among the thirty best outcomes in their fifties. Other confirmations of the accumulative hypotheses are the importance of achieving intimacy during young adulthood for marital stability later in life, and the contributions of a stable marriage and rich friendship network to achievement in the sphere of work. Like Erikson and unlike Gould and Levinson, Vaillant conceptualized adulthood in broad life periods. Vaillant's research suggests that the development of the reciprocating

self must, at least in part, be understood in terms of accumulative strengths or deficiencies.

Levinson's seasons of life. Daniel Levinson utilized qualitative analysis as a basis for identifying "the seasons of a man's life" and "the season's of a woman's life" (1978, 1996). Levinson gathered information through intensive biographical interviews that could be described as a story-telling, narrative approach. Although methodological details are curiously absent from *The Seasons of a Man's Life*, Levinson indicates in *The Seasons of a Woman's Life* that the book is based on twenty hours of interviews with forty-five women, which translates to two hundred to three hundred typed pages for each. As with his sample of men, professional women were overrepresented in his women's sample (fifteen each of homemakers, career women and academic women were interviewed).

Levinson has expanded the adult developmental stages from those suggested by Erikson, Gould and Vaillant by viewing the adult life cycle as a sequence of eras. Each era has its own bio-psycho-social character and makes distinctive contributions to the whole. Persons might be understood as active participants in constructing their own life structure. Adult development takes place within four eras, with five-year cross-era transitions. (See fig. 10.1 for a graphic depiction of Levinson's developmental model.)


LATE ADULTHOOD ERA
Late Adult Transition: Age 60-65
Culminating Life Structure for Middle Adulthood: 55-60
Era of Late Adulthood Age 60-
Age 50 Transition: 50-55
MIDDLE ADULTHOOD ERA
Entry Life Structure for Middle Adulthood: 45-50
Mid-life Transition: Age 40-45
Culminating Life Structure for Early Adulthood: 33-40
Era of Middle Adulthood Age 40-65
Age 30 Transition: 28-33
EARLY ADULTHOOD ERA
Entry Life Structure for Early Adulthood: 22-28
Early Adult Transition: Age 17-22
Era of Early Adulthood Age 17-45
CHILDHOOD & ADOLESCENT ERA
Era of Pre-Adulthood 0-22

(Adapted from *The Seasons of a Man's Life* [Levinson, 1978] and *The Seasons of a Woman's Life* [Levinson, 1996].)

Figure 10.1. Levinson's Developmental Model

Levinson believes that adult development can best be understood as individuals seeking to find their niche in society. By creating their life structure individuals are actually constructing their own "life space." The underlying pattern or design of a person's life at a given time might be considered to be a "snapshot" of a person's life structure. Development can be up (adolescing) or down (senescing), as both processes go on at the same time throughout the life span. The speed one moves through each era differs within the life of each person as well as from person to person. One person, for example, may get "stuck" in the early adulthood era, while another finds him- or herself restless and eager to move on the next.

The primary components of life structure are *relationships* with others in the external world. A relationship must be described in terms of what is *done, its meaning, what is given and received, the context, the place* and *evolution over time.* There is an obvious correspondence between the elements of a relationship as defined by Levinson and our model of the reciprocating self. Life structures have central, peripheral and unfulfilled components. Life structures also include external and internal aspects. When the external realities, for example, become extremely distant from an internal vision, goal or dream, an individual needs to reformulate or revision the goal or dream. Too much dissonance between external and internal aspects of a life structures renders a person susceptible to unrealistic expectations at best, and sets him or her up for failure at worst. *Satisfactoriness* refers to a person's evaluation of the external and internal aspects of his or her life structures.

Within any era an assessment can be made of a person's investment of their self in life.

While highly invested persons are intensely engaged in the process of living, lowly invested persons are disengaged from life. Investment in life can be both *positive*—excitement, enthusiasm or meaning, and *negative*—turmoil, suffering or fear.

Each era has development tasks that need to be mastered. A *developmental crisis* can be said to occur when a person is having great difficulty in meeting the tasks of the current period. One response to a developmental crisis may be to disinvest from life. Quitting a job, deserting the family or divorcing one's spouse are extreme examples of disinvesting.

Transitional periods consist of boundary regions that serve as bridges between eras or developmental periods. A glance at table 10.1 will indicate major transitions between one era and the next, and minor transitions between two periods within an era. Transitions include three tasks that are intertwined, and thus not necessarily done in sequence. *Termination* is more of a turning point than an end; it involves the transformation of a relationship. This might involve a person asking a question such as, "What am I going to do about my life?" *Individuation* is a process both within the self and with the external world. It might be the process, for instance, of establishing a firm yet permeable boundary between the *me* and *not me*. In so doing the individual is forming a more stabilized relationship with the external world. A healthy degree of individuation is necessary in order for a person to develop intimacy in a relationship with another. *Initiation* refers to the task of making choices to invest in new relationships or activities. When the reciprocating self is strong and secure, a person can better negotiate the many twists, turns and transitions that are a part of middle adulthood.

Crisis results when a person is having difficulty in mastering these tasks within the current period. An

“adaptive” crisis involves an inappropriate response to a stressful situation. For instance, some men and women at midlife have a sexual affair because they are unsure of their attractiveness or sexuality.

While Levinson developed his theory based on data gathered from men, he argues that the evidence from the women’s study in general supports the model developed for men.

He suggests that found gender differences in development can for the most part be understood in terms of *gender splitting*—the creation of a rigid division between males and females. (See the following section for a discussion of gender splitting among middle-aged adult women.) Men and women are both found to correspond to the suggested age sequencing of eras and developmental periods. Levinson is “embarrassed” by the order and eloquent simplicity of the sequence.

These three theories of adult development have several key findings in common. First, all three report a period of significant tension and transition between adolescence and early adulthood. Each confirmed that the period of struggle might continue well into the twenties as a young person strived to enter the adult world, in essence anticipating the need to establish emergent adulthood as a new developmental life stage. Second, all three theorists described a midlife crisis as occurring at roughly the same chronological age. Gould described the midlife crisis as occurring between thirty-five and forty-three, Vaillant at around forty but as early as thirty and as late as fifty, and Levinson at between forty and forty-five. Gould and Levinson found the crisis to be more severe than reported by Vaillant. A shared limitation of the three studies is that they represent a segment of the population that is significantly higher in education and income than the general population, a fact that should be kept in mind as we draw on them in gaining a picture of adult development.

The Stages of Middle Adulthood

Early middle adulthood. Middle adulthood begins with the age-thirty transition—roughly from ages twenty-eight to thirty-three. When people realize that they are moving out of the twenties, they begin to understand that there is little time left to change their life structure. Rather than trying to "keep options open," such a person begins to feel that "this is the last chance." For the person who is dissatisfied with his or her occupation, there may be the feeling that this is the last chance to "really do what I want to do." Early middle adulthood can also be a time of reevaluation, a time of considering new choices. After such considerations a person either concludes that he or she is satisfied with the life-structure choices made or quickly plans to make changes while they are still possible.

The age-thirty transition is followed by the age-thirty-three to thirty-nine *settling down* period. In this second attempt at building adult life structure, individuals seek to invest themselves wholeheartedly in work, family, friendships, leisure, community—that which is most important in life. The tentativeness of the early life structure (the twenties) is gone. On the job they strive to prove that they can make it. They begin in earnest to climb the occupational ladder. In family life the demands of mothering and fathering call a person to spend time with their children—to play with them, to become a scoutmaster, to coach a soccer team or take them camping overnight. This is a period of time when both women and men are generally very busy and committed as reciprocating selves to building their life structure. Toward the end of the settling-down period a person may begin to assess the progress made in light of the goals he or she has set.

In traditional marriages this description of early middle adulthood may be more applicable for men than for women. Women who are homemakers have the luxury of investing

themselves in the domestic life structure, settling into the role of being a wife and mother. For what has become a majority of middle-age adult women who are employed outside of the home, the above paragraph is applicable. As we move to an examination of the midlife crisis we will see that for these women an identity crisis at midlife can be responded to by *gender splitting*.

The midlife crisis. With the end of the settling-down period comes the age forty to forty-five *midlife transition.* The midlife transition is traditionally described as a crisis primarily for *men.* The issue of a female midlife crisis will be addressed following our focus on men. Adults continue to pass through individual stages of development throughout their lifetime. One of the most widely recognized stages is the onset of midlife, used to describe the feeling of not being able to keep up with the vast changes of the postmodern world. While it can be debated whether midlife is best understood as a crisis or a transition (Freund & Ritter, 2009), the rapidity of social and technological change tends to shock each new generation. Personal adaptations can reach crisis proportions when persons are not prepared for the future.

For most men the midlife transition is the "big one." It is the equivalent of a 8.0 earthquake on the Richter scale. A number of factors contribute to the probability that this transition will produce the greatest crisis, the most important factor being the rapidity of social and technological change.

In his study of career-oriented men, Daniel Levinson (1978, pp. 209-44) has identified four *polarities of midlife transition.* Although these polarities exist through the entire adult male life cycle, they are accentuated during transition periods. Men who have dealt with these polarities throughout their life, having met minor crises on a regular basis, do not experience the midlife transition as a crisis period. On the other hand, men who have not dealt with these

polarities are candidates for a major midlife crisis. Men in midlife can occupy a marginal status because of the *young-old* polarity. These men feel older than young men, but they are not ready to join the rocking-chair set just yet. One sign of this concern is that these men will attempt to appear younger than they are. They may dress in a sporty style or put themselves on a rigorous weight-lifting and running routine as ways of appearing young. The second polarity is *destruction-creation.* Having experienced conflict on the job and being battle-scarred and hurt by others, men in midlife may resort to the same tactics. They also are aware of the heart attacks and even death of friends their age. At the same time they have a strong desire to be creative. Having accumulated the needed training and experience, professional men look to middle age and beyond as the time when they will reach their peak in creativity and productivity. The *masculinity-femininity* polarity points to middle-aged men's attempt to sustain their manly appearance of strength and toughness, while at the same time they come to have a desire to become more nurturing. Their masculine side pushes them to further achievement and ambition, while their feminine side calls them to be more relational and sensitive to the needs of others. Needless to say this masculine-feminine polarity is a struggle that seeks resolution within the structure of the reciprocating self. Finally, the *attachment-separateness* polarity points to the need to find a balance between being connected to others and being self-sufficient. Men have a high need for attachment during the early part of their career because they need to learn from others who are more experienced. There comes a point when these same men need to pull away, to be in charge or at least to have the opportunity to try out their own ideas. While there is abundant evidence of the importance of attachment to healthy exploration among children, Feeney and Van Vleet (2010, p. 226) report the importance of attachment relationships "to

exploration and growth in adulthood and across the lifespan."

A major task that men must face during a transition is to confront a polarity as they become aware of it. Growth can come when a man finds a new way of being young, masculine, creative or attached. There is nothing wrong with a middle-aged man desiring to be young, for instance, but he must not allow himself to be stuck in a particular way of being young. When I (Jack) came to Fuller at age thirty-five, my body was still (barely) agile enough to play quarterback in our intramural flag football league. After I dislocated a knee, I continued my attempt to play quarterback with a knee brace. After a few years of struggling I realized that I was stuck in my attempt to be young. Since I gave up my need to be quarterback, I learned to enjoy playing other positions. At age sixty-five my playing days were long over, but I still strove to be young in a new way—being part of a cycling group that rides thirty to fifty miles each Monday, with extended multiday rides down the Pacific coast during the summer. With the onset of a balance condition several years ago I struggled to continue riding until I cracked four ribs. I have now "graduated" to a three-wheel trike with twenty-seven gears, allowing me to struggle to keep up with my riding group.

The publication of *Seasons of a Woman's Life* (Levinson, 1996) indicates that the midlife transition is less pronounced for most women. The major transition for women is the drawn-out process of moving from a traditional definition of femininity that largely limited them to domestic roles to an expanded definition that allows them to pursue a career. In this transition Levinson found that women more than men engage in *gender splitting*—simultaneously holding dichotomous identities.

Four types of gender splitting are noted among women—*domestic-public, homemaker-provider, women's work-men's work* and *femininity-masculinity in individual psyche.* Most

homemakers want to uphold a traditional view of marriage, while at the same time holding an antitraditional view that wants more independence, including equality with men, and to be in the public world. Many career women experience extreme conflict between an internal traditional view and an antitraditional view. The two groups have different resources and constraints as they move through life stages. Around midlife, homemakers may begin to experience a crisis in meaning and identity as their children move out of the home. Having invested so much of themselves in the mothering role, many midlife women respond by returning to school, continuing an interrupted career or beginning a new one. The crisis for career women is most likely from the tension of trying to balance marriage, motherhood and work. For these women leaving children (in daycare or preschool) might actually be a relief from the difficulty of trying to do it all. Given the dynamic changes that have taken place in gender roles, it should be no surprise to learn how profoundly these changes are affecting women's reciprocating selves at midlife.

In their study of women at midlife, Darling, Coccia and Senatore (2012) report that factors that negatively affect life satisfaction of women include having experienced more stressful life changes, having a higher body mass, sleeping fewer hours and having greater health stress. In a study of 286 women between the ages of thirty-eight and forty-seven, Smithson (2011, p. 666) found that self-reported "wellness was significantly higher for women who had advanced degrees, higher income levels, and were in a parenting role." In their article "The Motherhood Penalty at Midlife," Kahn, Garcia-Manglano and Bianchi (2014) report on the long-term effects of children on women's careers. They report that although motherhood is "costly" to women's careers when they are young, this cost is largely eliminated when women are in their forties and fifties, a period in life when many mothers are even able to regain ground in terms of previous loss in occupational status. The authors note, however, that

the wage penalty for having children persists for women who have three or more children.

Successful middle adulthood. The above descriptions of midlife tensions need to be balanced by a recent study suggesting that middle age may be less stressful than previous writings have suggested. For ten years the MacArthur Foundation Research Network on Successful Mid-life studied over seven thousand midlife Americans. Its director, Orville Brim, said, "On balance, the sense we all have is that midlife is the best place to be" (Goode, 1999). The study revealed that in moving from age thirty-five to age sixty-five, persons report increased feelings of well-being and a greater sense of control over their lives. A majority of participants report feeling better at present than they had during the previous ten years. Less than a quarter (23 percent) reported undergoing a midlife crisis, and of these only one-third attributed the crisis to the aging process. Seventy percent described their health as excellent, and most were very optimistic about their health in the future. A majority described their marriages or relationships as stable and relatively happy. In regard to personal autonomy and effective management of their world, male and females alike scored higher from the beginning to the end of the midlife period. This evidence of increased psychological well-being was especially evident for women. Contrary to what Sheehy (1991) reported, menopause was not a major contributor to midlife stress among women.

At the later end of middle adulthood (the sixties), both women and men reported a loss in personal growth, a decrease in a continued sense of purpose and a declining optimism about continuing good health in the future.

Berman and Napier demystify the midlife crisis by reframing it in terms of a *narrative change.* The midlife transition occurs when "the narrative shifts to include the awareness of mortality, and the understanding that one is in the middle of life and not the beginning" (Berman & Napier,

2000, p. 229). Thus midlife crisis is in reality "a period of life review in which the person reappraises his or her life, developing a coherent story about the past and present" (p. 229). Narrative change can involve revising life goals and aspiration, forgiving oneself for sins of omission and commission, making peace with a parent, reconnecting with an adolescent, or redefining success or failure in life. The ability to construct a narrative that makes sense allows a person to look to the future with confidence and anticipation. A midlife crisis occurs when the reciprocating self cannot successfully negotiate a narrative change.

This emphasis on narrative change, combined with the Successful Mid-life study, serves as a corrective to a common emphasis on the stress of middle age. Persons in midlife generally see this as a good time of life, being satisfied with their lives and aware and thankful about their personal gains. Midlife stress is centered more on worries about the future, especially around health and financial issues (Goode, 1999).

Erikson uses the term *generativity* to refer to the major developmental task persons must master during their middle adulthood years. Generativity is possible to the extent that polarities and gender splitting are confronted and dealt with creatively. To successfully combine all aspects of oneself into an integrated whole renders one a candidate for *ego integration* during Erikson's final age-sixty-plus developmental stage. The opposite of generativity is *stagnation*, the state of not growing, of being bogged down, of being static or of being stuck. When the polarities of *masculinity* and *femininity*, *young* and *old*, or *attachment* and *separation* cannot be recognized and integrated into a whole self structure, the culmination of middle adulthood may lead to *ego despair* during the final stage of life.

Middle-aged persons are living out generativity when they invest themselves in other people and delight in seeing their

work and ideas live on through younger persons. The sign of a generative person is that he or she is a person *for* others, or, in terms of our model, a reciprocating self who is an empowerer of others. Middle-aged persons have the knowledge and experience to influence others. Those who use their influence to control others are betraying a state of ego stagnation. Those who use their influence for others and to build others up are operating from a state of generativity, characterized by a mature reciprocating self.

Late middle adulthood. The amount of change brought about by the midlife transition may not be realized until it is over. For some, life is radically reoriented—a decision to prepare for the ministry, to begin a new career, to start a business, to take up a new hobby or even to quit work in support of one's spouse's career. For others middle age brings little change, which may reflect resignation to a boring job or a positive acceptance of the life structures already built. Others fail to listen to inner voices that question the meaning, value and direction of their current lives. For these the age-fifty transition can be crisis-filled. Persons who have seriously confronted and creatively dealt with the issues raised during their midlife transition seem to sail right through mature adulthood years.

The primary developmental task of mature adulthood, according to Erikson, is *ego integration.* Ego integration is the state in which the various parts of a person's life structure form a consistent and integrated whole, not a bad description of the ideal reciprocating self. Persons with high ego integration or strong reciprocating selfhood live with a confidence that their life has meaning, value and direction. Those who have shown mastery over the primary developmental task at each previous stage are candidates for high ego integration. For others, born into an atmosphere of distrust rather than trust, life has been experienced as a series of failures to master the primary task at each subsequent developmental stage. Lacking the needed inner

resources, these persons experience mature adulthood with *ego despair*, in which life lacks meaning, purpose and a sense of direction. Due to accumulative strengths or deficiencies the lives of persons at the mature adulthood stage vary widely.

Beginning at about age sixty and continuing on until retirement, usually age sixty-five, comes the *late adult transition.* In this transition an individual needs to conclude the efforts of middle adulthood and to prepare for an anticipated retirement. He or she begins to *disengage* from the situations, relationships and commitments that were the driving force during the mature adulthood years. Signs of disengagement include a reluctance to make difficult or controversial decisions at work and a pulling away from group and relational involvements that will end at retirement. These individuals want to retire with a quiet dignity, having no desire to do anything that might rock the boat.

Family Life

Approximately 90 percent of humans marry, the vast majority before they reach age thirty. The typical couple who marry while in their twenties can expect to live two-thirds of their life married or in adjusting to a marriage terminated by divorce or death. During middle adulthood married individuals usually pass through two separate family-life stages—*launching* and *postlaunching*—before retirement and late adulthood.

Families in later life are those that have passed beyond the child-rearing years. The typical single parent or couple whose children are in their twenties or thirties can expect to live one-third of their lives in this particular family life stage. Because of the increase in life expectancy, this stage can last several decades or more. Many find this time of life an awesome, complex and arduous journey, especially

when there are four or even five generations of family members to deal with.

Adults continue to pass through individual stages of development throughout their lifetime. One of the most widely recognized stages is the onset of midlife, used to describe the feeling of not being able to keep up with the vast changes of the postmodern world. While it can be debated whether midlife is best understood as a crisis or a transition (Freund & Ritter, 2009), the rapidity of social and technological change tends to shock each new generation. Personal adaptations can reach crisis proportions when persons are not prepared for the future stages.

The launching stage. The *launching stage* is that period of family life when children are in the process of leaving home. In chapter eight, on adolescents, we identified some of the tensions and issues that arise in the family when parents reach middle age and children reach adolescence. The successful launching of children is directly related to the degree to which the tensions and issues of the previous stage were addressed and resolved before the children leave. A successful launch is characterized by children leaving home but continuing to orbit at a safe distance around the family. In a failed launch the child either continues to be physically or psychologically within the family, or is jettisoned so far that the family is no longer instrumental in the continued life development of the child.

One of the key developmental processes among adolescents is differentiation. When children reach the launching stage with unhealthy differentiation, they tend to either develop a pattern of *dependence on* or *independence from* their parents. Healthy differentiated children can assume an *interdependent* relationship with their parents as they learn to become truly reciprocating selves. Unfortunately, the practice of adult children moving back in with their parents has become such a common practice that the term *boomerang children* has been coined to describe them. And middle-age parents can be

greatly affected when their young-adult children are unable to assume adult responsibilities.

Differentiation issues are relational issues by nature. The overly dependent or independent needs within an adult child usually reflect unresolved parental differentiation issues. When both parents have a mature reciprocating self, they can model a balanced relationship with each other and with their children. In their chapter "Launching Children and Moving On," McCullough and Rutenberg (1989) identify four things that parents can do to assure a better transition through the launching stage. First, parents must *refocus on their marriage relationship* and not allow any carryover of the tensions and issues that might have been a part of their parenting of adolescent and young-adult-aged children. If the marriage is strong, then it is easier for their children to leave home. Second, parents and children need to learn to *relate to each other as adult to adult.* Part of letting go for parents is accepting the adult status of their children. As long as their adult child remains a child in their eyes, the parents' self-identity is that of a parent—a protector, a caretaker and so forth. Accepting and allowing one's child to be an adult calls for a reformulation of the reciprocating self. Parents must literally learn to relate to their children in a new way—adult to adult.

Third, parents must *develop good relationships with the child's spouse and his or her family*. The most conflictive relationship tends to be in the daughter-in-law to mother-in-law relationship. The major reason for this is that mothers more than fathers involve themselves in their married children's lives. Part of the conflict may emanate from a young husband comparing his wife with his mother on such tasks as cooking, cleaning and parenting. This puts the daughter-in-law in a no-win situation since what her husband defines as good cooking and what he experienced as parenting was shaped by his mother. The next most frequent conflict is in the son-in-law to mother-in-law relationship. Although

this may be due to the mother's involvement in her daughter's marriage, the stereotype of mothers-in-law as an "interfering battle-ax" may work as a self-fulfilling prophecy. The next to least conflictive relationship is son-in-law to father-in-law, which tends to be absent of conflict if the father-in-law believes his son-in-law is adequately caring and providing for his daughter. Least conflictive is in the daughter-in-law to father-in-law relationship, which is frequently a good-natured-teasing type relationship.

Fourth, so much of parents' time and energy is focused on their maturing children that issues with their own aging parents may need to be more fully addressed when children leave home. Thus *resolving issues with the older generation* can make for a smooth and successful launching. Such issues might include dealing with elderly parents' increased emotional and physical dependence, financial insecurities following retirement or emotional feeling following the death of a parent.

However, there may be some societal reasons why leaving home is not as easy a process as it once was. In a highly technological society the majority of well-paying jobs demand high education, training and skills. Most entry-level jobs require a college degree at a minimum. The cost of a college education today is fifty thousand dollars and upward. This means that more and more adult children find themselves economically dependent on their parents for longer and longer periods of time. Even those who have been "launched" may find it necessary to assume the status of "boomerang children" by returning to the launching pad.

The postlaunching stage. A major consequence of children leaving home is a greatly changed and often-reduced parental role for parents. Such "role loss" can be detrimental to either a parent or a marriage or both if parenting was what provided a sense of meaning and purpose to the individual or the marriage. This might explain a third peak in the divorce rate after twenty-five years of marriage (Shapiro, 1996).

(The first two peaks are in the first two years and around fifteen to eighteen years of marriage.)

In a strong marriage, partners focus on each other, and the relationship is not dependent on the joint-parenting role. In general the decline in marital happiness that began with the arrival of children reaches its low point just before children leave home. Once children leave home marital adjustment increases, creating a U-shaped curve between length of marriage and marital happiness.

Increased life expectancy means that those in late middle adulthood may be "sandwiched" between their adult children and their aging parents. Since economic earning is generally the highest during late middle adulthood, members of this *sandwich generation* find themselves in the middle of two needy generations. They are called on to give emotional and economic support to their adult children and their elderly parents at the same time. A study of job burnout and couple burnout among dual-earner couples in the sandwiched generation revealed "significant differences in burnout type (job burnout higher than couple burnout); gender (wives more burned out than husbands); and country (Americans more burned out than Israelis)" (Pines, Neal, Hammer & Icekson, 2011, p. 361). Such dual responsibilities can result in couple burnout, especially among dual-earner couples who not only need to balance work and home life, but time for other family members and their own marriage (Pines, Neal, Hammer & Icekson 2011).

In anticipating retirement, this sandwich generation may be pleased to find that their adult children have finally gained a healthy degree of economic independence, but distressed to find that their aging parents have increased emotional and economic needs. Although the fact that people are living longer results in greater complexity and tension in family relationships, it also allows for the possibility for greater cross-generational family intimacy and support.

Marital Issues

Marriage matters for individual lifespan development. In a study of 1,681 individuals married over twenty years, Miller, Hollist, Olsen and Law (2013, p. 667) find "significant association between positive and negative dimensions of marital quality and physical health over the life course." In their analysis of long-term marriages, Berman and Napier (2000) suggest that midlife marriages are under pressure in four ways. First, marital *commitment* may be tested when a common focus on the children declines and the couple finds they have more time for each other. For couples whose commitment has been on the marital relationship and each other, this can be a exciting time of joint participation in life. For couples whose primary focus has been on what they have together as parents, there may be a need to build common activities and interests. Middle adulthood can thus be a time when the focus of the marital commitment is tested. Overall, research indicates that individuals who marry benefit from this relationship in terms of physical and mental health when compared to persons who remain single (Carr & Springer, 2010).

At middle age a couple can have an accumulated history together that includes a backlog of unprocessed feelings and imbalances in the relationship that need a measure of grace if they are to be adequately addressed. Berman and Napier (2000, p. 223) suggest that some couples may have fought and not allowed themselves tenderness or softer emotions, while in other marriages there may have been an "underfunctioner and an overfunctioner—and both are tired of this sense of imbalance." There are also several boundary issues a midlife couple may need to negotiate. A boomerang child or an elderly parent, for instance, may need care and reenter the home. Needless to say it takes a considerable amount of grace on the part of both spouses to face one another's shortcomings and to agree to work on their relationship.

By early middle adulthood a couple usually develops a *balance of power* and a pattern of decision making. Middle age creates a more intense push in both partners to fulfill their dreams and incomplete identities. To the degree that the balance of power has served as a barrier to the self--fulfillment of one partner, difficulty may arise. In Gray-Little and Burks' (1983) review on the relationship between marital power and marital satisfaction, egalitarian marriages were found to be the most satisfying, followed by traditional marriages. Wife-dominated marriages were the least satisfying. Given changes in the balance of power, it is vital that midlife couples master the practice of mutual empowerment.

The final midlife marital pressure identified by Berman and Napier (2000) is the *desire and expectation for greater intimacy in their relationship.* Middle age jars a couple into evaluating the process they have made toward greater intimacy. It is worth noting the similarity among the four midlife marital issues suggested by Berman and Napier and the centrality of unconditional commitment, gracing, empowering and intimacy to the biblically based model for relationships we presented in chapter three. In our biblical model of relationships we suggest that intimacy—to know and be known—is the goal of relationships. A number of barriers may retard the development of marital intimacy—inability or unwillingness to express feelings, overinvolvement in work, focus on children's needs, lack of communication skills and so forth. When children leave home, a couple lacking intimacy may panic about what life will be like with just the two of them. Where intimacy has not been achieved, a spouse may be tempted to look elsewhere for emotional and sexual fulfillment. Insecurity about self-esteem or body image may also lead a spouse to seek affirmation of his or her attractiveness from another source. Inversely, when marriage is based on the interaction of two strong reciprocating selves, it will be characterized by both closeness and

intimacy, as well as independence and separateness. Our model would suggest that true marital intimacy is possible only when both partners are highly differentiated individuals.

Mesosystem and Macrosystem Issues

We began this chapter by noting that persons in middle adulthood constitute the backbone of society because they are called on to provide much of the needed scaffolding in society. Participation and involvement in the major societal institutions beyond the family—religious, educational, political, economic—constitute the arena within which middle-aged persons play out major mesosystem issues. The degree of involvement in each of these social institutions varies greatly between persons. For persons with strong religious commitments involvement in church will be a high priority. Lee and Balswick (1989) have documented that mesosystem stress can be especially acute on clergy families when there are not appropriate boundaries between the family and congregational system. Mesosystem issues are not likely to emerge between the family and the political and educational institutions because involvement in the former is usually limited to voting, and in the latter to showing various forms of support to school-age children through participation in the PTA, serving as a homeroom parent or assisting in extracurricular sports, music or other activity.

The more serious mesosystem issues for middle-aged persons result from their participation in the economic institution. The competing demands of work and family life can be especially acute for younger middle-aged parents. The major issues are usually defined in terms of scarcity of *time* and *money.* Time is in short supply due to the dual demands of needing to prove oneself at work and the tremendous time it takes to parent young children. Money is obviously in short supply due to the fact that, while younger middle-aged

couples desire and need to make large purchases such as a home, furniture and automobile, they have not had the time to accumulate much financially. As persons reach midlife, patterns may have been developed where much more time has been given to work than to family life. Those who have devoted long hours at their jobs when they reach midlife realize that they have *spent little time with their children.* Some find that when they attempt to reach out to their now nearly grown children, their children are not responsive, and the parents have had little actual influence over them.

At the macrosystem level the rapidity of social and technological change ushers in a variety of stressors for midlife persons. Personal and occupational crises develop when people are unprepared for the changes taking place in their world. Persons in the labor force today are especially vulnerable when the job they have been trained for can *become obsolete* due to the latest technological innovation. Automobile workers, for example, experience understandable anxiety when realizing that robots can do the type of work they were trained to do. A similar anxiety plagues white-collar workers when they witness a computer doing the work previously done by ten people. Persons at managerial levels fear being overtaken by younger, better-trained college graduates who have received specialized training that was not a part of the curriculum when they were in school. Changed social norms may cause some men to fear that this young college graduate may even be a woman.

Societal norms define success in terms of employment advancement to higher status and earning capabilities. Midlife can be a time of crisis for the individuals who realize that they will *not reach the lofty goal* that they have set for themselves. The crisis can be intense for those who believe reaching a particular goal is the criterion on which they willing to accept themselves as worthy and valuable. Not reaching the goal in this case is a crisis in self-esteem. Other persons may feel that they accomplished

their best work at an earlier age and that life is now downhill and boring. The term *career burnout* has been coined to refer to such situations. Other midlife persons compare the progress of their career with the progress of others of a similar age and become discouraged because they have not accomplished as much. Such persons experience a crisis because they feel that they are *not on schedule.* Still others have dedicated themselves to the hard work needed to climb the occupational ladder and find that they are unable to settle back and relax when they are off work or on vacation. The crisis in this case is that they have become a slave to work and career. They are *workaholics!*

Does Intelligence Change with Age?

To understand the relationship between intelligence and aging, it is important to know how stable intelligence is over the human lifespan. In their attempt to answer this question Deary, Pattie and Starr (2013) calculated correlations for a sample of 109 individual intelligent scores between age eleven and age ninety. While they found a correlation of .54, which is generally considered to be strong (correlations range from a low of .0 to a high of 1), their finding does leave room for variation in individual stability in intelligence.

While it has long been assumed that intelligence declines with age, longitudinal research indicates that the decline is more gradual than previously assumed. Furthermore, decline is not even across all areas of intellectual functioning, occurs later than thought, actually increases in some respects and varies greatly from person to person. Evidence indicates that cognitive abilities related to daily living and work do not peak at young adulthood but continue into middle adulthood (Willis, 1989).

John Horn's (1982) distinction between *fluid intelligence* and *crystallized intelligence* is perhaps the most meaningful contribution to understanding cognitive changes in middle and older adulthood. *Fluid intelligence* refers to the abilities used in new types of learning activities such as inductive reasoning, memorization and rapid perception of spatial relationships. The evidence points to this type of intelligence reaching its peak in late adolescence. *Crystallized intelligence* includes the abilities to analyze problems, make judgments and draw conclusions based on information and knowledge gained from past experience. There is evidence that crystallized intelligence continues to increase across the lifespan as long as a person is open to social, educational and cultural experiences. Ritchie, Bates, Der, Starr and Deary (2013) report that "education is associated with higher later life intelligence, but not with faster cognitive processing speed." Gow, Corley, Starr and Deary (2013) identified *social network* and *support factors* as predictive of higher cognitive abilities in old age. They report that "loneliness, social support and living arrangement were most consistently associated with aspects of cognitive ability in older people, and these associations appeared to be partly, though not wholly, accounted for by symptoms of depression" (p. 454).

Changes in cognitive skills also need to be understood within a cultural context. It is possible that middle-aged and older adults experience *obsolescence* as the rapid accumulation and application of knowledge renders the education they received as youth and young adults out of date. The ability to learn and use computer skills is a case in point. I (Jack) have more than once asked my sixteen-year-old grandson to bring me up to speed in utilizing my computer. It was also quite a shock to observe my three-year-old grandson using a computer-generated learning program. But can an old dog be taught new tricks? In actuality there seems to be an interaction between the effects of *obsolescence* and

decreased *fluid intelligence*. Yes, middle and later adults are at a cognitive disadvantage because they did not learn today's knowledge in their formative years, but they also may have some declining capacities in memory and inductive reasoning. The interaction between these two factors may combine to yield what is perceived to be resistance to change or creativity among middle- and older-aged adults.

Believing that traditional ways of conceptualizing and testing for intelligence is inadequate, some have proposed new models for conceptualizing intelligence. Most suggestions point to the need for assessing a more *practical intelligence*, one that tests mental activity that successfully involves adapting to the environment. Birren (1985), for example, suggests that traditional intelligence tests might be limited because they fail to assess *competence*. Sternberg (1986a) suggested that there are three kinds of intelligence. *Analytical* intelligence refers to the analytical abilities to evaluate, judge, compare and contrast. *Creative* intelligence involves the ability to originate, invent, design, create and imagine. *Practical* intelligence consists of the ability to implement, apply, use or put into practice. Sternberg (1999) claims to have identified a combination of strengths in intelligence: some people are high in each of these three types of intelligence, others are high in several and still others are high only in one. Gardner (1983) has also proposed that intelligence is far more multidimensional than traditional intelligence tests would suggest. He argues that intelligence consists of the following "frames of mind": *logical-mathematical, linguistic, visual-spatial, musical, bodily-kinesthetic, interpersonal* and *intrapersonal* intelligence. Gardner believes that on any given task an individual is likely to draw on a number of these types of intelligence.

In a useful summary of the evidence on adult cognitive functioning, Lemme (1999) contrasts the *decrementalist view*, that cognitive development in adulthood follows a pattern of

universal, inevitable decline, with the *continued-potential view.* While this latter view acknowledges that cognition declines in adulthood, it also recognizes that some cognitive skills may continue to improve with age, and that some new cognitive abilities may even increase. Since fluid intelligence is more biologically based, its decline corresponds with physiological decline. Crystallized intelligence, on the other hand, is more experientially based and thus tends to remain stable or even improve with age.

The above evidence may lead us to ask if cognitive development really does end with *formal operations* as suggested by Piaget. Although the evidence does not call for a new stage of cognitive development, it does suggest that "the capacities of formal thought may be applied in new contexts during adulthood" (Lemme, 1999, p. 149). Cognitive development in adulthood is *quantitative* (what one knows) rather than *qualitative* (how one knows it). The cognitive advantage that goes along with aging is experiential or practical knowledge.

Parenthetically, some researchers do believe evidence exists for *postformal thought.* Lemme defines postformal thought as "an increasing relativism, the realization that real-life problems do not always have absolute answers, that contradiction and uncertainty are realities of life, and that knowledge and reality are only true temporarily" (1999, p. 150). Much of the argument for a postformal stage among adults has the ring of postmodern relativism, in contrast to the certainty of modernity (formal thought). Arlin (1984) suggests that problem-solving operations may be replaced with *problem findings.* In naming the stage after formal operations, Riegel (1973) even suggests that poor performance by adults on intelligence tests might better be interpreted as their ability to see alternatives beyond formal thought and a reflection of a more advanced stage of development—*dialectical operations.*

Emotional Intelligence

Emotional intelligence (EI) has emerged as an alternative to an exclusively cognitive conceptualization of intelligence. Although EI has been popularized by Daniel Goleman (1995), the formative model has been developed by Peter Salovey and John Mayer (1990). In essence, EI is *the ability to process emotional information, particularly as it involves the perception, appraisal and expression of emotion, emotional facilitation of thinking, understanding and analyzing emotions, and the management of emotion to promote emotional and intellectual growth.* In a practical sense, EI involves having the emotional sensitivity and mental ability to manage life in a way that will lead to emotional and relational stability, and thus happiness. This involves knowing how to identify healthy feelings, and how to turn negative feelings into healthy feelings. The finding that emotional intelligence is inversely related to depression (Lloyd, 2011) leads to the suggestion that identifying persons with low emotional intelligence "may provide the foundation for a non-pharmacological option for the treatment of late life depression" (Inglese, 2013).

The emergent thinking on EI is especially relevant to our conceptualization of the reciprocating self as it changes over the lifespan. More than any other way of conceptualizing intelligence, EI is directly related to the process of developing and maintaining a healthy and strong reciprocating self. In fact, we suggest that EI and the reciprocating self are highly correlated. Note how the follow characteristics and abilities encompassed by emotional intelligence are also an integral part of a developed reciprocating self:

- the ability to identify emotions in oneself as they are related to feelings, thoughts and behaviors
- the ability to identify emotions in others, including the ability to read facial expressions, body language

and tone of voice

- the ability to express emotions accurately, including wants, desires and needs
- the ability to discern between honest and dishonest expressions of feelings in oneself and in others
- the ability to stay open to all feelings, unpleasant as well as pleasant
- the ability to interpret the meanings that the emotions of self and others convey regarding relationships
- the ability to understand complex feelings, such as simultaneously feeling love and hate or surprise and fear
- the ability to recognize likely transitions among emotions in self and others
- an elaborated languaging ability that allows one not only recognize but to distinguish between feelings by labeling them

Each of the abilities in the above list directly contributes to the development and maintenance of reciprocating relationships and a healthy reciprocating self. It can be argued that these abilities might more accurately be conceptualized in terms of *wisdom* rather than intelligence. It might be best to respect the conventional way that intelligence is conceptualized, while arguing that there is a human quality beyond mere intelligence—wisdom—that is even more important than IQ in constructing meaningful relationships.

Does Wisdom Change with Age?

The short answer to this question is yes but with qualifications. Webster, Westerhof and Bohlmeijer (2014, p. 209) found that "middle-aged adults scored higher on wisdom than younger and older adults." They argue that wisdom increases with life experience, but that aging dampens openness. This may be related to Depping and Freund's (2012, p. 349) theory that decision making tends to be different among the elderly than among the young. Since decision making is based on weighing potential gains against potential losses, and the ratio of gains versus losses declines with age, "goal orientation changes from a predominant orientation toward gains in young adulthood to an increasingly stronger orientation towards the prevention of loss in older adulthood." This would explain the decrease in openness among the elderly.

Wisdom has emerged as an important concept in understanding human development (Baltes & Freund, 2003; Baltes & Staudinger, 2000). In an article reviewing the study of wisdom, Bangen, Meeks and Jeste (2013, p. 1254) reveal that subcomponents of wisdom include "knowledge of life, prosocial values, self-understanding, acknowledgment of uncertainty, emotional homeostasis, tolerance, openness, spirituality, and sense of humor." Wisdom can be defined as "knowledge about fundamental pragmatics of life and implementation of that knowledge through the life management strategies of selection, optimization, and compensation" (Baltes & Freund, 2003, p. 23). Note that this definition contains two components. First, there must be a *knowledge* about what is good and right in life. Second, there must be a *practical ability* to use that knowledge.

Wisdom as knowledge is unfortunately not automatically translated into wisdom as wise behavior. The latter may in fact be the more problematic aspect of wisdom. It is perhaps for this reason that Baltes and Freund (2003, p. 29) elaborate on how wise behavior as "a specific strategy of effective life management" develops. Three fundamental

processes of lifespan development regulation are identified—*selection, optimization* and *compensation. Selection* refers to the life-management task of *developing, elaborating and committing to goals*, which serve to give direction to development and a focusing on resources needed to reach those goals. In a religious context, for example, if being rightly related to God is identified as a primary goal, then all of life's activity and involvement will be *selected* in terms of how they affect this goal. *Optimization* refers to the process of *acquiring, refining, coordinating and applying the relevant means or resources to attain the goals selected*. Being rightly related to God may call for any one of a number of *optimizing resources*—meditation, prayer, chanting or singing, worship, Bible reading (perhaps even learning the biblical languages), silent retreats and so on. *Compensation* refers to *using alternative means to maintain a given level of functioning when existing means are lost*. For example, with declining eyesight and impaired physical mobility, an elderly person may come to rely on listening to tapes, radio or television programs instead of Bible reading or church attendance as a means of maintaining and nourishing their relationship with God.

Parenthetically, this suggestion is a significant modification of cognitive-development theory in which development is conceptualized primarily in terms of rational functioning ability. Rather than being "the idea of a fixed and domain-specific end state as conceptualized by Piaget or Erikson," wisdom, it is suggested, is a desirable end state of development (Baltes & Freund, 2003, pp. 26-27). Introducing the concept of wisdom results in a more dynamic and fluid conceptualization of human development and human strengths. Baltes and Freund argue that the "development of a culture of old age has lagged behind," for although older people may not be genetically well-equipped for old age, "older people are expected to continue to actively participate in social life and to optimize their level of

function" (2003, p. 24). These authors point to wisdom as the advantage elderly need in order to optimize their level of functioning in later life. A *culture of wisdom* is the optimal context in which elderly persons need to live. This wisdom culture consists of "an expert knowledge system about the fundamental pragmatics of life, including knowledge and judgment about the conduct, purpose, and meaning of life" (p. 27).

Na, Varnum, Kitayama and Nisbett (2013, p. 944) report that "wise reasoning is associated with greater life satisfaction, less negative affect, better social relationships, less depressive rumination, more positive versus negative words used in speech, and greater longevity." On the other hand, "there was no association between intelligence and well-being" (p. 944) Baltes and Freund (2003, pp. 27-28) suggest that the core domain of wisdom addresses important and difficult questions and strategies about the conduct and meaning of life; includes knowledge about the limits of knowledge and the uncertainties of the world; represents a truly superior level of knowledge, judgment and advice; constitutes knowledge with extraordinary scope, depth, measure and balance; involves a perfect synergy of mind and character (an orchestration of knowledge and virtues); represents knowledge used for the good or well-being of oneself and that of others; and though difficult to achieve and to specify, is easily recognized when manifested. This list represents an attempt to describe the optimal, ideal or desirable state of human development.

We suggest that what is missing in the wisdom model presented is the acknowledgment of God or a divine Other to whom an individual can be personally related. A major corrective to the model is found in Proverbs 9:10: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom." To fear, or to have awe or respect, of God is presented as the foundation upon which all other wisdom is based.

The subject of wisdom in the Bible is primarily dealt with in the Old Testament Wisdom books (Proverbs, Job and Ecclesiastes) and in certain parts of the New Testament, most notably writing that centers on "Jesus Christ who is God's wisdom and who reveals it to us" (Goldsworthy, 1987, p. 16). As the fulfiller of the Old Testament, only Jesus Christ can provide an understanding of the full meaning of the Wisdom books of the Old Testament.

The word *wisdom* (or *to be wise*) is used over four hundred times in the Bible. While many of these refer to *knowledge* of what is good and right, many also refer to how a person is to *practically live out* that knowledge. In Scripture, making the right decision and living the right way is linked with wisdom. Note, for example, Matthew's parable of the wise and foolish builders (Mt 7:24-29). While a wise man builds his house upon a rock, the foolish man builds his house upon the sand. The wise person "hears these words of mine and acts on them. . . . [But] everyone who hears these words of mine and does not act on them will be like a foolish man who built his house on sand" (Mt 7:24, 26). Although Matthew begins by associating wisdom with knowledge, he quickly adds that no one is wise unless they put that knowledge into practice. Thus Baltes and Freund's assertion that wisdom includes the two components of *knowledge* and *practical abilities* comports very well with a biblical perspective on wisdom.

Outside of the Gospels, 1 Corinthians 1-2 most directly addresses the issue of wisdom. The heart of the Corinthian passages can be summed up in 1 Corinthians 1:20: "Has not God made foolish the wisdom of the world?" We could wrongly conclude that Paul is discounting the value of any "worldly wisdom." In truth, all of us have absorbed and depend on much "worldly wisdom" in our daily living. The wisdom described in Baltes's model is valuable; those who have more of it are better off than those who have little. Goldsworthy (1987) helps us understand the difference between such worldly wisdom and godly wisdom by summarizing Paul's

assertions on the two kinds of wisdom mentioned in 1 Corinthians 1–2:

> First, Paul says that the gospel would be emptied of its power if he were to preach it with eloquent worldly wisdom (1:17). This is because the wisdom of the world judges this gospel, the message of the cross, to be foolishness (1:18). Such wisdom is therefore doomed to perish (1:19). Worldly wisdom is actually foolishness because it cannot put man in touch with reality by bringing him to God (1:20-21a). God's way of salvation through the preaching of Christ crucified is an offence to the Jews and stupidity to the Greeks, yet it is both the power and wisdom of God (1:18-24). So, that which the unbelieving world calls foolishness is in fact wiser than the wisdom of the world (1:25). Paul avoids the wisdom which the world sees as superior and persuasive, and centers his whole message on Christ crucified (2:1-4). He does this in order that faith might rest, not in man's wisdom, but in God's power (2:5). Paul's wisdom is wisdom from God which is taught by the Spirit of God (2:6-13). He who does not have the Spirit of God will never see this true wisdom for what it is (2:14-16). (p. 31)

To Paul worldly wisdom has meaning in a *limited* sense, but it falls short of God's wisdom, which has meaning in an *ultimate* sense. Paul is not saying there is no value to worldly wisdom, only that it fails to answer the ultimate questions of what meaning and purpose there is to life. The culmination of biblical wisdom is seen in the person and life of Jesus Christ, who was wholly God and wholly human. Jesus Christ modeled wisdom as knowledge *and* how to put it into practice in daily living and interaction with others. Even though Baltes's model of wisdom is limited, it is valid to the extent that it is modeled by the humanity of Jesus. Thus

we find that the “worldly” model of wisdom comports very well with a biblical view of wisdom.

While the development of wisdom comes with aging, it is a process that goes on throughout the entire lifespan. Hopefully, the end of midlife is accompanied by the recognition of others that one is becoming wise. Where there have been barriers to the development of wisdom, the mere passage to the elderly years is no guarantee that a person will become wise. Where the beginning of wisdom has emerged, the elderly years can be a time when the more routine and material concerns of life can be put aside in favor of a life in which the further development of wisdom can flourish.

11

Late Adulthood

The Senescing of the Reciprocating Self

During the last hundred years the average life expectancy has increased thirty years, in effect adding a new life-cycle stage. This last stage of life has been referred to as *The Third Third of Life* (Wright, 2012), with even an online journal called *The Third Third*—in reference to the last third of the human life cycle. Persons who have survived to the age of sixty can expect on the average to survive to the age of ninety; thus, late adulthood encompasses a wide age range. This chapter focuses on the last stage of adult life, those years that usually begin at retirement and continue until death. During the early years of development, scaffolds are dismantled to correspond to a child's developing capabilities and maturity. During the elderly years the reverse needs to take place as *senescing* (development downward) outpaces *adolescing* (development upward) (Levinson, 1996). As physical, cognitive and socioemotional capacities decline, scaffolding needs to be correspondingly constructed to care for and to meet the needs of the elderly. When deterioration is great, such as the case with dementia, there will be a corresponding decline in the capacity to reciprocate. In the declining years new types of scaffolding will need to be constructed—some within a familial context, some within the believing community and some within society

at large. A variety of issues—adjustment to retirement, health, sense of worth, meaning in life, relational intimacy, independence versus dependence and so forth—are addressed in this chapter.

As in each of the life-cycle stages, individuals vary in regard to the onset of their own developmental issues. Thus while we have addressed issues of launching children in the previous chapter on middle adulthood, for some, these may continue to be central issues during the elderly years. For most, however, the late-adult transition (age sixty to sixty-five) signals the end of middle adulthood and beginning of late-adulthood. To Levinson this is a major transition that requires a profound reappraisal of the past and an entry into a new era.

The Retirement Years

Although the age of sixty-five has conventionally been considered the age of retirement, there is no set age at which the elderly era begins. In their article "The Ever-Changing Meanings of Retirement," McVittie and Goodall (2012, p. 75) point out that the place of retirement has changed in the lives of individuals, and that "retirement can no longer be usefully taken as a single defining event" in an individual's life. In an article seeking to organize prominent theories about retirement, Feldman and Beehr (2011, p. 193) suggest a three-phase model of *retirement decision making* that involves "imagining the possibility of retirement, assessing when it is time to let go of long-held jobs, and putting concrete plans for retirement into action at present." Not surprisingly, Oakman and Wells (2013) found low job satisfaction and high social cohesion as factors predicting retirement intentions. Olesen, Butterwork and Rodgers (2012, p. 737) find that "poor mental and physical

health predict workforce departure in mid-to-late adulthood . . . (and) . . . particularly early retirement."

While in the past retirement was a threshold primarily for men, the fact that two out of every three women are employed outside of the home means that retirement issues apply to them, too. The mere *anticipation* of retirement, as well as retirement itself, can produce anxiety, as "working adults with retirement anxiety experienced information processing disruptions" stemming "from the negative emotional content linked to retirement concepts in long-term memory" (Gutierrez & Hershey 2013, p. 264). As to the connection between age of retirement and age of death, in a study that included the entire population of Norway, it was determined that age of retirement has "no effect on mortality" (Hernaes, Markussen, Piggott & Vestad, 2013, p. 586).

There is great variation in the degree of life satisfaction during the retirement years, with evidence suggesting a greater variation among men than women. For some men retirement is experienced as the pot of gold at the end of the rainbow. For others it is a difficult adjustment. The workaholic, for instance, is unable to relax and enjoy the fruit of his labor. Others may have tied their meaning and existence in life to busyness, activity and accomplishments. When they can no longer identify an objective accomplishment, they feel unfulfilled. In contrast, by their retirement age most women have developed a rich network of intimate relationships with family and friends. Thus the retirement years offer the opportunity to enjoy these relationships and spend more time with extended family, especially grandchildren. Many men, on the other hand, can claim to be intimate only with their wives, meaning they must learn to cultivate relationships beyond the world of work.

Retirement can produce stress at both the individual and marital levels. At the individual level Atchley (1982) suggests that retirement is a five-stage process beginning with the *honeymoon*, in which anticipated leisure time becomes

a reality. This is especially true of those who have worked hard all their life and were spurred on by the dream of financial security and leisure that they believed would be the fruit of their labor. For men this is often experienced as a time to "be a boy again," to pursue hobbies, tennis or golf, and to engage in leisurely travel that was not possible while working. For women leisurely pursuits are combined with the opportunity to be with family, especially grandchildren.

The *disenchantment stage* emerges when all play and leisure fails to yield a sense of purpose and meaning. Now the stimulation offered by a job might even seem appealing. To the workaholic, who has few interests outside of work or who defines self-worth purely in terms of work, disenchantment can be extreme. Some retirees get stuck at the disenchantment stage, experiencing later life as void of meaningful fulfillment.

The fortunate majority moves to the *reorientation stage*, characterized by the retiree seeking to engage in new, more fulfilling and meaningful activities. This is a transition stage that can be very brief for persons who quickly settle into a retirement pattern. If retirees do not successfully navigate this transitional stage, they may continue to be disenchanted with retirement. The retiree who reaches the *retirement routine stage* has learned to come to grips with the realities of retirement by finding activities that provide meaning and a sense of purpose. This is most possible for persons who have mastered their developmental tasks throughout life and who have created a strong and supportive life structure of family and friends. We suggest that a strong reciprocating self is vital to successfully navigating through these stages, and that, in turn, successful navigation serves to maintain a healthy reciprocating self or what Erikson refers to as ego integration.

This view of maturity, characterized by ego integration and a network of supportive family and friends, is consonant with a biblical view of spiritual maturity. The spiritually

mature individual will be an empowerer of others, seeking to invest him- or herself in others rather than needing to be served by others. The mature elderly person is able to combine the strengths of separateness and independence with an interdependence and connectedness within a network of reciprocally caring others. Such a balance between separateness and connectedness can be seen in the life of the apostle Paul. As Paul was nearing the end of his life, he prepared to pass the torch on to Timothy by writing, "The time of my departure has come. I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith" (2 Tim 4:6-7). For some there is a further stage—*termination*—the ending of retirement as an identifiable period, which can come when a person decides to return to work or when physical or mental capacities are so diminished that it eliminates retirement as an identifiable phase. We could do worse than to hold up Paul as a model of maturity during the retirement years, so when we look to the end of life we can affirm we have finished well.

Family Life

Retirement provides the time needed to reconnect with family in a way that may not have been possible during the preretirement years. The majority of retirees will be married and will have children and grandchildren. Each of these types of family relationships represents a potentially rich source of meaning and fulfillment for the retiree.

Retirement can have a positive or adverse effect on the marriage relationship. Most couples report postretirement as the most satisfying stage of marriage. Couples who are most satisfied maintain control of their time so they can engage in rewarding activities. These couples also tend to report a healthy sexual relationship with satisfactory expressions of affection and open communication, which allows them to

confidently resolve marital conflicts. In a sample of 1,502 persons age fifty-seven to eighty-five, Karraker and DeLamater (2013, p. 142) find that "29% of the married persons report no sexual activity for the previous 12 months or more"; not surprisingly, the lowest sexual involvement is correlated with increased age and poor physical health. Characteristics of highly satisfied couples include good health, financial security and involvement with church and friends (Iveniuk, Waite, Laumann, McClintock & Tiedt, 2014). Attitudinally such couples view retirement positively and do not view their mates as moody, stubborn, jealous or possessive (Bradbury, Fincham & Beach, 2000; Swensen, 1994).

In a less than satisfying marriage, involvement in work may have served to keep the focus off of the relationship. With increased time together the retired couple needs to confront marital issues that have been avoided in the past. Wives who enjoyed a certain degree of autonomy and privacy while their husbands were employed may experience his continual presence in the home as a bother. This is especially true in marriages where the retired husband fails to develop a network of male friends to pal around with. Retirement can increase marital control issues, a development that might be related to the finding that in the postretired marriage wives become more assertive and the marriage relationship becomes more equal (Long & Mancini, 1990).

A major transition takes place in retirement marriages when one of the spouses becomes chronically ill, making it necessary for the other spouse to assume the role of caregiver. Given that husbands are usually older than their wives and that women have a longer life expectancy, wives more often assume the caretaking role in marriage. As time and energy is focused more and more on the illness, the couple decreases involvement with other couples and friends. This is the time when an elderly couple most needs the assistance of their adult children and other family members. This is also a stage in life when childless couples

contemplate their late-life childlessness. Based on their in-depth study of such couples, Allen and Wiles (2013, p. 206) find that the conventional notion of "voluntary childlessness" is far from adequate. They report that couples "position" their late-life childlessness in a variety of ways—"as an active choice to break a family violence cycle," as "an outcome of social upheaval," as "something that felt natural within a meaningful life" and as something that "evoked feelings of both grief and relief over time." When children are not available, the caretaking spouse may become overburdened and overstressed when caring for a dependent spouse.

Grandparenting. One of the greatest potential joys in late adulthood is in *grandparenting.* Spry and active elders dressed in jeans and tennis shoes are replacing the popular image of grandparents as part of the graying, frail, rocking-chair set. In nonindustrial societies most grandparents are highly involved in the lives of their grandchildren. With parents needing to devote much time to work, the care of children and the inculcation of morals, beliefs and values are most likely to be passed down from grandparents to grandchildren. The only biblical reference to grandparenting points to the wisdom of this, as Paul writes to Timothy, "I am reminded of your sincere faith, a faith that lived first in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice and now, I am sure, lives in you" (2 Tim 1:5). Due to the decline of the extended family and the new mobility of modern life, few grandparents have the day-to-day involvement with their grandchildren that will allow them to effectively pass on their faith. As we have increasingly become a society in which both parents are working outside of the home, children are the losers; their grandparents are not present to assume the place they have had in the past in their grandchildren's lives.

Most adult children turn to their parents for help during times of stress and crisis. Grandparents are called on to

fill in the gaps and provide a significant amount of support to their children and grandchildren when divorce occurs. The role of grandparents in the lives of grandchildren can be especially meaningful at those transition points, such as leaving home, when the tensions between parents and child are at their highest. Think of the advantage for a child of any age who can draw on unconditional support and love from both maternal and paternal grandparents. Grandparents who have intense relationships with grandchildren during their childhood promote continuation of the relationship into adulthood (Geurts, Van Tilburg & Poortman, 2012a). Parenthetically it is worth noting that intense relationships between grandparents and grandchildren are predictive of adult children supporting their elderly (Geurts, Van Tilburg & Poortman, 2012b). Yorgason, Padilla-Walker and Jackson (2011) found that the emotional and financial support from nonresidential grandparents had a positive effect on their grandchildren.

As a reflection of increased family brokenness, there are an increasing number of grandparent-headed households in the United States. Grandparents who assume the responsibility of raising grandchildren face special challenges, including "financial burden, worry, health issues, and freedom restrictions" (Williams, 2011, p. 948). Drawing from a number of research studies on resident grandparents, Strom and Strom (2011, p. 910) suggest that successful grandparents are able to "establish suitable priorities, recognize the necessary adjustments in their thinking and behavior, and discover how to assess progress by being willing to amend their dreams, get to know grandchildren by spending time together, and adopt a perspective that enables management of stress."

Involvement by grandparents in the lives of their grandchildren varies greatly in contemporary societies. Neugarten and Weinstein (1964), for instance, identified five grandparenting styles—*formal, fun-seeking, parent*

surrogates, reservoirs of family wisdom and *distant figures*. The alternative styles reflect the differing circumstance grandparents find themselves in relationship to their grandchildren. For those who live a great distance from grandchildren, much must be packed into brief visits once or twice a year, meaning that they might be fun-seeking when present but distant figures the rest of the time. At the other extreme some grandparents become parent surrogates due to an inability of their grown children to parent. Regardless of grandparenting style, most grandparents can be counted on to become much more involved in their own children's and grandchildren's lives during times of stress and crisis. This is especially true when children divorce. Most grandparents give a significant amount of support to their divorcing adult children and grandchildren (Johnson, 1988). Given the amount of financial and emotional support grandparents give to married children and grandchildren, it is probably more accurate to describe the North American family as a modified-extended rather than as a nuclear family form.

Research has generated insights into the changing nature of what grandparents contribute to their grandchildren as they mature. Infant and toddler grandchildren benefit most, in the form of secure bonding, from grandmothers who provided physical and emotional care. During their early school-age years (five to ten), grandchildren most value what grandparents do for them and with them, such as showing love, giving presents and doing fun things. As grandchildren enter preadolescence they continue to value indulgent grandparents but also stress the importance of connectedness with them, and in so doing deriving a sense of family pride from their relationship with them (Ponzetti & Folkrod, 1989).

Given the often-strained nature of parent-teenage child relations, a grandparent can serve as a sensitive nonjudgmental listener to teenage grandchildren's problems and self-esteem issues, and give affirming attention to their

performances and achievements. The existence of an intimate and meaningful relationship between grandparents and teenage grandchildren can be mutually beneficial, contributing to the grandparent's mental health (Kivnick, 1982), and to grandchildren's successful resolution of adolescent identity issues (Baranowski, 1982). In relationships between sixty-five- to ninety-one-year-old grandparents and their adult grandchildren, grandparents most benefited from their grandchildren's emotional support (Langer, 1990).

A recurrent issue among grandparents who are highly involved with their grandchildren centers on boundaries. Grandparents might observe ineffective parenting methods in their grown children and think "been there, done that." Their dilemma is in deciding whether they should attempt to share their knowledge and in so doing risk being accused by their own children of interfering.

Aging Well

Before the advent of modern medicine, most people died of illnesses for which there is now effective intervention. As people are living longer, the question increasingly being raised is, "What does it mean to age well?" In an article titled "The Semantic Network of Aging Well," Fernandez-Ballesteros, Molina, Schettini and Santacreu (2013, p. 79) state that the concept of aging well refers alternatively to "healthy, successful, competent, optimal, vital, active, or productive aging." Gerontologists have traditionally focused on the negative aspects of aging, being content with "counting the wrinkles of aging" (Carstensen & Charles, 2003, p. 76). More attention has been given to elderly decline in personal functioning, psychological and social structures, and how this decline impairs the behavior of the elderly.

Although difficult life events such as retirement and bereavement can affect life satisfaction, chronological age in and of itself is not related to life satisfaction (Luhmann, Hofmann, Eid & Lucas, 2012; Poon and Cohen-Mansfield, 2011). It is interesting to note that life satisfaction is less related to chronological age than to *distance to death*—to actual time for which a person is still to live before dying (Carmel, Shrira & Shmotkin, 2013).

The focus on "successful aging" or "aging well," which began in the 1990s, has resulted in a more positive view of aging in later life (Aspinwall & Staudinger, 2003). The main components of successful aging have been identified as "low probability of disease and disease-related disability, high cognitive and physical capacity, and active engagement in life" (Rowe and Kahn, 1997, p. 143). Rocio Fernandez-Ballesteros (2003) added environmental or external variables to this list, such as access to health and social services.

With the increased lifespan, attention was initially given to the biological factors associated with aging. As it has become evident that chronic illness is "strongly associated with behavior factors such as lifestyle (e.g., diet, exercise), coping mechanisms, social networks, and social support" (Fernandez-Ballesteros, 2003, p. 142), more attention is now given to the study of social and psychological factors. For instance, in his review article "Humor and Aging," Gil Greengross (2013, p. 448) reported that "elderly people enjoy humor more than younger people, but they have increasing difficulty understanding jokes," that they "seem not to enjoy aggressive types of humor as much as the younger adults," and that "the elderly are especially sensitive to jokes referring to old age." A result of this redirected focus has been the discovery of a variety of positive aging experiences among the elderly. In one longitudinal study, most participants reported aging to be a generally positive experience (Fernandez-Ballesteros, 2003, p. 143). Cognitively, elderly persons reported having a

broader capacity for analyzing problems both intellectually and socially. Emotionally, the elderly reported feeling much more serene and relaxed than they were at previous lifespan stages. Another very fulfilling social dimension of the elderly life is relationships with grandchildren. Up until the age of eighty the elderly perceive that their gains outrun their perceived losses (Heckhausen, Dixon & Baltes, 1989).

That social interaction decreases with age is an accepted finding in social gerontology; it has been explained by a variety of theoretical models—withdrawal due to increased depression, the feeling by the aged that they have little to offer in social relationships, the death of friends, friendships impaired by sickness or cognitive decline, and social disengagement in preparation for death (Carstensen and Charles, 2003, p. 77). Laura Carstensen and Susan Charles (2003) report evidence revealing that each of these theoretical models has in fact little empirical support. Carstensen suggests that older adults are much more proactive in managing their social lives than is suggested in these theories. She finds evidence that older adults "pruned" relationships "so that only most important people remained" (p. 77). In a sample of 3,005 single individuals ages fifty-seven to eighty-five, Brown and Shinohara (2013) found that older adults actively seek out new relationship, that "14% of singles were in a dating relationship," and that dating "was more common among men than women and declined with age" (p. 1194). Not surprisingly it was also reported that compared to nondaters, daters were more socially advantaged and in better health.

The culmination of Carstensen's research was the development of a model called *socioemotional selectivity theory*, which "argues that under time constraints, emotional aspects of life are illuminated . . . [as goals] . . . shift from the search for novelty or information to the quest for emotional meaning." Thus "older people are not suffering

from limited opportunities to pursue social relations with others . . . [but] . . . are investing carefully and strategically in the people who matter most" (Carstensen & Charles, 2003, p. 78). There is also evidence that many older adults are technically savvy enough to use social media in "overcoming loneliness, relieving stress, and raising feelings of control and self-efficacy" (Leist, 2013, p. 378). Leist optimistically concludes that for older adults "online communities are suitable for providing and receiving social support when confronted with a difficult life situation, regardless of geographical location or time" (p. 578).

Needless to say, *socioemotional selectivity theory* helpfully informs us of what is taking place in the reciprocating selves of elderly persons. We can view older people as having diminished reciprocating selves. But in so doing, we should not assume that the elderly have necessarily lost personal agency. The capacity for being in interpersonal relationships with others remains, but given the decreased time left in life, the elderly become more selective and judicious in assessing the relationships worthy of investing their time. Granted, a proportion of the elderly are limited in their personal agency due to dementia and other limiting conditions, but many elderly continue to assertively act in ways that will assure maximum control over their own lives in the time they have left. What is typically defined as "stubbornness" on the part of the elderly might sometimes better be reframed in terms of selectively maintaining only that which is worth keeping in life.

Caring for the Elderly

In traditional nonurban societies the elderly are primarily cared for within an extended family unit. However, increased family complexity in modern societies makes this more

problematic—for instance, “parents with only stepchildren have worse outcomes than parents with only biological children,” and “elderly mothers with only stepchildren become disabled and institutionalized sooner, and elderly men with only stepchildren have shorter longevity relative to their counterparts with only biological children” (Pezzin, Pollack & Schone, 2013, p. 1084). In modern societies the elderly are more likely to be placed in professional retirement care communities. This change has strengths and weaknesses. On the positive side, retirement communities provide a ready-made community in which to participate and needed social and medical attention when a senior becomes less self-sufficient. On the negative side, the security that an intimate, caring family provides may be hard to duplicate in the context of larger impersonal elderly care communities. Family life has truly come full circle when a mature bilateral commitment of unconditional love between parents and their dependent children is reciprocated when the parents themselves age and become socially, emotionally and physically more dependent on their adult children.

Scripture gives some general guidance on elderly care. In 1 Timothy 5:16 Paul writes, “If any believing woman has relatives who are really widows, let her assist them; let the church not be burdened.” This advice needs to be understood in the context of Paul calling the church to care for dependent elderly who have no family. Members of the early church were called on to care for any widow who had no one to care for her, as if she were one’s own mother (1 Tim 5:2-3). If the way elderly parents were cared for during biblical times is to be taken as an ideal for all times, then the inclusion of elderly dependent parents within the adult child’s household is the ideal. When desired by both elderly parents and adult children, this would seem to be as close to the biblical ideal of cross-generational nurturing care as a family could achieve. There is a gender gap when it comes to taking care of elderly parents, as studies consistently show

that adult daughters spend more time giving assistance to their elderly parents than do sons (Sarkisian & Gerstel, 2004). Significantly, the quality of the adult daughter/elderly mother relationship was greater when there was greater similarity in religiousness (Sechrist, Suitor, Vargas & Pillemer, 2011). Given the importance of *hope* in religious beliefs, it is worth noting that a study of patients with advanced cancer shows that *hope* is an important ingredient that not only eases one's ability to cope with stressful situations, but also reduces caregiving strain (Lohne, Miaskowski & Rustøen, 2012).

However, it seems that God would honor alternative forms of elderly care systems. Given the strong emphasis on community in the Old Testament, a case could be made that the entire tribe or community rather than merely the adult children is responsible for care of the elderly. Some religious groups and denominations have established elaborate networks of retirement homes to care for the elderly, both their own and, in some cases, those who have no other source of care. Some interpret *tribe* in its broadest sense to argue that a society is morally obligated to make sure no elderly are uncared for. The overarching biblical principle seems to be that elder care should begin with family members as they are able. Given a lack of family, the responsibility then seems to fall on the believing community to care for their elderly as they are able. Only as a last resort should the elderly be placed in large institutions that are not embedded within the believing community. On a practical basis, a variety of social, psychological and economic circumstances need to be taken into account in deciding the best way to care for an elderly person. Along with a variety of circumstances and needs, we believe that God will honor alternative structures of care. At the very least, however, it seems to us that societies that build "safety nets" for the weak, homeless and uncared for are reflecting the biblical ideal most closely.

Demographers warn that modern societies in the future will be characterized by an "inverse pyramid" in which a greater proportion of the population are elderly. It is estimated that by the year 2040, over 20 percent of all people in the United States will be sixty-five or over (Hargrave & Hanna, 1997, p. 42). Some believe that due to the lengthening life expectancy, over half of the population will eventually be affected by such diseases as Parkinson's, Alzheimer's and other forms of dementia. The cost of maintaining this cohort of nonworking elderly, many of whom will live into their eighties and nineties, may exceed the combined funds available through Social Security and retirement accounts. Not only can medical expenses during the final years of life be enormous, but placement in a convalescent home can average around fifty thousand dollars a year. People who have worked hard and saved money over a lifetime can see their nest egg vanish in a very short time due to medical expenses.

Creating zones of proximal capabilities. Pruyser (1975, pp. 107-18) some years ago suggested that the elderly person is a mirror image of the child, only in reverse. The elderly must cope with three potential stress-producing transitions, *physical decline and disability*, *mental decline and dementia*, and *death.* While the child begins helpless and moves toward self-sufficiency, the elderly person is self-sufficient but devolves toward helplessness. While the child gains increasing mastery over objects in the environment, the elderly person has decreasing capacities over the objective world. While the child increases in security and self-respect, the senior becomes more insecure and loses self-respect. While the child has the security of dependency and moves toward independence, the elderly begins with security but experiences the insecurity of moving toward dependency.

Vygotsky's *zone of proximal development* refers to the range of skills that a child can accomplish only with the assistance of another (see chapter 4, p. 96). The task of parenting, caretaking or teaching is to build scaffolds that

enable a child to perform a task just beyond their present capability, but the scaffolding needs to change as the child begins to accomplish the task without assistance. Given the mirror image of childhood and the aging person, we suggest adapting Vygotsky's model to include the concept *zones of proximal capabilities.* By identifying such zones among the elderly, help—scaffolds—can be provided that will allow elderly persons to continue to accomplish tasks.

Elderly persons who experience a decrease in skill-oriented capacities have an increased need for scaffolding. Although it may appear that the caretaking of the elderly is the same as the caretaking of children, there is one significant difference. While children are on a trajectory toward increased task and skill development, the elderly are on a trajectory toward decreased task and skill capability. We suggest zones of proximal capability as a useful way of conceptualizing the range of tasks and skills that the elderly are capable of with the assistance of others.

Numerous examples of zones of proximal capability can be found within "assisted living" programs. Based on their study, Gronstedt, Frandin, Bergland, Helbostad and Granbo (2013, p. 220) conclude that "individually tailored intervention in nursing home residents focusing on physical and daily activities is effective in improving transfers, balance and physical activity level compared to usual care." Seen through the lens of the zone of proximal capability, the legitimate goal of assisted living is to allow the elderly to continue to do as much on their own as they are capable of doing. As they are able, the elderly must be allowed to be responsible for daily tasks such as personal grooming, dressing, preparing and eating a simple meal, driving to the store for groceries, and so on. With decreasing capabilities, the elderly may be able to continue living independently with assistance with some of these tasks. Delivery of a hot meal through Meals on Wheels is a good example of an assistance program that allows the elderly to continue to live in their

own home. Door-to-door shuttle transportation likewise allows the elderly who can no longer drive a car to continue to participate in a wide range of community activities while still living on their own.

Recognition of zones of proximal capability encourages caretakers to assess the present capabilities of the elderly and in the process to anticipate their future needs. If the minimum amount of assistance needed is given, then the maximum amount of elderly independence is likely to be kept intact. Elder care can err in two directions—by either *under*building or *over*building scaffolds. An elder whose need for assistance is underestimated may become frustrated, fearful and hopeless. But if the assistance is overestimated, the elder may experience helplessness, worthlessness or overdependence. Due to their size and impersonalness, institutional care may not provide elaborate enough scaffolding. On the other hand, family caretakers, because of their emotional involvement, are most likely to construct excessive scaffolding.

The best examples of institutional care are those with gradated comprehensive-care communities. At one level of these institutions, the living units for the most self-sufficient elderly merely serve as a convenient place to participate with similarly aged, self-sufficient people. With decreasing capabilities and increasing needs, residents can move to more intentional care units where they can draw on a wide range of services—meals, laundry, household cleaning, transportation, daily physical assistance and so forth. The emergence of dementia or severe physical limitations usually means moving to a care unit that provides even more intense personal care. Finally, a hospital care unit is provided for the most needy. Such gradated comprehensive-care communities may come the closest to providing appropriate scaffolding for the elderly. The best of these have ongoing built-in assessment programs capable of anticipating the increased needs of the elderly.

Parenthetically, it is easiest to illustrate a zone of proximal capability by using physical- and motor-skill-oriented examples, as we have done, but the elderly's need for relational scaffolding might be even more important. Research reveals that loneliness and lack of meaningful interpersonal relationships are among the greatest reported difficulties among the elderly. Although elder persons residing within caretaking communities need interpersonal scaffolding, those elders outside of such communities need it even more. Scripture has much to say about including the elderly as family. In the case of those who have no family the church needs to be the family of God for them.

The relationship between coping and health is cyclical. It is not only true that healthier persons are better able to cope but also that the act of coping contributes to the health of the individual (Whitbourne, 1996, p. 91). When caretakers offer a helping hand too quickly, they may be inadvertently hindering the elderly from maintaining health. Caretaker intervention might be most needed when the elderly resort to the unhelpful coping strategies of denial or withdrawal. In such cases, caretakers who do nothing may actually be enabling unresponsiveness because they fail to encourage the elderly to confront a stressful situation.

In his study of how organization systems care for the elderly as they decline, Candrian (2014) suggests that too often the goal within such caretaking systems is to *tame death*. While understandable, an unintended consequence of *taming death* is to relieve dying persons from participation in the choices and struggles of their own dying process. The creation of *zones of proximal capacity* is vital in assuring that persons at the end of their life are treated with dignity and included in their own dying process as much as is able.

The Diminishing Reciprocating Self

Physical, psychological and *social* capabilities in the aging process reflect self-identity of the elderly. Although we might expect these three sources of identity to be interrelated, there is evidence that elderly persons are capable of drawing on their one source of greatest strength (Whitbourne, 1996). In a study on how the story of aging is told, it was found that in the narratives of elderly persons the body is often split from the mind. In the narratives that our elders create, the body ages, but the self remains ageless. The self seems to be disassociated from the body, able to have a younger identity than the aging body would suggest (Oberg, as reported in Ruth and Vikko, 1996). Jan-Erik Ruth and Anni Vikko suggest that hope may occasionally be maintained in later life by repressing awareness of the present and instead remembering a younger, more active and well-functioning self (p. 177). Included in this, we suggest, is the ability to maintain a strong reciprocating self in the face of physical deterioration.

Now that I (Jack) and my wife are in our late seventies, we sometimes kid each other about having a "senior moment" when we temporarily cannot remember the name of an acquaintance. This is a normal (we hope) part of the aging process and is not to be confused with more serious forms of dementia such as Alzheimer's disease. It is estimated that, assuming current trends continue, by 2050 over fourteen million people will be victims of Alzheimer's (Frishman, 1997). Although there is much we could say about dementia among the elderly, we will focus our remarks on the theological questions posed by this condition, which seriously erodes the reciprocating self.

In chapter one we rejected a material body-nonmaterial soul dualism in favor of a nonreductive physicalism in which there is no soul, but rather suggested a human being having soulishness. Forms of dementia, such as Alzheimer's, are

capable of seriously robbing a person not only of memory but also of other mental processes. It seems obvious that the effect of these diseases is to diminish the capacities of being a reciprocal self. Given the emergent-functions model summarized in chapter one, it might be legitimate to say serious dementia affects one's soulishness. It would be wrong, however, not to view such a person, regardless of the effect of dementia, as a soul to be nurtured and cared for. The medical ethicist Stephen Post states, "The moral task is always to enhance the person with dementia" (Brown, Murphy & Malony, 1998, p. 201). Our commitment to a Christian ethic of agape means that regardless of an individual's emotional or intellectual capacities we will have utmost concern and compassion for every human being. It might even be argued that the soulishness of a person, regardless of the severity of the mentally incapacitating disease, is maintained by the love and care shown by a human community.

Death and Dying

Although death may come at any age, dying as a self-conscious drawn-out event is most common in the last phase of elderly life. Since dying elicits all sorts of emotions and reaction, it is worth considering what it means to die well. The most widely known model for understand a person's reaction to death is that proposed by Elizabeth Kübler-Ross (1970). In her five-stage model, Kübler-Ross posits an initial stage of *denial*, where a person rejects the reality that they are going to die. This is followed by *anger*, which can be directed at anyone or everyone—spouse, children, God or people in good health. In the third stage, *bargaining*, the dying person may try to negotiate a way out of death—resolving to stop smoking, to eat healthier foods or by promising God to live a better life. *Depression*, the fourth stage, can be both a reaction to the sadness associated with

the losses already experienced and an anticipation of future losses, such as not being able to see one's grandchildren grow up. When a person has worked through this depression, which can be a quick or slow process, the stage of *acceptance* is reached. This model, which is based on firsthand observation of how people die, has greatly influenced how we think about the process of dying.

In his attempt to develop a theology of death Ray Anderson builds on three relevant scriptural truths:

> That the body and soul alike are subject to death; that there is no dualism between the immortal soul and the temporal body; and that the individual's hope for redemption from death lies in God alone, who is the Lord of both life and death, rather than in personal immortality as an essential aspect of human existence. (1986, p. 45)

As a ministerial application of these truths, Anderson argues for a "human ecology of death and dying"—for a network of caring human beings to surround the dying person. We see this as consistent with what we have suggested about the maintenance of the reciprocating self. It is essential for the living to remain in community with the dying, for it is in the context of community that the self of the dying remains reciprocal.

Before his own untimely death in an automobile accident, Mansel Pattison was one of the leading Christian psychiatrists in the world. Several years before his death Pattison (1977) proposed an insightful theory of the dying process that is consistent with a biblical view of death and dying. Pattison suggested that all people project a trajectory of their life that includes an anticipated lifespan within which their lives and activities are arranged. This trajectory is suddenly challenged when the *probability* of a premature death is known. The person cannot

continue to live according to the constructed trajectory but must re-vision the trajectory. The period between the *crisis created by the knowledge of death* and the *point of death* is referred to as the *living-dying interval.* Pattison divides this interval into three phases, the *acute crisis phase,* the *chronic living-dying phase* and the *terminal phase.*

Pattison's key contribution is the importance of the reaction of the caring community to the dying person. He emphasized that it is crucial that the family or support system help the dying person respond positively during the acute crisis. A positive response will result in *integrated dying*, a negative response will result in *disintegrated dying* during the chronic living-dying phase. The end result, *termination*, ranges from being peaceful on the one hand to isolation, loneliness or terror on the other.

I (Jack) have witnessed events leading to integrated dying in my own Christian community. Several years ago the wife of a Fuller Seminary professor was told that she had terminal cancer and would die within several months. On learning this, the couple planned to return to Australia where both of their extended families resided. During their ten years of living in Pasadena, California, the couple had developed a rich network of caring friends. Before the couple left for Australia, small groups of their friends were invited into Julie's bedroom for a time of farewell goodbyes and prayer. After Rob and Julie moved back to Australia, their families were able to give the support and comfort she needed to move into the inevitable terminal phase. Through much grieving and many tears, Julie's entire network of friends and relatives, both in the United States and in Australia, joined with her in the *integrated dying* process.

In a disintegrated dying process the dying either shut off family and friends or the family and friends shut themselves off from the dying. Either way, the result is not to die well.

Pattison also provided helpful insights into understanding differing paths or patterns of death. This he does by suggesting that one might distinguish among *sociological death* (people withdrawn from the dying), *psychic death* (the patient acquiesces), *clinical death* (the brain ceases to function) and *physiological death* (the body dies). One path of dying involves first sociological death, followed by psychic death, then clinical death and finally physiological death. Another path involves first giving up (psychic death), followed by sociological death, both occurring long before clinical and physiological death. Another path of dying is for the patient and family to refuse to accept the probability of death, resulting in severe shock when physiological death does occur. In other cases the dying may reject life (psychic death), but family and friends tenaciously try to rally around the dying to motivate the person to live. A final path entails the family's refusal to accept the fact of both psychic and clinical death, resulting in the patient being kept alive physiologically by artificial means.

Although death can be a relief in the case of a severe illness, it usually comes as a numbing shock to a surviving partner. Free from responsibility with children and work, the lives of elderly partners usually revolve around each other, often resulting in mutual emotional dependency. Grief from the loss of a spouse can take the form of crying, anxiety, depression, sadness, loss of appetite, weight loss, sleep disturbances, tiredness, declining health or interest in life, and severe loneliness. Although loneliness reduces physical activity and is related to mortality among the elderly, "being happy may offset the negative consequences of being lonely" (Newall, Chipperfield, Bailis & Stewart, 2013, p. 921).

Due mainly to the wider supportive network of friends that characterize widows when compared to widowers, women adjust better to living after the death of their spouse. Older women

also gain independence through social networks due to their greater potential to "have bridging potential in their networks—between both kin and non-kin contacts" (Cornwell, 2012, p. 782). When compared with married women of the same age and life circumstances, it takes from two to eleven years for the psychological effect of a husband's death to disappear among widows (Heinemann & Evans, 1990).

The Old Shall Dream Dreams

In a multitude of ways aging has an accelerated diminishing effect on the elderly, as the rate of diminishment speeds up during the elderly years. However, it would be a mistake to end this chapter by only documenting the diminishing capacities of the elderly. In the previous chapter we suggested that wisdom increases with age and is the desired end state of human development. This is a welcomed counterexample to thinking of the elderly years only in terms of diminishment. Growing old can literally be a *growing* process in which a human rises above temporal concerns by growing closer to God. Quoting the prophet Joel, Acts 2:17 says, "Old men shall dream dreams." In commenting on this, James Loder states,

> To say the elderly will dream dreams is not a description of dementia setting in, as if they were drifting further from reality. Actually, the tone of the passage is thoroughly positive, triumphant, and focused on God's version of the future; their dreams occur because they are drifting closer to reality. This part of the passage refers to the privilege of the aging person to allow dreams, often God's language to his people, to speak beyond the organic condition and the present perceptions of circumstances about the time to come. (1998, p. 316)

Loder (1998, pp. 323-26) suggests that by focusing on elderly losses, it is possible to fail to recognize their gains in competence. One of these gains can take the form of *simplification*, as the elderly have less material and ego needs. In "Aging: Downward, Upward, or Forward," Paul Pruyser suggests eight ways simplification can be realized in aging. The first is to give up stubborn insistence on independence and accept some assistance as wholesome. The second is to let go of the tendency to maintain one's status in society through more meaningful definitions of what it means to "make it" in life. Third, ego individuation becomes more possible since one's self-esteem is less dependent on what others think. Fourth, an acceptance of failures and ambiguities in life allows relaxation of one's defenses. Loder suggests that as defenses relax, "the human spirit can be released into the assurance of forgiveness and God's providential care" (1998, p. 324). Fifth, work can be integrated into life instead of held separate from life and used to define self-worth. Sixth, the aged also have the privilege of living in the present without being anxious about the future. Seventh, having given up responsibility for the future, the elderly can invest themselves in the dreams of the younger generation without self-interest. Finally, the aged have the freedom to disclose their inner thoughts.

Taken together the above points can be understood as tasks of the elderly as they work toward ego integration. Within Erikson's perspective, an elder who does not develop these tasks risks ego despair. From a biblical perspective a person gains life by losing it—by dying to self and all of the symbols associated with self-importance. In dying to self, one finds oneself, a particular self that is anchored and maintained in a relationship with God. In old age people need no longer attempt self-validation through deeds and actions but can claim self-worth and identity that is derived from their relationship with God.

It is not necessary, of course, for a person to reach his or her elderly years before developing the tasks that will contribute toward ego integration. Hopefully, these processes are part of lifespan development during the middle years. Old age merely brings with it the type of psychosocial conditions that may make it more possible.

From a Christian perspective true ego integration means that our self-identity is centered in the person of Jesus Christ. This is the developmental teleology of the model we have presented. The goal of development is to be a reciprocating self in relationship with God and others.

A self that is truly centered in Christ can even embrace death, not in a morbid way but in the assurance that when death comes he or she will be in the presence of Christ. The Christian's identity is found in being raised in Christ. As Paul writes in 1 Corinthians,

> This perishable body must put on imperishability, and this mortal body must put on immortality. When this perishable body puts on imperishability, and this mortal body puts on immortality, then the saying that is written will be fulfilled:
>
> "Death has been swallowed up in victory."
>
> "Where, O death, is your victory?"
>
> "Where, O death, is your sting?" . . .
>
> But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ. (15:53-55, 57)

Part III

Building the Scaffold: Applications for Ministry

THE BOUNDARIES IMPOSED BY naturalistic assumptions generally limit discussions and understanding of human development to the contributions made by socio-psycho-cultural and physiological factors. In part three we attempt to correct this limitation by focusing on the moral, spiritual and religious dimensions of human development. In chapter twelve we utilize such concepts as moral identity and moral transformation in attempting to move the understanding of moral development beyond a traditional cognitive stage-development model. In chapter thirteen we try to move beyond a traditional cognitive model of faith development by focusing separately on spiritual and religious development. We utilize the concept of a differentiated faith in attempting to describe the reciprocal self as reflective of a biblically anchored understanding of faith. A truly differentiated faith will find residence in a faith community. Chapter fourteen in turn focuses on the nature of the reciprocating religious community. Based on the theological insights of such theologians as Jürgen Moltmann and Miroslav Volf, we find the trinitarian model of relationality to be appropriately applicable to the lived-out body of Christ. Given the obvious focus in this book on development throughout human life, this chapter includes

discussions of *intergenerational reciprocity* and *congregational differentiation.*

The source of the model we propose for the church—the body of Christ—is thus the same as for individual human development, which is not found in human wisdom but in the very relationality of our triune God, and in the relationship God seeks to establish with us.

12

Special Issues in Human Development

Morality

As with religiousness and spirituality, morality is a uniquely human phenomenon that defies simple psychological explanations. The reciprocating self is unquestionably a moral self, capable of making both mundane and complex moral decisions leading to specific actions or consequences. Yet despite best intentions, human behavior will always reveal an earthy mixture of failures and successes. Consequently, it is essential to remember that the reciprocating self as *imago Dei* is a self under construction, already beloved by God in the present but not yet transformed into eschatological perfection. Barth underlined the source of this transformation with clarity when he observed that in Christ we are presently bound to the person of God (Barth, 1961). This reciprocating vision of *sanctification* includes moral transformation and renewal. In a Christian sense the psychology of moral development should be premised on an understanding of reciprocity as sanctification.

With this theological provision we will turn to the problem of moral functioning in the development of a reciprocating self. Because our interest in sanctification reflects a concern for the integrity of Christian witness, we

want to find out what motivates and sustains exceptional moral behavior. For the theologian this task requires further work on doctrines of reconciliation, sanctification and justification. For us the task relates to moral judgment and processes associated with the reciprocating self. One way to explore these processes is to consider those individuals who demonstrate outstanding moral functioning capable of making a difference in the lives of others.

Lawrence J. Walker, a leading moral psychologist, notes that outstanding moral functioning might differ considerably depending on context. A college undergraduate worker with the Mennonite Central Committee might function morally on behalf of marginalized indigenous peoples in Chiapas, Mexico, by seeking *justice* for fair treatment. A middle-aged man might act morally by diving into a fast-moving river after a drowning child, an act of spontaneous *bravery.* Or an emerging adult woman might forfeit a lucrative career as a lawyer to live in community with the developmentally disabled, *caring* deeply for their needs. Whereas moral reasoning is important to each of these scenarios, it is likely that sustained behaviors in each area reference a deeper point where moral goals, values and spiritual commitment are known in terms of personal identity or reciprocating self. What then is the role of the reciprocating self in moral functioning?

In order to better understand moral functioning and the reciprocating self, we will take a brief tour of the moral psychology field. Our tour will cover three sections. First, we will consider the work of Lawrence Kohlberg and Elliot Turiel. Kohlberg's emphasis on justice, reasoning and moral judgment in human development was enormously influential, leading to Turiel's work on social domains of morality. Despite the rich theoretical contributions of Kohlberg and Turiel, their work is limited in helping us to understand how the reciprocating self is related to moral functioning. Second, we will examine moral identity as a theory and then in the lives of morally outstanding individuals reported in

the work of Anne Colby and William Damon (1992). Moral identity is implicated as a subset of the reciprocating self, and is typically preceded by experiences of transformation. Finally, we will conclude with a discussion of recent research with caregivers in L'Arche communities for the developmentally disabled.

Lawrence Kohlberg and Elliot Turiel

The roots of Lawrence Kohlberg's theory of moral development are clearly found in Piaget. This lineage makes it necessary for us to briefly review Piaget's ideas of moral development. Piaget interpreted ethical action in terms of *moral judgment.* Moral judgment represents the application of human reason in order to obtain the best (moral) solution to any situation. Piaget's thinking reflects the strong rationalism of the Enlightenment, including thinkers such as Immanuel Kant and René Descartes. For Piaget all humans are capable of reason and therefore of moral judgment. Consequently, the best means to understanding moral development include the use of *dilemmas* or hypothetical problems that require the application of moral judgment through problem solving.

Based on his work with children in the 1930s, Piaget observed two general stages of moral development. Piaget's observations were premised on the means by which children deal with dilemmas. For children under the age of ten, dilemmas were resolved by rigid and unbending application of rules. Rules provide a framework for understanding the consequences of any action for the younger child. Kela is a six-year-old girl who lives in New York City. Kela hears two stories that together represent a dilemma. In the first story a boy is helping his mother to make cookies. During their activity he accidentally bumps a shelf loaded with porcelain cups. The shelf is upended and the cups slide off, hit the

floor and shatter into pieces. Twelve cups are broken. In the second story another boy knocks a single cup off the same shelf while trying to steal a few cookies. Kela is asked which of these two boys behaved the worst. She immediately concludes that the child who broke the most cups was most misbehaved. Kela makes this moral conclusion on the basis of raw consequences (broken cups) instead of referencing motivation relative to the boys and their behavior (Piaget, 1932/1965).

After a transition around the age of eleven, Piaget observed that children apply their growing sense of abstract thinking to moral dilemmas with altered effect. With the advent of formal thought, older children and adolescents reach different conclusions about the same dilemmas. If Kela happens to be thirteen years old, she might view rules not as fixed benchmarks but as general guidelines to help human beings get along together. Thus rules are capable of bending where motivation becomes a higher or more abstract basis for moral standards. In the above scenario Kela might judge the boy who was stealing cookies to be the most misbehaved. Kela explains that the broken cups are accidental in both instances. However, the first boy is motivated to help his mother. This caring posture carries more moral currency than the thieving boy of the second story. Whereas the first boy accidentally causes more damage than the second, this issue is peripheral to his good intentions.

Some thirty years after Piaget's initial observations of children, Lawrence Kohlberg worked to establish a stagelike framework for morality in human development. Kohlberg began by interviewing adolescent and preadolescent boys from urban Chicago. Like Piaget before him, Kohlberg presented participants with a hypothetical dilemma designed to access the child's moral processing. In the now famous "Heinz dilemma," participants were asked to respond to an awful conundrum. Heinz's wife is near death from cancer. A new drug is capable of fighting the cancer, but it costs a small

fortune. Heinz cannot afford the drug, and fruitlessly attempts to borrow the money from local townsfolk. Heinz pleads to the pharmacist to purchase the drug at a lower rate, but the pharmacist wants to make a profit and is unrelenting. Heinz ends up breaking into the pharmacy and stealing the drug for his wife.

Obviously, the Heinz dilemma has no simple right or wrong answer. This is by design; Kohlberg sought to use the dilemma as a means for understanding how children and adolescents apply reasoning through moral judgment. Kohlberg and his team noted a range of participant responses to the Heinz dilemma. He organized the responses into a taxonomy or classification framework for moral judgment. To provide a check and balance against his own subjectivity, Kohlberg asked other psychologists to organize the same response data. The result was a six-stage framework for moral development that is widely known in psychological, educational and theological circles. As with Piaget before him, Kohlberg's stagelike framework assumes incremental change across the lifespan, although it is not expected that everyone will reach the highest levels of moral development (Kohlberg, 1984; Kohlberg & Diessner, 1991). Kohlberg's scheme builds on the justice ethic of Kant, emphasizing more and more abstract solutions to hypothetical dilemmas as evidence of moral maturity.

Stage 1. Preconventional (obedience and punishment). This is the moral-judgment orientation of early childhood. Like Piaget before him, Kohlberg noted that the child makes moral judgments with rules foremost in mind, particularly when immediate consequences are evident. A stage-one response to the Heinz dilemma might include the child's insistence that stealing is against the law and therefore wrong. Despite the motivational issues behind Heinz's action, the child is unwilling to justify the man's behavior. Because Heinz failed to obey the law, he should be punished.

Stage 2. Preconventional (individualism and exchange). Stage two represents a more finely nuanced understanding of

moral judgment than in Piaget. For this stage Kohlberg noticed that older children are able to make sense of the fact that different people have different viewpoints. A child's response might focus on the fact that the pharmacist perceived Heinz's action as wrong, but Heinz did not see his theft as wrong. Preconventional moral judgment at stage two emphasizes the individualistic needs and self-interests of other people. In this case the child understands that Heinz badly needs the drug. The drive for fairness makes its presence felt in the moral judgment of the child. Heinz made a fair offer for the drug, but the pharmacist was unwilling to make an exchange. Heinz's offer justifies his decision to break the law.

Stage 3. Conventional (interpersonal relationships). Kohlberg noted that children in early adolescence demonstrate more abstract moral judgment, following the pattern outlined in Piaget. Now Heinz's motivations are clearly a basis in forming moral judgments. Participant responses at stage three emphasized Heinz's good intentions to save his wife. Responses also noted that the pharmacist had poor intentions, namely, to profit on the new cancer drug at the expense of human life. Some respondents became visibly angry at the pharmacist's refusal to cut a deal with Heinz, a result of their ability to take on the perspectives of others. Participants were well aware of character traits in all of the dilemma's personalities and formed abstract conclusions that were conventional by virtue of the fact that anyone would have a right to do what Heinz did. Kohlberg found that stage-three moral judgment is often found in adults as well as adolescents (Kohlberg, 1984).

Stage 4. Conventional (maintaining social order). Kohlberg argued that more advanced conventional thinkers (typically adults) made moral judgments about society as a whole. Heinz is recognized for his good motives in a no-win situation, but this knowledge is balanced with a greater appreciation for maintaining social order through the

maintenance of laws and societal responsibility. These thinkers are fairly sophisticated in their ability to hold the many tensions of the Heinz dilemma in balance, but they tend to favor social order against a single exception such as Heinz. Thus these respondents tend to reason through the issues in a manner resembling stage-one conclusions that Heinz's actions are still against the law. Unlike the young child, however, these people understand the more abstract reasons that laws exist and the social order that they serve.

Stage 5. Postconventional (social contract and individual rights). Beyond stage four, Kohlberg noticed that some individuals use the Heinz dilemma as a way of considering what constitutes a good society. For this respondent (almost always an adult), moral judgment is applied on the basis of societal goodness, recognizing that social order does not necessarily mean that a society is a decent place to live. Respondents cited fascist and communist societies as examples. Usually this line of thinking includes some consideration of individual rights and the means by which democratic principles can be enlisted to ensure maximum respect for everyone. These respondents pointed to the wife's right to live as a moral imperative. Thus Heinz's actions were strongly justified in this view.

Stage 6. Postconventional (universal principles). Kohlberg identified stage six as a "dilemma-busting" perspective similar to great moral philosophers such as Immanuel Kant (Walker and Pitts, 1998). Like Kant, respondents articulate their own philosophical principles that define justice, not only for Heinz and his wife but for society as a whole. Moral judgment results in universal conceptions of what is just for everyone. This perspective recognizes that all people have value and should be treated accordingly. These respondents argued that the wife's life is the higher good above the values of commerce and financial transaction.

The elegance of Kohlberg's moral-judgment scheme quickly influenced a generation of thinkers. Many scholars and educators immediately found real-world application for the six stages, which turned up in curricula for moral education, assessment instruments and even theories of spiritual development (Fowler, 1995). However, the magnitude of Kohlberg's influence also made his scheme the object of criticism. Gilligan (1982) noted that Kohlberg focused primarily on boys in his early studies. Gilligan argued that morality took a different developmental course in girls, who emphasized caring principles over the stark justice of Kohlberg's moral-judgment paradigm. Turiel (1983, 2015) contended that moral judgment in fact arose through different domains of thinking. Known as *social domains*, Turiel (2015) revised and extended Kohlberg's work, arguing for structural-relational reciprocity between the agent and the other characterized by abstract moral reasoning and judgment. Social domains do not include personal concerns or values, which are referred to as *conventions* reflecting social contracts and exchange. Rather, social domains are highly specific categories of moral reasoning lodged in harm/welfare, rights and justice. To illustrate, a Turielian perspective would identify the phrase *It's not right for you to hit my friend* as moral and *It's not right for you to call our teacher by her first name* as conventional. The "big three" domains of harm, rights and justice, true to their origins in Enlightenment philosophy, were considered universal. Cultural differences were irrelevant to the primacy of moral reasoning and judgment framed by domains.

Turiel's project made good theoretical and intuitive sense. However, a serious problem gradually emerged with the heavy emphasis on abstract moral reasoning. A number of studies suggested that moral reasoning and judgment could be elegantly categorized through child and adolescent development in terms of social domains, typically where children respond to abstract dilemmas. Yet a growing body of

evidence suggested that moral reasoning and judgment provided weak or even null association with real-world moral action (Blasi, 1980; Colby & Damon, 1992; Hart & Fegley, 1995; Krebs & Denton, 2005; Walker, 2004). Children and youth with high scores on social domain indices of moral reasoning were not observed to behave differently in the real world than children and youth with much lower scores. Moreover, exemplary individuals renowned for humanitarian justice, bravery, compassion and moral fortitude were found to score in the average range on moral reasoning and judgment scales. These findings were punctuated by a startling finding that patients with serious damage to the prefrontal cortex of the brain could score quite high on abstract moral reasoning scales and yet were plagued by grossly unethical behavior in the real world, including lying, stealing and cheating (H. Damasio, 2002).

Walker (2014) correctly diagnoses the problem, noting that Kohlbergian stages and Turielian domains of reasoning

> require one to act from obligation and against one's personal inclinations, which essentially eliminates the motivation to be moral. The fundamental flaw is their contention that morality should not be self-regarding. These approaches reflect the intellectual legacy of the Enlightenment Era with its dualistic conception of human nature that pitted reason against passion with its narrow (formalist) definition of morality that excluded a broader consideration of the self or personality. The moral agent is left disembodied and enervated by these models. (p. 433)

Walker's comments are rooted in Augusto Blasi's seminal critique of Kohlberg and Turiel. Blasi argued that moral reasoning is only obliquely related to moral functioning. Blasi (1980, 1984) proposed a "self model" of moral functioning emphasizing the importance of *responsibility* in

mediating between reason and behavior. In the model an individual's fidelity to responsible courses of action must be consistent with personal goals, values and beliefs. Blasi argued that being moral in the end is an extension of one's self as expressed in identity. Blasi (1984) suggested that *moral identity*, or those features of a reciprocating self that support the flourishing of others in a manner consistent with one's personal goals, values and beliefs, constituted a stronger basis for understanding moral functioning.

Blasi's argument for moral identity became increasingly convincing given a growing body of empirical evidence suggesting that justice-oriented moral reasoning was only a small component in moral functioning. One of Kohlberg's students, Daniel Hart, tested the importance of reasoning and judgment with morally outstanding adolescents in the early 1990s. Hart decided to study youth from Camden, New Jersey, one of the poorest urban zones in America. Hart reasoned that moral features of a reciprocating self would clearly stand out where adolescents demonstrated high moral functioning despite difficult personal circumstances. Using criteria established by local Camden social workers and youth leaders, Hart and colleague Suzanne Fegley located fifteen adolescents in Camden that demonstrated outstanding moral and caring commitments (Hart & Fegley, 1995). These remarkable youth took leadership in caring for infirm parents and family members, and volunteered service to the poor in their neighborhoods. Hart and Fegley matched these exemplar youth to fifteen everyday kids from the same urban locations. All youth were given lengthy face-to-face interviews along with Kohlberg's moral-judgment interview (Kohlberg, 1984).

The Camden study surprised everyone, even its authors. Exemplar adolescents from Camden were clearly different from others in the manner by which they thought about the self, others and relationships. Their moral functioning was exceptional. Yet these exemplars scored no differently than others on Kohlberg's six-stage scheme of moral development.

Both exemplars and comparisons were mostly at the stage-three (conventional) level of moral judgment and reasoning. This meant that Kohlberg's assumptions regarding moral judgment in general and justice in particular may have less to do with the developmental processes that coincide with moral functioning. Even more important, moral judgment is only moderately able to sustain individuals in their caring commitments over time (Hart & Fegley, 1995; Reimer, 2003; Walker & Frimer, 2007).

The Camden study serves as a reminder that the development of moral functioning is highly complex, reflecting varied contexts of influence significant to a reciprocating self. Moral identity might be understood as a domain of the reciprocating self forged in the context of relationships with others who are capable of providing moral influence. Whereas the self and its reciprocating processes are more difficult to study than moral judgment, it may be that the moral-identity perspective is a logical next step beyond Kohlberg, particularly in an interest to avoid "losing the person at the center of morality" (Blasi, 1984, p. 138).

The Development of Moral Identity

Moral functioning might be understood as a universal human phenomenon, yet the details of how it is formed in a reciprocating self are likely based on context. Developing moral commitments appears to defy any single formula or combination of religious, cultural and educational influence. What developmental similarities can we identify that might indicate the origins of moral identity? In response to this question, we will suggest that exemplars typically become extraordinarily moral because of experiences of transformation. Additionally, we will argue that social influences (such as those found in families or communities) help to sustain moral functioning over time.

Moral transformation. Early theoretical work on moral identity implied a reciprocating self behind moral commitment. Moral identity was thought to arise on the basis of social influences (Blasi, 1984). These influential relationships were somehow able to change an individual's personal goals around explicitly moral concerns. In a famous American study, Anne Colby and William Damon (1992) conducted detailed interviews with individuals nominated on the basis of outstanding moral functioning. Individuals noted experiences of personal *transformation* when social influences altered their personal goals and commitments. Generally, these experiences of transformation were gradual, where social influences caused exemplars to reevaluate their capacities and define new strategies to achieve goals. The most potent social influences came from relationships where exemplars were challenged to grow and change. Over time, exemplars experienced successes in their work on behalf of others, learning to integrate their reciprocating selves with moral action.

Colby and Damon (1995) give an example of this process. In an exemplar interview a woman known for her care for the developmentally disabled told of how she began her career as an elementary school teacher. A mentor at this stage of her life encouraged her to take a job with dyslexic children because she needed work. In the context of the job the mentor helped the woman develop new skills and interests centered on the needs of the disabled. This gradual experience of moral transformation led to a complete restructuring of her personal goals around the care of those with profound disabilities.

The astute reader might ask whether the process of transformation leading to moral identity simply reflects a developmental transition up the "ladder" of Kohlberg's six-stage scheme. As in the Camden youth study, Colby and Damon (1992) gave exemplars Kohlberg's moral-judgment interview. Despite the remarkable achievements of the

exemplar group, half scored at the conventional level (stages three and four). This is exactly the same finding made by Kohlberg himself when he randomly interviewed adults from the general populace over a twenty-year period (Colby et al., 1983). Essentially, exemplars did not score differently from the general populace in moral-judgment level or sophistication. It seems that the transformational processes leading to moral functioning are integrated on the basis of reciprocating self-related processes rather than the ability to reason effectively about moral dilemmas.

It is likely that processes of transformation leading to moral-identity formation are cued by emotions that accompany the individual's experience of influential relationships. Eliana is a fifteen-year-old girl who lives with her mother and brother in a four-hundred-square-foot room in a very poor neighborhood of a large American city. Almost single-handedly Eliana began a neighborhood program to care for the elderly in a convalescent hospital about three blocks away. A year after its inception her program involves many people in relationships with infirm seniors. Eliana was interviewed in her tiny apartment while cockroaches climbed the walls and music blared from the apartment next door. In response to a question regarding how she came to identify herself as a caring person, Eliana's eyes grew misty:

> I would like to be a person like my mom. She doesn't let herself go by what people think of her. She lets herself go by what she thinks of herself and she doesn't do like most people and judge people by what she sees. She judges them by what they think and the way they are. This is how I learned to care. (Reimer, 2003, p. 131)

Eliana's relationship with her mother is deeply influential. It is clear that Eliana's representations of self are framed in terms of her mother and that these are linked to emotion.

In the justice-oriented thinking of Kohlberg and Piaget, emotion may be an unwanted distraction to the application of moral reasoning and judgment in the face of dilemmas. Yet Eliana's reciprocating self is evidently able to make excellent decisions that lead to moral functioning in spite of, or perhaps because of, intense emotion related to representations of her mother. This paradox should give us pause with regard to the place of emotion in moral reasoning and, potentially, transformation anticipating the development of moral identity in the reciprocating self.

Recent work in the field of cognitive neuroscience suggests that emotion is a critical factor in the development of moral functioning. The renowned neurologist Antonio Damasio (1994) retells the unfortunate story of Phineas Gage, a twenty-six-year-old railroad foreman in mid-nineteenth-century New England. Leading work crews in New Hampshire, Gage won a reputation as a diligent, conscientious boss who took personal interest in his men. Gage was an expert in tamping blast powder for controlled explosions to dislodge rock impeding the progress of the rail line. Using a meter-long iron rod, Gage would carefully tamp powder into small holes bored around the perimeter of large rocks. One day Gage accidentally struck flint with the side of his tamping rod, resulting in a premature explosion. The force of the blast drove the rod completely through Gage's skull, entering at a point beneath the left cheekbone and exiting through a quarter-sized hole in the top of his head. Incredibly, Gage survived his wound and recovered from the incident. However, it soon became evident that he had been altered by the injury. Gage was no longer able to make positive decisions about matters of relational and financial significance. His previously cherished moral standards and work ethic evaporated. Gage was not able to hold a job, could not execute the most basic plans, was insolent and uncaring toward his fellows, squandered his money, and left his wife for a life of promiscuity. After a brief career as a circus-

show freak, he died penniless and in obscurity some seventeen years later.

Damasio (1994) observed that Gage's injury was to the prefrontal cortex of the brain. A close comparison of Gage's skull to other similarly injured patients revealed that the brain's central processor for emotion, the limbic system, had been badly damaged. Damasio's patients evidenced many of Gage's symptoms. After their injuries, prefrontal-damaged individuals failed to work conscientiously, were impaired in their ability to realize goals through planning and effort, had poor social skills, and were dramatically affected in their moral functioning. Damasio and his wife, Hanna, gave several of these patients Kohlberg's moral-judgment interview, asking for responses to the Heinz dilemma (H. Damasio, 2002). Patient responses to the moral-judgment interview were entirely normal, demonstrating conventional-level (stages three and four) reasoning when matched to a comparison population without prefrontal brain injury. Yet despite this performance, patients continued to struggle greatly in attempts to achieve personal goals, living an uncaring and immoral existence.

From these findings Antonio Damasio (1994, 2002) proposed that mental representations of self and others are stored in episodic memory on the basis of emotions. These *somatic markers* of emotional memory help individuals confronted by morally significant circumstances to consider a range of facts, personal goals and options toward a positive response. Anticipated consequences are evaluated on the basis of emotion-labeled representations that recall similar situations, dilemmas and outcomes from the past. Moral reasoning pertinent to Kohlberg's dilemmas is for the most part unaffected by the absence of somatic-marker representations. However, *this deficit makes the regulation and motivation of caring behavior extraordinarily difficult*. Thus it would seem that the process of transforming personal

goals into moral ones might require a considerable degree of emotional regulation.

In Eliana's case, transformation of goals might happen where she is able to recall past situations experienced with a particular emotion or set of emotions. Cognitively, Eliana weighs the goals that were significant to her in the past with her present circumstances. This process of goal evaluation is emotion-cued and may result in the alteration of her present goals based on past experience, her present situation and her ability to anticipate future outcomes. Somatic markers of emotion provide Eliana with cognitive guideposts that outline the similarity of her present circumstances to past situations, and the possible options that best incorporate her goals and priorities consistent with a caring, reciprocating self. These emotion representations become Eliana's gut instinct that motivates her to care even when circumstances might suggest otherwise.

Damasio's findings (1994, 2002) raise the possibility that individuals with high moral functioning undergo transformation of personal goals through a cognitive process that links past, present and future with emotion-cued mental representations. Transformation may reflect cognition of broad dimensions, where moral judgment is augmented by emotional connections of social influences and experiences significant to the caring self. Thus moral development might at one level be aligned with the onset of autobiographical memory in middle childhood, leading to an increasingly sophisticated reciprocating self.

Moral identity in L'Arche. In their 1992 study of American exemplars, Colby and Damon (1992) made an unexpected finding that sent ripples throughout the field of moral psychology. The majority of the exemplars in the study reported faith in God. It turned out that faith proved a major inspiration to care and a general support for moral functioning. Many exemplars in the Colby and Damon (1992) study were detailed and explicit in accounts of how God's

influence was the basis for their moral identity. Most devout Christians would find this to be an intuitive if blatantly obvious connection. But for a secular psychological community the Colby and Damon (1992) discovery was something of a surprise. In one account a woman known as the "Queen of the Dump" spoke revealingly about her remarkable outreach to children living on top of a Mexican landfill:

> I used to get away from the house and away from my kids and I used to ask the Lord "Am I in the right place? Is this where you send me?" Because if I didn't have that vision I would have gone back because of what I was going through. But now my faith is stronger. See, at that time when I started it was weak. I was just going by that vision. (Colby & Damon, 1992, pp. 44-45)

With generous grants from the Fetzer Institute and John Templeton Foundation, I (Kevin) considered moral action in a unique setting—one informed by faith. L'Arche communities for the developmentally disabled are probably best known through the writings of Henri Nouwen. These ecumenically Christian communities provide a unique opportunity to explore the relationship between spirituality and moral functioning. *L'Arche* (French for "the ark") is an international federation of more than one hundred communities in thirty-five countries that cares for persons with developmental disabilities. Although officially ecumenical, L'Arche is predominantly Christian in ethos and Roman Catholic in practice. L'Arche is the genius of Jean Vanier, Canadian philosopher, religious leader, statesman and activist. In 1962 Vanier established a residential community for the disabled that was marked by relational commitments of altruistic love, not simply from caregiver assistants to the *core member*, as the disabled are known, but in mutual exchange between assistants and core members. Vanier's mission with the developmentally disabled led to a philosophy

of agape love as the redemptive element in L'Arche communities where

> everyone is of unique and sacred value, and everyone has the same dignity and the same rights. People with a mental handicap often possess qualities of welcome, wonderment, spontaneity, and directness . . . able to touch hearts and call others to unity through their simplicity and vulnerability. In this way they are a reminder to the wider world of the essential values of the heart without which knowledge, power, and action lose their meaning and purpose. (Charter of L'Arche Internationale, 1993)

In L'Arche communities, assistants and core members live peacefully together, sharing faith and everyday experience. L'Arche assistants are widely considered to be living altruists, given the scope of their moral commitment (Post, 2002). Some leave lucrative careers to serve in L'Arche. Assistants are invited to participate in community on the basis of theological commitments. Individuals are asked to carefully weigh their commitment in terms of a *calling*, which is typically ratified in year-long increments that require periods of spiritual *discernment* prior to renewal. In his many books outlining the philosophy and spirituality of L'Arche, Vanier describes a *downward mobility* of care and compassionate commitment:

> We live in a world of competition, where importance is given to success, a good salary, efficiency, distractions, and stimulations. Our world, however, needs to rediscover what is essential: Committed relationships, openness and the acceptance of weakness, a life of friendship and solidarity in and through the little things we can do. It is not a question of doing

> extraordinary things, but rather of doing ordinary things with love. (Vanier, 1999)

The grant-funded studies of moral identity in L'Arche focused on assistants. What motivates individuals to give up so much in order to serve others in this way? What sustains these individuals in their moral commitments? We might consider the example of "Tina," a long-term L'Arche caregiver assistant with a painful history (Reimer, 2009). Years spent in L'Arche shifted her sense of self-worth in positive directions, importantly through an altered understanding of personal pain after watching the disabled core members working through their own struggles. The disabled keenly understand what it means to be perceived as different or potentially defective. In the unique context of L'Arche, Tina moves through an incrementally transformative process. She observes that *tolerance*, previously a cherished value for relationships with others, carries a toxic double standard. Tina could easily extend tolerance and acceptance to others, but in the early years was incapable of extending these values toward herself. For Tina, the disabled core members modeled a better way. Through their example, she finds herself increasingly able to authentically extend tolerance both inwardly and outwardly.

This transformative process yields changes in Tina's capacity for moral action. Self-conscious emotions, introduced in the lifespan chapters, are capable of influencing personal goals linked with the moral self. This can cut in multiple directions. The tragedy of Phineas Gage and Damasio's brain-damaged patients suggests that when the capacity for self-conscious emotions is restricted, the self can quickly become untethered from moral goals. Remarkably, moral reasoning is relatively unaffected. But the individual's capacity for compassion or morally altruistic behavior is potentially compromised. Self-conscious emotions such as shame, guilt and pride provide reinforcement for

goals affiliated with moral action involving others (Reimer & Reimer, forthcoming). Reinforced goals help to define the reciprocating self. We can consider this at a practical level through Tina's valuation of tolerance. Even though Tina was a tolerant person upon arrival in L'Arche, she was disabled in her capacity to make tolerance a self-referencing value. But this begins to change with months and years spent living in community. Tina's experience in L'Arche teaches her that others sometimes wake up in a bad mood. They struggle with their own personal sense of shame. No matter how things might superficially look, people shouldn't be judged too quickly. They are still beloved of God. Tina begins to realize that she too is beloved of God.

An upshot of this discussion relates to the accumulation of memories that record situations instructive to Tina on matters of tolerance and self-affirmation. She may find herself confronting a distraught core member wielding a large stick. In that moment, Tina remembers similar situations from the past along with self-conscious emotions capable of aligning self with tolerant and compassionate objectives. In the moment she slows herself down and considers that the core member deserves tolerance in the same manner as she does. She can extend tolerance to the extent the core member doesn't threaten Tina's sense of self as worthy of tolerant acceptance. Tina is able to invite the core member to sit down for a chat. She respects and honors the issues living beneath the difficult behavior. This core member may have missed regular medications or endured conflicts at work. There may have been a trigger event related to something in his difficult past. Tina's goal to extend tolerant acceptance is reinforced by realigned emotions, no longer dominated by personal shame but now a sense of pride that her actions can make a tangible difference.

Tina's movement toward a mature compassion is evident in her growing ability to trust others. Trust is perhaps the most evident fruit of transition from debilitating shame to a

place of empathic and compassionate maturity. Tina's growing capacity to trust others emerges from a stable moral identity. Her reciprocating self is established on goals reinforced and sustained by self-conscious emotions, principally pride and guilt (Reimer & Matusba, 2012). Trust catalyzes the ability of L'Arche community members to adopt the perspective of others, thereby better understanding how to respond with genuine compassion. In reciprocal fashion, community members come to know themselves and others more intimately. Trust flourishes. It becomes easier to extend forgiveness, knowing the full range of another's hurts and fears. Perhaps the most profound manifestation of compassionate love in L'Arche encourages L'Arche core members and assistants to adopt the perspective of others, using that knowledge to compassionately loving ends. Perhaps unexpectedly, community members come to better understand themselves through this knowledge of others. It is much easier to trust when individuals first know and trust themselves.

Bowlby observed realignment of goals with self as part of childhood, framing this process as a function of attachment. Securely attached children are presumably able to trust. This capacity propels maturation, particularly as children develop the ability to understand what things are like for their parents. It is much harder for children to have a tantrum or create an argument if they can understand that mom feels terrible because of the flu, or dad recently lost his job. Knowing the good intentions of others quickly changes the picture. Shared, reciprocating identities are built on common goals. Bowlby called this process a *goal-corrected partnership*. Such partnerships are common in L'Arche, notably between caregivers like Tina and disabled core members. Tina and core member Alfred share a common identity of empowerment and recovery from painful histories. This identity is premised upon shared goals such as persistence, fortitude and conscientiousness. With time, Tina's personal

goals are refashioned on the basis of partnerships with other assistants and core members such as Alfred. In the case of L'Arche, these goal-corrected partnerships elicit new possibilities for relationship and healing—opportunities characterized by compassionate love.

Concluding Thoughts

We have considered the importance of moral functioning in a Christian psychological project, reviewing the developmental argument for moral judgment in Lawrence Kohlberg. Recognizing the limitations of Kohlberg's paradigm, we considered moral identity as a way of thinking about the reciprocating self through relationship with others. For adolescent and adult exemplars alike, moral identity unfolds in the context of transformation and social influence. These contextual factors are experienced, recorded in memory and are cued by emotion. Perhaps most significant of all, in many instances moral identity is related to our knowledge of God in relationship. With this in mind, we turn now to consider the developmental significance of God's influence in human affairs.

13

Reciprocating Spirituality

PEOPLE ARE SPIRITUAL. THEY ARE RELIGIOUS. They have been since the beginning of the human species. Surprisingly enough, until the last decade, if you were to scan the existing research in developmental psychology, you might think otherwise. Not until about the year 2000 did developmental scientists start to take this aspect of being human seriously. Fortunately, that is not the case for Christians (and of course followers of other religions)—we have been thinking about, writing on, experiencing and practicing spirituality and religion for hundreds of years. Given the recent surge in empirical research in the areas of spirituality and religion during the last decade, this chapter might be the most significantly modified from the original edition of this volume. Not only is it the most drastically updated, but it also offers a somewhat unique perspective from the others. One of the main purposes of this book is to provide a *theological perspective* of psychological approaches to human development. In contrast, this chapter actually takes a more theological subject—faith—and emphasizes a *psychological perspective* on something central to the Christian experience.

Overview

In this chapter we review current religious and spiritual trends and overview psychology's touch-and-(mostly)-go relationship with transcendent domains of study such as spirituality, religion and faith. Next, we present the most recent formulations of spiritual and religious development present in the psychological literature. As the crux of the chapter, we offer *reciprocating spirituality* as a conceptualization for understanding the complexity and richness of humankind's engagement with the transcendent and explore how it might develop and take shape through the interaction of individual factors and one's interaction with their developmental systems. In this discussion we emphasize the potentially developmentally rich context of religion. We conclude with a biblical reflection on the God's role as Father, Son and Holy Spirit in our personal experience of reciprocating spirituality.

Landscape of Spirituality and Religiosity

Although spirituality and religion have been a central part of people's lives for thousands of years, the study of spiritual and religious development remains significantly underexplored within psychology compared to other more traditional domains of study like cognition and identity. The paucity of research on a central element of human functioning within the developmental sciences is surprising considering that youth and adults alike report high levels of religious beliefs and participation. A 2013 Pew Research Center poll found that 90% of respondents in the United States believe in God or a universal spirit while slightly more than 78% belong to a particular religion. This same study found that 35% of respondents pray multiple times per day while 42% pray at most once per day. Twenty percent of respondents said they "seldom" or "never" pray. Another Pew poll conducted in 2014 found that nearly a quarter of Americans (22%) attend

religious services once per week. Eleven percent of respondents attend services more than once per week, while 16% attend one to two times per month, 21% attend “a few times per year,” 16% “seldom” attend and 13% “never” attend. Seventy-eight percent of respondents in a June 2012 Pew poll said they consider themselves spiritual people, while 37% are “spiritual but not religious.”

In regard to adolescents, Benson, Scales, Syvertsen and Roehlkepartain (2012) conducted a “global portrait” of youth spirituality among 6,725 youth ages twelve to twenty-five, spanning eight countries across five continents.[1] The results suggested that spirituality and religion are relevant to many of the world’s youth, with 77% of youth indicating some type of religious affiliation. Furthermore, most participants indicated that the following aspects of spirituality were important life goals: following God or a higher power (61%), feeling close to God or a higher power (65%), and praying, meditating and studying sacred texts (69%). The most representative study of religion in American youth documented that the vast majority of adolescents (84%) affiliate with one particular religious group (Smith & Denton, 2005).

Among those who are not religious, most self-identified as “just not religious” (10%), “atheist” (1.5%) or “agnostic” (1.5%). The remaining 3% of “non-religious youth” seemed uncertain, suggesting some adolescents may have “unexplored” religious identities.

Although research documents the prevalence of religion and spirituality among people on this planet, it is important to note that these trends are changing. As previously mentioned, religious attendance is decreasing. This trend is not only apparent over time regarding age differences, but also in regard to historical time periods. Teens attend religious services less frequently as they get older through about age thirty, the age when people seem to go back to church. Then

religiousness generally increases throughout adulthood as people age. Additionally, Child Trends' (2014) analysis of Monitoring the Future Data demonstrates that, like the adult population (Pew Forum on Religion & Public Life, 2012), the numbers of religiously unaffiliated adolescents are increasing. Although still relatively religious in comparison to other developed nations, US adolescents show a high degree of diversity in affiliation, including a growing number who self-identity as spiritual, but not religious. For example, in the National Study on Youth and Religion (NSYR) 8% of the sample responded "very true" when asked if they considered themselves "spiritual but not religious" and 46% said "somewhat true" (Smith & Denton, 2005).

Historically Not "BFFs" (Best Friends Forever): Religions + Social Science

Spirituality and religion have a historic and complex relationship with the social sciences. In fact, psychology of religion predates the official founding of the American Psychological Association in 1892. Early psychologists were committed to establishing psychology of religion as a scientific enterprise. At the turn of the century William James and G. Stanley Hall and their students pioneered theoretical and empirical studies in psychology of religion. However, as the twentieth century progressed, social scientists such as Thorndike and Watson rejected spirituality and religion as a viable field of scientific study. The new behavioristic thinking of the day suggested that religion (and spirituality) belonged to the past and was not a part of the modern scientific world. Thus the academic field of developmental psychology as well as other social sciences emerged without a central concern for spirituality and religion and "grew up without interest in religion, fully committed to secular culture, and dependent on the canons of

modern science" (Kerestes & Youniss, 2002). Fortunately, the last decade has witnessed an increase in scholarship in the area.

Although most psychology abandoned the study of transcendence, the subfields of psychology and sociology of religion and spirituality remained alive (though marginalized), producing significant theoretical and empirical advances. Toward the end of the twentieth century developmental psychologists began to heed the overwhelming evidence that spirituality and religion were a significant part of life for young people and adults globally. The increased evidence in the scientific literature established a positive relation between spirituality/religion and health and well-being and decreases in risk factors and dangerous behaviors. This data, coupled with the mass media's coverage of youth violence in the 1990s, propelled further research exploring factors that promote positive development in youth.

Currently, the social sciences are experiencing a revival of interest in spirituality and religiousness. As noted, polls demonstrate that spirituality and religion are important to a significant number of adults and youth in America. Religious institutions are being recognized for playing an important civic role in society (Putnam, 2000) and, as mentioned, the current literature documents positive associations between religion and physical and mental health outcomes (see King & Boyatzis, 2015; Pargament, Mahoney, Exline, Jones & Shafranske, 2013). In fact, the percentage of peer-reviewed articles on religion and spirituality published in the six top-tier developmental journals increased by more than 50% from 1990–2002 to 2003–2012 (King & Boyatzis, 2015). That said, only 1.4% of articles from these top journals address spirituality and religion.

Given the flux in American spirituality, it is appropriate that social scientists not only track spiritual and religious behaviors and attitudes, but that they have demonstrated a new interest in understanding the nature and function of

spiritual and religious development for children, adolescents and adults (see Barry & Abo-Zena, 2014; King & Boyatzis, 2015; Pargament et al., 2013). Given the mounting evidence that the first three decades of life are particularly vital in how spirituality is developed, thwarted or misdirected, this chapter focuses on spiritual and religious development during childhood, adolescence and emerging adulthood. The radical cognitive, emotional and social growth of childhood sets an important foundation for growing spirituality. During adolescence the continued growth in these areas and the salience of the developmental tasks of exploration and identity formation force issues of beliefs, meaning, purpose and identity to be confronted during adolescence and emerging adulthood. Not surprisingly, increasing numbers of scholars (e.g., Arnett, 2000a; Barry & Abo-Zena, 2014; King & Boyatzis, 2015; Warren, Lerner & Phelps, 2012; Willoughby & Good, 2008) recognize the second and third decade of life as a particularly fertile time in the life cycle for exploring issues of spirituality and religion.

Defining the Topic

The purpose of this chapter is to address the current psychological understanding of religious and spiritual development in light of the reciprocating self. If we recognize God's intention for humans to become reciprocating selves, what does that mean in terms of our spirituality or our religious experience? Do we have a reciprocating relationship with God? How might psychologists understand this? How do other aspects of human development (e.g., cognitive, social, moral) relate to religious or spiritual development? And what is the difference between religious and spiritual development?

Before addressing these questions, let's pause for an experiment. Think of a person who is spiritual. Who comes to

mind? Perhaps someone who is into meditation, yoga, and finding strength and hope within themselves. Perhaps an environmentalist who is rejuvenated by spending time in and is dedicated to preserving creation. Perhaps you or a friend at church who has a deep relationship with God, who always seems to be able to discern the presence of the Holy Spirit in his or her life. Now, think of a person who is religious. Who comes to mind? A devoted person? An activist engaged in social justice? Is this a rule-bound person, who religiously goes to church on Sunday? Is he or she moralistic? Judgmental?

Perhaps a nun who sacrificially stays awake multiple nights a week to ensure a narcoleptic receives her medication?

How would you describe yourself?

These stereotypes about spiritual and religious people within our culture abound. We do not find these stereotypes helpful but overly simplistic. However, they are important to acknowledge because they exist. As we think about our own faith development or attempt to nurture faith in others, it is important to acknowledge the complexity and richness of spirituality and religiosity.

In general, *spirituality* is often described in personal or experiential terms; *religion*, on the other hand, generally includes beliefs, practices and rituals that are shared with a community of believers and associated with a specific religious tradition. Research suggests that for the most part Americans understand both "being religious" and "being spiritual" as distinct but overlapping constructs (Marler & Hadaway, 2002). In other words, people can be spiritual without being religious and vice versa, or they can be both.

Getting more technical, within the social sciences *spiritual* generally refers to that which is considered divine, sacred, transcendent or beyond the material. *Spirituality* refers to the human propensity to be aware of and seek after a sense of ultimacy such as God, absolute

truth, all of humanity or creation (Pargament et al., 2013). Others describe spirituality as a universal human capacity or a quality of a person's character, personality or disposition that propels and maintains this search for transcendence.

Within the social sciences *religion* is often conceptualized at the level of an organized socio-cultural-historical system and is related to a specific faith tradition that has implicit or explicit beliefs, practices and polity. For instance, a well-accepted definition of religion is the following:

> An organized system of beliefs, practices, rituals, and symbols designed (a) to facilitate closeness to the sacred or transcendent (God, higher power, or ultimate truth/reality) and (b) to foster an understanding of one's relationship and responsibility to others in living together in community. (Koenig, McCullough & Larson, 2001, p. 18)

Although an emphasis on personal and institutional levels may point to distinctions between religion and spirituality, to overemphasize this point and dichotomize the constructs is short-sighted and limits understanding of the complexity of both religion and spirituality. Religion cannot be viewed as purely institutional. Religious experiences include important individual-level processes such as selecting, interpreting and constructing religious worldviews. Conversely, when spirituality is treated as a strictly individual phenomenon, the rich and varied ways that spirituality expresses itself in intimate relationships, families, congregations, organizations and cultures may be overlooked. Personal spiritual expressions are often embedded in larger religious, social and cultural contexts. Religion and spirituality are multidimensional constructs that consist of diverse cognitions, feelings, behaviors, experiences and

relationships (King, Ramos & Clardy, 2013; Pargament et al., 2013).

According to this perspective, spirituality involves seeking transcendence and connecting to something bigger than one's self and may occur within or outside of a religious context. The latest work on spiritual development suggests that spirituality involves more than an experience or feeling of transcendence, but involves transformation and contribution. Specifically, experiencing a reality beyond the self leads to the discovery of meaning, informs one's identity and commitments, and influences how one lives in the world (King, Clardy & Ramos, 2014). We refer to this as *reciprocating spirituality*.

As we discussed in previous chapters, a relational developmental systems perspective emphasizes that development occurs through the mutually influential relations between individuals and the many levels of the ecology in which they are embedded across time (Lerner, Lerner, Bowers & Geldhof, 2015; Overton, 2015). From a relational developmental systems perspective, religious and spiritual development occur through ongoing transactions between individuals and their multiple sociocultural contexts (Lerner et al., 2003; Lerner et al., 2015). From this perspective, *religious development* can be described as the systematic changes in how one understands and participates in the doctrines, practices and rituals of religious institutions. Thus, from a relational developmental systems approach, as a young person interacts with friends, family, faith community and so on, he or she will change in beliefs, commitments and engagement in religion. This process is well recognized. Less clarity exists regarding the nature of spiritual development.

Along these theoretical lines, recent research suggests that relationality is central to spirituality. Spirituality involves seeking transcendence and connecting to or *relating* to a source of ultimacy. These systemic approaches highlight the significance of the reciprocal interactions between

individuals and their world. Transcendence involves a shifting of an individual's cognitive and emotional orientation from oneself to another in such a way that provides ultimate value and meaning beyond the mundane and material, shapes identity and motivates an active response (King et al., 2014; Lerner et al., 2008). When a person experiences a meaningful connection with something of significance beyond him- or herself (e.g., God, higher power), he or she may become aware of and feel connected to God or a divine entity, nature, a sense of all of humanity or a specific religious community. These experiences are spiritual when this "connection" between an individual and "something beyond the self" promote changes in how one views oneself and the world to the extent that one's behavior and actions are changed. Spiritual development brings about fidelity. Thus s*piritual development* is growing in the capacity to transcend the self in such a way that transforms one's beliefs, identity, commitments and behaviors.

Spirituality is more than a feeling of transcendence, but a growing sense of identity or awareness that motivates or propels young people to care for themselves and to contribute to the greater good. As such, spiritual development has been defined as "the process of growing the intrinsic human capacity for self-transcendence, in which the self is embedded in something greater than the self, including the sacred. It propels the search for connectedness, meaning, purpose, and contribution. It is shaped both within and outside of religious traditions, beliefs, and practices" (Benson, Roehlkepartain & Rude, 2003, p. 207). In her recent book *The Spiritual Child*, Lisa Miller (2015) describes spirituality as having two characteristics that are consistent with our formulation of reciprocating spirituality. She describes both (1) a relational and (2) a prescriptive component. Spirituality is a "sense of a close personal relationship to God (or universe or nature or

whatever term each person uses for higher power) and a vital source of daily guidance" (p. 7). All these perspectives affirm that spirituality involves relating to something beyond the self and also informs how one lives their life. Below we discuss how reciprocating spirituality involves transcendence, fidelity and generative actions.

Central to this understanding of spirituality is *transcendence*, the notion that an individual has an acute awareness of something or some other greater than him- or herself. In this regard, spirituality as an attribute of personhood usually relates to a manner of living that is carried out with the deep awareness of self, others and the divine. For some, spiritual development entails the ability to be connected in a meaningful way to God, to fellow believers, to all of humanity or even to nature. Some contemporary understandings of spirituality distinguish among religious spirituality, humanistic spirituality and natural spirituality (Emmons & Paloutzian, 2003).

For our discussion of reciprocating spirituality, we suggest that transcendence occurs in transactions that call forth devotion and exert ordering power on the rest of one's life and provides a sense of meaning and purpose. Although an expression of the divine is not needed to instigate spiritual development, the forces that stimulate this kind of spiritual growth are imbued with divine-like qualities, such as immanence, boundlessness and ultimacy (Pargament et al., 2013). This spiritual transcendence instigates, as James (1985) described, systemic changes within the self and leads to increases in one's awareness (Benson et al., 2012), identity (Templeton & Eccles, 2006), fidelity (King et al., 2014), purpose (Damon et al., 2003) and action (King & Benson, 2006). Not all transactions are transcendent (though maybe for Mother Theresa or St. Francis they were?). Specifically, those transactions between an individual and another (e.g., God, nature, community) promote transcendence when the interaction informs beliefs, meaning, identity,

purpose and fidelity and serves to motivate contribution to the well-being of the world beyond the individual.

Research on adolescents suggests that spirituality involves living and acting consistently with one's beliefs (Benson et al., 2012; Dowling et al., 2004; King et al., 2014; Warren et al., 2012). This is referred to as *fidelity*. Erik Erikson (1965, 1968) described fidelity as the virtue that results from resolution of the identity crisis. Fidelity is loyalty to a belief system that is so profound it informs our roles and actions. As such, it is a virtue that shapes and motivates the way we live out our life. Fidelity emerges when transcendence occurs at meaningful levels to the extent that identity is changed, commitments are made and action results. Fidelity involves clarity and commitment to a value system, helps one navigate through the waters of life and motivates a lifestyle that is consistent with our beliefs.

So an example of what fidelity is *not*: My (Pam) first concert experience was going to a Rush concert in Chicago in the early 1980s (my parents made me go—honestly!). Such a concert, with emotionally charged music and throngs of people moving to the rhythm of Neal Peart's drumming, could be said to be a transcendent experience. No doubt my cognitions and emotions were aligned with the 18,500 people at the Rosemont Horizon, now Allstate Arena, in Chicago. However, by our definition of reciprocating spirituality, this was not a spiritual experience because my identity, sense of fidelity and behavior were not changed by the concert. Now, this might not be the case for all of the attendees at the concert, but for me it was not a spiritually transformative experience.

Research has demonstrated that transcendent experiences provide meaning and shape one's sense of oneself and the world around oneself. Spirituality calls forth devotion and thus exerts ordering power on the rest of our lives and provides a sense of meaning and purpose in life. Here's an example of what fidelity *is*. Several years ago, I (Pam) conducted a study on spiritual development among youth from

different faith traditions around the globe. The study involved visiting thirty youth in their hometowns. These kids lived in the United States, Great Britain, India, Jordan, Peru and Kenya and represented eight different religions. The participants in the study were all identified through an extensive nomination process. The youth were chosen because they were recognized for living with a profound sense of spirituality in their culture (see King et al., 2014). Here's a quotation from a seventeen-year-old boy from the United States that reflects this notion of fidelity:

> It (spirituality) makes me feel like I'm in a great orchestra of people who have always been so tight and had this great sense of morality and community. And I'm just glad that I can contribute to that.

His comment reflects a sense of transcendence and connection that informs his sense of beliefs and morality. Thoughts and feelings of connection to God, nature and humanity were not only apparent in this youth's life, but so were acts of service.

Generally spirituality and religion, at least those traditions with prosocial belief systems, call people beyond themselves and to have concern and compassion for others (Fetzer, 1999). *Contribution* is the third marker of reciprocating spirituality. Beliefs and practices encourage individuals to transcend their own lives and to commit to contributing to other institutions. In an interview, the same youth above said, "My spirituality motivates me to provide impassioned service, from a religion of compassion, not of compulsion. I take all that is a part of who I am and put it into a life of service work" (King et al., 2014).

In this study on spiritual exemplars, twenty-nine of thirty youth reported being engaged in acts of service. The only one who did not was an atheist from Northern Ireland. Although not religious, he was devoted to understanding truth

with a sense of spiritual devotion. This young man, then aged nineteen, was the most unique participant in our study. He had no corporate practice or expression of his spirituality. He pursued his sense of spirituality in almost complete isolation. Given the religiously tumultuous context of his upbringing, he did not perceive his spirituality to be anything to share—not even with his family or his girlfriend. He pursued questions of truth and meaning in dialogue with a high school teacher, who nominated him for the study. It is interesting to note that his pursuit of truth did not have any ordering effect on his life's action.

An important finding from our spiritual-exemplars study suggested that coherence among beliefs, identity and behaviors is evident in mature spirituality. As such, spirituality engages many facets of the human experience. For these youth, spirituality was more than a feeling of transcendence, but instead was a means for understanding themselves and the world around them, as well as shaping their behavior. The exemplar narratives demonstrated the potential pervasiveness of spirituality. Although these youth may not be typical, they exemplify the potential complexity and potential impact of spiritual development. The extent or maturity of these young people's spirituality was evident in both the coherence and consistency of their lives. From this perspective, spiritual development is indicated by the extent of meaning found in these exemplars' experiences of transcendence, strength in their commitment to and conviction of particular beliefs, and the seeming consistency of their actions. Katherine, a Christian from England, described this well:

> And so becoming a Christian was about making God the center and living out a Christlike life. It wasn't about "doing this and not doing this." It was something . . . obviously those things, you did them,

> but you did them out of a love for God and because of who you were—not because it was the law.

As she explains, spirituality is not simply about following laws or "doing this and not doing this," but instead, these narratives suggest that spirituality is about transcending the self, formulating an identity and belief system, and maintaining a lifestyle that is consistent with one's worldview. The extent of spiritual development pertains to the extent to which these transactions influence the beliefs, purpose and behaviors of an individual.

To summarize, relational developmental systems perspectives frame development within a set of person-context processes useful for exploring the complexity of spiritual development. In addition, such an approach highlights the plasticity of human development (Lerner et al., 2015; Overton, 2015) and the resulting capacity for change and growth in development generally, and in spirituality specifically. Relational developmental systems also emphasize the reciprocity of interactions between individuals and their world, highlighting that spiritual development is an active process and involves relating and responding. Thus we emphasize not just any type of spirituality, but reciprocating spirituality, in order to emphasize the relational and active processes in spiritual development.

Development of Reciprocating Spirituality

Diverse interactions within the individual and between an individual and the world they live point to the complexity of religious and spiritual development. As such, religious and spiritual development affects other aspects of development, such as attachment, cognition, identity and morality. How then does spiritual and religious development take shape throughout the lifespan? We have argued that spiritual

development involves transcendence, fidelity and action; and, religious development involves growing in the capacity to participate in the beliefs, practices, rituals and communities of a specific religious tradition. What are the specific developmental implications of these formulations? Surely, infants, toddlers, teens and elderly do not all exhibit transcendence, fidelity and contribution in the same matter? Surely they do not assent to doctrinal beliefs or engage in religious practices with the same level of understanding or conviction? Are these processes more readily apparent the older one gets? Are religious and spiritual development linear? Given that, for Christians, we experience spirituality as a part of our faith, in the following section we refer to reciprocating spirituality and spiritual development in the context of religion.

As in all domains of development, the processes involved in religious and spiritual development take place in the ongoing bidirectional interactions between individuals and their context. This relational developmental systems approach allows us to understand how spiritual and religious development occur at every level of the developing system—from the individual level of brain development to macro-levels of social and cultural systems. Although research is at nascent stages across these various systems, existing literature gives insight into the complexity and nature of spiritual and religious development. Given that neurology and brain development are newer to the developmental sciences since the last edition of this volume, before discussing religious and spiritual development through the lifespan we offer some neurological perspectives on religious and spiritual development.

Reciprocating spirituality and the brain. Religiousness and spirituality develop within individuals and between individuals and social institutions. The role of the brain is no different here than in other types of development. Religiousness and spirituality are not singular human

capacities that are located in a specific location of the brain. Rather they involve complex emergent properties that come into being through interactions with other people, social-cultural systems (like religion) and God. For further explanation, we borrow from our esteemed neuropsychologist colleague in the school of psychology at Fuller Theological Seminary, Warren Brown, and his discussion of brains, baseball and religion (see Brown, 2006).

Brown argues that religious experience is not a unique brain function, meaning that there is not a specific neurological system or part of the brain (as in the case with music or language) that is responsible for religious or spiritual experience. Rather, religious and spiritual experience involves a "conglomerate of individual human capacities" more like intelligence. Brown explains that if religiousness and spirituality were reducible to a unique region or system, we would be able to examine behaviors and experiences and identify responsible cognitive subcomponents, and then study the many contributing processes in order to find relatively unique or specific neural systems. This is not the case with religious and spiritual development. For example, previously in this chapter we identified a myriad of psychological processes and experiences that are involved with spiritual development—transcendence, meaning making, fidelity, contribution—and with religious development—engaging in beliefs, practices, rituals and communities. No single region or system of the brain is responsible for these diverse and complex capacities that are involved with these psychological phenomena. In other words, there are not religion-specific systems or parts of the brain.

Rather than thinking of religion as a singular capacity like music or language, Brown suggests that religion is more like baseball as a sociocultural construct that includes a very complex set of behaviors and experiences. Like baseball, religion involves many complex layers of interpersonal and social organization. Religion is not strictly an individual

phenomenon but rather a form of human relatedness and social activity. For example, religion involves complex cognitive capacities that allow for engagement with a historical system of beliefs, practices and peoples. Spirituality, even when experienced outside of a religious tradition, necessitates various forms of cognition such as intelligence, perception and emotion to allow for experiences and behaviors involved in transcendence, fidelity and service.

These are not solely intrapersonal or phenomena within the individual, but rather occur among individuals, creation and God. For example this could occur through interactions with family, experiences in nature, praying to God or attending a church. These experiences are simultaneously enabled by existing cognitive capacities and instigate the development of new or more complex cognitive capacities. In other words, neural systems simultaneously facilitate an individual's religious experience and are also changed by an individual's religious experience. We are reciprocating selves, both impacting and being impacted by our surroundings.

Given this reality, the constellation of cognitive capacities involved in religious and spiritual development is described as *emergent*. The concept of emergence presumes that distinctly new properties or capacities come into being based on the interaction of lower-level functions. The relational developmental systems paradigm acknowledges that a sum is not always reducible to its parts. The massively complex and interconnected neural network that is the human cerebral cortex is perfectly suited for emergence of higher-level capacities. Dynamic systems theory explains that when pushed or challenged from its status quo or equilibrium by environmental interactions, existing systems (in our discussion, existing neural networks) self-organize into larger patterns that comprise new, more complex capacities. From this standpoint, neural patterns "self-organize (and reorganize) as demanded by the continual give-and-take of interactions with the environment" (Brown, 2006, p. 17).

Religious and spiritual development are contingent on such emergent capacities.

Given that there is no unique brain basis for religiousness and spirituality, we ask if they are distinct from other domains of development—such as social, emotional and identity development—or are they dependent on these other domains of development? If transcendence involves shifting one's cognitive and emotional orientation onto something beyond the self, is this just hypersociality? How is such relatedness different from other relationships—whether between people or between individuals and God? We have argued that these experiences are spiritual when they have consistent ordering power on how one views and acts in the world. This necessitates high levels of self-awareness, meaning making, devotion and commitment. From a relational developmental systems perspective, this raises an empirical question—is spiritual development an emergent property that is truly distinct and qualitatively distinct from other aspects of development, or is it better understood as a sum of parts or as overlapping?

The primacy that we place on *relationalism,* both in regard to the trinitarian theological basis for our reciprocating-self model and our acceptance of the relational developmental systems paradigm, influences us to accept the former. Although all of the many parts may be important contributors, it is the mutually influential *relationships* between these parts that mean reciprocating spirituality is an emergent property. While some might suggest that spirituality serves an integrative function—coordinating various forms of cognition such as perception, affect, meaning-making behaviors and so on—we believe that such a view must also yield to the reality that spirituality itself is a dynamic whole that is in a continual state of emergence and reemerging.

In summary, clearly, no unique neurological system contributes specifically to religion. Rather it is more

helpful to consider religion as a complex social-cultural system involving a wide variety of activities and experiences that are enabled neurologically by a large number of more general cognitive capacities and skills. Given this basic understanding of the multilevel nature of reciprocating spirituality, we turn our discussion toward understanding the development of reciprocating spirituality through the lifespan.

Reciprocating spirituality and the lifespan. As in all domains of development, reciprocating spirituality takes place in the ongoing bidirectional interactions between individuals and their context at all levels of the developmental system—from the biological to psychological to social to cultural and to supernatural levels. Consequently, reciprocating spirituality involves a constellation of capacities that engage an individual with the world around them—such as people, nature, congregation and God. In this section, we explore how reciprocating spirituality may take shape throughout the lifespan. Please note, although we focus our discussion by examining different stages of the lifespan, we do not propose a stage theory. Rather we view the development of reciprocating spirituality through a relational developmental systems perspective emphasizing how the psychological capacities characteristic of different ages facilitate reciprocal interactions between an individual and the world in which they live that promote spiritual and religious development.

In doing so, we build on the work of James Fowler (1981), who proposed a theory of faith development from two decades of research that emphasizes the motivation to discover meaning in life, either within or outside of an organized religion. Fowler identified six stages of faith development that explain how religious and spiritual development occur from infancy through the latter years in life. For Fowler, faith is a universal, dynamic quality of human life that involves trust in and loyalty to centers of value (e.g.,

religion, family), images of power (e.g., God, government) and master stories (e.g., the biblical narrative). Trust in these sources provides meaning and guidance for our lives and acts to sustain and encourage us in our life's journey. Fowler based much of his understanding of faith development on the emergence of other developmental capacities (e.g., identity, cognition and moral reasoning). Specifically, Erikson's understanding of crisis, psychosocial development and the eight stages of ego development strongly informs Fowler's understanding of faith development. Piaget's explanation of cognitive development also plays a strong hand in Fowler's articulation of the role of religious beliefs in faith. Similarly, Fowler draws on Kohlberg's theory of moral development to explain the moral aspect of religious development.

Although Fowler's theory was enthusiastically received (especially in the 1980s and 1990s) as a helpful means for understanding the emergence of religious faith and for creating and evaluating religious education and ministry programs, it has come under scrutiny, as have many of the linear, modern developmental theories. As we have noted, scholars today recognize that development is not always straightforward and does not always proceed according to stages (Lerner, Lerner, Bowers & Geldhof, 2015; Overton, 2015). In addition, postmodern sensibilities have highlighted the need for more complex and less reductionistic theories that emphasize the influence of systems, person-context interaction and nonlinear development. Furthermore, the influence of positive youth development and positive psychology has shifted the emphasis to adaptation rather than crisis for understanding human development. Consequently, we offer a lifespan developmental systems perspective of reciprocating spirituality.

All development occurs through relationships, but it is especially seminal to spiritual development because spirituality involves transcendence, a highly acute form of

connection and awareness of something beyond the self. Dietrich Bonhoeffer (1963) wrote, “The individual personal spirit lives solely by virtue of sociality. Only in interaction with one another is the spirit of human beings ever revealed; this is the essence of spirit, to be oneself through being in the other” (p. 48). According to Bonhoeffer, not only does a person’s self-identity take shape in relationship with others, but spiritual identity also develops in the context of relationship with others. We agree. Spirituality is dependent on sociality. Spirituality is thus contingent on social being, and being social is the foundation for religious experiences. How might we understand this throughout the lifespan?

Reciprocating spirituality involves sufficient cognitive and emotional capacities to be aware of and grasp that which is beyond the self, while growing in self-knowledge and understanding. This process eventually requires and promotes the development of identity, purpose, values, meaning systems and eventually results in fidelity to an ideology. Further, reciprocity is evident as a person responds to transcendence (out of fidelity) with actions that are consistent with their beliefs, values and self-concept. Such actions are characterized by contribution, compassion and leadership and require prosocial, moral and civic development (Lerner et al., 2003). Consequently, mature spirituality is characterized by connection, commitment and coherence.

Psychological understanding of how one grows in their capacities to experience transcendence, make meaning, construct an identity and commit to beliefs that motivate sustained contribution to the greater good may be helpful to understanding how reciprocating spirituality takes shape. We recognize that what qualifies as “beyond the self” or as a transcendent relationship varies throughout the lifespan and is affected by one’s cognitive capacities. In addition, some transcendent relationships may be more pertinent or meaningful at different stages.

No doubt, early in life parents and caregivers are the most prominent experience of an "other." Infants rapidly develop cognitive capacities to be aware of and distinguish between themselves and another (see chapter four's discussion of object relations theories). For example, the warmth of the relationship between a baby and his or her mother or father is thought to influence the way an infant can differentiate between itself and others, whether God or another person. The amount of trust experienced in these early relationships might also affect the degree to which the individual will experience relationships with God or other people. These are the building blocks of relationality, and we suggest also of reciprocating spirituality.

King and Boyatzis (2015) suggest that early relationships with "earthly" others allow babies and young children to develop the relational capacities necessary for eventual more abstract experiences of relatedness or transcendence. Safe, emotionally attuned, nonimpinging relationships between babies or children and their caregivers may enable them to develop "horizontal" spirituality in various social contexts that will provide the foundation for the development of reciprocal spirituality with what is further beyond the self—such as God or even the "community of saints." This more "vertical" spirituality may be more salient depending on cognitive and affective capacities.

We emphasize that young children's spirituality, or those with less sophisticated cognitive capacities for whatever reasons, is merely different from, not less than or deficient with regard to typical adolescent or adult spirituality. This idea that early spirituality would be grounded in human relationships is plausible in light of the many theories of development, from object relations and attachment theory to cognitive-developmental theory to faith development theory to psychosocial perspectives, that emphasize early trust as integral to the later development of spirituality and faith (King & Boyatzis, 2015). Fowler described his first (pre-)

stage of faith as primal faith that is derived from an infant's experience of mutual interaction with parents and caregivers, being formed in the basic rituals of care and interchange. In addition, existing attachment theory and research support these ideas (Granqvist & Dickie, 2006). For example, in a recent study on attachment styles and teenage conversion experiences, Sarah Schnitker and colleagues (Schnitker, Porter, Emmons & Barrett, 2012) found that youth with secure parental attachments experienced more gradual religious conversions, suggesting that internal working models of childhood attachment figures form a basis of attachment to God.

In addition to relationality, the emergence of cognitive capacities (both rational and affective) allows for variability in apprehension of God and doctrinal beliefs. Although there is some debate regarding humankind's innate capacities to imagine and understand the supernatural (see Barrett, 2012), young children demonstrate the ability to imagine the supernatural (see chapter six). Their natural intuitions regarding the supernatural are counterintuitive to the naturalistic paradigm that dominates Western adulthood. Research has noted that children's imagination and lack of analytical skills enable them to engage in spiritual emotions of wonder and awe (Roehlkepartain et al., 2006), which may yield more openness to spiritual experience, whether through nature or religion. This early assent to supernatural beliefs may be essential to reciprocating spirituality. In early childhood, the acquisition of language, imagination and feelings plays an important role in religious and spiritual development. Stories, gestures and symbols stir the imagination that is not yet always controlled by logical thinking. What is reality and what is fantasy is not so important. When fused with children's own feelings, their own intuitive images of good and evil and conscious images of God enable children to experience God in very real ways (Fowler, 1981).

As children grow and develop the capacities to interact with others, they begin to reason in a more logical and concrete, but usually not yet abstract, manner. Fowler suggested that they develop the ability to order the world with categories of time, space, number and causality, which allows one to begin to differentiate between reality and fantasy. Also as these capacities develop, children can begin to take the perspective of others as well as begin to capture meanings from stories. They interpret stories and symbols literally. Their perception of God is anthropomorphic, based on humans they know—often their parents or characters from other stories.

As children grow and encounter different paradigms of reality that challenge their initial beliefs of such things as God, Jesus and heaven, they are forced to personally reconcile contradictions and reconsider spiritual ideas. In fact, research has demonstrated that as children get older, they do not discard their initial "thought processes about God but instead develop a coexistence model that integrates their previous intuitive and often supernatural accounts with later-developing scientific explanations" (King & Boyatzis, 2015, p. 982; see Legare, Evans, Rosengren & Harris, 2012).

The onset of formal operational thinking that typically emerges during adolescence enables teens to wrestle with abstract ideas and concepts. Youth begin to integrate what they have learned about religion into a coherent belief system and sense of identity. They become concerned with their identity, beliefs, purpose, vocation and future. Initially, religious identity, beliefs and practices are often consistent with those closest to the young person. For instance, the extensive research of the National Study of Youth and Religion in America has shown that most American high school students tend to adopt the religious orientations of their parents (see Smith & Denton, 2005). It's generally not until youth leave home for college or work that they

begin to explore different belief systems and differentiate their own religious and spiritual commitments.

Whether scaffolded by their family or the result of personal searching, as a person constructs (or reconstructs) their sense of identity, a sense of knowing God may lead to a deep integration of God concepts into one's identity. As individuals (whether child, adolescent or adult) integrate sets of images of themselves into their identity, they simultaneously form a set of beliefs, values and commitments that provide direction and guidance for living, resulting in the sort of fidelity we have described.

Additionally, new cognitive and affective capacities make possible mutual, interpersonal perspective taking. Given these increased relational competencies, intimacy and friendships become a powerful force in the lives of adolescents. The desire for personal relations with significant others is often associated with a hunger for a personal relationship with God in which a young person feels known and loved. Conceptions of God may take on greater depth. Furthermore, loss, challenge and doubt may also deepen faith by making meaning out of difficult situations and by renewed devotion or commitment to spiritual ideals. In addition, heightened emotions that often accompany the onset of puberty and remain throughout much of adolescence may increase an individual's tendency to experience awe or other forms of affective arousal (sexual and otherwise) that may deepen an individual's sense of awareness and connection to God or a religious community. Emotions such as love, awe and joy often are a motivating factor that propels individuals toward religious conversion, commitment and ongoing devotion (Keltner & Haidt, 2003). Such yearnings (whether enabled by developing cognitive and affective neurological systems or hormones) for belonging, self-understanding and significance may be crucial to the emergence of reciprocating spirituality.

From Fowler's perspective, adolescents are in the synthetic-conventional stage. He noted that although these beliefs are not settled without some abstract thinking, people at the synthetic-conventional stage may still conform to the religious beliefs of others (as in Kohlberg's conventional level of moral reasoning) and have not fully analyzed alternative religious ideologies. They have a tacit system of religious beliefs and values, which they know but they cannot necessarily explain because of their unquestioning allegiance to an external authority. Although this stage might be characteristic of some adolescents, we note it is characteristic of some adults who for whatever reason do not extensively explore existential, religious or spiritual issues or who foreclosed on identity issues. The spiritual-exemplar study discussed earlier also demonstrates that adolescents often exhibit spirituality that is far more differentiated that this synthetic-conventional stage suggests (see King et al., 2014).

As individuals question and examine the values and beliefs they have accepted in life thus far, their commitments become explicit and can be critically supported, unlike the tacit commitments of the synthetic-conventional faith where commitments are unexamined and uncritically approved. In many cases, during late adolescence or emerging adulthood identity emerges that is not merely defined by a person's relationships to others but is consciously chosen. As the developmental system expands and brain development enables more consistent self-reflective capacities, individuals can take fuller responsibility for their lives and their religious beliefs at this time. For example, during the college years individuals often intellectually challenge their personal values and religious ideologies. Fowler explained that when this occurs, authority is relocated to the self, where the self, not the greater community, assumes the burden and responsibility for faith and belief. Current research on religious-attendance trends among emerging adults

confirms this self-orientation characteristic of this season of life (see chapter nine). Although often described as self-absorbed and self-oriented, cast in the light of spiritual development perhaps this season of life is better understood as a time of exploration as a means of making meaning and constructing identity (see Barry & Abo-Zena, 2014).

Fowler suggests that during the transition to adulthood, individual experience of faith is centered on using one's intellect to explain and rationalize one's religious beliefs and experiences. This is often evident on college campuses. Have you witnessed students engaging in "apologetics"? I (Pam) can remember many a late night offering my best attempt at rational explanations to my dormmates regarding their deepest existential questions about God, Jesus, suffering, life and so on. For me this was a time of intentionally working out intellectually what I believed. Fowler noted that with this type of faith rational understanding is prioritized over mystical insight. For example, he suggests that religious symbols may be questions; in this case, they have a rational rather than a mystical meaning.

However, for some persons their experiences with their developmental systems may shift them into a form of faith in which they no longer need to be able to explain or rationalize all aspects of their beliefs and values. They begin to embrace paradox and integrate polarities in their lives. For example, they begin to recognize that they are simultaneously a constructive and a destructive person. Paul captured this well when he wrote, "For I do not do the good I want, but the evil I do not want is what I do" (Rom 7:19). Such individuals do not need things to be black and white; rather, they grow comfortable with the gray areas—the ambiguities and mysteries—of life. For example, they can rest with the tension that God is all-powerful and loving, yet great suffering and pain remain in this world. Symbols, narrative and myth may become very important.

Fowler explains that after having looked critically at traditions and having analyzed their meanings in the previous stage, some individuals hunger for a deeper relationship with the reality that the symbols mediate. Our teleology, being in relationship with God and others, emphasizes that reciprocating spirituality involves a deepening relationship with God. The late practical theologian James Loder (1998) in his book *The Logic of the Spirit* urged that faith is not rational, but relational. Faith is about knowing God and God's love for us, and responding to it. Our deepest longing or our developmental goal is "to behold the face of God" (p. 272). From a teleological perspective the purpose of human life is to deepen intimacy with God, which occurs directly through encounters with the Father, Son and Holy Spirit and also through the family of God. For Loder, spiritual development does not occur through increased understanding of religious beliefs or universal truths; rather, it transpires through the deepening of our intimacy with God. It is through this intimacy that the Spirit is released more fully in our lives. Through this experience of Christ we are given meaning, guidance, hope and motivation to act.

Consequently, as our relational capacities develop, our capacity to relate to God changes. Thus far we have described how typical social relational processes bring about the development of reciprocating spirituality, whether through promoting attachment, cognitive development or identity formation. In short, we have discussed how experiences of "horizontal spirituality" or relatedness with an earthly other may contribute to "vertical spirituality" or supernatural transcendence. However, it is important to explore the religious and supernatural contexts in the development of reciprocating spirituality.

Given our premise that Christian reciprocating spirituality involves relating to God, it is important to consider the roles of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit. In

short, as Christians we relate to the Father because of our salvation through Jesus Christ and the ongoing work of the Spirit. This side of eternity we will never fully understand the mystery of God's love and grace through our intellect. Rather we have to experience it. The experience of forgiveness and God's grace has ultimate reordering power on our lives. The Spirit of God is at work bringing God's eternal love into our daily realities. In a recent sermon at my (Pam) local church, the preacher explained this well. She proclaimed that love is not just an ethical virtue, but an "eschatological power" (Peacore, 2015). Love as an eschatological power that has the capacity to bring about change now and into the forevermore is a profound thought.

How do we psychologically understand this gift of God poured out into the depths of our being? No doubt, ultimately God's being and actions are beyond human comprehension. That said, psychology provides increasing insight into how people may encounter the transformative love and presence of God. For example, we have increasing insight into how spiritual practices may facilitate physiological changes that allow individuals to be transformed. For example, the explosion of mindfulness practices and research has demonstrated how various exercises may impact people's level of anxiety, depression and increase their awareness, focus and emotional regulation (see Brown & Ryan, 2003; Hofmann, Sawyer, Witt & Oh, 2010). Science has also revealed that different types of meditation and spiritual practices can actually change the physical brain and thereby facilitate a deepened sense of connection to that which is beyond the self—perhaps to other people and to God?

Recent research by neuroscientist Richard Davidson on the emotional brain has begun to reveal how brain functioning enables individuals to sustain keener attention, have more attunement with others and be connected to our intuition (see Davidson & Begley, 2013). Specifically, a recent study involving brain scans of Tibetan Buddhist monks provides

insight into how consistent spiritual practices may in fact change physical brains and enhance one's capacities for awareness and attunement that is often associated with compassion (Davidson & Lutz, 2008). This study found that monks who have meditated for tens of thousands of hours over time had actually altered the structure and function of their brains. Meditation increased their attention and reduced their emotionally reactive behaviors, which can distract from attunement. This study specifically examined the effects of focused-attention and open-monitoring meditation. For example, focused-attention meditation entails focusing attention on something specific like an object or a Bible verse over a sustained time. Alternatively, open-monitoring meditation involves nonreactively monitoring the content of one's moment-to-moment experience. Regardless, both forms of meditative practices heighten one's awareness of oneself and one's surroundings. Said differently, consistent spiritual practices may increase one's capacity to be a reciprocating self—with humans, creation and perhaps God.

From a theological perspective, spiritual disciplines such as meditation, silence and *lectio divina* (a method of meditative Bible reading) serve to draw believers into the reality of the presence of God, allowing Scripture and the Holy Spirit to re-form and shape them rather than studying Scripture and analyzing the text for meaning. Merton (1969) wrote, "The whole purpose of meditation is to deepen the consciousness of the basic relationship of the creature to the Creator, and of the sinner to his Redeemer" (p. 62). Such practices promote awareness of and dependence on God and Christ. Although we can understand this from a psychological and neurological perspective, this does not negate the work of the Holy Spirit. We acknowledge that God may use biological systems or psychological processes to transform us, but at the end of the day we do not reduce these spiritual activities to physicalism. Ultimately, grace, mercy and faith are not permanent inalienable possessions that we

gain by our efforts or spiritual practices. No. Merton reminds us that "true contemplation is not a psychological trick but a theological grace" (p. 70).

Merton also emphasizes that contemplation leads to action and action to contemplation. At the heart of reciprocating spirituality is this bidirectional movement between transcendence and behavior. We argue that spirituality involves interactions between the self and some form of other that informs one's beliefs and commitments, and propels individuals to live in a manner mindful of others. Consequently, reciprocating spirituality involves the increasing capacity to respond not just in belief commitments, identity and fidelity, but also in sustained actions that benefit others. Thus the development of character and competencies that enable individuals to act in this world is necessary. Such character and competencies take shape throughout the lifespan. Children, adolescents and all adults can gain skills that enable them to contribute to their surroundings in constructive and appropriate ways. For example, a young child might take care of a pet, or offer a neighbor a cut flower. An adolescent may participate in a service project. An adult may volunteer as a teacher in a church. As spirituality develops, these activities may initially be more episodic, but reciprocating spirituality is marked by increasing consistency and coherence among experiences, beliefs and behaviors.

This notion is in contrast to Fowler's theory that relegates such maturing action to his final stage, "universalizing faith," a stage few people ever reach according to his research. Two qualities characterizing people with "universalizing faith" are (1) their ability to transcend specific belief systems and experience a sense of connection with all beings, and (2) their commitment to overcoming division, oppression and violence. Mohandas Gandhi, Martin Luther King Jr. and Mother Teresa are examples of individuals that lived in this stage. They were able to

move beyond self-interest and their own religious ideologies in order to bring about love and justice. At this stage individuals begin to see value in others and injustices in the world from God's perspective rather than through their own perspective. Fowler refers to this as decentralization from self. For Fowler this leads to a transformation from personal values to a universalization of the capacity for love, compassion and justice.

Reciprocating spirituality emphasizes that all individuals regardless of their stage of development or potential disabilities have the potential to contribute to the world beyond themselves. Sustained action benefiting the greater world (whether family, neighborhood, congregation or continent) is a response to transcendence—from a Christian perspective, from a response to experiencing God's life-altering love. Profound doctrinal understanding does not often predicate a religious conversion, but experiencing a profound sense of love or gratitude often does (James, 1985). It's important to emphasize the bidirectional nature between practice of one's faith and experience of one's faith. As Christians we often talk about the importance of *praxis*—experiencing God through practicing or living out one's faith. I (Pam) recall taking a group of high school students on a mission trip to Malawi. One student was forced to go by his parents. I do not think there was a conscious fiber of his drug-addicted being that wanted to go on this trip. That said, through his experience of painting a hospital and playing games with local children and despite the turbulence of his withdrawal, he encountered God's love and grace in a life-transforming way. His "spiritual experience" started with very practical and simple service and engagement with others. Often action leads to transcendence.

Supporting this experience, research demonstrates that service offers many potential benefits to spiritual development (Youniss, McLellan & Yates, 1999). Active participation within a religious community (e.g., through

worship or community service) places the individual within the sphere of other religious adherents. For example, when youth volunteer to serve at a homeless shelter affiliated with their church, they identify themselves as active members and contributors to their specific religious tradition and community. Shared social relationships with others therefore motivate individuals to question, affirm, doubt and wonder about their own understandings and beliefs and their own place within the religious family.

Before concluding this section, we emphasize a developmental "special sauce" of reciprocating spirituality. By "special sauce" we refer to the unique processes involved in reciprocating spirituality that move spirituality from merely seeking the sacred to responding to relationality. This special sauce is fidelity. Reciprocating spirituality is predicated on the emergence of fidelity that results from the resolved commitment to an identity (hopefully, but not always, during adolescence) (see King, Carr & Boitor, 2011; Lerner et al., 2003; Lerner et al., 2015). Fidelity, the unflagging commitment to an ideology that transcends the self, allows people to integrate their moral and civic identities giving them a spiritual sensibility. As individuals commit to an ideological framework and gain a sense of fidelity, they are able to transcend individuality and engage in a more noble purpose (Damon, Menon & Cotton Bronk, 2003). In this sense, "Ideology provides the social glue that allows identity to transcend individuality and become synthesized with the collective" (Youniss & Yates, 1997, p. 23). Youth, within a moral and value-laden framework, develop not only integrated civic and moral identities and a commitment to an ideology but also a transcendent or spiritual sensibility that propels them to contribute to the common good (Lerner et al., 2003).

Consequently, we recognize that the development of reciprocating spirituality varies. As we have discussed, younger children may not have the reflective skills necessary

to consciously integrate their experiences of the sacred or their beliefs with their identity and actions. As the work of Henri Nouwen has demonstrated, mentally handicapped individuals' spiritual development may be more based on their relational capacities than rational capacities. We believe that the religious and spiritual development trajectory is unique for all people based on their individual (e.g., biological, psychological) factors and their relations with their contexts (e.g., cultural, religious). Despite these diverse expressions, we argue that the developmental trajectory of reciprocating spirituality is toward coherence of experiences of transcendence, fidelity and one's way of living in the world.

Religion as Context and Reciprocating Spirituality

From a relational developmental systems perspective, we are interested in how characteristics of the individual and the context interact over time to influence reciprocating spirituality. We see the individual as a dynamic entity at the center of a network of biological, psychological, socio-historical, cultural and supernatural contexts. The bidirectional influences between person and context provide the basis for the high levels of variability in reciprocating spirituality that exist among individuals. Such a view acknowledges the role of core psychological processes, such as cognitive capacities, and also typical systems of influence, such as family and friends, on religious and spiritual development. In addition to these traditional influences, those uniquely religious and spiritual elements (e.g., relations with the divine) and religious and spiritual contexts (e.g., worship) must be considered. Furthermore, such a systems view also must account for divine or supernatural influence.

Contexts such as family, peer relationships, schools, congregations and culture may all play potentially rich roles in the development of reciprocating spirituality. Although it is beyond the scope of this chapter to cover in depth these areas of potential influence, we consider the unique role of religious influence. Religion is a very complex sociocultural system, which includes belief systems, fellow believers and an acknowledgment of a transcendent other (e.g., God, a higher power, absolute truth). Consequently, there are many ways that religious environments shape an individual's religious development. In particular, religion has the potential to provide opportunities for religious development and commitment through ideological, social and spiritual contexts (King, 2003).

Religions have a rich ideological context in that they actively promote a coherent worldview that offers prosocial values and behavioral norms grounded in a belief system, a function of religion that Peter Berger (1967) refers to as *plausibility structures*. Especially in a culture where people are bombarded with many different values and beliefs, religion's ability to provide a clear and consistent set of beliefs and values enables people to grow in their ability to make sense of the world, find meaning and have faith. Religion offers ultimate answers and perspective about the larger issues in life, enabling individuals to become more clear and committed about their religious beliefs and religious identity.

From a social perspective, religious institutions intentionally teach these values, and members may embody these ideals and values and serve as role models. In addition, the faith community provides an intergenerational network of enduring, caring relationships through which youth may wrestle with issues pertinent to identity exploration as well as offer experiences in which they can explore personal gifts.

Finally, such institutions offer a transcendent environment that enables youth to transcend their daily concerns and encounter a supernatural Other and a faith community in a meaningful way that nurtures their religious growth. Often spiritual experiences (e.g., answered prayer, corporate worship) call an individual's attention beyond themselves, inspiring them to commit to something greater than themselves (Lerner et al., 2003; Youniss et al., 1999).

As we have described, reciprocating spirituality is not simply a process of "unfolding of an entity" but is the interaction of biological, social, cultural and spiritual factors in which multiple domains and functions develop to promote reciprocating spirituality. Of these, religion is potentially an especially potent context. Recognition of multiple contexts and their interactive relationship with variables of the self necessitates much more than a singular conception of reciprocating spirituality. Consequently, development is not linear but is multidimensional and multidirectional. As a result, we do not talk about the development of reciprocating spirituality in stages but rather in terms of the interactions of a person and context over time. It is these interactions that help or hinder the development of the reciprocating self in relationship to God.

Biblical Reflections on Reciprocating Spirituality

In the next section of the chapter we look at a biblical and theological perspective of such development, review existing theories in light of our understanding of the reciprocating self and then discuss how other aspects of human development affect spiritual and religious development.

> I thank my God every time I remember you, constantly praying with joy in every one of my prayers for all of you, because of your sharing in the gospel from the

> first day until now. I am confident of this, that the one who began a good work among you will bring it to completion by the day of Jesus Christ. . . . And this is my prayer, that your love may overflow more and more with knowledge and full insight to help you determine what is best, so that in the day of Christ you may be pure and blameless, having produced the harvest of righteousness that comes through Jesus Christ for the glory and praise of God. (Phil 1:3-6, 9-11)

These are some of Paul's opening words to the church at Phillipi. There are several theological truths relevant to reciprocating spirituality embedded within this text. First, Paul reminds us, "The one [God] who began a good work among you will bring it to completion by the day of Jesus Christ." Specifically, the Reformed tradition firmly believes that God initiates faith in us. We believe that humans are not able to initiate faith, but faith is a gift from God. Second, Paul states that this good work of faith that God began in us is a process. Our experience of religion and faith is a developmental journey that will be completed only when Christ comes again.

Paul prays that the Philippians' love may "overflow more and more with knowledge and full insight." He suggests that our love for God (and others) is to grow in understanding. It is not an ignorant, blind love, but a love informed by knowledge and wisdom that makes a difference in our lives—this increased understanding will enable us to "determine what is best," to be "pure and blameless," and to produce a harvest. This statement teaches that religious and spiritual development involves growing in the capacity to love God (and others), growing in knowledge and understanding so that we may live rightly (according to God's will), and suggests that religious development involves socioemotional and cognitive development as well as behavior and action. Paul's notion is consistent with our understanding of

reciprocating spirituality that involves transcendence (loving and knowing God), fidelity (beliefs and knowing what is best) and contribution (produce a harvest).

However, Paul extends our psychologically based model to include an important aspect of divine mystery. Paul reminds us that we are to be "filled with the fruit of righteousness that comes through Jesus Christ" (NIV). Paul clearly states that righteousness does not come on our own but through Christ. Theologians use the term *imputed righteousness* to refer to the mysterious act of Christ exchanging our sin for his righteousness. In a sense he makes a trade with us. He takes our sins and gives us his righteousness. Calvin referred to this as the *mirifica communitatio*, or wonderful exchange. Christ takes what is ours and makes it his, and he takes what is his and makes it our own. Consequently, Paul is suggesting that there is a supernatural or divine aspect to religious development. No matter how sophisticated our moral development or our sense of identity might be, this kind of development is beyond our control. Finally, Paul reminds us that the faith initiated in us and the love, knowledge and righteousness that result all happen for the glory and praise of God.

Conclusion

We are created to live in reciprocating relationships with God and others as we become more like Christ. As Christians this is the goal of all of human development, and it guides our understanding of spiritual and religious development. We propose reciprocating spirituality to capture the complexity and pervasiveness of human engagement with the divine. The development of reciprocating spirituality involves the growing capacity to relate to God (as the Father, Son and Holy Spirit) and fellow believers in such a way that provides

meaning and guidance for one's life and that yields a life lived according to the Christian ethic. This occurs through participating in the doctrine, beliefs and traditions of one's faith in such a way that promotes a reciprocating relationship with God, others and creation. This systems view acknowledges the richness and complexity of spiritual and religious development. It does not seek homogeneity in development but allows for heterogeneity. Reciprocating spirituality calls us into a loving relationship with God our Creator—to be more who we were created to be, and to live as God's beloved servants in this world.

14

Turning Steeples into Scaffolds

The Reciprocating Religious Community

> *God's goal for creation is community, a redeemed people dwelling in a renewed creation, enjoying the presence of a Triune God.*
>
> Stanley J. Grenz and Jay T. Smith

IN THIS LAST CHAPTER we think about reciprocating spirituality as *differentiated faith*. Some Christians are more comfortable with expressing their personal experience of God as "faith" rather than "spirituality." Although our notion of reciprocating spirituality involves action and a response to God, for some "faith" is almost like a verb and implies an active pursuit, reliance and response to God. Consequently, in chapter fourteen, we propose differentiated faith as an integrative concept based on our understanding of reciprocating spirituality (chapter thirteen) that depicts a personal relationship with God. In doing so we examine the wider religious and social context within which a differentiated faith might best be developed, nurtured and maintained. In balancing a christological and trinitarian emphasis we will look at some implications for ministering to persons as they move and develop through each stage of the lifespan.

Scripture calls us to be conformed to Christ, not by a dissolving of our self, but by means of a relationship with

Christ in which the self is distinctively maintained even as it is in the process of being transformed. Just as trinitarian theology has been foundational for our model of the reciprocating self, so we will utilize it in understanding the biblical ideal for religious community. While our focus will be on community, since human development is generally thought of in terms of individual development, we will briefly speculate on how trinitarian theology and an emphasis on *relationality* in both our reciprocating-self model and in the RDS paradigm might inform counseling and congregational ministries.

Differentiated Faith

From a trinitarian theological perspective the purpose in life is to be in a reciprocating relationship with God and others. As such it is our understanding that the goal of spiritual and religious development is to experience intimacy with God that allows for communion with the Godhead and does not sacrifice the particularity of the individual. We refer to this as differentiated faith. Differentiated faith incorporates both spiritual and religious expression that allows for a reciprocating relationship with God that emphasizes both unity and uniqueness. Although similar to *reciprocating spirituality*, differentiated faith is nonreductionistic and allows for the presence and action of God in the process of formation. It can also be influenced by other aspects of human functioning and development (e.g., moral development, identity development). Finally, differentiated faith is not only characterized by intimacy with God but also by a life that responds in action to the mutual love of the Creator and created.

Based on the discussion of the *imago Dei* in chapter two, differentiated faith is lived out in communion with God in a way that facilitates a deeper knowledge of God and self. In

this way a relationship with God is characterized by a differentiated believer and a differentiated deity. As figure 14.1 illustrates, differentiated faith occurs when an individual's relationship with God is balanced by unity and uniqueness. Such faith does not lead to enmeshment with or detachment from God. This is important. Some faith traditions emphasize unity with God to the extent that the unique will, gifts and interests of an individual are subjugated to the perceived will of God. The Bible is very clear that we are uniquely gifted and that our uniqueness enables the body of believers to function effectively. In our relationship with God, human uniqueness is not lost. At the same time, neither are we to emphasize uniqueness to the extent of losing our intimacy with God or God's family.

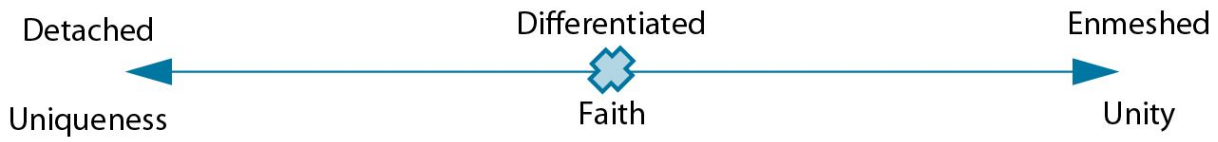


Figure 14.1. Differentiated faith

As discussed previously, spiritual development is understood as growing the basic human capacity to transcend the self and deepen awareness and relatedness to God (as Father, Son and Holy Spirit) and God's created order—both human and nonhuman—in such a way that provides meaning and guidance for life according to a Christian ethic. Religious development is then understood as the emergence of the ability to engage and participate in the doctrines, practices and community associated with a religious tradition that facilitates intimacy with God and fellow believers.

Differentiated faith incorporates both the spiritual and religious, recognizing that (1) spiritual development emphasizes the experience of transcendence, fidelity and

action and that (2) religious development emphasizes engaging in the doctrines, traditions and community of a particular religion—both resulting in greater intimacy with God (and others) and motivating individuals to respond with God's love for the world. Differentiated faith is not solely about being spiritual and being in touch or having a profound relationship with God. Nor is it merely about being religious and believing all the correct doctrines or performing the right religious practices or being a part of the right religious community. Both spiritual and religious development are necessary for differentiated faith—both draw us into intimacy with God and the church and move us to serve as a response to a loving encounter with God.

Differentiated faith also recognizes the possible supernatural, biological and psychological influences that might in theory operate within spiritual and religious development. We acknowledge the life-altering power of God's presence and acknowledge that psychology may provide insight, but ultimately is not able to explain how the Holy Spirit might bring about transformation, whether conversion, growth or healing, in the life of an individual. We also accept that the emergence of differentiated faith is affected, but not exclusively, by other aspects of human development. For example, identity, cognitive abilities, emotions and social skills can play a significant role in spiritual and religious development.

Finally, differentiated faith manifests itself in a life lived in response to knowing God and God's love. Such a life is marked by living in covenant with other believers or participating in a worship community as well as serving and reaching out to the greater community. Differentiated faith, spiritual development and religious development at their best result in an individual that contributes to society in a manner of love and justice.

Nurturing Differentiated Faith

How is differentiated faith nurtured? Although there is a growing distinction between spiritual and religious development in the field of psychology, since differentiated faith is dependent on both, we will examine the two together. Within this book, we have taken an ecological/systemic perspective of development—recognizing that development takes place in the interactions between people and their multiple contexts. Consequently, we are interested in how characteristics of the individual and characteristics of the context interact over time to influence differentiated faith. In considering development as systematic change, we see the individual as a dynamic entity at the center of a network of biological, psychological, sociohistorical, cultural and divine/supernatural factors. Such a relational developmental systems approach recognizes that individual differences between and among people expressed by nature, nurture and the timing of interrelations between nature and nurture provide the bases of the high levels of variability in religious and spiritual development.

Such a view identifies the core elements and processes of human development that are involved in religious and spiritual development by describing the various behavioral domains (e.g., relational experiences between self and other) and processes (e.g., cognitive capacities) that religious development involves. In addition to these core processes, those *uniquely* religious and spiritual elements and contexts that contribute to differentiated faith must be considered.

Consequently, spiritual and religious development are not simply processes of "unfolding of an entity" but are the interactions of biological, social, cultural and spiritual factors in which multiple domains and functions promote differentiated faith. Recognition of multiple contexts and their interactive relationship with variables of the self necessitates much more than a singular conception of

religious or spiritual development. This is true both in terms of quantitatively measured growth (e.g., in amount of religious knowledge) and qualitative growth (e.g., change in subjective experience of the sacred). Consequently, development is not linear, but is multidimensional and multidirectional. We must avoid a dualism that views religion and spirituality as separate from the person as a whole.

It is best not to conceptualize the development of undifferentiated faith in stages, but rather in terms of the interactions of a person and context over time that help or hinder the development of the reciprocating self in relationship to God. Consequently, as we discussed in chapter thirteen, there is not one sequential order of development along the path to religious or spiritual maturation. This view emphasizes the change that occurs through time based on the interaction between the person and the multiple levels of context.

This approach to spiritual and religious development allows for appreciating the role of different aspects of human functioning and social, historical and divine influences. For example, such a view acknowledges that because of an individual's cognitive capacities, religious knowledge can show growth at different times throughout the lifespan. In addition, it can account for the influence of historical events in shaping religious beliefs or spiritual experiences that might contribute to a deepening intimacy with God. Furthermore, such an ecological/systems approach recognizes the possibility for divine influence in bringing about change in the lives of individuals.

The thesis of this book—that human beings are created to live in reciprocating relationships with God and others—points to the general goal of all of human development and guides our understanding of spiritual and religious development specifically. Thus differentiated faith involves utilizing our human capacities as persons created to bear the image of Christ. This will be manifested as we relate to God

and fellow believers in a way that provides meaning and guidance for life and a consistently lived Christian ethic.

It is our observation that contemporary culture is not always conducive to promoting reciprocating selves or reciprocating spirituality. Thus, following a section on how the reciprocating self may be adversely affected by the *saturated self*, we will examine the most important ecological niche for the development and maintaining of the reciprocal self—the reciprocal faith community.

The Issue of Identity in Contemporary Society

In *The Saturated Self: Dilemmas of Identity in Contemporary Life* (1991), Kenneth Gergen suggests the emergence of three types of selves corresponding to societal change in the last two hundred years. Prior to 1900 a *romantic self* with a fixed inner core that was passionate and volatile was the norm. Based on "deeply committed relations, dedicated friendships, and life purposes" (p. 6), the core of the romantic self was thought to be a *moral character* responsible for personal actions and willing to accept the consequences for them. Gergen believes that during the 1900s the *modern self* gradually replaced the romantic self. The modern self is viewed as being machinelike and governed by reason. Within modernity, volatility is treated as a mental problem and passions are harnessed by way of involvement in rationally based educational, religious and familial institutions.

At present the modern self is becoming *saturated* by technologies that dominate life. Thus the modern self is beginning to be replaced by the *postmodern self.* Lacking a stable inner core or a reason-governed personality, the postmodern self is a *relational self* in which relationships with others are mediated by various technologies. Gergen predicts that forms of mediating technologies such as the Internet, cell phones and computer-based mate selection will

increasingly dominate the formation of relationships in the future. Lacking an inner core, the identity within the postmodern self will exist only as a collection of external images, such as the "curated" lives and identities portrayed on Facebook or Instagram.

In modern consumer-oriented society each individual develops relationships based on a social-exchange model in which the goal is to maximize profit within each social relationship. Investing in relationships with an expectation that they will result in a handsome return becomes the bottom line for relationship formation. Lacking a socioemotional dimension, relationships become increasingly instrumental, measured in terms of what can be gained from the relationship. Through the marvel of electronic technology the sheer number of relationships multiply, while at the same time they become superficial, lacking any sense of commitment or depth.

With the publication of his book *Relational Being: Beyond Self and Community* (2009), Gergen gives his answer to the dilemma of the *saturated self*. Before the publication of *Relational Being*, we ventured to give our own answer by viewing the *saturated self* through the lens of our *reciprocating self* model, stating in our first edition that "relationships are dependent on well-formed personal identities. Where personal identities are shallow, the ability to enter into deep, caring and intimate relationships is limited, thus contributing to a shallow, less secure or even vacuous self" (Balswick, King & Reimer, 2005, pp. 287-88). An examination of *Relational Being* reveals that our assessment comports well with Gergen's own.

Our mutual focus centers on *relationship*—"Whatever value we place upon ourselves or others, and whatever hope we may have for the future, depends on the welfare of relationship" (Gergen, 2009, p. 396). It is more than coincidental that we both draw upon Buber, with our utilization of Buber's theory of relatedness, as seen in chapter three, to illustrate the

meaning of *the reciprocating self*, and Gergen's quotation of Buber—"In the beginning is the relationship" (2009, p. 396).

It is also worth noting that Gergen's view of the formation of the self is consistent with the RDS paradigm. He states, "In all that we say and do, we manifest our relational existence. . . . [Thus] . . . we may abandon the view that those around us cause our actions. Others are not the causes nor we their effects. Rather, in whatever we think, remember, create, and feel, we *participate* in relationship" (p. 397).

The focus of Gergen's *Relational Being* goes beyond mere theory, as it is also an urgent call for modern societies to practice relationality. Gergen suggests that we must be "wedded to the ways we live our lives together . . . [engaging in] . . . practices that invite productive co-creation of meaning, and most especially, that break the barriers of antipathy" (p. 397). We take this as a dramatic call for the biblical understanding of what God intends the Christian community to be. Parenthetically, it might be noted that in his bestselling book, *The Social Animal: The Hidden Sources of Love, Character, and Achievement* (2012), social commentator David Brooks makes a similar argument as Gergen, emphasizing that the human person emerges out of relationships.

The Reciprocal Self Embedded in the Reciprocal Community

Our model for understanding human development—the reciprocating self—is based on a trinitarian analogy of being and becoming. In *After Our Likeness*, Miroslav Volf (1998), and in *Covenant, Community and the Spirit: A Trinitarian Theology of Church*, Robert Sherman (2015), both develop a model of the church based on the image of the Trinity. Volf's stated purpose is to find a "theologically

appropriate ecclesiological response to the challenge of modern societies" (1998, p. 16). Structural elements of modern societies have affected the church and community life in a way similar to how they have affected the self. Thus we draw on Volf's model as an appropriate bridge to move from a focus on the reciprocating self to the reciprocating community.

Volf suggests that members of the church are to indwell each other in the same way that the Father, Son and Holy Spirit mutually indwell each other in a *trinitarian fellowship.* This is humanly possible to the extent that the Holy Spirit dwells in the hearts of a people living in a community of the Spirit. Volf uses the concept of *mutual interpenetration* to describe the nature of the relationships among the Father, Son and Spirit. This mutual interpenetration involves a "mutual giving and receiving" wherein "Trinitarian persons are not only interdependent, but also *mutually internal*" (p. 208). This can be seen in the words of Jesus: "So that you may know and understand that the Father is in me and I am in the Father" (Jn 10:38). This is read by Volf as pointing to the *mutual exteriorization* (*perichoresis*) of the Father and the Son, a reciprocal *interiority* of trinitarian persons. Within every divine person as a subject, the other persons also dwell; all members of the Trinity mutually permeate one another. While together being the one God, in their mutual indwelling the Father, Son and Holy Spirit do not cease to be distinct persons. Since persons who have dissolved into one another cannot exist in one another, the distinctions among the three persons of the Trinity are precisely the presupposition that makes interiority possible. *Perichoresis* is "co-inherence in one another without any coalescence or commixture" (p. 209).

Just as the reciprocal interiority of the Father, Son and Spirit determines the character of their unity, so the reciprocal interiority of members of the body of Christ determines the unity of the local church or fellowship.

“Like the divine persons, so also ecclesial persons cannot live in isolation from one another; Christians are constituted as independently believing persons through their relations to other Christians, and they manifest and affirm their own ecclesial personhood in mutual giving and receiving” (p. 206). Each person in the church is to *give* to each other member as God has gifted them. In a reciprocal sense, however, each member is to freely *receive* from each other member as God has gifted them. This last point is important, for it points to the need for persons to receive from others without any sense of inadequacy. To be empowered by another is how God intends for the body of Christ to function in a normal sense. This may mean that the hyperindividualistic Western cultural influence on the church needs to be tempered by the communal emphasis of New Testament Christianity.

Christ himself is acting in the endowment of the gifts of the Spirit to the church. Spiritual gifts are *universally distributed*; they are given to all members of the body of Christ and to all local fellowships. Universal distribution implies *common responsibility* for the life of the church. This in turn implies *mutual subordination* (Eph 5:21), which means that members of the body are *interdependent* in regard to their giftedness (1 Cor 12:7-11). Finally, gifts of the Spirit are not to be thought of as irrevocable, but can change over the life of an individual’s lifespan and within the body over the life of a church. Gifts of the Spirit are endowed to members of the body of Christ as a dynamic whole, within which members of the body are to reciprocally use their gifts for one another.

In our human frailness the issue of power is likely to interfere with God’s ideal for mutual empowerment within the body of Christ. Drawing on Jürgen Moltmann, Volf suggests the principle that “the more a church is characterized by symmetrical and decentralized distribution of power and freely affirms interaction, the more will it correspond to

the Trinitarian communion" (p. 236). If the church is truly reflecting the trinitarian model, relationships will be *reciprocal* and *symmetrical*, with all members expressing their gifts for the good of all others. God's ideal for human community is that each member will want to be and to do what God wants them to be and do in relationship to each other—to participate together as a community of love. Objectively, Paul states that those outside of the church will know Christians by their love for one another.

The Christian community can love perfectly to the extent that it is participating in God's own love. In *Life Together*, Dietrich Bonhoeffer (1954) details his concept of a reciprocating community, developing both spiritually and psychologically. In his chapter "Confession and Community," he suggests that mutual confession is the final breakthrough to fellowship and community.

Since no community this side of Christ's return will love perfectly, there is a place for rules and regulations in the body. A measure of both developmental and spiritual maturity, however, is the degree to which external rules and regulations become internalized—an interior part of each member's self-structure. Just as Jesus prayed to the Father in anticipation of his death—"Not my will but yours be done"—so members of the church are to give up self-will, loving each other enough to give their lives for the other.

Congregational Differentiation

In the trinitarian model the Father, Son and Holy Spirit consist of a *differentiated unity.* Although each indwells the other, each maintains a distinct personhood. What would differentiated unity look like at the congregational level? Drawing on family-systems theory, differentiation can be conceptualized along a continuum leading from *enmeshment* at one extreme to *disengagement* at the other. Each extreme

represents the lack of differentiation. Enmeshment is the state of fusion between persons, sometimes referred to as *undifferentiated ego mass.* Here unity is so complete that individual members have no separate identity of their own. In its most extreme form, persons cease functioning as individuals related to God. Instead, they have given over their identity to the group. Congregational enmeshment can be accompanied by *collusion* between an authoritarian leader who needs to dominate and followers who need domination. Less extreme forms of congregational enmeshment can be seen in high-demand or abusive congregations, where blind obedience is given to a leader by followers.

There is little *interdependence* in the enmeshed church since all members are *dependent* on the leader. A constant barrage of authoritarian commands and demands maintains dependence. There is little empowerment taking place in enmeshed churches. There are few personal boundaries. One fixed boundary around the entire congregation functions to keep congregation members from being influenced by anyone or anything outside of the church. Full allegiance and attention must be given to the leader.

The disengaged church is the opposite of the enmeshed church. Rather than experiencing too much unity, church members in a disengaged church hardly interact with each other. Membership consists of being on the church roll, but active participation together as the body of Christ is rare. Whereas sufficient personal boundaries may exist for individual members, there is practically no boundary around the congregation as a body. Energy and enthusiasm for life is found outside rather than from within the church. Identification with the body of Christ is minimal. Dietrich Bonhoeffer (1954) offers this appropriate warning: “Let him who cannot be alone beware of community. Let him who is not in community beware of being alone” (p. 78).

The church that reflects the trinitarian model encourages a differentiated unity that is maintained by members finding

their *primary identity in Jesus Christ.* Differentiated unity in the church body goes hand in hand with each member's *differentiation in Christ*. This can be seen in Paul's writing to the Galatian church: "I have been crucified with Christ; and it is no longer I who live, but it is Christ who lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me" (Gal 2:19-20). In a similar way we find in Romans 6 that Paul contrasts his *old self*, which has been crucified with Christ, with his *new self*, which is alive in Christ. The apostle John writes of the believer's new identity in terms of an exchanged life where I am in him and he is in me (see Jn 17:21).

With members of the family of God finding their identity in Christ, relationships are characterized by a mutual reinforcing and supporting of each other. At the organizational level, healthy differentiation is characterized by members experiencing unity in their *connectedness* with the congregation and their *separation* from the congregation as a whole. While personal boundaries exist around each individual, they are permeable, open to mutual interpenetration. Each member creates a place in his or her self for the other while not losing his or her own self. While the congregation needs strong boundaries to provide support and accountability for each member, these boundaries are also permeable. Based on a secure identity in Jesus Christ, members are free, and they are encouraged to live fruitful lives outside of the community.

Intergenerational Reciprocity

At the structural level the church must be a community in which relational interdependence is allowed and even fostered. The church must be structured so that it can respond to the developmental needs of persons at all lifespan

stages—infants, toddlers, teens, young and middle adults, and the elderly (Allen & Ross, 2012; Menconi, 2010). It is imperative that those working in the church and parachurch organizations have a good understanding of age-specific developmental issues. This includes knowledge of age appropriateness in such areas as faith and moral development, so there will no be unrealistic expectations of persons of a certain age. Thus Christian ministry has rightly used developmental psychology in emphasizing age-appropriate religious learning and worship activities.

The rate of change in popular culture—dress and fashion, music, the popular arts, communication style and the like—makes it necessary to focus Christian ministry (outreach, evangelism, worship) on specific age cohorts, igniting what has come to be known as *worship wars.* I (Jack) recently witnessed a multigenerational worship service in a church that has tenaciously resisted change to a multiservice, generation-specific format. I found congregants' reactions to the wide variety of worship styles both a bit humorous and a bit tragic. Older members of the church sang the old hymns fervently. The dominant response by the younger generation to the hymns ranged from mild tolerance to boredom. When the lyrics of an upbeat praise song were projected onto a screen, accompanied by a worship band, the younger folks clapped their hands and sang with great gusto. But most older congregants stood in confused bewilderment. The end result for many churches has been the creation of separate generational worship services for the different age groups.

However, an unintended negative consequence of such generational age grading is the potential construction of barriers across the groups, hindering the development of caring cross-generational relationships. Such churches are in danger of becoming isolated, age-specific, homogeneous subcommunities. Why is this not good, or what is being lost in the process? *Complementarity* between parts of the body of Christ (1 Cor 12). In a profound way both the *gifts* and the

needs of church members are correspondingly related to the ages of its members. Simply put, to a large extent the needs of younger persons correspond to the gifts and resources of older persons, while the needs of older persons correspond to the gifts and resources of younger persons.

Some may argue that such intergenerational needs can best be met among members within the same extended family, and that the church should not be burdened with the responsibility of fostering intergenerational relationships. However, this ignores the weakening effect on contemporary family life caused by high geographical mobility. A strength in the extended family of the past was the rich interchange between family members of different generations. Cross-cultural research suggests that traditionally the main socializers of children have been grandparents. In the past children learned morality and values at the knees of their grandparent. The majority of children growing up in modern societies are deprived of the benefits of an everyday relationship with their grandparents. Today's children often grow up with their nearest grandparent hundreds or even thousands of miles away. Correspondingly, many grandparents are living out their elderly years void of regular face-to-face contact with their children and grandchildren.

We suggest that the best way to foster intergenerational relationships in modern society is for the church to become what it was designed to be. The primary Greek word used in the New Testament in describing the church is *koinonia*, a word referring to a community in which Christians are united in purpose and identity. Robert Banks (1980) points out that in the economy of New Testament society, *koinonia* was meant to represent a new type of community between the all-inclusive, impersonal state (*politeia*) and the exclusive, blood-based household (*oikonomia*). He suggests that the size of the first Christian churches was limited to between twenty and thirty persons since this is the number that could meet in a home of New Testament times. Research suggests that most

persons are able to maintain intimate relationships with twenty-five to thirty persons at most (Pattison, 1984). Putting this together, we suggest the early church functioned much like an extended family. All believers cared for and supported each other as family.

Banks (1980) observes that of the many metaphors used in the New Testament for church, none is used as extensively or as adequately as the family metaphor. The New Testament describes church members as the *family of God* who are the *children of God* and who are *brothers* and *sisters* in Christ. Although Jesus did not dissolve the natural order of the family, his desire for the church was that care and support transcend the family to the Christian community. In response to the message that his mother and brother had arrived, Jesus rhetorically replied, "Who are my mother and my brothers?" We are told that he then looked at those sitting around him and said, "Here are my mother and my brothers! Whoever does the will of God is my brother and sister and mother" (Mk 3:33-35). John 19:26-27 records that "when Jesus saw his mother and the disciple whom he loved standing beside her, he said to his mother, ' Woman, here is your son.' Then he said to the disciple, ' Here is your mother.' And from that hour the disciple took her into his own home." By his words and actions Jesus radically redefined the meaning of family. The church needs to be a community characterized by family-type relationships.

The focal point of references for the New Testament church was "neither a book nor a rite but *a set of relationships*, and that God communicated himself to them . . . *through one another*" (Banks, 1980, p. 111). Perhaps what is most needed in the local church today is a radical redefinition of *family* (Clapp, 1993). The term *fictive kin* has been coined to refer to the development of family-like relationships between persons whose biological families are not available. During my (Jack's) children's formative years, we lived over one thousand miles away from both my and my wife's parents.

Across the street from us, however, lived Hank and Mimi, an elderly couple whose own children and grandchildren lived far away. Our family became as *fictive kin* to Hank and Mimi, celebrating birthdays, anniversaries and special occasions together. Hank and Mimi became grandfather and grandmother to our children, and Jacque and Jeff became granddaughter and grandson to them. Many a meal, milestone and ritual were shared together as an extended family.

Young parents and their young children who are deprived of grandparents can benefit from the attention and nurture given by nearby elderly persons. At the same time elderly persons who are without family nearby can benefit from their involvement with these younger children and families. Young parents are overloaded and have little time, but time is the one commodity that elderly persons have plenty of. The elderly are often lonely, but in sharing life with younger parents and their children, their loneliness may yield to intimate belonging. The benefit to children from church members may be especially important when there is only one parent in the home, as one study found that greater religious participation of single mothers correlated with positive children's behavior and less likelihood of problem behaviors (Petts, 2012).

Principles of Cross-Generational Fellowship and Ministry

The above is just one example of cross-generational complementarity that might be fulfilled within a religious community. We suggest several principles that might be helpful in facilitating cross-generation reciprocity in fellowship and ministry. First, *worship and ministry need to be conceptualized as normative activities to be engaged in by members of all ages.* God gifts all members of the body to minister to other members of the body. Even without self-

awareness, God uses little children to minister to other members of the body (Green, 2014).

Second, *ministry is to be based on the reality that human relationships are an important foundation for a relationship with God.* In our discussion on reciprocating spirituality in chapter thirteen, we referred to early-life relationships as potential experiences of "horizontal spirituality," which enable more abstract experiences such as a connection to a religious community or which facilitate a relationship with God as experiences of "vertical spirituality." Worship, Christian education, mission and other ministry programs are designed to keep the significance of relationships as formative to a person's growing capacity to know and encounter God, and are extremely important. Promoting opportunities for affective attunement, trust and affirmation become seminal from this perspective.

Third, *ministry is to reflect the combination of giftedness and spiritual maturity.* In *Life Passages for Men* (1993), James Wilder observes that Scripture distinguishes between giftedness and maturity. Whereas gifting is God's domain, spiritual maturity is a human domain. Maturity is a relatively independent dimension of human life God gives us that unfolds through time and involves interaction with Christian community. The combination of giftedness and spiritual maturity brings about a fruit-bearing stage that Scripture describes as *fruitfulness.* Whereas fruitfulness is a characteristic found among all members, God allows for *seasons* of spiritual development that can correspond to chronological age. The Christian community needs to be sensitive to the specific developmental needs of members at every age. The point made earlier in this book—that human development involves both *adolescing* (growth) and *senescing* (decline)—may be worth noting in this regard. As persons age, they become less self-sufficient, less able to meet the needs of others, *and* they become more needy of others.

Fourth, *while ministry is to be to reciprocal, it need not be a symmetrical exchange.* This gets at our earlier point about a covenant relationship with God and each other. *Mutuality* does not quite convey the idea since *mutuality* so strongly suggests equal and identical give-and-take. In relationships the give-and-take (reciprocity) may not be equal. A person may receive from another what he or she cannot give in return. Inversely, a person may give to another what the other may not be able to give in return. This lack of symmetry is, however, no defect or detriment to a covenantal relationship—it may in fact be its essence. God does for us what we cannot do for ourselves!

Scripture has much to say about a more mature member *discipling* or *caring for* the less mature or less self-sufficient member. It is obvious that the very young and immature and the very old and dependent will need to be supported and cared for more than what can be expected of them. Unconditional love means rejecting any "scorekeeping" of how much one member of the body is getting from another.

Fifth, *ministry is to be an empowering process—where one person uses his or her personal resources for the other with the purpose of building up and serving the other in Christ*. Developmentally, members within the family of God will be at different level of maturity—cognitively, socially, emotionally, intellectually and spiritually. The teleology of development in a community context is that members of the body of Christ have the capacity to *give from their own giftedness* and *receive on the basis of their needs*. Acts 4:32, 34-35 describes the early church this way:

> The whole group of those who believed were of one heart and soul, and no one claimed private ownership of any possessions, but everything they owned was held in common. . . . There was not a needy person among them, for as many as owned lands or houses sold them and

> brought the proceeds of what was sold. . . . And it was distributed to each as any had need.

The principle here is equally true for all types of needs and resources within the Christian community. In more than just material needs, members of the body are to emotionally and socially care for one another. There is no place in Christian ministry for a dualism that separates out physical, emotional and social needs from spiritual needs; ministry must be to the whole person.

Implication for Counseling Ministry

The focus in this chapter has been on how developing persons might best be nurtured and cared for when embedded within a Christian community. Our progression through each developmental stage highlights the ways individuals become different due to a combination of contributing factors. While our *relational* bias directs us toward emphasizing that healing might best take place in community, the church is not and never will be a perfect community because it is composed of imperfect individuals. Just as there are degrees of authenticity in Christian communities, so there are varying degrees to which individual persons develop into authentic beings, with some struggling more than others with hurt and brokenness. Thus a legitimate need within Christian community is for "one-on-one" contact, support and counseling.

One-on-one ministry might go by the name of mentoring, discipling, lay counseling, spiritual counseling, spiritual direction, ministerial counseling or individual therapy. While we recognize that each of these concepts carries with it significant differences in regards to expectations and ethical implications, for the sake of simplicity, we will use the generic term *counseling ministry* as we address implications of our relational model for one-on-one ministry.

Although most counseling ministry will not involved dealing with serious psychological problems, a helpful beginning for recognizing the importance of *relationality* in counseling is provided in a relevant chapter in the *Handbook of Child Psychology and Developmental Science*. In their chapter, "Developmental Psychopathology," Cummings and Valentino (2015, 1:569-71) suggest that individual therapy includes recognizing the following:

1. the importance of *contextual embeddedness,* suggesting that development is an ongoing interplay between an active, changing individual and a dynamic, changing context;
2. that the individual is an *active organism,* as people play a major role in their own development;
3. the *multiple, diverse causes of development*, where causal factors are capable of mutually interacting;
4. *holism*: since there is an interdependency among the parts of any developmental system, development cannot be fully understood by dissecting the parts; and
5. *orderly change and directionality*: development follows orderly pathways of continuity and change.

Based on our conceptualization of the reciprocating-self model we add the following suggestions for persons engaged in counseling ministry.

First, although it is obvious from an RDS perspective and from Cummings and Valentino's comments, an individual's personal struggle or brokenness is not likely to be the result of any one factor, but the result of a multitude of interactive factors. Furthermore, these interactive factors may represent more than one level—cultural, sociological, psychological, neurological, physical or spiritual. This should be a caution to counseling ministries that tend to focus on *one* specific reason for a person's problem.

Counselors must not look at only one level, but be open to all levels of developmental influence. Such recognition will at the same time introduce a mixture of humility and frustration, but is a needed guard against resorting to simple or easy solutions to a person's presenting problem.

Second, since the self develops as part of reciprocal relationships, a focus on the healthiness of a person's *relationships* should be primary. When possible a person's relationship(s) as well as the person should be considered in the healing process. This would point to the importance of marital, parent/child, family or personal relationships as legitimate focal points in the counseling process.

Third, a counselor should recognize that one's ability to deal with a person's presenting problem is not only based on counseling skills, but also on knowledge and understanding of an individual's developmental context. For example, a troubled child may or may not be a product of unhealthy parenting, as it might also be, at least in part, a result of neurological or related physiological disorders. It would also be misguided to view all problems as simply "spiritual problems." Evil in all its forms certainly plays a role in our human struggle to live authentic lives, but to view all problems within such a simple formula will be very self-limiting in the counseling process. When a counselor finds her- or himself out of their depth in understanding, it should go without saying that it is important to refer to a counselor/therapist with greater expertise and knowledge.

Conclusion

Let us revisit how the reciprocating self as a developmental teleology helps us with the predicament of the developmental dilemma raised at the beginning of this book. First, the reciprocating self provides a theological lens through which to view development. We find that, in general, developmental

theories are not strong in providing any sort of teleology. That is, they are tentative in addressing or defining the *goal* of development. Existing theories generally define *processes* inherent in development, but without directly discussing the goal of development.

Second, our model of the reciprocating self takes the focus off *pathology* by emphasizing *positive development.* The psychological community has built much theory and practice on the repair and healing of persons. This emphasis has resulted in a deficient model of human development, lacking a clear understanding of positive or optimal development. We suggest that our model of the reciprocating self provides a theological perspective of optimal development.

The study of lifespan development has largely consisted of a number of separate theories. Until the recent emergence of the RDS paradigm, an understanding of lifespan development has been hindered by the lack of an overall view that would help us understand the many different existing theories and approaches to the different stages and aspects of development. We suggest that our reciprocating-self model comports very well with the RDS paradigm in providing a general framework through which to understand and even evaluate developmental theories.

The journey that takes a newborn infant from total dependency to human maturity is a long and complex process. Along the way there are a number of biological and sociocultural factors that contribute to individuals becoming all that God intended them to be.

God’s intention for humans is to develop as distinct individuals in mutual and authentic relationships with divine and human others—for God’s glory. Although infants are born human, potential for maximum human development is contingent on being nested in caring and supportive relationships with others. Progress toward becoming a mature reciprocating self is fostered best within a network of relationships characterized by unconditional love, grace, empowering and

intimacy. The goal of the maturation process is to become a person with the capacity and inclination to reciprocate each of these characteristics: *to love and be loved, to forgive and be forgiven, to empower and be empowered,* and *to know and to be known.* Our model for this is not found in human wisdom but in the very nature of our triune God and the relationship God seeks to establish with God’s people.

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Notes

Chapter 2: The Reciprocating Self: A Trinitarian Analogy of Being and Becoming

1 Although full discussion is beyond the scope of this book, for our purposes, nonreductive physicalism refers to an understanding of human nature that is based on the physical body (physicalism). Consequently, capacities for relating to God and others emerge out of the complex cognitive and emotional capacities enabled by our biology. These capacities for transcendence are referred to emergent properties and based on biology, not a nonphysical substance such as a soul. Although nonreductive physicalists do not acknowledge that human nature is endowed with a soul or a distinct substance that is the image of God, such scientists and philosophers are nonreductive insofar as they recognize the existence and reality of God.

Chapter 13: Reciprocating Spirituality

1 Although sampling was not random, efforts were made to represent a range of socioeconomic and educational backgrounds.

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Praise for *The Reciprocating Self*

"Every human life originates in a relationship with another person, and humans thrive when their lives involve mutually beneficial, positive relationships with family, friends and community members. *The Reciprocating Self* creatively integrates developmental science and the wisdom of Christian theology to provide innovative and singularly significant insights about the nature and importance of human relationships in creating human lives marked by meaning, love and fulfillment. Professors Balswick, King and Reimer have written a book that exemplifies the powerful contributions that can be made to understanding and enhancing human development through bridging the best of social and behavioral science and theological verities in a manner that both informs and inspires."

Richard M. Lerner, Bergstrom Chair in Applied Developmental Science, Tufts University

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"All empirical and theoretical accounts of human development raise a basic normative question: What counts as maturity or developmental advance? Much contemporary social science tries to sidestep the question; this book does not. It is unique in

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Andrew Root, Luther Seminary, author of *Bonhoeffer as Youth Worker*

About the Authors

WE BEGAN OUR THINKING about human development together when Pam and Kevin were teaching assistants to Jack in two courses, Child and Family Development and Human Lifespan Development, in the Fuller School of Psychology. We soon discovered that we were complementary in our interest and knowledge of lifespan development—Pam in adolescents and young adulthood, Kevin in neuropsychology and infant and child development, and Jack in middle and late adulthood. While all three of us had formal education in theology, Pam's enthusiasm for trinitarian theology serves as the integrative foundation of our book. Out of our enthusiasm for teaching together and our desire to understand God's intention for human development, we decided to write this book together.

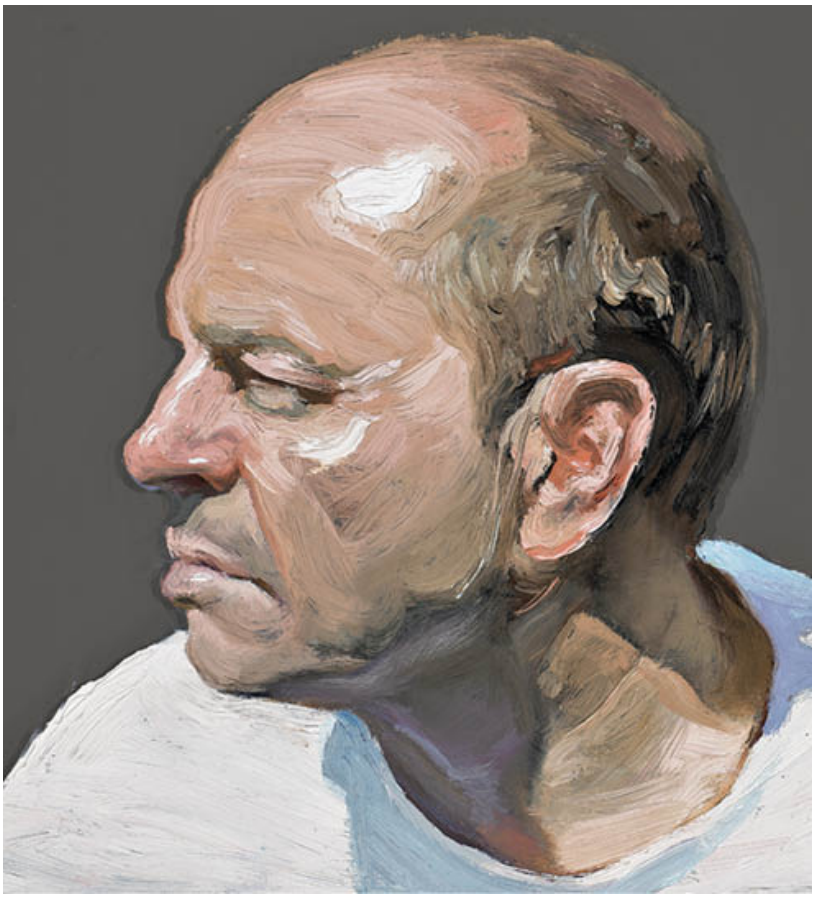
Jack is now a senior professor at Fuller. He continues to teach and speak internationally, and he writes prolifically. His research in marriage and family issues and religious mental health has resulted in more than eighty articles and monographs, as well as a long roster of books. In addition to *The Reciprocating Self*, his most recent books include *Authentic Human Sexuality* (3rd edition, forthcoming), *The Family: A Christian Perspective on the Contemporary Home* (4th edition, 2014), *A Model for Marriage: Covenant, Grace, Empowerment, and Intimacy* (2006) and *Relationship-Empowerment Parenting* (2003). He coauthored many of these books with his wife, Judith

Balswick. Although they reside in Pasadena, they travel avidly, keeping up with family and friends.

Pam is the Peter Benson Chair of Applied Developmental Psychology and Associate Professor of Psychology in the School of Psychology at Fuller. Pam's primary research interests are applied research at the intersection of human thriving and spiritual development. Her work combines theology, empirical research and community engagement to further understand what contexts and settings enable youth to thrive. Her primary academic outlets are developmental psychology and psychology of religion. Pam is ordained in the Presbyterian Church (USA) and when not studying youth thriving, she's hoping to nurture it in her three children.

Kevin is Director of Undergraduate Programs & Student Affairs in the School of Education, University of California, Irvine. A developmental psychologist, he is coinvestigator for the HABITVS Project on compassionate virtue funded by the John Templeton Foundation. His research program considers character through humanitarian exemplarity. Kevin has authored or coauthored more than sixty publications. He is ordained in the Presbyterian Church (USA).

About the Artist



THE PORTRAITS ON THE COVER were generously shared by Pasadena artist Ray Turner. Turner graduated from the Art Center College of Design, Pasadena, California, in 1985, where he subsequently taught for thirteen years as a professor of painting and drawing. These portraits are a small sample of over six hundred portraits from Turner's *Population* series, which he started in 2007. This body of art is a community-embracing work in which the artist endeavors to honor the uncelebrated and celebrities of a specific community. Each show is based on his encounter with the diversity of a city where he represents the "gardener to the governor." The originals are acrylic painted on glass squares. The depth and layers of paint allude to the complexity and uniqueness of the human spirit. Ray's work is a profound and vivid illustration and celebration of the dignity and diversity in which God creates humankind. His work has been featured in museums across the country and in media from the *Huffington Post* to *The American Art Collector* to the *San Francisco Chronicle*. For more

information on Ray Turner's art, please visit rayturner.us. The authors are honored to have his work on the cover of *The Reciprocating Self*.

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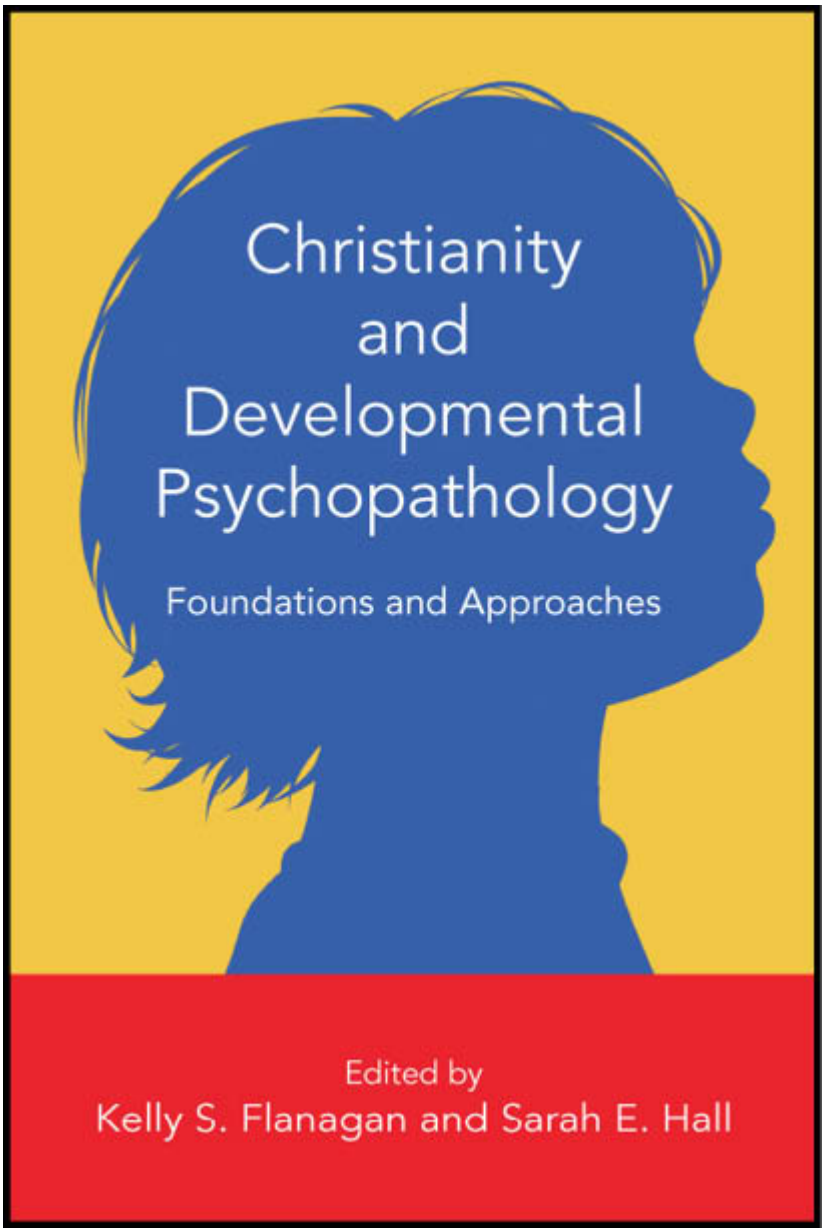

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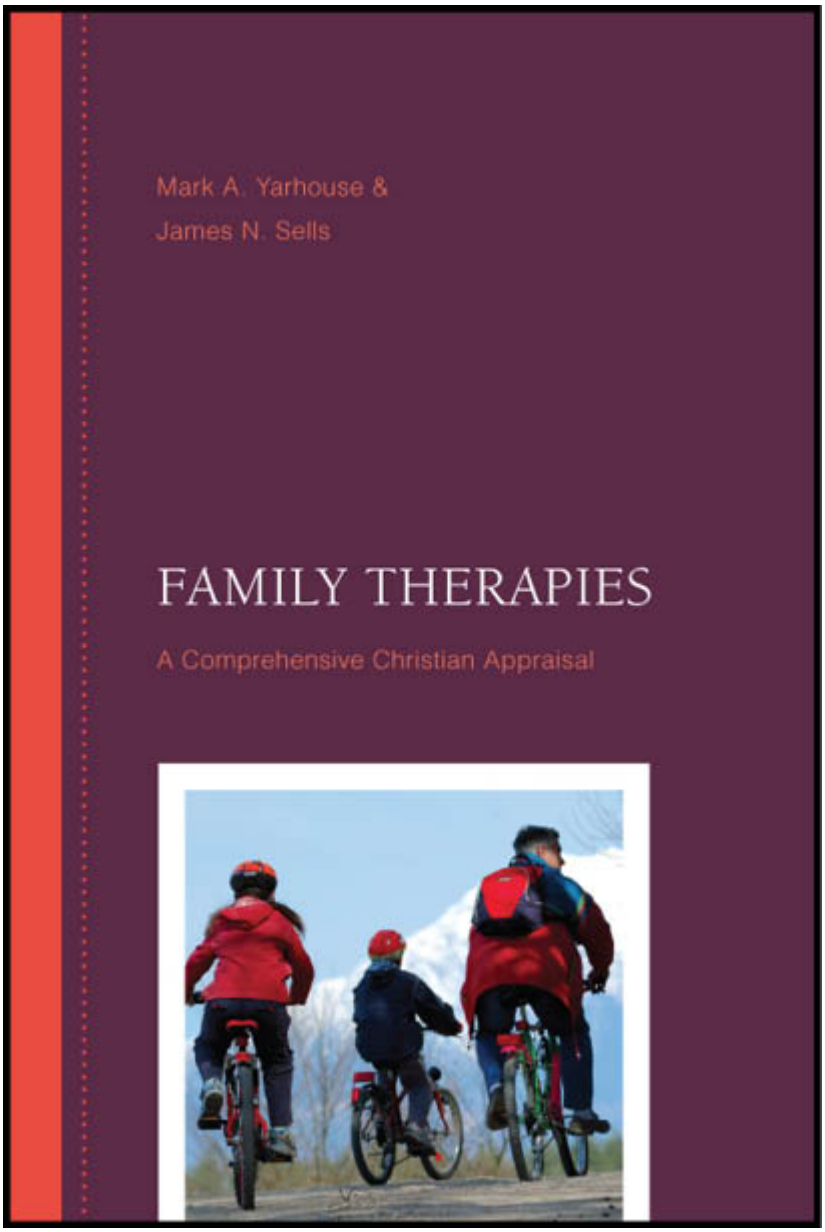

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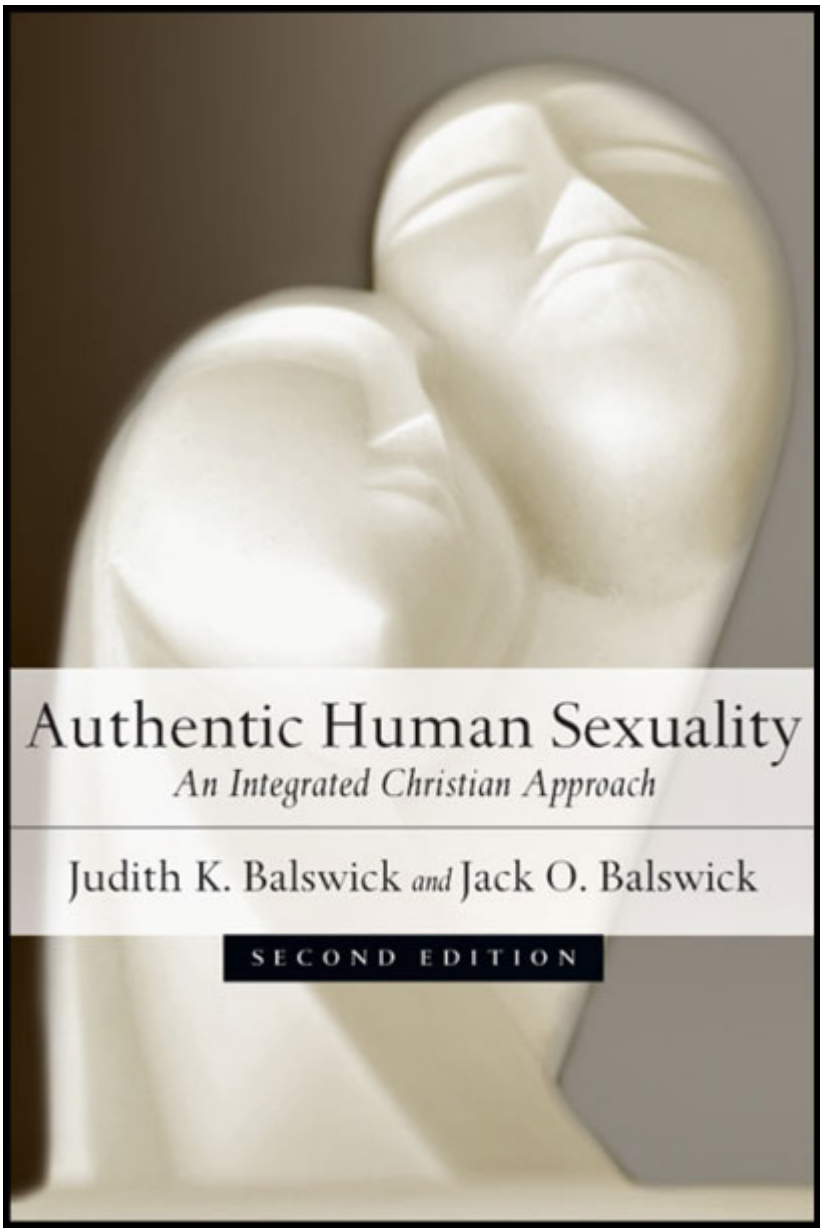

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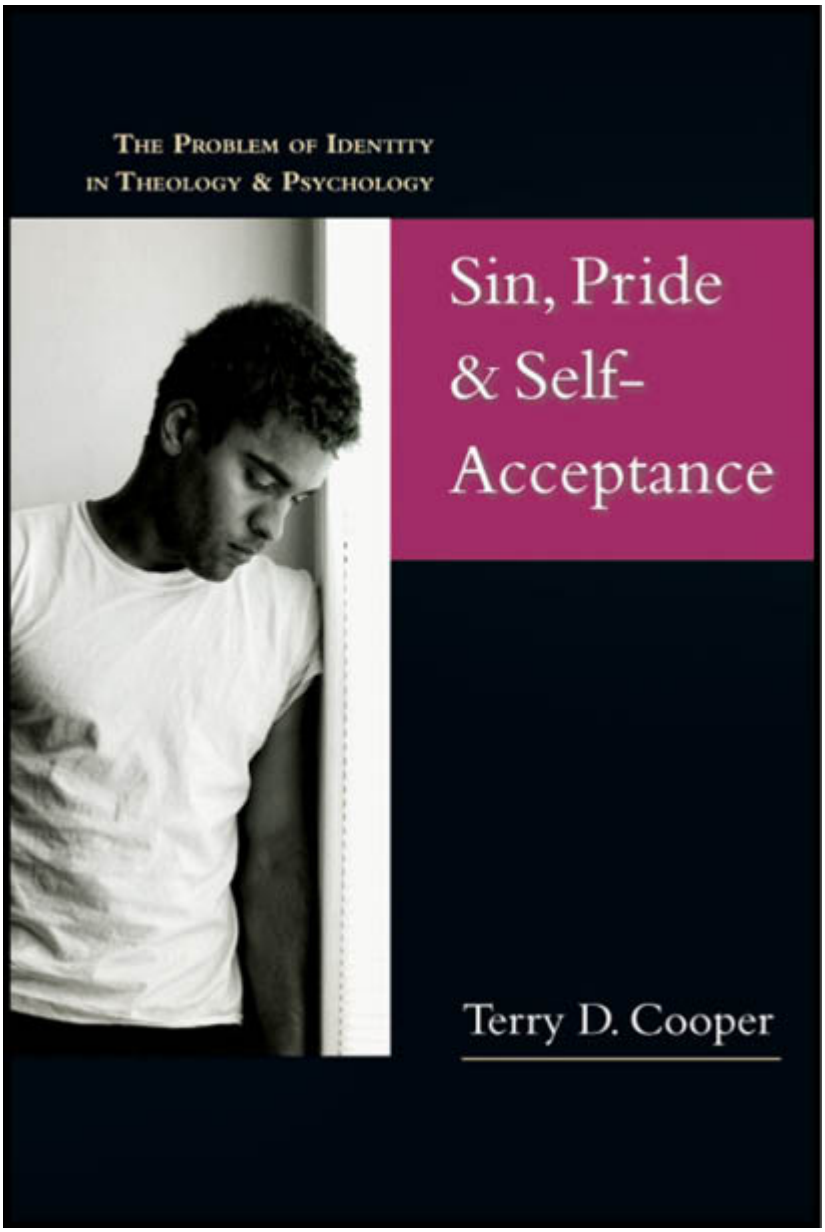

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